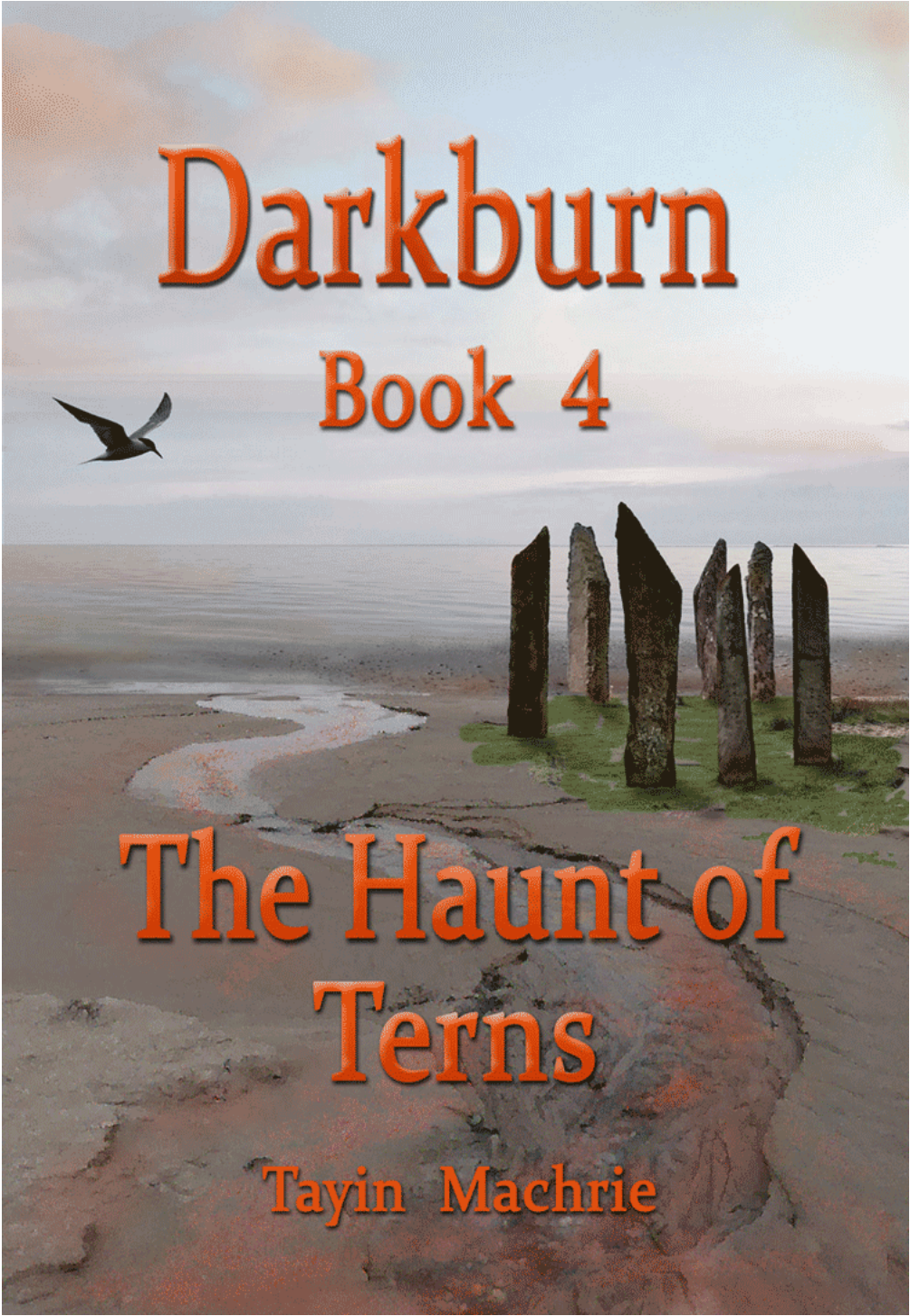




Darkburn

Book 4

The Haunt of Terns

Tayin Machrie

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The Haunt of Terns

Chapter 1

The high forbidding walls of Kelvha City were long out of sight and the landscape had changed again. Gone were the narrow fields that had radiated from each huddled Kelvhan village, luminous with infant beans and barley. The Castle's carefully thicketed hunting forests lay far behind them now; indeed, all trees, all cultivated crofts and pasturage had gone.

Instead, the Riders faced a bleak and barren country that seemed to Parthenal to be practically devoid of any life at all. Surely it hadn't always been like this? A few years back, he'd ridden through this land past restless, lowing herds of small but noisy oxen. It had been a lush green country then.

There was no lush green here now. The horses trod upon a uniformly greyish carpet of some dull creeping plant; a lichen or a moss, too insignificant to have a name – or one that Parthenal knew, anyway. At first, a few bedraggled weeds had poked their heads up through the drab grey mat in drooping spikes; but even those had disappeared.

Just one more of the inexplicably blighted regions of the world. He found himself doubly depressed, both by this dreary landscape and by the slowness of the Vonnish army in traversing it.

"This was a mistake," he muttered to Rothir.

His riding-partner turned his head. "What was?"

"Avoiding the main causeway out of Kelvha. That road would have been much faster."

"Where it wasn't choked with carts, maybe," answered Rothir, who seemed surprisingly content. He evidently didn't mind this plodding progress across a dismal plain.

"A mistake," repeated Parthenal; and then was shocked at his own thoughts. Huldarion, make an error? That had never happened yet. He assumed their chief had issued the command to march across this empty country in the hope of added speed. But if so, that hope had been unfounded: for while the land here might look flat, it wasn't. So many bumps and lumps and pock-marks scarred the leaden ground that the army could not move with any haste.

Still, an unimportant error, for battle was not imminent, and this was not yet the full Vonnish army. Parthenal craned round to view the long, thin line that crawled in Huldarion's wake. It held not quite a thousand Riders of the Vonn, plus a few extras like the Ioben huntsmen, and the odd Kelvhan volunteer.

Those two serving-women from the Castle were still there: he glimpsed them in the middle of a group of female Riders. That was a surprise. He'd thought they would have cut and run by now, once they'd got away from Kelvha Castle – away from the upset over that sad suicide, for which they would have borne the blame.

But he didn't blame the pair of maids for wanting to escape. In spite of all the feasts and dances he'd endured within the castle, he'd been glad to get away himself, unscathed if somewhat frustrated – in more ways than one. Now he was desperate for some action.

"It'll take us a week to reach your sister's farm at this rate," he complained.

"I don't think Huldarion's in any hurry," answered Rothir in his deep rumble.

"No, that's obvious. He's got his new bride to keep him busy, hasn't he?" said Parthenal. As soon as he spoke he compressed his lips in self-reproach at the bitterness in his own voice. That was something that he needed to beware of. Having kept his feelings for Huldarion a secret for the last eighteen years or so – ever since he was a teenager – he would be abysmally ashamed to have them guessed at now.

Even his closest friend did not know the truth. "I believe Huldarion and Meya discuss Kelvhan politics together," Rothir answered mildly.

"Oh, I'm sure they do. Especially in that fine carriage of hers, late at night." There. He'd done it again.

But Rothir merely laughed, his mood at odds with the weather-beaten sternness of his face. He was annoyingly cheerful, considering that this half-army was marching across unpromising terrain towards certain battle and possible death.

"I think Huldarion probably chose the best of the bunch to marry," he said, "when I consider how flatteringly you described the other candidates."

"They weren't all dreadful. Lady Janeya was much younger and prettier than Meya." Parthenal, instantly remembering that Lady Janeya was now dead by suicide, wanted to beat his head against a wall. He hurried on. "You're right, of course: we're lucky that Huldarion didn't pick Gaelera, even if she is the Post-Regent's daughter."

"That's probably why he didn't pick her. Who on earth would want Nerogun for a father-in-law? Especially since we've learnt he's been conniving with our enemy. He may have Kelvha under his thumb but he'll only support us in this war against the stonemen for as long as it suits him."

"Nerogun won't have Kelvha under his thumb much longer," Parthenal pointed out, "not once Prince Faldron becomes High King. That's only a few months away."

"Oh, Nerogun will make himself indispensable." But Rothir's cheerfulness had dissolved into his normal reflective frown. "I felt sorry for those other girls," he said. "Even the princess. She may have all the fine dresses and servants she could want but in the end she's just a bargaining tool. And as for poor Janeya..." He shook his head. "Was that because of us? Was it because Huldarion turned her down and made her relatives angry?"

"Very likely," said Parthenal. He didn't actually care about Janeya, who had flung herself so unnecessarily out of a high window. Of course he felt sorry for the girl, but he'd never even spoken to her; and he felt more sorry for her two maidservants, back there in the train amidst the other females.

Our women never used to ride so separately, he thought: that's the result of just a few short weeks in Kelvha. We've already adapted to their hierarchies. Even Huldarion is haughtier than he used to be.

He looked over at Huldarion, who was talking to Veron. The hunter was animated and paid no attention to Meya, although her carriage was right next to his horse. Left out of the discussion, she looked on with a chilly countenance.

Good, thought Parthenal. She's not yet our queen, and she needs to remember it, even if she doesn't like Veron's abrupt manners. But then what does she like about any of us Vonn – apart from Huldarion's high rank?

Time to stop staring, though. To camouflage his interest in Huldarion, he gazed back once again at the Riders in the rear. A couple took it as a signal to trot up and join him. Both were female, although at first glance neither looked it – particularly the one with the crooked nose. Her rusty hair was plaited tight and pulled back on one side in the Ioben archer's style. It

suited her, thought Parthenal, that boyish look. Her horse, however, was too grand for a lowly archer. It was Eled's old horse Poda, but she rode it well.

Parthenal felt a swift wave of memory wash over him: that time she had been up in his own horse's saddle, wounded and half-conscious, borne between gigantic trees. A very different land to this.

"Yaret," he said, with affectionate concern. "How goes it with you?"

"Fine," she said, "although I don't care much for this country."

"Depressing, isn't it?"

"There are regions north-east of Obandiro that are not so different," said Yaret soberly. She spoke Vonnish fairly fluently now, but with a marked northern burr, and with the odd phrase in Standard interposed. "Places where the earth is lacking life; as if it had been poisoned. Although that sounds too dramatic. Things do grow there. Just not many things."

"There are stretches west of the Thore and north of Kelvha that are the same," said Rothir.

"It's a pity to see the land struggling so," she commented. "In fact, it's very worrying. Why are there places like this?"

"Because that's the way they are," said Parthenal. He was not really bothered, for this stretch of land would soon be crossed, and the sooner the better; but Rothir nodded.

"I've wondered that myself," he said. "This region used to be more fertile. Who knows what happened?"

"Somebody knows," said Yaret forcefully.

Rothir looked at her with creased brows. "You mean Adon?"

The name gave Parthenal a start. It was always a jolt to hear it spoken openly; for the Vonn more often referred to that detested person as the ignoble one.

Yaret shook her head. "I know little of Adon," she said, "apart from what I've heard from you and Leor. I know that, like Leor, he's a wizard; and that the two of them are kin, although Leor has apparently disowned him. Actually I was thinking more of Leor himself. Surely a wizard ought to know what's happened to this place."

"Well, he's around somewhere," said Parthenal, glancing up and down the line of nodding horses. "If you can find him, ask him."

"I saw him riding alongside the priest's cart," said the second woman, Durba. She was several years younger than her companion, and currently quieter. Although she had recovered her lost voice she did not use it much. "He's friendly with the priest, and with that little man from Kelvha's library."

"I'll find him later," said Yaret. "How much further?"

"Across this barren strip? We must be near the end of it." Parthenal squinted ahead. "Aren't those trees up there on the skyline?"

"They look to be another four or five miles distant." Yaret sounded unusually out of sorts. Normally she was the one who tried to raise the others' spirits.

"It's not like you to grumble," Parthenal remarked.

"Her leg is hurting," explained Durba.

"Is it?" said Rothir. "How bad?"

"Just the odd twinge," said Yaret, with a reproving glance at Durba.

"Ask Shebel to find you something for it," advised Rothir.

"I have. And the herb-mistress in Kelvha gave me some ointment, which does seem to help."

"When we get to my sister's farm," said Rothir, "Olbeth may be able to recommend some other remedy."

"Is that where the other Riders will meet us?" Durba asked.

"Yes. They should be mustering near the farm now, so that over two thousand of us will march on from there."

Still not much of an army, Parthenal reflected. Once the Vonn joined up with the Kelvhan forces, they would be swamped.

But Yaret commented, "That seems a lot," making him recall that she came from a small town that might be better labelled a large village... And which was now not even that, but merely a ruined field of ash.

"Two thousand soldiers is nothing by Kelvha's standards," he assured her. And they all fell silent for a moment, mindful of the fact that they were vastly outnumbered by their allies as well as by their enemies.

"But we won't go straight there," Rothir added eventually. "First we'll head for the estate where the Lady Meya's daughter lives. We're to take her to Olbeth's farm, since her current home's no longer safe."

"Or so the Lady Meya thinks," said Parthenal.

"She has a daughter? How old is she?" enquired Yaret.

Parthenal shrugged. He had no interest in children generally and in Meya's daughter in particular.

"Five, I believe," said Rothir.

"Ah! She'll like it on the farm, then," said Yaret. "Make sure your sister gives her jobs to do."

Rothir smiled. "At five years old?"

"Of course." She was perfectly serious. "At five I could already spin, and throw the shuttle through the loom. I fed the chickens and made bread and was learning to milk the goats. I was fully of the opinion that my grandparents would never cope without me."

"Was that true?" asked Durba.

"That they couldn't cope? Not for another twenty years or more. They were still going strong when." Yaret stopped abruptly; just as her grandparents' lives had stopped, so suddenly and violently, last year – along with most of the lives in that little, distant town, Obandiro. Parthenal glanced sidelong at her, slightly worried, but she simply looked thoughtful. After a few seconds she added, "My bread was inedible. Even the chickens refused to eat it. What's going on over there?"

"I don't know. Something's holding us up." The foremost Riders had halted, looking down with serious faces.

Parthenal, taller than the others, raised himself in his stirrups to crane over the heads. What he saw made him grimace in distaste and frustration; because this would mean yet more delay.

"Ach. There's something lying on the ground," he said. "Four of them."

"Four what?" asked Rothir.

"Bodies."

Chapter 2

Rothir's hand went immediately to his sword hilt. "Animal or human?"

"I can't tell yet." Parthenal was already pushing his horse Alda between others, whose riders sat gazing at the bodies sprawled on the ground. "Human," he announced.

Huldarion, stiff and upright in the saddle, glanced up, his scarred face expressionless as always. "Stonemen," he said. "All four of them."

"They're a long time dead," commented Parthenal; for the bodies seemed to be half-buried under a dull blanket of mossy growth. Veron had dismounted and was squatting by the corpses to inspect them. Rothir jumped down from Narba to join him.

Veron looked up. "No, these are recent," he said curtly. "They died within the last two days, I'd guess. This green stuff must be an attempt by their killers to disguise the bodies."

Rothir moved one corpse's head from side to side before letting it drop. "They still have all their stones. So Kelvhan soldiers probably aren't responsible, because they would have removed them. I can't see any obvious wounds. What were they doing out here?"

"Spying on us," Solon said.

"Well, this one was asleep. He's lying on a bedroll, underneath the moss. His pack is here as well. Perhaps it was the stonemen themselves who were using moss for camouflage." Rothir picked up the crude canvas pack and upended it. A crumbling slab of biscuit and a waterskin slithered out. He shook the gurgling waterskin. "Still full. Looks like they made camp here and then were killed in their sleep."

"Who by?" asked Meya.

"Anyone who doesn't care for stonemen, which means half the world," retorted Parthenal. He wanted to move on. There was nothing special about dead stonemen; he'd seen hundreds on the battlefield. "Passing traders. Hunters."

"Not hunters," Veron said, as he tried to turn a second body over – with difficulty, for the vegetation seemed to have entangled it. "These men were neither stabbed nor shot. Throttled, maybe."

"By somebody who did not care about the power of their stones, or perhaps was not aware of it," commented Huldarion, "since they have not been harvested."

"At least we have a superfluity of stones ourselves," said Thoronal, with his old pomposity. "We don't need these."

"But we don't know how many darkburns we may meet in days to come," warned Uld, who was always cautious: always providing for unlikely contingencies, in Parthenal's opinion. "We can never assume we have enough protection against them. And not all our allies may have stones. We should harvest any that we find, if only to prevent our enemies from doing so."

"True," said Huldarion. He nodded to Veron, who immediately pulled out a knife and set to work on the bloody task of prising stones from the dead man's forehead.

"Only three on this one," he remarked.

"Ah," murmured Huldarion, in something almost like dismay.

Veron looked up at him. "Three not enough for you?"

"The man was low ranking," said Huldarion.

"Then they all were," said Veron, and he went back to work with his knife.

"Hurry up," muttered Parthenal, too quietly for anyone except himself to hear. The stonemen's rank was irrelevant. They were all reckless murderers – and all of them were drugged out of their heads. He wondered, not for the first time, whether he ought to try and feel some pity for them; and decided, as before, that it wasn't worth the effort. Why feel pity for such a vicious and degraded foe?

"Only two stones on that one," said Veron, straightening up; "so maybe he was a new recruit. Perhaps he – whoa! What? What the...?"

It was Yaret who shouted suddenly, "Step back! Step back! Veron, Rothir – step back!"

Rothir at once stepped back smartly. Veron tried to. But his feet seemed to be stuck although Parthenal could not tell how. Veron bent down and began to slash with his knife around his ankles.

"Cursed plant," he said, "it's got itself caught round my legs."

"I think it's wriggling," said Rothir in sharp surprise. "What is it?"

"Damned moss. It won't come away from my boots."

"Take your boots off," advised Huldarion.

Veron tried to wrench his left foot from its boot. "I can't," he said, through gritted teeth. "It won't. The stuff's drawn tight around the leather."

"I'll cut your boots off," Rothir offered. Walking over to Veron he stooped and began to saw at the heel seam – or where it ought to be, for the leather was barely visible beneath grey moss.

"Rothir!" cried Yaret urgently. "Don't stand still! Keep walking! Everyone, keep the horses moving!"

"What for?" demanded Thoronal; but Uld said sharply, "Do it. She's right."

"What?"

"It's got my horse as well." Uld's horse was struggling to lift one of its hooves, which seemed fastened to the ground.

"What's got it? What are you talking about?" said Thoronal. Parthenal thought that his cousin was being exceptionally stupid; for he himself had immediately begun to make Alda walk. His horse stamped imperiously beneath him, trampling the humble moss. Meya's carriage started to trundle away briskly as its driver flicked the reins. Meya clutched at the seat, looking gratifyingly startled.

But a few of the other horses – perhaps those that had stood still for a little longer – were unable to move freely: one leg, or two, or all, were caught by twining tendrils that would not let them go.

Uld jumped down from his saddle and drew his knife to slash at the thin stems. Although they looked frail, it seemed to be no easy task. He cursed beneath his breath – most unusually for Uld – until Ikelder too dismounted to help him.

Rothir was walking around Veron, pausing for no more than a few seconds at a time to hack at the dull growth that coiled around the hunter's ankles. Meanwhile other Riders were vainly trying to cut away the creeping fronds that snagged their horses' legs.

"Don't stand still!" commanded Huldarion, whose own horse was pacing up and down.

"I won't. But I don't know what this is. It looks so fragile; yet the stems just won't cut through," said Uld. His voice held a strained, anxious note which Parthenal had never heard before from the staid Rider.

"It's as if they're made of wire!" exclaimed Ikelder in frustration, tugging at a strand around the hock of Uld's horse. His knife made no impression on it. The narrow stems sprang back at him so that he leapt up in alarm.

Parthenal seized the reins of Rothir's horse to keep it moving as well as his own. While he walked Alda and Narba up and down on this directionless parade, he glanced round at the other Riders. He felt half ready to laugh. What could be so terrible about moss? It must give way at any minute, surely.

But on the other faces he saw tension – even fear. It was bizarre. Nothing but moss. Absurd to think that it could threaten them.

And then, as if he'd fallen without warning into a bad dream, the landscape changed, to seem a vast grey sea: a writhing ocean made of tiny snakes, determined to catch and cripple his companions. This dreadful transformation, he knew well, was only in his mind. Logic rejected it as an impossible nightmare. These were only tiny plants. Yet there Veron still stood, ensnared.

"We need to warn the rest," Huldarion said sharply. "Delgeb. Landel." At once the two Riders wheeled their horses round and hastened down the line.

"Huldarion – you yourself should move on with all speed," said Parthenal, hearing his own voice equally sharp with apprehension. "Follow Lady Meya. Don't risk getting trapped."

Huldarion raised his chin. "You mean that I should leave my men trapped here instead?" Although his tone was level, Parthenal could tell that he was angry. Huldarion blames himself, he thought, for choosing this route rather than the causeway. Although who could have known?

"You should leave now," he told Huldarion strongly. "You and everyone who can move on should do so." He glanced down to check Alda's shifting hooves. Were those tiny fronds he saw caressing them?

It was too ridiculous. No monster had caught the Vonn, no fearsome darkburn, no appalling cataclysm of fire and terror: yet caught they were, by this small creeping organism; and he felt a swiftly surging panic lest they should all be trapped and suffocated here – just as the four dead stonemen had been.

"This isn't working," Veron said tersely. He was tugging at the strands that were now knotted round his ankles, tight against the boots, and seemed to be creeping up his shins. "Wolf and bear and lion have I fought and killed, and then this – this damned lichen – is to pull me down!"

"It won't," said Rothir. "We won't let it."

"Veron," said Yaret, her voice quiet, "I can call the huntress."

Veron looked up at her with blazing eyes. "No."

"But she would–"

"No. I shall not call her, and you must not either. This is not her realm. I will not have her endangered too."

"These plants are something quite unnatural," said Rothir, breathless with effort. Straightening up, he once more walked around Veron, and checked his own boots before stooping down again, this time taking out his flint and tinderbox. Parthenal saw the flame flicker and die as Rothir held it to the plant. It would not catch.

"We need Leor," declared Huldarion. "Where is he? *Leor!*" he bellowed, with a fierceness shocking in someone who always showed restraint. The shout was repeated down the line, a diminishing set of echoes of "*Leor! Leor! Leor!*" growing fainter until they disappeared. But there was no sign of the wizard.

"I'll go and find him," offered Parthenal, already wheeling Alda round. Yet to his frustration he could not hurry. The pitted ground appeared designed to slow and trip his horse; so that what had been previously a mere annoyance now seemed actively malignant.

Nearly all the Riders in the line were now tramping on at Huldarion's command. He rode past them, calling out for Leor.

"Show yourself!" he shouted. "*Leor!*" Could the wizard have concealed himself with magic? It would not be for the first time. He looked for the priest's cart, where Durba had reported seeing him.

He couldn't pick it out. But, to his relief, he glimpsed the familiar beacon of red hair, with its two long streaks of white, atop Leor's lanky frame on his equally lanky horse. The wizard was being led by Tamu, the little Kelvhan archivist, who looked uncomfortable on a restless

pony. Exactly why Tamu had left the dusty library of the castle to ride out with the Vonn was not clear to Parthenal; nor did it matter now.

"Tamu said somebody was calling me," said Leor reluctantly.

"Everyone was calling you. Come, quickly!" Up the line they rode, with Tamu's pony following, seemingly against its rider's wishes. Rapidly Parthenal explained the situation.

Leor sighed. "Wizardry, you think? So therefore I must understand it? You expect me to counteract this plant?"

"If you cannot, then no-one can," Parthenal answered grimly.

They arrived at the slowly shuffling circle of Riders that surrounded Veron and the four dead stonemen, moving round as if in some obscure religious ritual. Huldarion was still there, to Parthenal's dismay, although his horse was moving freely. Five horses were rooted to the spot, their vainly twitching limbs and rolling eyes betraying their growing panic. One whinnied with a high anxious note and set the others neighing in distress.

Unlike the horses, Veron showed no panic, even though the grey stems were now wrapped tight around his lower legs. Parthenal thought he saw minute new tendrils uncurling as he watched. Rothir still worked to unprise them from the hunter's feet.

Meanwhile Veron was slicing at his breeches with his knife; but the plants must have worked their way right through the fabric, for even where the cloth was ripped away, the clinging stalks were fastened leech-like to his skin.

There was a single twitch at the corner of Veron's mouth when he looked up and said, "If you can't free me from this, Leor, you'll have to cut my legs off."

For a second, Parthenal assumed that he was joking. But then he realised that Veron was deadly serious. Nausea rose in his throat.

"You wouldn't survive that," said Yaret, nudging Poda to make the horse keep moving.

"Why not? You did," Veron retorted.

"Barely," she said. "And that was one leg only."

"Leor – what can we do?" demanded Solon, turning to the wizard. "Tell us now." Everyone turned to Leor, gazing expectantly at his gaunt face.

"How should I know? I don't even know what sort of plant this is," said Leor. "I haven't come this way for years. Everything has changed."

"Surely you have more to say than that!"

"The Farwth could do the same as this strange plant," said Rothir, without pausing in his work. "In Farwithiel we saw dead stonemen trapped by vines."

"Maybe, but that doesn't help me," said Leor. "This is not the work of the Farwth."

"Obviously." Rothir, impatient, straightened up before walking round Veron and bending down again. "But it's equally obviously done by some magic power."

"Why is this the only plant that thrives here?" said Ikelder. "Has it strangled all the others? And has it captured human beings before?"

"How would I know?" said Leor irritably.

"You know who's done this, Leor," said Huldarion sternly. "Therefore you ought to understand how it was achieved; and how it can be undone."

"I am not Adon," said Leor.

"Stars alive!" exclaimed Rothir. He stood still for a moment to glower at the wizard. "Do you mean you're not even prepared to try?"

"If that's the case," said Solon coldly, "we'll see how immortal you really are, Leor. Will your head reattach itself to your shoulders, do you think?" He half-drew his sword with an angry hiss.

Was Solon play-acting? Parthenal, startled, couldn't tell. The whole situation seemed unreal. He realised with another lurch of his stomach that Solon was looking truly murderous.

Huldarion put out a restraining hand until his counsellor reluctantly let the sword slide with a metallic whisper back into its sheath.

"Don't kill Leor until after you've killed me," said Veron harshly. "Yaret's right. I won't survive losing both my legs, and I wouldn't want to. You'll have to kill me soon, if this stuff gets much higher. It's not letting go. It's digging in. You do it, Rothir."

"Veron," said Yaret.

He glared at her. "No. Call the huntress afterwards, once you're well away from here. Tell her how it happened."

"Veron," said Yaret. There was a break in her voice.

"Leor," said Huldarion, turning to the wizard, "to you our lives are fleeting and our deaths mean little, but by the long friendship between you and our people, I beg you to try what you can do."

"Your deaths mean little?" said Leor, staring. "They don't mean little."

"Do something, man," growled Rothir. "Not to try is worse than failure."

"Just give me time to think..." Leor tapped his long hands against his temples. "I want to help, believe me. But I don't even know what this plant is called. I have nothing to hang a spell on. I need a name."

"Brienot," said Tamu unexpectedly. The little archivist sat nervously on his twitchy mare, which was constantly in motion without his urging. He looked as if he would much prefer to be elsewhere.

"The plant's called Brienot. I've seen it listed in an old botanical dictionary. Unique to eastern Kelvha. Related to clover but with a tiny greyish leaf. Doesn't usually catch people. At least the dictionary didn't mention that." He spoke in a breathless rush and then stared at the ground.

"Brienot," repeated Leor. "Like clover, did you say? Let me see." He began to move his lips, trying out unspoken words.

"Be quick," said Solon grimly.

"But I need to be careful!" objected Leor.

"Just do it," Huldarion commanded.

Leor muttered gruffly into his beard. "No, no, that's no good," he mumbled.

"Try it anyway!"

"I will count to ten," said Solon; and once more he drew his sword with a snarling rasp of steel. Although Solon was a man who more often showed his displeasure through sarcasm than open rage, he was implacable once angered. In battle he was strong and merciless. With another wave of nausea Parthenal thought that Solon might actually carry out his threat.

And what would that mean for the Riders? For them to kill the wizard, their long-standing ally? He felt that they stood on the brink of some unknown but terrible land.

"Wait," commanded Huldarion levelly. Such iron authority. Solon, gripping his sword, sat rigid in the saddle as if held against his will. "That will not help. And Leor would throw you to the floor before your sword could touch him."

"Indeed I would," said Leor, although without conviction. He licked his lips and began to mutter again. "*Anaga loth brienot, anada loeth halesrath*—" No, that's still not right."

"You need to hurry," warned Rothir, tugging at the creeping strands that now encircled Veron's legs more than half way to his knees. Veron's face was set like ice.

"*Halesraka*," said Tamu unexpectedly. "It's proto-Ondial, isn't it? *To wither*."

"Is it?" said Leor blankly. "I know it's very ancient. I'm dredging this up from the depths of my memory. What's *blight*?"

"The verb or the noun?"

"For stars' sake," said Solon. The sword twitched.

"Noun."

"*Oflega*," said Tamu.

"Of course is it." Leor began to recite again, this time with more confidence. The strange words flowed from him with growing resonance as if they took on their own power. He turned to face Uld's horse, which had begun to whinny desperately.

"*Halesraka ne oflega brienot digana fror*," Leor intoned in a deep voice, stretching out his hand. His eyes were half closed. His hollow-cheeked face looked hungrily intent.

But Solon growled, "It's not working. If Veron dies I really will take your head off your shoulders, Leor, regardless of whether it can fix itself back on."

The wizard threw back his red hair and looked up at the sky. So did Parthenal, although he saw nothing there but low menacing clouds.

"Well?" said Solon. He raised his sword.

"Oh," said Durba. "Listen. Listen."

Then Parthenal became aware of a thin sound, directionless and faint: a crackling, a soft popping as if invisible rain were falling on dry leaves. But there was no rain.

"Ah," said Veron, and now there was a change in his voice. "It's tightening."

Uld's horse quivered as it tried and failed to rear up. Then it began to scream. It was a dreadful shuddering burst of agony and terror such as Parthenal had only heard amidst the clamour of the battlefield.

Solon swung his sword around his head. Parthenal did not know whether he meant to use it on Leor or Veron. What was happening? What was this nightmare? For a moment of paralytic horror he knew he was about to see one of his friends die at another's hand.

"No," said Ikelder firmly, striding in front of Leor. Parthenal knew he ought to join him. Yet he felt powerless.

Rothir, crouching by the hunter, said abruptly, "Wait. They're breaking."

For a dreadful moment Parthenal thought he meant Veron's bones. But Rothir added, "The stems are breaking." He tugged at a tendril that bound Veron's foot. The hunter gasped. But the grey stems shuddered into fragments.

Veron reached down and with shaking hands began to strip the clutching stalks from his other leg, peeling them away in brittle sections like dead ivy from a tree. The remaining cloth of his breeches came away with them: beneath, the skin was streaked dark red.

Then the air was full of a thousand whispers. The very ground appeared to shiver, as the plants collapsed and gently withered, shrinking down almost to nothing. Uld's horse finally succeeded in freeing itself: it reared up, its legs bleeding from long wounds. Landing heavily, it began to kick and screamed again before charging off across the plain.

"Come; you're nearly free, Veron," said Rothir encouragingly, pulling off more crumbling tendrils.

Veron was shuddering. As the last stems fell away, it seemed he would have fallen too, if Rothir had not held him up; and it took a very great deal, thought Parthenal, to make Veron fall.

"Bear him to the Lady Meya's carriage," said Huldarion. "And then let us depart from this cursed land without delay."

Parthenal, no longer paralysed, and ashamed of his inaction, sprang down from Alda. He helped Rothir to lift the half-fainting man up into Narba's saddle, and held him in place while Rothir mounted behind him.

"At least Narba's used to this," he said.

Veron made no sound. His face was taut and his eyes closed while the stolid horse began to walk. Beyond the thudding of the hooves whispered thousands of faint rustling voices, as the

clinging stalks dried up and turned to dust. The ground no longer held even the smallest hint of green. It had turned dull brown as far as Parthenal could see.

No-one spoke as the horses trampled through a landscape that now appeared completely dead: a desert of dusty, sterile earth. The air smelt stale and ancient.

But there was green on the horizon – that low line of trees. Parthenal fixed his gaze on them, praying they would stay green until the Riders reached them.

Closer they crept, and closer, and still the line of trees stood tall, unchanging, thank the stars; so there was a boundary to this stricken land. Of course there was. Even though it seemed far wider than he had remembered, like all lands – and like all horrors – it must have an end at last.

Yet still no-one spoke. As if they feared to break some spell, they concentrated on keeping the unhappy horses moving steadily. Parthenal felt as he had stood on a precipice while it began to crumble underfoot. Why had he done nothing? He glanced across at Solon and at Leor, both glowering. How could so small a thing have threatened to alter all their lives so quickly?

But Huldarion is unscathed, he thought; for which I'm thankful. As for Veron, he's as tough as boiled leather armour. He'll soon recover.

When he looked back, the line of sombre Riders and their carriages was like a phantom train. It travelled through a ghostly cloud of dust that swirled languidly, aimlessly, around them, in great sweeping arcs of haze.

"Is that what you meant to do, Leor?" said Yaret at last.

The wizard frowned at her. "It worked, didn't it?"

"It worked. I just hope it didn't work everywhere as well as here. What if brienot is growing harmlessly elsewhere? Will it die? What about clover? Will that all wither too?" She did not sound accusing, merely thoughtful.

Leor did not reply for several seconds. Then he said heavily, "Magic always has consequences."

"That is true of every type of power," she said.

"But you had to do it," said Rothir. "Regardless of the consequences."

"Yes. Yes, I did." Leor looked almost majestic, lifting his head as if he'd just discovered some new unguessed ascendancy within himself.

"It's lucky Tamu knew the words you needed," Yaret said, deflating him again.

Parthenal looked round once more: this time for Tamu, who was trying to stop his wayward horse from prancing sideways. Head down, shoulders hunched, as Parthenal gazed at him the archivist looked up straight into his eyes. Tamu's lips parted for a second before he closed them and hurriedly stared down again.

It was the glance of an instant; but Parthenal recognised that fleeting look. He had seen it many times, on other faces. It made him feel – if not delight, for Tamu was not his type at all – then a certain reassurance. As if he was being nudged awake from a dark dream, he felt relief at this welcome signal of normality. Life was as it should be, after all. He was conscious even of a frisson of mild pleasure; for it was always pleasant to be wanted.

And never really a surprise. Aha, he thought, smiling inwardly as he rode on towards the trees: Tamu, our little nervous friend, I think I know your secret now.

Chapter 3

"I expect you may be left with scars," said Meya to Veron, who was lying prone within her carriage, "but no lasting damage. The wounds look superficial. There is hardly any blood."

She was aware that she sounded more peremptory than sympathetic. She did not like Veron – an uncouth man who paid little heed to ceremony, appearing wholly unaware of the respect due to her rank – and beyond that, she was afraid of him.

It was not a pleasant feeling. Meya was not given to unnecessary fear and did not care to admit her unease even to herself. But Veron made her wary. Even now, while lying safely disabled on the comfortable couch within her carriage, the huntsman eyed her as a not-too-hungry wolf might eye a goose.

However, I'm no goose, she thought, except perhaps in stubbornness; and in protective fierceness where my offspring is concerned. In defence of my own daughter I would fight off any wolf.

The thought of Aliya brought that familiar surge of love, so close to pain. She turned to Shebel, the Riders' herb-mistress who was waiting by her side, and told her, "You may as well try that moss of yours, now that we have stopped for the night."

On her other side Huldarion looked on, his face showing as much concern as she had ever seen on it. Meya was learning to read that lean scarred face despite its immobility. She both resented and admired the solicitude he showed for his wounded Rider. Her own father, the esteemed General Borovin of Kelvha, had instilled in her the importance of attending to one's inferiors.

Carefully Shebel began to apply poultices of dampened star-moss to Veron's legs: the network of red oozing weals ran from the man's knees down and round his shins.

A primitive treatment, Meya thought, no better than a folk remedy used out of habit and desperation. But then my salves have not succeeded in soothing the inflammation or lessening the pain.

Watching Shebel's deft, skilled hands at work, she conceded to herself that she felt like an imposter in offering to tend the wounded man. It was true that she had nursed her mother prior to her death, and had treated many castle servants for more minor ailments; yet that made her no doctor.

However, Meya would never acknowledge such a failing aloud, even though she now found herself with nothing to offer but advice. And she would offer that to Veron whether he wanted it or not, because it made the loftiness of her position clear.

"You need to keep yourself still," she instructed him. "No riding until your legs are healed. Drink plenty of water, and keep your body cool. You may have the use of this carriage for as long as you require." She resigned herself to using her smaller, second carriage: a travelling-coach with narrow seats and space for luggage, not designed for comfortable sleeping, although it was where Janeya currently slept in the guise of her maidservant.

Instead, Janeya would have to sleep on the ground with the women Riders. It was a lot to ask of such a high-born lady – even one who had disgraced herself as Janeya had – but the girl would not complain. She was still too wrapped up in mourning her lost footman.

Meya felt some pity for her, but not a great deal, because Janeya's pain was self-inflicted and only in her mind. For all her dislike she felt more pity for Veron, whose physical pain was evident. Despite her reassurances she knew his wounds were of a nature outside her experience.

Tough as an iron cable, she thought, for he uttered not a single moan while Shebel tended to his red-streaked legs; but the tension in his face betrayed him.

"No bandages," he said in a weak rasp.

"Really?" said Shebel. "Then I shall leave your legs loosely dressed, just enough to keep the star-moss in place." Her soft voice held compassion. From Veron, no response except a faint twitch of the jaw. Meya remembered that Uld's horse, along with four others, had had to be put down in its increasing agony, which had not abated but had rather grown throughout the day, despite the plants' removal and the attempts of the wizard to alleviate the pain. His magic spells had done nothing for them or for Veron.

Huldarion leaned over the couch. "I have painkilling drugs that you can take," he said.

Veron shook his head. "I'm not a stoneman." His voice was barely there.

"I know that. I do not mean the Athelid the stonemen use; only ethlon. If you don't care for that, I have a medicine from Farwithiel called belvane, which is not addictive as ethlon is. It is not as strong either, but it serves to take the edge off." Meya was reminded that Huldarion himself was an expert in enduring pain; he only occasionally allowed himself the minimum of medication to dull the throb and pull of his twelve-year-old burns.

After a few seconds Veron nodded. Huldarion reached under the folds of his cloak and brought out a vial. He raised Veron's head with a gentle hand, so that Meya immediately felt excluded. Such tenderness, for such an uncouth man!

"I will have food and water sent in to you," she said, and parted the curtain to step out of the carriage. Outside, several Riders and a pair of shaggy huntsmen were waiting for news.

"How is he?" Delgeb asked.

"He is in pain," said Meya haughtily. She did not particularly care for Delgeb, any more than for Veron, and for similar reasons. A senior Rider she might be; but she lacked respect. She was loud and even pushy. Most unfeminine.

I too am pushy, an inner voice informed her.

But I am never loud, Meya corrected it swiftly. Or hardly ever. Only when needful. And I am of the highest rank of Kelvha and soon to be the queen of all these Riders. They should remember it.

So, adopting her most queenly manner, she announced, "The King is with Veron and is advising him on medicines for the pain."

"The King!" said Delgeb. "He is not that yet."

"It sounds strange to hear him called so," commented Maeneb, who stood apart from the others. She could hardly talk of being strange, thought Meya; with her remote air and clipped speech Maeneb was, for all her beauty, one of the oddest women Meya had ever met... apart from the Lady Gaelera, with whom Maeneb had mysteriously become friendly back in Kelvha Castle. That unlikely friendship had filled Meya with a faint disquiet.

"Are we to ride on?" The query was from Piril. She was as bad as the rest. For a mere servant-girl to speak so bluntly to her, with no *If it please my lady...*

Meya felt a second's outrage, and had to subdue it. For was she not responsible for Piril's presence? Had she not arranged the escape of Piril and Janeya from the castle? If Piril no longer regarded herself as a lowly maidservant, Meya had only herself to blame. Perhaps she should have left the girl to suffer whatever punishment the Post-Regent might have chosen for her.

But no. That would not be right. Although she had no knowledge of what Nerogun got up to in his dungeons she was sure that it would not agree with her own ideas of justice.

So she swallowed her resentment and told Piril, "The army is to ride on with all speed, now that we have reached this more salubrious country." They had left the desert of dust behind them, crossing woodland to reach an area of normal if unpopulated pastures.

"How will Veron travel?" This was one of the huntsmen, a wild-looking fellow.

"In my carriage," answered Meya haughtily. "I have offered it for his use. I myself will leave you for a little while, and travel in my other coach to fetch my daughter."

"Not alone, surely," Delgeb said.

"Certainly not. There will be a driver. And the King – the Lord Huldarion, I should say – has allotted me four Riders to accompany me on the journey. Perhaps you could be so good as to summon them, Delgeb, for they are not all familiar to me. Rothir I believe I know. But Ikelder I do not; nor the Lady Camburé, although I am informed she is a sister of the Lady Tiburé. The fourth is Lady Tiburé's daughter, the Lady Alburé, whom I have met before."

"We will send them here to you," said Delgeb with a bow. These female Riders did not curtsy, only bowed, an aberration of which Meya did not approve.

Maeneb bowed likewise. As the pair of them strode away in their unbecoming fashion, the others followed, the huntsmen trooping off reluctantly. Only Piril paused, and then dropped her a deep curtsy.

"My lady," she said. Well. That was better. "My lady, I will go with you as your maidservant, if you so desire."

"Thank you, Piril. But I need no servant for this short journey, and my daughter Aliya has her own nursemaid. It's better that you should stay here with your mistress – I mean, your fellow-maid Jebil, who must now leave my second carriage. She may need looking after. I shall go and speak to her now." Meya thought it was fortunate that there was no-one around who could have overheard her slip. Although several of the female Riders of the Vonn were aware of Jebil's true identity, the male Riders were not.

And Huldarion was not. Meya did not like this secret that she had to keep from him. But if Lady Janeya's identity should somehow be discovered – which the stars forbid – it must be provable that he was not complicit.

Piril bowed, dropped another curtsy, and then both frowned and smiled in confusion.

"A curtsy will suffice, my girl," said Meya, conscious of her own magnanimity. No doubt Piril was trying her best in difficult circumstances; which was more than Janeya was doing.

When she entered her second carriage Janeya – now called Jebil – was in the luggage area at the back, crying again. Was the girl made of water? Her eyes were so red, her skin so blotched, her hair scraped back so unattractively that she was unrecognisable as the lively, high-born lady who once graced the dancing-hall of Kelvha Castle.

The one Huldarion should have chosen as his wife, thought Meya, before she sternly rebuked herself. Huldarion chose me, and he was right to do so. I shall prove that he was right... So long as I can be faithful to both him and Kelvha.

She stood still for an instant, caught in that thought, before addressing the weeping girl.

"Janeya, my dear. You are to join the ranks of Vonnish women for a while. This carriage is needed, for I am to go and fetch my daughter. You know that she is staying in the household of your relatives? Your uncle Melegan's family?"

Janeya raised her blotchy face. "You told me Melegan is out of favour now," she said dully.

"Sadly so. But while I'm there I can sound out his relations, the Lord and Lady Hapligran; and perhaps I can learn where some suitable refuge may be found for you."

Janeya shook her head. "I want no refuge," she murmured, "except in the grave with Lorolo."

"My dear Janeya," said Meya bracingly, "we don't know that Lorolo is in the grave." However, there was a fairly good chance of it, she thought. "Now gather your things. Piril will look after you." Moved to pity by the girl's wretched appearance, she moved forward to give her a brief, affectionate hug. Janeya succumbed but did not respond, so she stepped back again.

As Janeya mutely gathered up her bundles, Meya reflected that she certainly needed looking after. Piril would do that, as she had done for years... until she had betrayed her mistress.

Was Piril trustworthy? Well, she had also helped to save Janeya. And anyway the two of them would soon be gone – within a day or two, she hoped, once she had learnt where the Lord and Lady Hapligan would be retreating to. As Melegan's relatives, they would probably seek obscurity in some far-flung corner of the Kelvhan dominions, but that very obscurity meant the girls would be as safe with them as anywhere.

She hustled Janeya with her belongings out of the carriage and towards the camp of female Riders just in time: for as she returned Huldarion came striding up to her. Her heart began to beat a little faster. Why was that?

It is this secret that I have to keep, she thought. How angry would he be to learn it? I am teaching myself to read his countenance, but I do not know the tenor of his mind. And yet I've lain with that scarred, strong, able body... Perhaps the body means more to me than the man does.

That was a disconcerting thought. Meya curtsied low to hide her face in case it showed her guilt.

"No need for that," said Huldarion, a little as she had just spoken to Piril. "I wonder if I ought to come with you when you go to fetch your daughter?"

"There is no need for that either," she replied, raising her head. "You've given me four Riders. Why do you think you ought to come as well?"

He swept his arm back. "Because of what just happened on the march out of Kelvha. Because of the trap that was laid for us."

Meya was startled. "Was that a trap? Was it not simply... some malign but random magic? Nobody could have guessed beforehand that you would choose to leave the causeway and cross that stretch of land."

"So I would have thought," he answered gravely. "We did not decide on that direction until the night before. I had considered that if any attack were to be made, it would be more likely on the causeway, where there are large areas of cover. I did not expect an ambush on that open, empty ground."

"Yet you were ambushed," she said. "And by a weed."

"By sorcery. Which means that we were watched. Those dead stonemen that we saw may, I suppose, have been the spies, who then were felled by their own weapon – or rather, by Adon's." Huldarion sighed. "I hoped we might be free of spies once we'd left Kelvha. But now I must assume the opposite. We must be on our guard at all times."

"Do you think Aliya may be at risk?" she asked anxiously.

"I was thinking more of you," he said.

"Oh, don't worry about me. I can look after myself."

"But I would rather look after you, my dear." He was standing close to her, so close that she could scent that strange faint odour of his body, both alien and attractive; which brought a disconcerting rush of memories of their bed. He took her hand.

Meya was alarmed. What was the meaning of this unnecessary gallantry? Although she had pledged to marry Huldarion, that was purely a political decision for both of them, was it not? The bedding had been an unexpected shock of pleasure; but this pretence at romance was not needed. And if it was not mere pretence – well, she needed the real thing even less.

"The men and women you have allocated to protect me will do that task ably for you," she said, smiling, "and here they are now." The arrival of the four Riders gave her an excuse to withdraw her hand from his.

The mere sight of Rothir, she thought, stern, broad and shaggy, should induce any lurking stonemen to run away immediately. The man beside him, thinner and awkward in his movements, with a crooked smile, was, she guessed, the promising young captain Ikelder.

Alburé – a handsome girl – appeared fittingly lofty and ladylike. The other woman, sadly, did not. This, presumably, was Camburé: faded and plain-faced, in an equally plain gown, she looked no more distinguished than a housekeeper of the middle tier. Meya suppressed a sigh at the thought of how far she was from the grandeur of Kelvha Castle.

“Ladies, please to accompany me in my carriage,” she said graciously. “The gentlemen shall ride. Shall we be gone without delay? I long to see my child.”

Even as she uttered the last sentence she wished it had been left unsaid. It sounded too dramatic, although it was true indeed – her longing for Aliya was a constant physical ache, the sense of her daughter’s nearness like a punch to the heart; yet that was exactly why she wished she had stayed silent. She had exposed herself.

And there was another worry. As the ladies settled in the cramped seats of the enclosed front section of the carriage, Meya found that various fears kept pushing forward in her mind. How was Aliya? Would her daughter be ready to leave at such short notice? For the sake of secrecy, no messenger had been sent ahead: they were not expected. How quickly could the nursemaid pack?

Outweighing all these was the worst fear of all. How well would Aliya remember her? Her child was only five, and it was a full two months since the last of Meya’s all too short, infrequent visits. Would Aliya even want to go away with her? What if her daughter cried?

This was so dismaying a prospect that Meya found herself barely able to make conversation as they swayed and jolted over the rough terrain in the rattling carriage. Her companions were no help; Alburé seemed lost in gloomy thought, while her drab aunt Camburé made a few mundane observations that required little answer.

“The countryside must be a lovely place for your daughter to grow up.”

“Yes, indeed, a very healthy place,” said Meya.

“And I understand she is to stay for a while on Olbeth’s farm. Also a very healthy, pleasant place. I am sure that she will like that too.”

“I trust so,” Meya answered coolly.

But that brought another worry. What sort of farm would this Olbeth woman have? Would it be suitable? What sort of person would she be? Peering out of the side window she saw Rothir’s forbidding countenance as he rode watchfully along. Would Olbeth be as grim and unprepossessing as her brother? What should Meya do if her child were to be made unhappy?

It seemed an endless journey to the tidy fields and orchards of the Hapligan estate. By the time the carriage rattled up the tree-lined driveway to the long low manor-house, her mind was a whirlpool of love and longing mixed with apprehension. When she saw three carts parked up outside the colonnaded entrance, the apprehension grew.

The carts were half loaded with bedsteads, chests and boxes. More boxes, with clothes spilling from them, stood piled haphazardly nearby. A wicker hamper had shed its load of linen, which had been trampled in the mud: but no people were in sight to rescue it. What was happening here? Why was no-one coming out to meet them? Where was Hapligan?

As her carriage pulled up she did not wait for its door to be opened for her. The wheels had barely stopped when she rose from her seat and jumped out. It was undignified, but Meya did not care. One over-powering question pounded through her head, drowning out all others: *Where is my daughter?*

Chapter 4

She ran past the silent carts and under the colonnade, and was two yards from the door when suddenly it opened. Unable to halt in time, she collided with the person in the doorway.

It was not Lord Hapligran. It was his steward, a normally staid man who was now looking as wild and flustered as Meya felt.

"Oh, my lady! I'm so glad to see you. We sent word to Kelvha Castle – but I don't know if it reached you – the household is to be entirely broken up! My Lord and Lady Hapligran have already left, first thing yesterday morning–"

"What?"

"–because they did not think it safe to stay, and it seems that they were right, for a squad of guards came here a few hours later looking for them, and we had to say we did not know where they had gone, which was no less than the truth–"

"Where is my daughter?" asked Meya. She seemed hardly able to speak, even to breathe.

"My lord and lady urged Flodda to go too, and take Lady Aliya, but she refused. I did not know what you would want, my lady. I did not know what to advise. So they left without her and headed north with speed, but that is all I know of where they went, I told the guards so!" The man was agitated, pulling at his waistcoat distractedly as if trying to tear it to bits.

"But my daughter," said Meya urgently. "My daughter."

"She is still here, my lady."

The ability to breathe returned. "Unharmed? The guards did not ask after her? They did not look for her?"

"Well, my lady... I implied – I let them think that Lady Aliya had gone with my Lord and Lady Hapligran. When the guards marched through the house hunting for my lord and lady, in case I was lying, which I would never do, Flodda kept her in the kitchens and pretended she was her own daughter." The man began to clench his hands together in unconscious supplication. "I hope we did right. The guards did not seem to be seeking Lady Aliya in particular. They gave orders for the whole household to be dismantled, and the property loaded on the carts and driven to Kelvha City. So we have begun that task. I would have brought the Lady Aliya to the Castle with us."

"Let me see her," said Meya, sweeping into the house.

So the low-born nursemaid had pretended Aliya was her daughter! Meya did not know whether to feel more grateful or annoyed. She was grateful, of course. Of course she was. But the cheek of it! Flodda, the daughter of bootmakers in the slums of the northern quarter, to pretend she was Aliya's mother!

If I am ungrateful, thought Meya as she hurried down the corridor past a litter of crates and packing-boxes, it is because I am afraid. Not particularly of Nerogun's men. I can deal with them. What I fear most is that Aliya will love Flodda more than she loves me. That she will see Flodda as her truer mother.

Now she was at the door to Aliya's room. It stood ajar: the room was empty, stripped bare of clothes, of toys, of Aliya's books, of all her things. Where was her daughter?

"Mama!"

She spun around.

"Mama! Will you tell Flodda I don't like this dress? I want to wear my proper dress!" Aliya stood in the passage, almost unrecognisable as the child she had last seen two months ago.

"Oh, Aliya!" Relief made her feel faint as she swept her daughter into her arms and hugged her tightly. Aliya hugged her back for a heart-warming second or two before she pulled away.

"And I don't like my hair," she said. "It's horrid. It hurts. Will you tell Flodda to do my proper hair?"

Meya held her daughter at arm's length to study her. She wore a peasant's dowdy smock, plain brown and slightly grubby: her hair was tied in two long braids tightly fastened back behind her head. She looked like a scullery maid – a very small one.

"Oh, Ma'am," said Flodda, who now came scurrying up the passage, "Oh, Ma'am, I did it for the best, believe me. When we heard the soldiers were on their way, ma'am, I was so afraid – I've kept her dressed like this and by my side at all times, in my room or in the kitchens, Ma'am, since my Lord and Lady left, for safety's sake."

"I hate this dress," said Aliya with a pout.

Meya felt a swift, heavy wave of emotion; love and exasperation and annoyance. Being a mother was so tiring. Every time she was away from her child she forgot how exhausting it was, and every time she returned, a few minutes with Aliya reminded her. "Aliya," she said, "you were in danger, not bad danger, but Flodda kept you safe. Say thank you to her."

"Thank you," said Aliya, turning round to curtsy to Flodda – which she did very prettily, although the mousy little maid did not even smile. Indeed Flodda looked tense and drawn. A scared mouse. Or perhaps some sort of weasel, Meya thought, in looks if not in character. A little fangol in a pinafore.

"I am very grateful to you, Flodda," she said formally. "I have come here with some Riders of the Vonn to convey you both to somewhere safer. How long will it take for you to pack?"

"Ma'am, our belongings are gathered, safe in the cold store, if there is someone who can carry them."

"We can do that." It was a deeper voice: Ikelder, who now came down the passage with the steward. "My Lady Aliya." He bowed, and again Aliya dropped a curtsy – this time a more formal and rather over-elaborate one. She must have been practising. Meya felt another surge of slightly exasperated love and pride.

"Then let us be gone as soon as we may," she said. She took Aliya's soft, self-willed little hand and led her out, leaving Flodda to direct the Rider about baggage.

The two female Riders still sat inside the carriage. Rothir stood by it, watching the sky.

"Star-gazing?" she said sarcastically, to hide her own flurries of anxiety.

"Something just flew overhead," he said thoughtfully; "something very high, but not a bird."

"Ikelder may need help with the luggage," she said pointedly, and he nodded and strode towards the house.

"He didn't bow," said Aliya, turning to watch him.

"Not everybody needs to bow to you," said Meya as she opened the carriage's side door.

"My Lady Camburé, my Lady Alburé, may I present my daughter?"

Aliya curtseyed, with enormous gravity. And Camburé came unexpectedly to life.

"Well!" she exclaimed. "Lady Aliya! How very enjoyable to meet you. And have you any little friends around your person: any kittens hiding in your hair, or puppies tucked into your pocket?"

"No," said Aliya, but her dignity was slipping.

"No butterflies resting in your handkerchief? No baby piglets in your bonnet?"

"There wouldn't be room," said Aliya, with a giggle in her voice, and then she turned to Meya. "Mama? Can we bring the ducks?"

"No, my dear. There will be ducks where we are going, and other animals too."

"Ah!" said Camburé. "Ducks don't like moving house, or rather, moving pond. But at the farm where we will stay, the piglets will be waiting for you, in a squeaking row, their little tails all wagging in delight."

There was a definite giggle as Aliya was helped into the carriage and wedged herself between the two Vonnish ladies.

"Our ducks here have had seventeen ducklings, and I have given them all names," Aliya announced. And when Camburé asked what those names were, she began to reel them off. Silly names. She was probably making them up on the spot. What a nonsensical conversation, Meya thought, as she directed the two male Riders and the steward where to stow the bags and boxes in the rear section of the carriage. But at least Camburé's ridiculous chatter saved her from having to reassure Aliya.

She herself was not given to talking nonsense. Once they had set off again, with the nursemaid Flodda perched atop the baggage in the back, Meya made a point of interjecting through Camburé's tale of seventeen ducklings and a naughty orange fox.

"Sit straight and still, my dear." For Aliya was bouncing in her seat.

"Yes, mama."

"Try not to play with your hair like that."

"It's not my proper hair," Aliya said.

"You have braids like a little milkmaid," Camburé told her. "Or perhaps a little swine-girl – if only they were curlier, to match your piglet's tails."

Aliya giggled some more. Meya was outraged. What was all this talk of pigs in reference to her daughter? It was most unseemly. Not only that; she felt herself undermined by Camburé's gentle banter. Meanwhile Alburé was almost silent.

Yet Aliya seemed content, and was fully occupied as the carriage trundled away, completely ignoring the disappearance of her previous home and instead demanding to know more about the naughty orange fox; so that Meya had to admit that Huldarion had perhaps chosen Camburé to accompany her with good reason.

I am not a happy-humoured mother, she thought, a little dismally. I have no sense of fun. But her confidence almost instantly reasserted itself: was she not taking the utmost care of her daughter? It was not a sense of fun that enabled her to do so – it was her authority and rank. So she sat back in the seat opposite the others and listened to Camburé and Aliya rattling away as fast as the carriage wheels, exchanging ludicrous ideas about where baby ducks could live and how they could escape a rather stupid and entirely mannerless fox.

Rothir appeared at the carriage window.

"My Lady Meya," he said tersely, "There is a troop of Kelvhan soldiers up ahead, advancing presently at speed to meet us."

"So?" she responded, almost as severe as he was himself.

"May I suggest your daughter could be hidden underneath the seat?"

Meya opened her mouth to protest. What could there be to fear from a troop of Kelvhan soldiers? Both her father and her late husband – stalwart commanders within the Kelvhan army – would have been appalled at the idea.

"As a precaution, my lady," added Rothir.

Meya's heart began to thud alarmingly. She was suddenly reminded that things in Kelvha were not as they used to be: that everything was moving, changing, and not necessarily for the better: that Melegan and his connections were now all out of favour, and that a squad of guards had already been sent to hunt for his relations – to what ends she was not sure. Although Kelvha and the Vonn were allies she knew that everything was now in flux.

"Aliya," she said with some urgency, "could you lie underneath that seat, behind the ladies' skirts?"

"I'm sure a nimble little thing like you will squeeze in there in no time," said Camburé quite calmly, shifting her heavy skirts aside. Aliya was disconcertingly ready to jump to the floor and wriggle underneath the padded wooden seat.

"While you're there," said Camburé, speaking to her skirts as she rearranged them, "I'd like you to decide which is your favourite duckling in the story, and what you think should happen next."

Meya opened her mouth to protest. What time was this to be talking about ducklings?

But Aliya's voice said, "Nemalotti!" and Camburé answered, "Yes, she's my favourite too. Now, think about your story without making any noise, my little piglet. No snuffling, no grunting, no digging for truffles under there."

There was a small snort and then Aliya was silent.

And now Meya was aware of the thudding of many hooves ahead – and all too soon, around her on all sides – as the carriage drew to a stop.

"What is the matter?" asked Alburé in a loud, clear, haughty voice. "Why have we stopped? Oh! Good afternoon, captain." For a Kelvhan soldier had appeared at the carriage window; and there were more mounted soldiers on the other side.

"My lady." The Kelvhan addressed only Meya, not the others.

"Captain," she said with a smile, because she recognised him – his name escaped her, for he was low-born, but a useful warrior, she knew that much. "My cordial greetings to you and your men. What can I do for you?"

"My lady," he repeated, and then seemed to hesitate.

"Let me out of this carriage," said Meya immediately, and although she was perfectly capable of doing it herself she waited for him to open the carriage door and help her out. Rothir stood by, his hand not on his sword hilt but very near it: he sensed danger then, as she did herself. Ikelder stood close to the troop of soldiers, in a more casual posture, although a very still one, like a wound-up spring waiting to be released. She was aware that two or three soldiers had dismounted to peer into the back of the carriage. They ordered the nursemaid out and then ignored her while they turned bags over and looked behind them.

"What is it, Captain?" she asked their leader once she stood before him. He was a tough, wiry man who appeared middle-aged but was younger than his face suggested: a man aged by battle, as her husband had been. He was a combatant, she knew, and not a diplomat.

So, she thought, they have sent an able fighter here to meet me. Why?

No, I know why. More importantly – who sent him?

She motioned imperiously to Rothir to step back a little. With a slight bow, he obeyed.

"Whatever the problem is, you may speak plainly to me," she told the captain, keeping her voice low and as warm as she knew how. "These Vonn cannot hear us just at the moment. You know, my father General Borovin valued you most highly." This was likely to be true, and her father had been a hugely respected figure in the army in his heyday; but she wished she could remember the man's name. A strange name, she knew – but what was it?

"My lady." He was troubled, she could tell. "My lady, may I ask whence you have come, and what your errand was?"

He knew, of course. So she shook out her skirts, dispelling the creases, as she answered.

"I have just been to the country estate of the Lord and Lady Hapligan; where for almost two years now my daughter – the General's grand-child – has been housed for her health. I hoped to bring her away with me; but regrettably I was too late."

"Too late, my lady?" He was watchful.

"Lord and Lady Hapligan had already left, early yesterday, and had taken my child with them. The steward did not know where; they had not told him. That they went north was all he knew – at least, they set out in that direction, but they may have turned aside since then." She gazed at him fully now, allowing her real anxiety to show. "I am sure my child is safe, but all the same... I know that Lord and Lady Hapligan have recently undergone... misfortune."

I imagine that you and your men might be on your way there now, to ensure their safe passage to another area."

He said nothing. She nodded slowly.

"I understand," she said. "They departed in a hurry and left many of her things behind. I have them in the carriage. Whatever Lord and Lady Hapligan's mistake may have been, my five year old daughter could have had no part in it. I trust that when you find them, you will bring her safely back to me." She took a deep breath and looked at him appealingly. "Aliya was the General's only grand-child."

"My lady," said the captain. She read no friendliness in that deep-etched face, but no hostility either. "May I ask why you have not set out in pursuit of Lord and Lady Hapligan and your daughter?"

"I intend to do so," she said simply, "as soon as possible. As you can see, I have but two Riders of the Vonn with me: two ladies of the Vonn as my companions: a driver, and a maid. We are hardly equipped for a swift pursuit. But I have no doubt that as soon as I report this situation to the Lord Huldarion of the Vonn he will provide me with as many men as I require."

The Kelvhan captain looked across at Rothir: an assessing, wary look. Yes, she thought, these Vonn were feared.

Rothir, in his turn, seemed to take the look as a signal to step forward.

"Captain," he said, his low voice rumbling, "I believe I saw you defeat my companion Aretor – Lord Aretor – in the castle combats."

"You did, my Lord," the captain said. "And you were the man who fought the tiger."

"Indeed."

"I trust you suffered no lasting injury."

"Nothing to speak of, I thank you," said Rothir. The man has no rank beyond his military one, thought Meya in automatic irritation, you need not thank him! Let alone offer him your hand – for that was what Rothir was now doing.

"Rothir," he said.

"Novesnu," said the captain, grasping the hand in his own. Of course: that was it, she remembered now. An outlandish name.

Rothir bowed. Too much honour altogether, she thought – but it seemed to do no harm. For when the captain turned back to her, his face had gained decision.

"My Lady Meya," he said, "I am glad to see you in such capable hands. You need not ask the Lord Huldarion for his assistance. When we find my Lord and Lady Hapligan – as I am sure we shall, wherever they may be – I will vouch for the safety of your child, the late General's granddaughter. May I hand you back into your carriage?"

She accepted his hand graciously. While she was stepping in, he had a good look around the carriage's interior. The two Vonn ladies gazed back at him; Alburé with one eyebrow coolly raised, Camburé with mild indifference.

"Ladies," he said, with a faint question in his voice, so that Meya immediately felt afraid that he was going to ask them to rise from their seats.

"We appreciate your attendance on us, captain," said Alburé with lofty dignity. "Lord Huldarion will be most gratified to hear of the respectful interest you take in our well-being; as will my father, his chief counsellor, Lord Solon." She spoke with such astonishingly quelling superiority that Meya felt that she herself could not have outdone her in aristocratic hauteur.

"Ladies," he repeated, but this time Meya heard resignation in his tone. He would not dare to risk insulting these high Vonnish gentlewomen by asking them to jump up at his bidding.

"I thank you also, Captain Novesnu," she said swiftly. "I know that I can trust you, as my father did."

"Your daughter's welfare is of great importance to me," he replied soberly. "I wish her well." Did his eyes dart towards the seat where Aliya lay hidden? If only the child could remain so still and silent just a minute longer...

"And if you find her, you will send word to me?"

"I will, at once, my lady Meya."

"Please convey my gratitude to Lord Nerogun." By this, she hoped to learn if it had indeed been Nerogun, or someone else, who had sent this troop to find her.

But the man's face betrayed nothing beyond a flicker of the eyelids. "My lady, I bid you a safe journey."

He withdrew. She heard him exchange words with the other soldiers: they had found some children's clothing in the bags, but nothing else of note. The little mouselike maid had not been thought worth questioning, beyond a curt demand of who the clothes belonged to? They had not even asked whose maid she was.

Then at a word of command the hoofbeats started up again. Meya listened to their diminishing percussion as the carriage resumed its slow grinding trundle. Nobody within it moved, except that Camburé coughed, and twitched her skirts a little.

Meya felt as if she were frozen in her place. Dared she speak to Aliya yet? Dared she now? Still she sat, through long unchanging moment after moment, until Rothir rode up beside the window.

"They are gone," he said. Yet she still felt frozen. She knew and did not want to know that they had come to find her child.

"Any little piglets under the seat may come out now," said Camburé conversationally, as she moved her skirts aside, "and we can talk about those ducklings."

With a rustling scrabble Aliya emerged from underneath the seat. She looked subdued and downcast. "I don't want to talk about the ducklings any more," she said.

"Come and sit my me, my child," said Meya, and Aliya moved to her side of the carriage. She leaned over and laid her little head on Meya's bosom and wrapped her arms around her waist. Meya settled her on the seat and stroked her ugly braided hair and held her gently. The thing in all the world most precious to her. She felt dazed, shattered. "You did well, my dear," she said. Aliya did not answer.

Her most beloved child. This was the moment she had yearned for, had dreamt of for so long: the moment when she should drive away with her daughter clinging to her, the little hands gripped tightly to her cloak; the small warm body snuggling against hers: but not like this, no, not like this at all.

Chapter 5

"Hold still," said Yaret. She laid a restraining hand on Veron's shoulder as he tried to raise himself from the couch inside Meya's ornate carriage. He was too weak to push against her. It seemed an odd reversal of a former time, on the midnight streets of Kelvha City, when he had seized her and dragged her down an alley. On that occasion she'd been helpless in Veron's iron grip: but now he was the helpless one.

"You wriggle like a restless child," said Shebel to him in courteous rebuke. "Does it hurt?"

A silly question, thought Yaret. Of course it hurt. The belvane that Huldarion had given Veron had had a minimal effect. She could tell that, not by any complaints he made, but by his face, gripped tight in pain. But she understood that pain was not the reason why Veron was trying to move.

"I know you want to be up and on your feet," she told him, her hand still firmly on his shoulder, "because you don't like being held down: but truly, you'll heal faster with the star-moss kept in place."

"I doubt it," said Veron, his dark gaze snapping from one woman to the other.

"Why do you doubt it?" asked Shebel. Her tone was soft; and, to Yaret's ear, ever so slightly patronising.

"Never needed it before," Veron retorted. It was true that where the brienot had spared his legs, they were laced with old scars: some, at a guess, where he'd been gored by boar-tusks, and one appeared to be a vicious wolf-bite, while others less identifiable were no less cruel.

"You aren't going anywhere for a while. Lay still," commanded Shebel in her velvet tones.

"For a little longer," added Yaret. "Until Lady Meya returns, at least." She sympathised with him, suspecting that it was not the star-moss he resented – or even the necessity of succumbing to Shebel's orders – but rather the fact that he had to do so in a Kelvhan lady's carriage and on her fine embroidered bed.

However, now there came the rumble of another carriage drawing close to theirs. She heard Rothir's voice with a faint but definite feeling of relief. They were safely back, then. Although there was no reason at all why they should not have been.

She heard the other carriage door open and the passengers descend. Meya's voice spoke, so quietly that it was barely audible. "Rothir, I wish as few people as possible to know that my daughter has arrived."

"I'm afraid a lot of people will have guessed," said Rothir. "They knew the purpose of your journey."

"None the less. Let them think that I was unsuccessful."

Yaret stuck her head out of the carriage's front awning. Meya frowned up at her.

"Can Veron be moved from there?" she asked.

"Better not just yet," said Yaret, "although he'd be delighted to be free of Shebel's ministrations."

A small figure with tightly plaited hair was climbing down from Meya's carriage. She looked about her solemnly, and then stared up at Yaret, who raised one hand in greeting. The child studied her and fingered her drab dun skirt as if wondering whether to curtsy, before she decided against it. Instead she rubbed her hands up and down her legs.

"I hurt my knee, mama, under that seat," she said. "But I didn't make a single noise, did I?"

"You did very well," Meya assured her, with a faint throb in her voice which Yaret had not heard before. "And now, Aliya, it is time for you to meet the Lord Huldarion, who will be King of the Vonn, and who is so kindly looking after us."

Nothing about her marrying him, Yaret noted – as doubtless did Huldarion himself, now striding towards them. But one thing at a time, she thought. First, the child had to meet Huldarion, and that was bad enough: for who could look on that dreadfully scarred face without flinching?

Aliya, however, did not flinch. She studied Huldarion as she had Yaret, with a faint frown, appearing to accept the scars. Then she whispered loudly to her mother, “Does he know who I am?”

“My dear,” said Meya with slight asperity, “he knows exactly who you are. And as I told you, not everybody needs to bow to you.”

Aliya evidently decided to remedy this omission with her own elaborate curtsy, so deep that she gave a wobble before recovering herself with massive dignity. “I am pleased to meet you, my Lord Odarion.”

Huldarion bowed stiffly, as was his wont, and held out his hand – the unscarred one. Aliya did not take it. Instead she turned and clung to her mother’s skirt, saying with a sob in her voice, “Mama, I’m tired and I’m hungry, and I want Flodda to put me on my proper dress!”

Yaret stepped fully out into the open. Up on the driver’s platform she swept her own bow, a more flourishing one than Huldarion’s.

“My Lady Aliya,” she said, “we hope this comfortable carriage will soon become available to you. The problem is, it already has an occupant whom we can’t kick out just yet – a renowned wolf-hunter who now lies wounded on the bed after being attacked by a fiendish magic plant. And that is entirely the truth,” she added, noticing Aliya’s eyes narrow, “and you may come and see him if you wish.”

Aliya needed no prompting. At once she released her mother’s skirt. Ignoring Meya’s attempt to restrain her, she scrambled up into the larger carriage, pushed aside the awning and surveyed Veron as he lay on the couch surveying her in turn. He had thrown off the coverings again and Shebel was tutting as she replaced the dislodged star-moss.

“Are you a famous wolf-hunter?” Aliya demanded.

“I am,” said Veron, with something of a snarl.

The snarl did not deter Aliya. “And have you been attacked by a magic plant?”

“He has indeed,” said Shebel.

Aliya sat down on the edge of the couch and inspected Veron’s half-covered shins. “A magic plant,” she said thoughtfully. “Hmm. It looks very red. If it was really magic I think you ought to see a wizard.”

“We have a wizard around somewhere,” said Yaret, “but I have to say he hasn’t been a great deal of use so far.”

Aliya settled herself more comfortably on the end of the couch. “When I feel ill, I like my maid to tell me a story,” she said to Veron, who gazed at her with a faintly appalled expression. “So I am going to tell you a story, Mr Wolfman, but you have to lie still and listen. It will make you feel better.” She looked up at Yaret. “You may bring my bags in now,” she said.

“Oh no,” said Veron. He looked more disconcerted than Yaret had ever seen him.

“Oh yes,” said Yaret, and retreated. As she climbed down from the carriage she heard Aliya’s voice.

“I said, lie still and listen. I am going to tell you a story about some ducklings and a naughty orange fox – no; I mean a naughty purple wolf.”

Veron’s voice rumbled, too muffled for the words to be distinct.

“This one is purple,” said Aliya, more clearly, and severely.

Yaret walked over to Rothir who was handing bags down from the back of Meya’s carriage to Camburé and a small maid who looked half-starved. As this servant put the last bag down, she turned and addressed Meya with nervous boldness.

"Ma'am, if you please, if it pleases you – if Aliya's presence is to be kept secret, perhaps I could keep her by me as if she were my own child, ma'am, as I did at the Lord Haplignan's."

"An excellent idea," put in Yaret, seeing from Meya's thunderous expression that she was about to disagree.

"Indeed, it would seem politic," said Cambur .

Meya's mouth opened and closed again, before she said, barely opening her lips,

"Perhaps, then, Flodda, for a day or two. Just until she arrives at the farm where she is to stay."

"It would be a wise precaution," said Huldarion gently. Meya did not look at him.

"Am I to accompany her there also, ma'am?" asked the nursemaid.

"I expect so, Flodda. Yes." Meya's reply was barely audible.

"We can explain the necessity to Aliya," said Yaret. "She seems like a bright child." She turned to Flodda. "Have you knowledge of herbalism?"

"A little, ma'am."

"Then you can be an army medic for the time being," she suggested to the nursemaid. "You could stay in this carriage, perhaps, in pretence of tending the wounded man who currently lies there. In fact, you could usefully tend to him in earnest, if he will allow you. Aliya could stay with you, in the rear section, as if she were your daughter, while her true mother is in this neighbouring carriage."

"Indeed, that arrangement will do until we reach the farm, my dear," said Huldarion.

Meya sighed. "She'll complain about her hair," she said a little dully.

"Good," said Yaret, "if it means that she complains of nothing worse. I expect she has a great deal to worry about just now, but let her pretend it's only clothes and hair and it'll be easier for her to cope with."

Meya drew herself up as if to retort sharply – probably along the lines, Yaret predicted, of *Pretend? How can you pretend to understand my child?* But then she merely sighed again and nodded resignedly.

"We will move on to the farm as soon as may be," said Huldarion.

"What, this whole army?" Meya asked.

"This is only half our army: the other active Riders of the Vonn will be already mustering at Olbeth's farm. It's an important source of stores for us – the only one in this area, in fact, since Bruilde's farm is gone. So there the whole army will load up with provisions."

"Then let us leave as soon as possible," said Meya somewhat sadly.

"I will give the orders to move on," replied Huldarion gently. He paused, looking at her as if he wished to say more. But she did not even glance at him before he walked away.

The bags that had been unloaded from the back of one carriage were hoicked up into the other. Meya and the subdued nursemaid climbed in. Lucky Veron, thought Yaret; she had no doubt that if he'd had the strength, he would have leapt out of the bed and made a swift escape.

She turned to Rothir. "Why the need for secrecy about Aliya?"

"A troop of soldiers stopped us on the way back here. I'm sure they were checking for her presence." He was looking grave.

"But why? She's five! Surely not even Nerogun could wish harm on a five year old child."

Rothir shook his head. "It's not the child herself that counts," he said. "It's the possibility of using her – whether for ransom or negotiation. She's a lever. And I'm not totally convinced that it was Nerogun who sent those soldiers."

"Why? Who else commands the Kelvhan soldiers?" Then she caught at the memory of a face; one she had seen after the battle in the northern Outland Forts. Old, sharp, grey-bearded, wily. "You mean Shargun? The Arch-Lord Marshal?"

"And nominal head of the Kelvhan army. Possibly. Actually I don't know who I mean. That's half the problem. When we reach the farm, will you come with me to meet Olbeth?"

"Oh," said Yaret, taken aback. "Me? I mean, yes, of course I will – but she doesn't know me. With so many hundreds of Riders, surely there are old friends she'd rather meet."

"Plenty of time for all that. We'll be there for a few days. I think you'll like her," said Rothir.

"Well... I hope she will like me." Whilst she was not generally made shy by unfamiliar company, Yaret felt herself becoming anxious at the prospect of meeting Rothir's sister. Yet there was no sane reason why that should be.

There was an insane reason, of course. But she was schooling herself to understand that Rothir did not think of her that way. So it was an unwelcome jolt to be made aware that despite her frequent sensible self-admonitions, she still thought of him with more than simple friendship.

That was something she would have to change. It would not be easy. And she felt the necessity for it as a kind of grief. She told herself, severely, that she had far greater causes for unhappiness. How could she place the deaths of all her countrymen on a lower tier than her own self-centred longings?

It is because I am alone, she thought, that I cling to this desire for closeness with Rothir. But the ones that I have lost, and the few I left behind, must not be forgotten. They must come first, always.

Chapter 6

The following day, when she set eyes on the farm, a far worse anxiety than meeting Olbeth laid hold of Yaret.

It was the smoke that did it. Two burnt fields and the black stumps of a coppice told the story. Even though the farmhouse and its out-buildings appeared to be undamaged, the lingering smell of smoke had already made her throat close up and her mind begin to fill with an inescapable swirl of images. Streets inhabited by ashen corpses, the drifting hazy pall above the only thing that stirred... The finding of Obandiro rushed back at her so strongly that for a moment she could neither move nor speak.

"We had word of this," said Rothir. They had paused their horses to gaze down into the valley a half mile away. He was frowning but not discomposed. "They were attacked a week ago, by about two dozen stonemen; and one darkburn."

Yaret sat still and looked. He probably thought her quite unmoved, when in truth the ability to move was gone. All her brain would see were shattered houses, greyly silent streets: and in the ash, small, lonely footprints.

She tried to focus as Rothir continued matter-of-factly.

"Huldarion had already left men to protect our supply base here, and more had turned up prior to the muster. So the stonemen were easily overcome. No injuries apart from minor burns. Olbeth had some stones for protection, of course, so the darkburn couldn't get near the house. When it tried to run off, the surviving stonemen caught it up and herded it away; which makes me think they may have used up more darkburns than they'd like, if they're now trying to conserve them."

"Good," said Yaret, her voice a croak.

He turned to her. "Are you all right?"

"Mmm." In a moment they would have to cross that scorched terrain. She felt that had she been on foot she could never have forced her legs to walk down past those empty smoking spaces. And that was stupid, for had she not been in far worse places than this one, and seen worse sights? This was only a burnt field or two.

It is because I've seen such sights, she told herself, that this one floors me now.

But Poda followed Narba in any case. Yaret sat rigid on the regal horse while they approached the farmhouse. Her dead no longer stood behind her shoulder: she felt them ranged along the roadside. Although they did not look at her, she was conscious of a sense of deep reproach. Why? What could she have done?

Maybe that was just her sense of shame at surviving the onslaught of the darkburns on her town. No; shame not at surviving it – but rather at not experiencing it. She had not been there. She had escaped the fires, the slaughter, the destruction. Shame on her.

She glanced around and saw among the other Riders Sashel, looking sombre. Did he feel as she did? Did he too tremble at the smell of smoke and feel the presence of the dead? Did his brother rise before him? No way of knowing.

Not just him, she thought. All the Riders must have dreadful moments in their memories. Yet as they drew close to the farm she found that her anxiety receded, the real scene gradually taking over from the one that haunted her imagination.

Like and yet unlike: the memory of her grandparents' ruined small-holding faded under this more solid view. Olbeth's farmhouse was not as tall as her grandparents' home, nor as narrow: its single storey of limed plaster had wide jutting arms that embraced a cobbled yard hemmed in with sheds and barns. The crops in the surrounding fields, unburnt, appeared to thrive: she saw sweetroot and bristling barley. Would the barley be growing in Obandiro?

Yaret switched her gaze to the tents that marked the upward slope behind the farmhouse. There were a lot – at least a hundred tents, she guessed, with figures walking busily between them, and horses grazing round the edges.

So that was Thield. The city of the exiled Vonn, which according to Rothir moved constantly, to avoid attack: and which now found itself established by this sprawl of sheds. An incongruous setting.

“Where is the Kelvhan army?”

“Still a dozen miles behind us,” said Rothir. “They won’t bother coming closer. Not grand enough for the Kelvhan High Lords – even in the house. Especially not inside the house. I don’t think Prince Faldron would appreciate being put up on a farm.”

“But it’s a big farm. All those barns.”

“True. It has its own forge: that dark stone building on the left, at the end of the track,” said Rothir, a note of wistful longing in his voice.

“Theol told me that you were a blacksmith. And that you made your own sword. The Kelvhan blacksmith – Martun – admired it, so he said.”

“Did he? I don’t remember,” said Rothir. “If so, it was very kind of Martun. In truth, I lack practice. And he wouldn’t think our forge was very grand compared to his, against the castle walls.”

“Well, let’s hope this place is grand enough for Meya to let her daughter stay. How do you think Olbeth and her husband will take to their new charge?”

“Oh, they’ll be fine. It’s Aliya herself who may not be so happy.”

“We’ll soon find out,” she said.

For they were through the open gates now. Yaret noted that those gates looked as if they were never closed, judging by the long grass that grew around them. A peaceful place then, normally. As their horses rode into the yard with a clatter of hooves on cobbles, she saw Meya and Huldarion being greeted by a tall man with deepset eyes and a curling smile.

“That’s Olbeth’s husband, Wiln,” said Rothir.

Although Yaret could not hear Wiln’s words, she could see how stiffly Meya responded. Her head half turned to look behind her before she jerked it back to face the front. Then she was led into the house.

She wants her daughter, thought Yaret, and cannot publicly acknowledge her. But Aliya and her nursemaid were not far behind; for they trotted alongside the stretcher on which Veron was now being carried into the yard. Two of his huntsmen hefted it while Veron shifted restlessly.

Seeing Yaret, he raised a hand to beckon her. Even that small movement appeared to be a major effort. When Yaret and Rothir walked up to him, the sweat was glistening on his face.

“Is the pain worse?” she asked.

He did not answer that. Instead he flapped his hand at Flodda, saying hoarsely, “She’s no use. Send her off. You come.”

“Actually, I need to go with my lady Meya in any case,” said Flodda with breathless eagerness. She grasped Aliya’s hand and hurried off as if she couldn’t wait to get away, dragging Aliya with her.

“What about Shebel?” Yaret asked Veron.

He shook his head. “No. You.”

“Bring him in,” said Rothir to the huntsmen.

They carried Veron in through a porch and past a guard of two great shaggy hunting dogs with watchful eyes and waving tails, whom Rothir greeted with a brief caress. The porch led straight into a large gathering-hall, its fireplace glowing a warm welcome which Veron turned his face away from. There was a continuous bustle of people filling the place with noise: Riders

and farmhands, most carrying packs and sacks, and trundling barrels across the flagstoned floor.

"Calenir! Are you all mended now?" Rothir stopped to talk to one young man. The stretcher-bearers and Yaret pushed on through the crowd, until a compact, dark-haired woman appeared.

"This way," she said. She led them to the far end of the hall and through a doorway, out of the bustle and into the sudden peace of a wide wood-panelled corridor, which held many other doors. Windowless and softly lit by oil-lamps, its brown shadows seemed at odds with the brightness of the spring outside. Yet it also felt very solid and protected and reminded Yaret of the earth-houses of the Uin-Buin.

At the woman's direction the two huntsmen carried Veron down the corridor and through the last of its doors into a small room with a single window. The sill was two feet deep, indicating how impenetrably thick the house's walls must be. As the stretcher-bearers carefully laid Veron upon the bed, Yaret walked over to the window to inspect the view. A shed: a corner of a straw-strewn yard: the track that led to the smithy; and beyond all these, wide rolling pastures where ruddy long-haired cattle grazed.

It made her homesick. She had to remind herself that home was no home now; that she was here to play her tiny part in trying to give Obandiro a future.

So do your tiny part as best you can, she thought. Pay attention. The grazing on those fields looked better than Obandiro's; much better than the blighted lands which they had recently passed through. When she turned to address the other woman her mind was running on that barren country.

"Do you grow clover here?"

The young woman stopped in the act of adjusting Veron's pillows, which she had been doing in a manner both gentle and efficient. Her dark gaze was acute.

"Clover? We have some in those meadows. It keeps them green. Occasionally we sow it, but more often it propagates itself."

"Does it thrive, these last few days?"

Veron laughed with a short, fierce, desperate-sounding rasp, while the woman said in some amusement, "I believe it does. The fields look lush enough, at any rate. I'll ask my husband Wiln to check when next he's out there."

"Oh! So you're Olbeth?" Yaret, disconcerted, attempted to explain. "It's just that the plant that wounded Veron was a relative of clover called brienot, but with its nature altered, probably by magic. When Leor cast a spell to wither up the brienot I wondered if it might have withered up the clover too – if the magic spread that far... the two species being akin, you see." What a fool I must sound, she thought ruefully, babbling about clover at such a time.

"It would be interesting to know how wide the spell's effect might be," said Olbeth. "But it seems not to have come this far. No, lie down, Veron. You need to rest." When she laid a hand upon his shoulder he struggled against it, attempting to lever himself off the bed.

"I don't want to rest!"

"But she's right, you must," said Edrik, one of the stretcher bearers; a grizzled man whose normally stoical face bore an unusually worried expression.

"Don't tell me what to do!" Veron's voice was harsh, if weak. He tried to push Olbeth away. "I've had enough of lying down. D'you think I–"

He stopped, for someone else was entering the room: a much smaller person, who put one hand on her hip and pointed an accusing finger at him.

"Get back into your bed, Mr Wolfman," Aliya said, "and don't you dare get up until I say."

Veron remained where he was; not quite in the bed, but not out of it either. Aliya made a small, perfunctory curtsey to Olbeth.

"I'm afraid he's quite naughty," she said. "You have to keep an eye on him. I've been telling him stories but he doesn't listen properly. He wriggles. Have you got any medicine for him?"

"I'm going to find it in a minute," Olbeth assured her.

"Good. And he needs food."

"My Lady Aliya!" Her nursemaid appeared in the doorway, looking abject and flustered. "Please, come back with me now! I'm so sorry sir, sir, ma'am, ma'am, sir." She addressed everyone in the small room in turn.

"I'll come with you later, Flodda," said Aliya imperiously. "Right now I have things to do." She turned back to Olbeth. "I'm going to the kitchen. I need to order the wolfman something to eat. Will your cook know how to make tumbled eggs?"

"If you mean scrambled eggs," said Olbeth courteously, "then yes. At least, I know how to make them. I myself am the cook, as well as the lady of the household."

"Oh! You are a lady?" Aliya looked surprised.

"Broadly speaking," Olbeth said.

After a moment's thought Aliya made another, slightly deeper curtsy. "You might not know it," she said, "but that person there" – she pointed to Yaret – "is a lady too although she does not look it. I'm afraid she doesn't have the proper clothes."

Olbeth turned to look again at Yaret, who bowed. "I am Yaretkoro," she said.

"I thought you might be. I'm very glad to meet you," said Olbeth, her eyes alight.

"Eggs," said Aliya firmly. "I want three eggs. Do you have any duck eggs? Because they are the best."

"You can check whether our ducks have laid this morning," answered Olbeth. "I'll show you and your nursemaid the way, before I go and find the medicine. And I also need to check if my baby has woken from his nap."

"A baby? Hmm," said Aliya, as if deciding whether to approve or not. "All right. Flodda, come along." She gave Veron a warning look. "But you stay there," she told him. "I don't want any nonsense from you."

As soon as the two women and the child had left the room, Veron began to struggle out of bed again.

"You'd better do as she says, and lie down," said Yaret, wondering if she dared to try and force him. It would not take much force to hold him down. But it would take considerable courage. And I have not as much courage as a five year old, she thought; or at least, Veron will not hold back from me as he does from Aliya.

He paused now, sitting on the edge of the bed, but she suspected it was only to try and gather enough strength to move again. When Edrik took his arm he shook it off abruptly. But he himself was almost shaking. Tremors ran through his body.

"Lie down for a few moments," advised Yaret. "Rest, and wait for Olbeth to return. There's nowhere else for you to go in any case."

He closed his eyes. "Can't endure..."

She waited, almost in anguish herself. How could she allay the pain? What ought she to do?

"Can't endure another of her stories," said Veron huskily.

"She's trying to take control," said Yaret, "because she doesn't understand what's going on. Bear with her." She risked putting an arm around the hunter's shoulders to encourage him to once again lie down. She could feel his heartbeat, way too fast, too forceful, pulsing through his fevered body. His muscles, hard as wood, were quivering.

But at least he didn't shake her off. What he needed was distraction: Aliya had unwittingly provided that.

"I take it you don't have children of your own?" she asked as she tried to ease him back against the pillows.

"Ach. No." He let himself be laid back, slowly, rigidly. "Huntress," he added after a few seconds. "Before."

"So the huntress has had children? Were they all girls?" she said, wondering *and were they leopard cubs or human infants?* Maybe they were interchangeable, as the huntress was herself. But that was not something she could ask.

"Don't know. Never met." Veron's speech was jerky.

"Well, listening to Aliya's stories will be good practice for when you have your own."

The hunter merely grimaced and plucked at the sheet that was covering his legs. "Off."

"You want it off your legs?"

"Heavy." He seemed to be too weak to remove it himself. When she obeyed, his legs looked worse than before: the weals were higher, darker, fiercer, deeper. It frightened her.

Veron sighed. "Might have to cut my legs off after all," he said in a single outward breath, and then in the next, "Can't be worse than this." He spoke as if speech hurt him. His lips were very pale.

"Do you want me to find Shebel?" she asked. "Do you want ethlon?"

"No." Veron paused and closed his eyes. "Maybe."

"I'll see if I can find her. Stay here. Don't try to get up. You stay here too," she told the pair of huntsmen, Edrik and Aurok, giving them a look full of meaning. Both seemed cowed, almost scared, if such a thing were possible for such tough men. She doubted their ability to keep Veron – whom they regarded as their unquestioned lord and master – in place against his will.

But the huntsmen were in unfamiliar territory here. And so was she, as far as medical matters were concerned. As she hobbled down the shadowed corridor, she wondered if she ought in fact to call the huntress. Was Veron's condition bad enough? How bad was bad enough? Quite apart from the pain that he was suffering – and that must be extreme – his wounds alarmed her. They were not healing, but increasing. Poison? Or malignant magic? Ethlon might dull the pain. It would not cure the cause.

Would the huntress be able to do more? She rolled the name, extremely carefully, around her head. *Unsaryun*. She saw within her mind those ice-blue eyes; that heavy body wrought of fur and muscle, of speed and ruthless strength. She sensed the cold air of the mountains, sharp peaks wreathed in freezing mist.

But this was not the huntress's territory. And it was not up to Yaret to summon her: Veron would have to do that for himself. So she did not speak the name aloud.

"Rothir!" she called out, when she glimpsed him talking in the busy hall. "Rothir, I need you!"

He immediately switched all his attention to her, and strode over. "What is it?"

"Veron. He's bad. I'm going to find Shebel. Can you help guard him? He keeps trying to get up. Those two huntsmen won't dare stop him, but you will."

"Whether I can is another matter," said Rothir, but he went off at once towards Veron's room. As she hurried through the hall, and out across the cobbles of the front court past the ranks of carts, Yaret felt slightly sick. A familiar feeling; but familiar from where? That time when Rothir had sent her riding on her own towards the craggy thumb, while he protected Eled from approaching stonemen.

This was quite different. But a sick man's life was still at stake. Such a responsibility. She passed a row of barns, and following the muddy trail of hooves and wheel-ruts, ran up the slope – her leg complaining – until she reached the town of tents so oddly planted on the hillside, like clumped bushes. The tents were bigger than she'd thought: each would comfortably house a dozen men.

But she did not know where to find Shebel in this newly mushroomed town. So she resorted to calling her name repeatedly, like some frantic bird, until Delgeb stuck her head out of a nearby tent.

"What do you want Shebel for?"

"Veron. Where is she?"

Delgeb shrugged. "No idea. Will anybody else do?"

"Anyone with ethlon," said Yaret.

"Parthenal!" yelled Delgeb, with extraordinary loudness, and Parthenal at once appeared from a neighbouring tent. "Veron needs ethlon."

He nodded. "All right. I have some. Let me get it."

"I'll go and look for Shebel meanwhile," offered Delgeb. "I'll send her to you." She hurried off.

Parthenal re-emerged from his tent and strode with Yaret down the hill. While she told him of Veron's condition he nodded, apparently unmoved, until they entered the yard.

Then he said reflectively, "Well! Doesn't seem a minute since the last time I was here. Always liked the place."

"Last time?"

"Winterfest. Olbeth puts on a good feast. Rothir was a bit down, as I remember – not that it's always easy to tell, with him – but the rest of us had a fine time. Sashel and Gordal were there."

"I never knew Gordal."

"Larger than life. He filled a room." They walked into the smoky hall, Parthenal gazing around with a furrowed brow. "And still here. I feel as if that loud voice of his is about to boom out some bad joke. He could be standing just behind me."

"The dead do that," said Yaret. "It's not quite a haunting; it's just that they don't leave." Sometimes she was fully conscious of her own dead, sometimes not. They faded in and out of her awareness. But they never disappeared entirely.

Hurrying to Veron's room they found the two hunters standing by the door as if on guard, while Rothir sat on the bed hugging Veron in an unyielding embrace. Veron looked both furious and exhausted: he struggled in Rothir's grip, and then subsided as Parthenal came over.

"You may as well sit still," Parthenal advised, "or I won't be able to give you any ethlon."

"And I won't be able to put this salve on your legs." Olbeth entered, carrying a plate of scrambled eggs in one hand and a stoneware jar in the other. "Wiln is keeping Aliya away," she said. "He's taken her on a tour of the animals. I'm glad you're here, Parthenal. Have you brought ethlon? Use that first, I think."

Parthenal sat down on the bed beside Veron and took a vial from his upper pocket.

"Three drops," he said, dribbling them between the pale lips.

Veron sat still embraced by Rothir, with his eyes closed. A minute later he opened his eyes again and said, "No good."

"Give it a little longer." Parthenal's voice was unusually tender. He could be so gentle, thought Yaret, when ministering to the sick or injured. Not much tenderness was evident at other times.

Veron gave the shadow of a nod and allowed Rothir to lay him down. Voices called casually outside: hooves scuffed on the cobbles: inside the chamber, all were silent, until Veron spoke again.

"No good."

Shebel came in and Parthenal addressed her. "He's had three drops of ethlon. No effect."

"I have belvane here," said Shebel in her cool, considered way. "You had that before, Veron; did it not help a little?"

"No," said Veron. "No good. Just cut my legs off." It occurred to Yaret with a dreadful jolt that he wasn't joking. She saw how Rothir's face drew taut and grim.

He would take that responsibility on himself, she thought. But nobody should have to do it. And even if it could be done without tremendous pain and trauma, even if Veron survived, the most determined hunter cannot hunt without his legs. I have one wooden leg, not two; and I can barely run. Veron would surely rather die.

She felt her own muscles pull as tight as the sick man's – her pulse race as hard and fast. There had to be a better cure than this.

"There is one other thing that I can give you," said Shebel, sounding a little less collected than before. "I have it here." Taking a small canister from her bag, she carefully uncorked it. "Only... I've never tried it on a patient. Except for one man, and he did not live long afterwards."

"Hah!" It was no more than a sigh from Veron.

"He died because I gave him far too much. I didn't know the dose. It quelled his pain, but it killed him within hours. He was a captive stoneman: and this paste is Athelid."

Yaret caught her breath. Athelid. The drug that the stonemen took daily to relieve the agony of their stones. If it could make a man forget he had stones drilled into his skull, surely it could work on Veron's legs? But only if Shebel got the dosage right.

"No!" objected Parthenal. "You still don't know the right amount – to say nothing of the side-effects. We can only guess from the stonemen's behaviour that they aren't good."

"What do you think?" Rothir asked Veron. The hunter's face twitched.

"Try," he muttered.

"A few grains only," said Shebel. She prised a tiny morsel of whitish paste from the canister on to a wooden spatula and wrinkled her forehead at it. "Well, here goes," she said.

Veron closed his eyes as she put the spatula to his lips. His jaw worked: they waited for another long moment. Somewhere outside a dog howled, long and plaintive.

Veron's eyes reopened. He looked different. Alert.

"Let me go," he commanded. Rothir released him cautiously. The hunter sat upright on the bed and looked around at his audience with a scowl. When he pushed the sheet aside his movements were quick and decided.

"Better?" said Shebel.

"Better," said Veron.

"Good. Can I just–"

"No," said Veron. "You're done here. Get out. Well? What are you staring at? You think I'm a travelling show? Get out of here, the lot of you!"

"We just need to check that you're not–"

"Out!" roared Veron. The croak had vanished. "I've had enough of being prodded and peered at! Leave me alone! And where are all my knives?" He felt around his belt. "Have you stolen them?"

"Narduk has them," answered Edrik, looking startled. "He'll keep them safe until you–"

"Narduk? That joker? Bring them to me!" snapped Veron. "And now, the rest of you, get out!"

Olbeth motioned to the others that they ought to leave. When she began to pull the sheet over Veron's legs, he whipped it aside, wrenching it from her hands so violently that Yaret was suddenly afraid.

"Veron," said Olbeth firmly, "you are our guest here on the farm. Stay inside this room."

She put the plate of eggs down next to him, withdrew swiftly behind the others and closed the door. An instant later there was the crashing thud of crockery being hurled against it.

Olbeth leaned on the door, her face grave. "This room has no lock," she said quietly. "Parthenal and Rothir: stay here, please, until I can get a couple of men to replace you. Also I think you huntsmen should go outside and stand guard by his window. Don't let him out. And on no account should you let him have his knives."

Chapter 7

"He'll need another dose tomorrow," warned Yaret. "How many more doses do you think you've got?"

"At the rate I gave it to him? At least fifty," replied Shebel.

"So if he has it twice a day, like the stonemen do, that's enough for three weeks. Four at most."

"Maybe. But I can't keep feeding him Athelid twice a day!" protested Shebel.

"I agree," said Olbeth in her low, calm voice.

"Why not? It worked," said Maeneb. "The pain has almost gone." Veron's pain had been growing steadily until then, as she had been increasingly and uncomfortably aware. It was strange to sense anything emanating from Veron. Usually all that she could gather of his feelings was a kind of fierce excitement. The pain had been a coil of burning tightness, impossible to ignore. Its absence was a vast relief to her.

The four women were sitting at the end of the long table in the firelit hall, which was temporarily empty of other people. All baggage had now been unloaded and the bearers had dispersed. The only sound in the room was the faint crackle in the great hearth: a sound from winter.

Maeneb recalled the last time she had been here, in this very seat, during winterfest. That had been a happy occasion, she supposed – for most, if not for her; although she herself hadn't found it as dreadful as she had expected. She had almost felt that she belonged.

But this was very far from winterfest. The hall was hot with its unnecessary fire, which she assumed had been lit as a token of warm hospitality. Underneath the dark oak table one of Olbeth's dogs was lying on her foot. It was giving her cramp and she couldn't kick it off.

"We need to cure his wounds, not just alleviate the pain," argued Shebel.

Maeneb countered, "Allaying the pain may give you time to find a cure."

"His wounds are worsening," said Yaret sombrely. "By some horrible magic, I presume. They've been growing deeper and redder almost by the hour."

"I have more salves that I can try," said Olbeth, "if he will allow me to apply them while he's drugged with Athelid."

Shebel shook her head. "That might not be easy. We already knew that Athelid makes the stonemen aggressive. It makes Veron outright dangerous. And will your salves be any different to mine? Because mine seem to have done nothing." Then, as Huldarion and Meya entered the hall, she stood up to greet them. "My lord; my lady," she said formally.

While Yaret and Olbeth rose also, Maeneb remained seated. Huldarion had never required her to stand up for him before. No reason to start now; though thankfully the dog decided to stand too, releasing her foot, and then wandered huskily around the table to Olbeth before it settled down again.

Huldarion motioned them to sit, and they obeyed. Meya did not join them. She looked out of sorts and out of place.

"I hope your room is to your liking?" Olbeth asked.

"Very much," said Huldarion.

"It will suffice," said Meya, thin-lipped.

"Indeed, this whole farmhouse of yours is to my liking," said Huldarion, almost wistfully. Maeneb could understand that wish for permanence, after years of making do with Thield for a home. The ever-moving town of tents was coldly flimsy compared to this solidly built house; but she herself would choose to live somewhere less enclosed. Higher ceilings, bigger windows. She remembered Gaelera's chambers in the tower at Kelvha Castle, the tall leaded

panes around the window seat. Those windows had attracted her, although the view from them – of other narrow-windowed walls – had not.

“Is Wiln still looking after Aliya?” asked Olbeth.

“He has taken her with her nursemaid to see the pigs,” Meya replied, her voice softening. Lately Meya’s mind had become muffled or maybe muddled, more indefinite, as if wrapped up in a woollen cloak; and also more uncertain. Maeneb assumed that this was related to the presence of the child – although from what she herself had seen of Aliya, she was an annoying brat.

Just now she sensed some discontent in Meya’s mind. “How goes it with your hunter?”

“Not as well as we might hope,” said Shebel with a grimace, and she explained the situation while Huldarion listened intently. Well, he never listened less than intently.

At the end he turned to Olbeth. “Have you any medicines that may work?”

“I have plenty of things that I can try,” said Olbeth. “But I’m not optimistic. They will be the same remedies that Shebel has already used.”

“A cure for Veron will not be found in any medicine cabinet,” said Yaret.

Meya turned to her with a frown. “How can you be sure of that?”

“Because the wounds were caused by malignant wizardry. My belief is that only wizardry can cure them. Even Aliya thought as much – she instantly said that what we needed was a wizard.”

“She did? She thought of that all by herself?” said Meya, and Maeneb felt an increase in the fuzzy pride that suffused her.

But Huldarion shook his head. “Leor has already tried to cure Veron, without success,” he said. “None of the spells that he’s come up with have been any help.”

“And yet the spell must surely have its counterpoint,” said Yaret. “Perhaps we need more botanical lore. Tamu knew only the name of the plant – brienot – but even that knowledge allowed Leor to act against it.”

“Botanical lore,” mused Maeneb. “If only the Farwth were close to hand. It would be bound to know.”

Yaret looked at her keenly. “Why, yes, you’re right, it would. And you can communicate with the Farwth, can you not, Maeneb?”

“Not at this distance,” said Maeneb, startled.

“But surely! What about those reports of Eled’s health you’ve given us? You got those in Kelvha, and that’s further from Farwithiel than here!” said Yaret.

Maeneb was taken aback. Everyone was looking at her now. It made her feel uneasy as she attempted to explain.

“Those messages came only when the Farwth willed them. It can send word to me, it’s true – or rather, it can send thought; but the messages I try to send back go unanswered. And I have tried. At such a distance I think I’m just not strong enough for it to hear me.”

“How far are we from Farwithiel now?” asked Yaret.

“Perhaps a hundred miles,” said Olbeth.

“Less, if anything,” Huldarion added. “I think, Maeneb, that whatever your misgivings you should try to ask the Farwth about the brienot, in any way you can.”

“Who is this Farwth?” enquired Meya, a little haughtily.

“I’ll tell you later on, my dear,” said Huldarion. Maeneb could sense that Meya did not care for that dismissal. But he was speaking again to Olbeth. “Meanwhile we’d better continue with the Athelid: and please try your salves. We’ll hope to find some cure.”

“No cure will work if we cannot keep him resting in one place, as I’ve commanded him,” Olbeth answered. “I’ve set two men to guard his door, and his huntsmen will patrol the yard outside; but we can’t be sure that they’ll be able to restrain Veron if he decides to go.”

Huldarion nodded. "In fact, such guards may not be necessary. Although you may not realise it, Olbeth, you did the best thing possible in ordering Veron to stay within his chamber. For while Athelid makes people more aggressive, it also makes them amenable to suggestion. So be as firm with him as you like."

Why did that speech startle Meya? Maeneb was puzzled by the wariness she felt awakening in the other woman's mind. There had surely been nothing in Huldarion's words to cause it. Could she have resented the familiarity of his tone to Olbeth? It was no more than the warmth he sometimes showed to any of his closest friends – Rothir, for example. Although Huldarion had been annoyed with Rothir ever since the raising of the darkburn...

Well, that did not concern Maeneb. And neither did Meya's odd reaction, which might be born of nothing more than snobbery. A tedious emotion. While Maeneb could not escape from sensing other people's feelings, she found them frequently uninteresting. She was much more anxious about this new idea that she herself should speak to the Farwth.

How could she convince them that it was impossible? At such a distance she might as well attempt to talk to the stars. And even if she could somehow ask the Farwth for advice, it was not biddable. It had never replied directly to any question she had put to it in Farwithiel. It would not give a useful answer now.

But Huldarion was looking at her in expectation. "Can you try the Farwth?"

"I can try," she said helplessly, already feeling the frustration of predictable failure, "but it won't work. It never has before."

"Try none the less."

That was an order, and Maeneb could not flout it. She nodded wretchedly at being given a task whose difficulty nobody else could comprehend, and at which she was almost certain she would fail.

"I am going to retrieve my daughter now," Meya told Huldarion, her voice cool, "before she decides to adopt a piglet as a pet."

"Come, then, my dear."

As they turned away, he offered Meya his arm. An unnecessary pretence of affection, thought Maeneb. Or was it real? There was warmth there, too, when he looked at Meya. But a different sort of warmth. A heat. Her thoughts shied away from it and she was glad to see the pair depart.

"I will go and check if those guards are having any difficulty," said Shebel, and she got up and glided gracefully away.

Yaret turned to Olbeth. "Where would we find the most ancient tree on your property? I noticed a stand of large selver trees up on the hill, beyond the camp."

Olbeth's hand stilled in thought, so that the dog she was caressing gave a tentative whine and put his paw upon her lap.

"Those selver trees are old, but not the oldest," she replied. "We have some oaks... but they're only three or four hundred years. No, I think the oldest tree must be the yew."

"And where is that?" Yaret glanced round as if expecting to see it springing up between the flagstones.

"It's almost a mile away. Do you want to go there? I'll get Rothir to show you." Olbeth stood up.

"You come too," said Yaret to Maeneb.

"Any old tree is not the Farwth," she objected.

"Come anyway."

Yaret jumped up. Olbeth was already crossing the hall with the dog padding behind her. Maeneb felt obliged to follow them. Her spirits sank still lower; whatever hare-brained idea Yaret had, it wouldn't work.

Olbeth led them through the farmyard – where they were joined by the second dog, its mind a sudden flurry of delight – and down a short lane towards an outbuilding with a long, blackened chimney. There was a smell of smoke and hot, sour metal.

“He’s in the forge, of course,” she said. “His favourite place. Rothir! You’re wanted!” she called in through the door.

Rothir emerged from the building with a fat-cheeked baby in his arms. “Just showing the forge to Doval,” he explained. Doval bounced in his grasp, sang *Bababa*, and waved both arms, hitting Rothir in the eye.

“You mean you wanted to check things out here.”

“I admit it. I was seeing how much iron we have left.”

“Plenty. Let me take him now,” said Olbeth indulgently, and he handed the baby over.

Maeneb was glad she was not expected to do any baby-handling. Babies were extremely disconcerting: their minds a mess of noise and colour, jumping from huge excitement to bottomless distress within an instant. Worse than dogs.

Yaret didn’t seem to mind it, however, for Maeneb detected the same sudden warmth she had just sensed in Huldarion. Yaret must like babies.

With the baby tugging at her hair, Olbeth said, “Rothir, could you show these two the old yew tree in the table field? They’d like to visit it. Take the dogs along as well. They need a run.”

Rothir asked no awkward questions. Instead, with a nod, he clicked his fingers at the dogs and set off with them bounding eagerly ahead. Maybe he assumed the women simply wanted exercise, no less than the huge hounds.

She thought it odd that Rothir seemed so cheerful. Contentment radiated from him in an inexplicable wave. But of course it wasn’t inexplicable at all, because he was at home here on his sister’s farm. Maeneb felt a pang of envy; for while she was slightly more comfortable in this place than many others, it was in no way a home.

Indeed, ever since the exile from Caervonn with her mother, Maeneb had called nowhere home – not even Farwithiel, where her father was a warden. Her last visit there had been the first time she had felt accepted by the Farwth.

But the ruler of Farwithiel was a law unto itself and she had little faith that it would hear her now. So she dragged her feet as they entered a field full of some gold-green ragged crop. In her previous visits to Olbeth she had never been this way before: they walked around the field-edge beside a battered orange-lichened wall.

“Why do you want to see the yew tree?” asked Rothir at last.

“Olbeth says it’s the oldest on her land,” said Yaret. “I want to use it to ask the Farwth for its help, about the plant that caught Veron.”

“The Farwth? How will that work?”

“The wardens told me that the Farwth was connected to every tree within hundreds of miles, by its roots and maybe by the earth itself. So I thought the oldest tree might give us the best chance of communicating with it.”

“Hmm,” said Rothir, a touch sceptically. “Even if you could speak to the Farwth in that way, it is not susceptible to pressure.”

Maeneb was grateful. “No, it certainly is not,” she agreed. “Do you remember how it reacted to your threatening it, Rothir?”

Yaret looked at him in surprise. “You threatened the Farwth? When was that? And why?”

Rothir made a dismissive gesture. “It doesn’t matter. It didn’t work in any case. The Farwth had already made its own mind up.”

“I can’t imagine threatening the Farwth,” mused Yaret, walking on. “And while I agree that it’s not susceptible to pressure, I think it is susceptible to... curiosity, maybe. It can be compassionate, without understanding what compassion is.”

"It doesn't think in human terms," said Rothir.

"No. And yet, and yet: I feel a strange connection to it. While I was staying in Farwithiel, one of the wardens told me that the place grows into people's dreams."

"Does it grow into yours?" he asked.

He spoke to Yaret; but Maeneb harshly answered, "No," to stop any further discussion, because she felt the distant presence of the Farwth at many times, not just in her sleep; and this was something that she guarded jealously.

Perhaps Yaret sensed Maeneb's displeasure, for she said only, "A little, sometimes. I like this farm." She sounded wistful as she gazed out at the lumpy pastures, dotted with untidy trees and the scruffy long-haired cattle. Maeneb thought it very ordinary.

"So do I," said Rothir.

"It has just the right amount of rise and fall. Height and shelter. Woods and meadows. Wildness and domesticity."

"It's very muddy," Maeneb said.

They tramped along a path worn through damp grass – the two dogs threading eagerly back and forth on their own scent-driven routes – until all the farm buildings had disappeared behind them, hidden by the undulations of the land. After one last rise they came to a high hedge with a low wooden gate in its middle.

Rothir unlatched it. "This is the table field, where the old yew tree is."

"Oh!"

The exclamation came from both the women. Beyond the hedge a large tree had come into view, low and broad with dark wide-spreading branches; but that was not what made them gasp.

"A stone table," said Maeneb in some wonder.

It was a table far too high for anyone to sit at. The horizontal slab was balanced on three other slabs of rock which were arranged in a tight triangle; and it was higher than her head. Rothir let the dogs through the gate to romp around, and closed it behind them. No sheep grazed in this field. It must be rabbits that kept the grass close-cropped.

"Is that a tomb?" asked Yaret.

"Probably, so Wiln says," he answered.

"The tomb of his ancestors?"

But Rothir shook his head. "His family have only farmed here for a few generations. The place had no inhabitants when his forebears settled here and built the farmhouse. Yet they weren't the first to live here. There were the foundations of a former building; and ancient walls – we just walked alongside one of them – and boundary markers. To say nothing of various old bits that they dug up; mostly broken pottery. Stone knives. The odd bronze tool."

Yaret walked over to the stone table and around it. It was a good six yards long, thought Maeneb: each of its supporting slabs must be four or five yards in length, and over two yards high. She watched Yaret squeeze through the narrow gap between two of the upright slabs – the only gap where such an entry was possible – and come out again a few seconds later.

"Wow," she said.

"I can't get in there," said Rothir with a rueful smile.

"I only just managed it," Yaret admitted. "You should bring Aliya here; she'd like it."

"It's a tomb, not a children's playpen," said Maeneb, who was on edge. The stone table was nothing but an unwanted distraction from her looming task.

"Have a look inside, Maeneb," urged Yaret.

"Why?"

"For a second. Just to see."

"Oh, for stars' sake," she muttered underneath her breath, and wriggled through the stone gap. The surface was gritty and caught at her clothes.

Inside it was surprisingly dark. The gap behind her let in no more than a bright sliver of light: two more blades of brightness were the other gaps between the upright slabs, barely wide enough to slide a finger through. Alternate dazzlement and shade.

It wasn't cold, though. Within the slabs, it felt cocooned. As if something were holding you safe in there, cradled in a huge stone hand... and there was a sense of enormous stillness, a feeling that the world outside had slowed and almost stopped.

Maeneb pushed herself back through the gap in a hurry, scraping her cheek. But the world had not stopped, unfortunately. The other two were walking over to the yew tree. Reluctantly she followed, entering the shadow underneath the tree's wide low-slung canopy. She had to duck to avoid the branches that brushed their springy needles on her face.

"So what are we supposed to do?" she muttered. The yew's trunk seemed to be made of several gnarled and knotted stems, which together must have measured several yards around. Under here it smelt of cool earth, faintly sweet.

"How old is it?" asked Yaret.

"Hard to know," said Rothir. "A thousand years at least. It could well be double that."

"So not even half as old as the Farwth. Still, I expect the Farwth knows of it. The root system must be extensive." She ran her hand down the grey ridged trunk.

"So?" said Maeneb.

"So," said Yaret patiently, "what we can tell this tree may be passed on the Farwth, through roots and more roots, all the way to Farwithiel."

"You want me to talk to this tree?"

"Why not? We talk to the Farwth. And what is this tree but a miniature Farwth?"

Maeneb put a hand to the twisted trunk. It was not totally unlike the Farwth, it was true, although that great unforgettable mass of intertwining trunks and stems was a full two miles in circumference.

"After all, Yaret talks to darkburns," Rothir told her, with a smile. He really was in an unnaturally good mood.

"You told Huldarion you'd try, Maeneb," urged Yaret.

"Oh, I'll try," she said. "I just don't think that I'll succeed."

"Let's link hands. I know you don't care for that, but it's only for a minute. You too, Rothir. And we'll all direct our thoughts at the Farwth together, through this tree."

At that, Rothir did look slightly perturbed. But he took Maeneb's right hand in his big, hardened one, while Yaret gripped her left hand firmly.

Maeneb shuddered. She intensely disliked such close contact: it made her skin crawl and her instincts revolt. A minute had better be all that it took.

So get on with it. She aligned her thoughts towards the distant Farwth, far to the north and east.

First she pictured the blighted country the army of Riders had passed through, with its creeping, sickly vegetation, then Veron struggling in the brienot's merciless grip; she visualised the painful weals left painted on his skin, burning through towards the bone. And she asked the Farwth for its guidance.

Show us a cure, she begged silently, *tell us what can be done*. She had no faith that she would be heard.

"Is anything happening yet?" asked Rothir in a murmur.

"Ssh." She leant her forehead against the rough ridged bark and closed her eyes. Yews were extremely poisonous, she was well aware; yet they were not malignant. Adon had made of the

innocuous brienot something not only far more toxic than a yew, but actively seeking to do harm. He had configured it to do his will. Manipulated it.

Adon did this. He distorted and perverted the harmless brienot. And now we have no remedy, she told the trunk that seemed to lean on her as she leant on it. All we can do is allay the pain and wait. And all that will happen is more pain.

But the Farwth did not understand pain. *His leaves will wither, she thought, his bark will peel off, disease will ravage and destroy him. Unless you can help.*

Breathing in the shadowed sweetness of the yew, she waited for an answer.

None came, of course. Why had anybody thought it would? Opening her eyes, she studied the pattern of cracks. A maze without a destination or solution.

Yaret opened her own eyes.

"Any good?" she asked. "Did the Farwth respond?"

"What do you think?" Maeneb withdrew her hands sharply from the others' grasp and laid her palms upon the deeply scored bark.

Yaret shook her head slowly. "I heard nothing. But we had to try."

"The distance is too great."

"Perhaps. Or maybe the Farwth will send you word in its own time."

"It had better not take long," said Maeneb bitterly. She was angry with herself – unreasonably; and angry with the Farwth, despite her consciousness that such anger was also unreasonable, and unproductive. She feared for Veron, and if no cure could be found, she knew that now she would feel obliged to blame herself.

Oh help him, help him, she said silently to the tree, for the sake of the brienot if nothing else, because what was done to it was a blasphemy of nature.

She paused. No answer came. No soundless yet reverberating voice. No wordless thoughts that resonated through her head. Nothing but the faint breeze sighing through the needles all around her.

"We'd better go back," said Yaret, and now she sounded weary. "You can still keep listening, Maeneb. An answer may still come."

Rothir said nothing. He probably thought the whole attempt was pointless.

As they walked out from underneath the yew and past the stone table, thick clouds were gathering to the east, piling themselves up in heavy roils that looked like boulders ranged along the sky.

"It's going to rain," said Maeneb dully. That was all that seemed worth saying on the long trudge back towards the farmhouse. Her boots stuck to the mud. Yaret was limping.

They plodded past the forge without talking and re-entered the farmyard. Aliya was there with her nursemaid, kneeling down to look at something in a crate that squeaked and snorted.

"So what do we do now?" said Maeneb dismally.

"You keep listening," said Yaret. "Just in case."

Rothir said, "And I shall go and talk again to Leor."

Chapter 8

Leor squatted underneath the stand of selver trees high on the hillside, where the tall grey trunks concealed him from the swarming camp below. He could hear the distant thump of mallets as tents were erected, and the faint banter and occasional warning shouts of the Riders doing the erecting; but the only person he could actually see – and who could see him – was Tamu, sitting as alertly as a sparrow on a fallen trunk to watch him.

“All right. Let’s try this one,” said Leor heavily. Pointing a weary finger at the little pile of vegetation on the ground, he launched without much hope into the next spell on his mental list. “*Brienot a brienot, ha del enfuala sin balu...*”

Tamu, listening attentively, said, “That’s not brienot, though. It’s only clover.”

“I know. Give me a chance: next I’m going to say the spell again, with clover substituted. I’m approaching this logically.” But even as he repeated the charm, with the substitutions, Leor knew that there was nothing logical about his approach. It was born, rather, out of sheer desperation.

Clover was the nearest thing that he could find to brienot. He was sure his magic wouldn’t work on it. In fact he almost willed it not to work, because if by some extraordinary chance it did, the results could be extremely dangerous. Clover lived all over the place. It was a vital constituent of the fields.

So, to minimise the danger, he was focusing his magic on this tiny, shielded heap of greenery. It was like trying to cook a single bean. It felt ridiculous: a pointless exercise. Yet what else could he do? How else could he discover how to counter Adon’s spell, unless he could work out exactly what Adon had done?

Anyway, his words – however phrased – were having no effect at all upon the clover. As Rothir came marching up the slope towards them, Leor was glad of the excuse to straighten his stiff legs, and abandon this latest vain attempt.

“No luck, then,” said Rothir immediately, reading his face.

“I’m afraid not. And you?”

“Yaret and Maeneb have just tried speaking to the Farwth, via an old yew tree. Yes, I know; but it seemed a possibility, if only a faint one. However, no luck there either. I don’t suppose that you could try that, could you, Leor?”

“Speaking to the Farwth? From here? I have only ever talked to the Farwth face to face. Or face to leaf.”

“You could try anyway.”

“I could,” said Leor, “but we are plucking at straws here. What I need to understand is what Adon has done. And I don’t, at all. Changing the appearance of the brienot is one thing: I can do that. I can change a plant’s habit, the way it grows, its size, within the bounds of natural possibility. I can make it embrace a tree-trunk but I cannot make it pull the whole tree over. And I cannot with any spell I know make it so deadly and so poisonous that no medicine or counter-spell will be of the slightest bit of use.”

“But there must be–”

“I tell you, Adon must have woven wizardry into the plant itself. He made of it a different thing – no longer a true plant, but a...” Leor waved his arms helplessly. “A hybrid. Something between plant and magic. A creeping sorcerer with leaves.”

“All right, forget the plant,” said Rothir. “Concentrate on Veron’s symptoms. The wounds the plant left, and especially the pain. Because nothing will alleviate it except the stonemen’s drug Athelid, and he can’t keep taking that for long. It has side-effects. I just looked in on him

before I walked up here, and I got a mouthful of abuse. He's not attacked anybody yet, but he could at any time."

Leor shook his head. "Did you not pay attention?" he replied reproachfully. "I tried every charm for Veron's pain that I could think of, on the journey here. None worked. If anything, I think I made it worse."

"All the same..."

Tamu stirred on his log. "And when Leor first tried to charm the brienot, that made matters worse as well. He merely tightened the plant's grip."

"That's true," admitted Leor, although it filled him with despondency to say it.

Tamu said, "It was as if his spell to counteract the magic simply reinforced it."

"What?" said Leor. He spun round and stared at Tamu, who shrugged.

"That only just occurred to me," he said. "But is it something that Adon could weave into his wizardry?"

Leor leant against the nearest selver tree and thought about it. He felt bone-weary; not just from effort, but from his growing sense of failure. It weighed him down.

Yes, he thought, it most likely could be done. And the more he considered it, the more likely it appeared that it had been done. He groaned.

"If you're right, Tamu," he said, "and I think you may be, then any spell that I can try is bound to fail – indeed, to make things worse. I killed the plant but not its magic: that's what's taken hold in Veron's body. All the spells that I know, Adon knows also. He can not only build in a defence against them, but can turn them to his purpose." He struck the tree with the side of his clenched fist. "He's left me powerless."

Rothir was watching him with a frown. "I don't understand that. You were not powerless when you raised the darkburn from the pit up by the Outland Forts. Nor were you powerless when you sent a river through the streets of Kelvha to put out the fires. Adon could not stop you there."

But Leor pounded at the tree again, in helpless anger and frustration, until the stinging of his fist reminded him of the foolishness of such an act. He stopped and rubbed his hand, bidding the pain to go away. Such minor magic worked easily on himself. Why not on Veron?

"Those spells were different," he said. "Adon wasn't expecting me to use that sort of magic. And they weren't even spells as such. Although they started out as standard charms, they took on their own... sort of... They were just..." He spread his arms, unable to explain his wizardry in a way that these ordinary men would comprehend.

How to describe the flow of force that he had felt on both of those occasions? The feats had been achieved almost by instinct, by the will of the magic that he held within him; by its need to be undammed. All he had done was to allow it – to set his power free. His sorcery had done the rest.

"I was just a channel," he said quietly. "I was just an instrument." Then he left the tree and walked swiftly away from the others, through the murmuring wood. The wind high in the branches spoke a musical language quite alien to him. The trees had become the instrument of the wind. How did that relationship work? What hope had he of understanding it? What hope had he of understanding anything?

When I raised the darkburn, when I made the flood, he thought, it seemed a mammoth effort, all but impossible, until I let the magic take it over. Then it did it by itself.

Could he let his magic loose to flood over Veron? He had a strong feeling that, if he could – if he could undam that force to remove Veron's pain – it would do it by removing Veron's life. His wizardry untrammelled would be huge, a vast whirlwind of power: it could not be focused on one man's legs, or one tiny creeping plant. It would destroy them. Which was not an ideal outcome.

He became aware that the other two were following him as he walked.

"Go away," he said over his shoulder. "Please. I need to think." He strode on up to the hill's rounded summit and stood beneath the sighing trees to look down at the country on its other side. A scene of nature shaped by man, not magic. Neat close-cropped pastures, a stone sheepfold, a few grey scattered sheep like small reflections of the clouds that gathered in the sky above them.

Although he had said that he needed to think, Leor found he was incapable of thinking. What was the point, when he could not understand any of this, when he could not work it out? What was the point of puzzling about what magic could outwit Adon, when Adon knew all his magic and could use it to outwit him?

They had learnt the same spells together, six centuries ago and more, two charmed children who soon outstripped their guardians: they had practised magic skills together, seeing who could blow a wall over the fastest, or turn a pond bright pink... Although it seemed to Leor, looking back, that Adon had never practised anything. He had always succeeded perfectly, first time.

He never doubted himself, thought Leor. Unlike me. I doubt myself continually. Maybe that is why I don't succeed – because I don't believe I can. Adon believes he can do anything.

I cannot believe. And thinking is useless to me. I cannot think. All I can do is feel. Anger, grief, dismay, shame, bitterness. I am my own darkburn. Last year I told myself I had forsworn my wizardry because I did not want to be like Adon. In truth it was because I knew that I could never be like Adon. I could never wield my magic as skilfully and strongly as he does. I cannot make it do just what I want.

Leor let his head drop to his chest. The sight of the white streaks in his own beard only added to his shame and self-dislike. So old, and he had gained so little wisdom, such meagre skill, compared to Adon! What was the point of his being a wizard at all? The frustration and fury began to roll up inside him, like the slowly massing clouds that hung low and heavy in the sky.

He could not make his magic do what he wanted. Very well. He would let it do what it wanted. Whatever that was.

Leor raised his head, and then his arms, and spread his fingers. Those fields ahead of him were empty: so let his wizardry do what it willed.

Without giving it form or direction, without placing around it any guard or control, he felt the power rise up in him and flow through him like a river. Just do what you like, he thought, I don't care any more.

That tingling flow, that heady rush, that sense of an unstoppable giant presence shouldering its way out through his body, down his arm and past his hands to fill the empty fields–

Below him on the slope the sheepfold exploded. Its stones shot high into the air – two hundred feet at least, he thought in some amazement, watching them slow and seem to hover momentarily; until, on their starting to come down, he panicked and ran backwards.

He ran straight into Tamu, bowling them both over. Around them with a cacophony of heavy thumps and splintering snaps the sheepfold's stones hit earth and tree-branch. Pine needles fountained from new-made craters in the ground: trees cracked and roared and groaned as rocks bombarded them: one great bough crashed down in three large pieces.

A final stone rolled to his feet, and stopped. After the thuds and crashes it seemed very quiet. He lay next to Tamu, wondering if was safe to stand.

"What. In. Stars'. Name?" said Rothir, his voice full of astonished reproof.

Leor sat up. Tamu was rubbing his knee, and wincing; but Leor felt the echoes of his own fury roll around him still. He would not apologise to anybody for simply letting free his magic. That was what they all wanted of him, for stars' sake. What else should they expect?

So he scrambled to his feet, and rounded on Rothir.

"I'm doing magic. Is that all right with you? I'm a wizard. This is what happens if you want a wizard for an ally. You have to put up with the odd explosion. So take it as a lesson to be careful how you speak to me!"

Rothir was looking grim.

"How did I speak to you?" he said softly. "Did I say anything that would justify your destruction of my sister's buildings?"

"It was only a sheepfold."

"And the killing of her sheep?"

Leor looked around. And then he realised that the fallen stones were interspersed with bits of ragged, bloody carcass. A sheep's leg lay nearby, still profusely bleeding.

"I... that was not my intention," he said, feeling slightly stunned. "I didn't know that there were any in there."

"It's what a sheepfold is for," said Rothir. "To hold sheep. How will you explain this to Wiln?" His voice was still dangerously quiet.

But another voice was calling to them, much more loudly: "What is going on here? What was that noise?" It was Thoronal, marching heavily down from the wooded ridge.

Leor groaned inwardly. Of all the men to arrive just now, it had to be one of Huldarion's chief counsellors. And the most pompous one. "I was experimenting," he said stiffly. "It went a little awry."

"Experimenting? What on earth with? And what is this?" Thoronal picked up the sheep's hind-quarter and held it, dangling, dripping blood.

"Sheep," said Tamu.

"I'll tell Wiln it was an accident," said Leor.

"It was no accident," said Rothir, his voice still very low and even.

"You've been carving up Wiln's livestock? What did you think you were doing, Leor? All I can say is, you need to tidy up this mess right now. And you'd better not let Huldarion know about it," announced Thoronal, in the tone of a scolding schoolmaster. "He's got enough to deal with at the moment, without a rogue wizard massacring his host's sheep."

"And hostess," said Rothir in a deep, quiet rumble. "This is my sister's property, not just Wiln's."

Leor turned to Rothir. "I apologise. Like I said, that was not my intention."

"What was your intention?" Although Rothir seemed very calm, Leor began to feel a little... not exactly afraid, for Rothir surely was his friend. But he felt a rapidly dawning realisation that he would not like Rothir to become an enemy.

Nor would he care to displease Huldarion. This act would certainly do him no favours in Huldarion's eyes. He tried to frame a reasonable answer. Yet what had his intention been? The truth was, to express his anger and frustration. His magic had certainly done that for him. And the sheep had borne the brunt of it.

"Spells are unpredictable things," offered Tamu. Standing up, he shook each of his legs and arms cautiously in turn. "Oof. If we need to keep this, um, interesting event from Huldarion's knowledge, then perhaps the best thing we can do is pay Wiln and Olbeth for the damage, and eat the evidence."

"And eat the...?" Thoronal frowned. "Well," he said ponderously, "that's one solution, I suppose. All right. That makes sense. Rothir, if I find the money, can you set it right with Wiln, discreetly?"

After a moment, Rothir slowly nodded.

"Good. Gather up all the bits, and bring them over to the camp, as unobtrusively as you can. The men won't object to an unexpected mutton roast, I'm sure." Thoronal plucked a ragged haunch out of a nearby tussock. Then, carrying a bleeding joint in each hand, he began to trudge back up the hill.

Rothir gazed at Leor. "That was no accident," he said again, even more softly than before.

"I was trying to see what my wizardry would do, without direction," Leor explained. "I didn't expect it to do that."

"Without direction? It didn't occur to you that it might be a little dangerous?"

"Like I say," said Leor. He was feeling most uncomfortable.

But at last Rothir turned away, to pick up a blood-soaked head by one horn. He tossed it in a thicket before plucking out a foreleg and an unidentifiable bloody lump. "You'd better start hunting bits of sheep," he said distantly, and walked off after Thoronal.

Leor ran his hands through his hair. "I really did not mean any harm to those poor animals. I didn't know that they were in there," he said plaintively to Tamu, although Tamu was not looking nearly as severe as Rothir had. Indeed, the archivist was surveying him with something more like pity. And when he spoke his tone held no reproach: only mild enquiry.

"You've been studying magic for how long?"

"Over six hundred years," said Leor wretchedly.

"And you've never given it free rein before?"

Dismally, Leor shook his head. "I've always practised wizardry the way that I was taught. Which is: first decide what you want to do. Then decide the best spell to do it. Adapt the spell as necessary. So, no, I've never left it up to the wizardry to do itself."

Tamu walked over to the broken branch and detached a floppy grey object from it. It was a tail. He pushed it in beneath the fallen log so that it was hidden.

"I think you may need to start your studies all over again," he said. "I'm sure that was an accident. But it's not one that you would want to have repeated."

"Ah," groaned Leor. "But how do I start again? Where do I begin? How do I learn to control something that's so strong?" That is stronger than I am by far, he thought.

Tamu gazed at him with compassion. "I expect you'll work it out," he said. "Like learning to read in a new language. The fundamentals will be the same as those you know already. Once you learn the alphabet and grammar, the meaning will take shape."

"You think so?"

"I hope so," answered Tamu gravely, "because you need to learn it fast."

Chapter 9

"I'm not happy about the piglet," Meya said.

Huldarion looked up from the map that was lying open on the table; initially with pleasure at hearing her voice, and then in slight exasperation as he registered the words.

"What does the piglet matter?" he asked. "Your daughter seems happy to be here. She's already settling in well. If a piglet adds to her happiness, why not accept it?"

"It is not seemly for my daughter to adopt a piglet as a pet," Meya said with indignation.

Huldarion sighed inwardly. "She's only five, my dear. There will be time enough for her to worry about what's seemly when she's older. For now, just let her be content." He was not accustomed to using this tone of voice: to reassure, to soothe; and suspected that he was not much good at it. He hoped that Meya would not require soothing often. His natural inclination was to be logical, dispassionate, commanding.

"If you are to be a king, Aliya will be a princess," said Meya stiffly.

Huldarion immediately thought that that was not necessarily the case – unless he were to adopt Meya's daughter. Take her on, as if she were a little piglet, he thought.

"Why are you smiling?" demanded Meya. "I find nothing to entertain me in our current situation."

He did not think he had been smiling. His scars prevented it. How had she detected his amusement? But her tone of voice removed any temptation to reveal the source of his humour.

Deliberately he rolled up the map that he had spread out on the oaken table in the great hall. It told him nothing new in any case: it was merely a reminder of how far he had to go.

He had already made the decision to march on southwards to the Place of Terns, before turning east to find the enemy. A perverse decision, perhaps. Yet he felt drawn to see the area marked on the old merchant's map that Tamu had found.

It was not only that he thought there might be knowledge to be gained there – ancient stonemen's habitations, and even existing strongholds – but he also felt a strong curiosity, a pull towards the place for another reason. Ever since he'd heard the captive stoneman speak of his childhood in the Place of Terns, Huldarion had felt that pull: as inexorable as the heavy tug of tides against the sea. He needed to discover if the stoneman had been accurate in what he said.

The prisoner – no, not just a prisoner, no nameless soldier, for his name was Girik – had spoken of a dormitory by the sea; of swimming, and of dolphins; and he had said that he was twelve years old. He had looked twenty.

This revelation, above all, nagged at Huldarion. It drew a thin dark thread of unease through all his carefully woven plans. Although he'd kept it from his soldiers – indeed, from everyone – he needed to understand the truth of the stoneman's claim. Hence his desire to see the Place of Terns, to find out if the story was corroborated.

Was this foolish? The Kelvhan commander Jeveran, whose opinion he respected, had clearly been sceptical about the diversion. The Kelvhan army, Jeveran announced, would not take the same route. It would meet up with the Vonnish army later, to the east, once Huldarion had finished what Jeveran obviously regarded as an unnecessary detour.

He wondered if Meya regarded his march south in the same way. Without full knowledge of his motives, she must wonder at it. Sometimes he wondered at himself.

Huldarion sighed. Meya was right, he thought. There was little to lift the mood in their current situation, apart from the sight of Aliya hugging her beloved pig. The whereabouts of the enemy was unknown. They were not close – the scouts had ascertained that much – but

the stoneman army would be massing somewhere, that was certain. Probably far eastwards, closer to Caervonn, by the fringes of the Darkburn forest, or deep within it...

And meanwhile he was heading to the sea. He told himself that if stonemen truly lived there, it would be a useful stage in his campaign to overcome them. But he knew that he did not fully convince himself.

"How is Veron?" asked Meya. "I dare not go into his room."

"I hardly dare myself," Huldarion said. "He snarls and snaps as if he were a wolf. At least he's staying put: I think that's largely down to Olbeth."

"I thought it was the Athelid that made him obedient."

"Up to a point. He has not been indoctrinated to subservience all his life as the stonemen have. They have no agency beyond what their leaders tell them. Veron, I think, commands himself despite the Athelid's effects."

"When you leave here..."

"We will have to leave Veron behind," Huldarion said reluctantly. "I can only hope that his wounds will slowly heal and that the Athelid will no longer be required. Meanwhile Olbeth will tend him, as will your nursemaid Flodda; and a dozen other Riders will stay on here too – those still recovering from old injuries."

"A dozen wounded men? Will they be enough to protect Aliya, if enemies attack the farm? Because the stonemen have been here already and may come again." Her voice was twanging with anxiety.

Huldarion took her hand; and then, at the faint tightening of her brows, let it drop. How baffling, he thought, that she who was so welcoming and warm in bed was so aloof and cool outside it. But he was aware that unlike him, Meya did not feel at home here, on this unassuming farm.

"The fact that the stonemen's attack did not succeed may well deter them from any more attempts. Remember, that attack was not targeting us, but more probably our stores, most of which will soon be loaded on our carts. In truth, few of the Vonn know of Aliya's identity," he reassured her. "To them she's Flodda's child. But they'll look after her because she is a child. Olbeth will care for her" – again he saw that small tightening of her brows – "and I will leave Camburé here also, to share the load with your nursemaid."

"It was Camburé who put the idea of a piglet into Aliya's head in the first place," muttered Meya; but at least she raised no more objections. Huldarion rose from the table.

"Come," he said. "We shall inspect the troops together, now that all the Riders are collected. Tomorrow I'll ride out to meet the Kelvhans, who are camped ten miles away: and our army will depart the day after. You, my dear, may either come with us or stay at Olbeth's farm. The choice is yours entirely."

"You need not call me your dear," she said, a little coldly. "I am affianced to you. That is sufficient. Let us go and see these troops."

She does not like this place, Huldarion thought, it is not grand enough. I wish it didn't matter so much to her. She plainly doesn't care to leave her daughter here. None the less, Aliya will be as safe here as she could be anywhere.

He refrained from offering her his arm as they crossed the cobbles of the courtyard. When they walked across the muddy fields towards the tents, Meya lifted up her skirts, but did not slow her step.

Although she likes things done with due propriety, he reflected, she is not physically fastidious. That's just as well, considering the damaged body she has married. It seems a miracle that she does not reject me...

Again he repressed the urge to take her hand: that warm, sometimes caressing hand. I am a novice still where women are concerned, he thought.

The tented town of Thield was lately much expanded, with more tents in the process of being set up on its fringes. They now numbered several hundred, including those that held equipment and provisions. Their mottled walls were well camouflaged against the churned-up ground. Beyond them stood the ranks of carts, equally plain but serviceable, nothing like the showy gilded carriages that Kelvha used. Meya's own pair stood out like vaunting peacocks amidst a flock of curlews.

All around him, reunions were taking place, as Riders met old friends or family members. He saw Hilbré with her husband, deep in conversation. They rode in different companies, for Seldec was her junior in rank. Yet her manner to him was attentive and respectful. A successful marriage surely despite that gap.

Two of his senior counsellors had also just been reunited with their wives. Huldarion greeted them with new-found curiosity, wondering how their long marriages coped with the strains of separation. Uld's wife Jonab seemed as easy-going as ever, despite the wheezing of her lungs – an affliction she had suffered for some years. Was her good temper an illusion? What did she really think of her husband's riding off once more to war, to leave her wheezing alone?

He did not like to ask. But Uld and Jonab's fondness for each other was evident in the way they spoke, in soft elliptical half-sentences; in the small touch of a finger on an arm; in the shared pride they expressed in their children – both now adults, a tall young woman and a taller, younger man who were riding in the ranks.

Uld and Jonab seemed to have successfully ridden through any battles in their partnership. So too surely had Thoronal and his wife Eblaine, although she was as reticent as always. Their boys were ten and thirteen now; Eblaine had brought them from their small town in Outer Kelvha to see their father before the army set out once again. While Thoronal joked with his sons in his laborious manner, Huldarion spoke to his wife.

"Eblaine. I'm sorry we cannot stay here for longer. It's hard for you and for the boys to be so long parted from your husband."

"We're used to it," she said. Perhaps a touch of resignation there.

"But it must be difficult."

She gave him a quarter smile and a half shrug. "Thoronal is happy."

"He has not been quite at ease these last few weeks. I think perhaps he misses you." In fact Huldarion knew well the true cause of Thoronal's disquiet: it had been apparent ever since he made that fatal error in battle, not so far from here. Thoronal's over-confidence had led to the deaths of seven of his Riders. Death by firedrake: a terrible end. He wondered if Eblaine had heard about it.

If she had, she gave no sign. "I don't think he misses me much," she said coolly, and turned to watch her husband with his children.

"He holds you very dear," Huldarion said, because Thoronal had once muttered words to that effect. Eblaine did not respond. So she resented his absences, most probably, and blamed Huldarion for them. That was an inevitable by-product of their exile. If the Vonn were ever to return to their ancestral home, it must mean marching out to battle.

With a sigh he went to greet his other captains and saw with gratification that Meya was already talking to them earnestly. Crade and Orbrel had been scouting to the west, without finding any signs of stonemen: Meya knew the questions to ask them and showed knowledge and interest in the answers. Huldarion could see it pleased his men. However, maybe the women would not be so impressed, for he had noticed that Meya did not speak so naturally to the senior female Riders.

Delgeb, for instance, who came up to them now. "The tallies are all done," she said. "We've allocated Riders to the usual companies, as you requested."

"Good. We may reallocate before we fight, depending on how many captains are appropriate."

"And the women?" Delgeb asked, her voice somewhat sharp.

Huldarion answered courteously. "I said I would not keep you hidden away despite Kelvha's dislike of seeing women fight in battle. And I will not hide you in the battles yet to come. Perhaps we can't have female captains in those future conflicts; but for now, we shall have three. You are one, Delgeb. Hilbré and Tiburé shall be the others."

"Tiburé?" asked Solon. "Are you sure that she's still up to it?"

Huldarion glanced over at him, surprised at this open display of bitterness. That was one long marriage that had not gone well... Although their rift was common knowledge, Solon normally kept any grievances to himself. Perhaps some new argument had occurred between them.

"I'm sure that Tiburé is fully capable," he answered.

"She's younger than I am," Uld pointed out.

"Yes, but you don't go hot and red, and shout and sweat like women of that age," said Solon, somewhat unnecessarily in Huldarion's view.

"There are remedies for that," said Meya coolly. Delgeb too was looking askance at Solon.

Huldarion swiftly changed the subject. "The provision carts should now be almost loaded," he said, and sniffed the air. "Talking of provisions, something smells good around here. Is that roasting meat?"

"Mutton," said Rothir. "Courtesy of Wiln."

"How thoughtful of him. Wiln and Olbeth are being very generous to us. We must not overtax their hospitality. Tomorrow we will finish our preparations, and ride out early the next morning."

"South?"

"Provided Kelvha are still in accord. They do not altogether agree with my route; but from their point of view, it is but a few days wasted," Huldarion said. "When I meet Commander Jeveran – what's that sound?" For a strange noise had just started up: a dim, insistent hum.

"I don't know," said Rothir.

"Is it bees?" suggested Crade. The captains' heads turned, as did Huldarion's, while they tried to identify the source of the peculiar sound. It seemed to come from all around them.

"It might be a swarm of bees, I suppose. Or the wind," said Uld doubtfully.

But both ideas seemed equally unlikely, for the sound was rapidly growing stronger. It became a resonant, throbbing, almost singing note – or several notes laid over one other – like the ringing of a distant, penetrating bell.

"Oh," said Uld, in sudden shock. His wife looked at him in surprise. But Huldarion felt the same shock; for, like Uld, he now recognised it.

"Uld? Solon? Come with me," he said swiftly. "The rest of you, please return to your tents. Meya? Will you kindly escort Jonab? I'll join you in a little while."

Without waiting for an answer he strode away, the two men following, and also Thoronal; the only other man amongst his Riders who knew what made that sound.

It was no bell, although it rang like one when touched. No bell, but a bowl: the great, gold-plated, finely engraved bowl which had been found concealed within the walls of the ancient temple of Borgun. A mere touch on its rim was enough to make it sing.

As he marched downhill towards the carts Huldarion's predominant emotion was sheer anger. Who had dared to touch it? He blamed the over-serious young priest, who had vowed to guard the thing, promising it would stay hidden in its cart amongst provision sacks. It must be Hokiro who was making the bowl ring – and if not, why wasn't he protecting it according to his vow? Why had he allowed some other person access?

"Kelvha must not learn about that bowl," he muttered. "It would put our whole alliance in jeopardy. It must not become common knowledge. Who in stars' name has had the gall to tamper with it?"

For he knew the bowl's inscription, telling of Kelvha's ancient subservience to Caervonn, would be anathema to the lords of Kelvha. But quite apart from that, the bowl's great age and rarity as a precious heirloom of his house also made his anger flare.

They reached the carts. The ringing sound still seemed to flow around them, encircling them in its clear bright call: the Riders who had been loading up the gear were looking in all directions in bewilderment – everywhere but at the guilty wagon.

Solon ran ahead and climbed up into the covered cart that held the bowl. A second later he emerged, dragging the priest out roughly by his blue gown and long hair.

"He's the only one in there with it," said Solon, breathless.

It was as he had thought, then. Huldarion walked up to the priest.

"What were you doing?" he said, despite his fury keeping his voice low. His mere presence was already drawing gazes, but the continued ringing served to shield his words.

"I did nothing," said Hokiro. A hollow-cheeked, earnest man, he did not resist Solon's grip. "I did nothing. When I heard the bowl begin to ring I entered the cart to see who had crept in. But there was no-one there."

"Somebody set it off," growled Solon.

"If no-one's touching it, it should stop soon," suggested Uld.

But the sound showed no sign of diminishing. Its chime washed over them like a shimmering, calm sea. In other circumstances, Huldarion would have called it beautiful. He climbed up into the cart, his scars complaining, and ducked beneath the canvas canopy.

There was the bowl: not laid in its wooden crate, nor wrapped in a woollen blanket as it ought to be; but standing on the lid of the closed box with the discarded cloth beside it; and still singing. Huldarion placed his hands upon its rim to try and stop the sound. He felt the vibrating tremor of the metal running through him, up his arms and through his chest. It seemed to shake his very heart.

And still it rang. His hands were not enough. He picked up the blanket, and threw it over the bowl, folding it over and round. The sound was muffled now. He held the great bowl in his arms, hugging it as if it were a crying child, his dearest object; and slowly, slowly, the ringing became hushed and finally shivered into nothing.

This is my Aliya, he thought, my love, my country, my chief reason for living. The thing for which I strive. My beloved kingdom of Caervonn.

He released the bowl and straightened up. Now that it was silent he almost missed the sound: that sense of many voices twined in one, the clear, pure, woven notes.

Uld had climbed up and stood beside him. They looked at each other, before Uld shook his head in wonderment.

"Let us place it in the box," Huldarion murmured. The two men stowed the wrapped bowl in the crate. Then both stepped back outside.

"I did not set it singing," said the priest. "I swear it."

"Somebody did. Who took the bowl out of its box? Who uncovered it?" Huldarion knew his voice was stern. So it ought to be. This priest needed to be aware of his displeasure.

"I did *that*," confessed Hokiro. "Once I knew that we had stopped for a few days, I felt that the bowl needed air. And light, after being so long incarcerated."

"It needed air." Solon's voice was scathing.

The priest nodded.

"It's a heavy thing," said Uld. "Too heavy for one man. Who helped you lift it from its crate?"

"I asked the Kelvhan bookman – Tamu. He already knew about the bowl: he was the one who read the inscription, if you recall. I have allowed nobody else to see it, as you told me. But it was yesterday when he helped me lift it out, and it did not ring then."

"Where is Tamu now?" Huldarion asked.

"I don't know."

"I saw him before we walked over here," said Uld. "He was with Leor, a good distance away. I don't believe this can have been him."

"I think Tamu has too much sense in any case," Huldarion said. He looked into the priest's face. Previously he would have said that this too was a sensible man, and one incapable of deceit.

But would I not say that also of myself? he thought. Yet I am fully able to deceive, given the right circumstances. Every man is, for the sake of something that he loves – or hates.

"How would Borgun interpret the ringing of this bowl?" he asked the priest severely.

Hokiro took a long breath and then stared into space as if listening.

"Borgun would say: it does not sing without a reason. It may be a summons. It may be a celebration. It may be a warning."

"Which?" said Huldarion sharply. He was searching for a clue as to Hokiro's motive; for he must surely be responsible. So he was nonplussed when Hokiro hesitated.

"I don't know. But I think perhaps – because it rang of its own volition – that it sensed danger. So maybe both a summons and a warning."

Solon grunted. "Hah! A warning not to leave it in the care of a half-witted priest!"

Huldarion put up his hand to bid Solon be silent, and addressed Hokiro. "What sort of danger?"

As if to answer him, a strident horn-cry called across the hill.

Chapter 10

"That's the wake-horn!" Thoronal exclaimed.

"Eastern boundary," said Solon. Releasing the priest, he began to run towards the look-out point beyond the carts, upon a rise of ground. Huldarion saw the tiny figure of a sentry raise the wake-horn to his lips again. The sound reached him a second later.

And a second after that, Huldarion saw the reason for the horn's urgent call. The cause was small and dark and indistinct, yet at the sight of it his heart seemed to momentarily stop beating. The thing appeared to whirl and spin, so that it confused the eye. Leaving a steaming trail along the grass, it rushed towards the camp in a blur of heat and shadow.

Darkburn.

As always, the very name – the mere thought of it – almost disabled him. The scars all down his left hand side began to burn again in memory. He did not need to feel the creature's aura to know again that terror. Every time he saw a darkburn, the horror of that first encounter came rushing back, vivid and unasked: his brother turned into a sheet of flame, the shadow that crouched over him seeming to feed upon his agonising death...

And he himself, trying to slash the darkburn with his sword, feeling his own skin melt like candle-wax. Knowing already that this unknown thing, which had no purpose but to terrify and kill, would burn down his house, bring down his dynasty, and destroy his life.

Every time a darkburn rushed towards him, it was his younger brother he saw burning: his beloved Caervonn he saw being eaten up in flames. And the darkburn at the heart of the disaster.

Pain and fury welled up in him now. He felt himself to be almost shaking and hoped his weakness was not visible. He must not let this creature overcome his self-control; nor could he let it harm his people. Indeed, it ought not to have the power to, for all his Riders now possessed protective stones.

So he told himself that he'd defeated many darkburns now and ought to be accustomed to them. Commanding his wild heart and flailing wits to calm themselves, he called the Riders to defensive posts – although they required no calling, but were already reacting to the horn-cry. Men and women had dashed out of the tents or sprung down from the carts. Half of them ran, swords drawn, to the eastern boundary. The others split themselves, without fuss, between the other boundaries; for while the alarm had sounded to the east, it did not mean that there was no danger elsewhere.

On spun the darkburn towards the camp. As Huldarion ran to join his men he smelt burning grass, and something worse: the darkburn stench of rank decay. It turned his stomach no less than did the fearful aura now enveloping him. The sense of hatred, anger, bitter loathing; the urge to die. He knew that the northerner Yaret had her own theories about darkburns – that they were somehow related to what she called lins, the harmless and seldom-glimpsed spirits of the earth – but at this moment, seeing the blotch of smoke and terror rush towards him, he could not give that any credence. Darkburns sought only to destroy.

At least this time it was a solitary one. And surely it would soon spin away, repelled by the stones harvested from dead stonemen, which all the Riders carried.

Indeed, as it approached the ranks of Riders who waited motionless, swords drawn, the darkburn abruptly veered aside. He could not see its shape. It dazzled the eye with darkness.

But it did not turn and rush away, as he expected. Instead it raced a little further to the side and then hurtled at the ranks again; rebounded, and rushed along the line before a third attack.

And this time it did not retreat. It leapt upon one man and seemed to knock him to the ground in a sudden flare of smoke. At once the soldiers who were nearest leapt at it, hacking with their swords, but to no avail. They had to pull back almost immediately, their hair sparking and clothes smoking. He saw that they were men of Melmet and Gostard – the small remnant who had decided to ride on with the Vonnish army, rather than return home.

Was it possible that their squadron had no stones? Filled with dismay, Huldarion was already running towards them when he saw two Riders leap to their defence. Hilbré and Birané: both quiet in manner, experienced in battle, the two women slashed doggedly in turn at the huddled darkburn until it finally collapsed.

Huldarion ran up to the group, relief flooding through him as the darkburn's aura faded and dissolved. The thing was reduced to a charcoal fragments scattered round the fallen man. The man himself was dead, the stars be thanked; for no man could live – or would want to – with the burns that had consumed his upper body.

Huldarion turned to the soldier beside him. It was the Gostard leader: a deceptively sleepy-looking, but tough, soldier.

"Jerred. Had the man no stones?"

"I don't know. He's Melmet, not one of mine." Jerred tried to turn the body with his sword.

"I am of Melmet. We all have stones; the Baron made sure of that," said another man nearby, sounding shaken, "and Ivald should have had one too."

"Only one?"

"Maybe he lost it," Jerred said. "No, wait. What's that?" From the charred flakes of the man's tunic something small had fallen to the ground.

"That's his stone," the other said, picking it up. He immediately dropped it with a cry of pain.

"Turnip-head," said Jerred without rancour. Producing a ragged kerchief, he took up the hot stone to show it to Huldarion.

The stone looked right; rounded at one end, pointed at the other; faintly glistening; yet it had not worked. Why not? Why had it failed to repel the darkburn?

It was a cause for worry – but there was no time now. He looked anxiously across the eastern fields: for where a darkburn was, an attack by stonemen generally followed.

"Keep in formation," he told the men of Melmet. His own Riders needed no instruction. Armed and alert, they held their positions, two ranks of archers flanking the swordsmen and women.

And nothing there for them to shoot at – yet. Huldarion glanced back at his tented town: Meya was in the heart of it, where Delgeb and the others would protect her. What about the farm?

He strode swiftly over to the north side of the encampment to look down at the farm buildings. Wiln and Calenir, and half a dozen others – Tiburé and Camburé included – were ranged outside the farmhouse, weapons drawn. Wiln carried a long scythe: he refused to wield a sword. Of Olbeth, a skilled swordswoman, there was no sign.

Stay inside with your baby, Huldarion commanded her silently, before realising that he had forgotten Aliya. And with Aliya, he amended. Look after her. But most of all look after yourself.

Ikelder left his post to come running over to him.

"You have no shield," he said. "Here."

Huldarion took the proffered shield with a nod of thanks. He had left his in his tent. It is as well, he thought, that my Riders are readier than I am. I must improve. But my Riders are impressive.

"Go with a dozen others to help defend the farm," he told Ikelder, who at once began to summon comrades. A sound man. But Huldarion hoped that these precautions would prove unnecessary.

It was so, so quiet. And then not. As he walked along the eastern boundary, the stonemen suddenly made their attack – if it could be called that. A man in a red tunic jumped up from the undergrowth some hundred yards away, and ran towards the cover of the woods. There was a united twang of bowstrings from the archers, and the stoneman fell.

A second one half stood up behind a bush, and instantly was toppled likewise, pierced by a dozen arrows. Then several others all leapt up at once from their concealment. These ones did not retreat but charged the Vonn with their curved swords and vicious axes held aloft.

The swordsmen kept their line. The rank of archers shot another volley, then stepped backwards to reload their bows, the second rank replacing them. He saw Maeneb and Yaret among their number, and heard the sighing hiss of arrow-shafts. Four men dropped to the ground.

Now only three stonemen were still upright, still running at the Vonn. The next volley of arrows felled them. He heard Rothir give a shout, at which his company of sword-wielding Riders ran out across the field.

They should have waited for my word, Huldarion thought; but this was no crisis, it was the flimsiest of attacks. And Rothir's shout was timely. For as the riders advanced, half a dozen more stonemen jumped up from their shrubby hiding-places, brandishing their battle-axes as ferociously if they were not outnumbered by a hundred men to one. He heard the grating clash of metal hitting metal and a single wordless cry.

The stonemen can be fearless, thought Huldarion, watching the unequal fight; is that entirely a result of the Athelid that they are drugged with? But they are not co-ordinated. Unlike us.

He felt a glow of pride at the smooth mechanism of his fighters; and repressed it, because complacency could be fatal. The unexpected could always happen – like now, when a tall and powerful stoneman knocked down Aretor with an axe-blow. Trampling over him, the man began to run towards the camp, swinging his battle-axe and roaring.

"Hold!" cried Maeneb to the archers, because the two Riders racing out to meet the lone stoneman were in the line of fire. Fardir was the first to reach him. His sword-thrust had no immediate effect. Instead Fardir was struck by a blow of the man's axe across his shoulder.

Immediately Parthenal leapt past his comrade and slashed at the stoneman's arms with two great sword-swipes, one way and then the other: both the axe and short sword tumbled to the ground. Huldarion was amazed that the man's hands did not follow. Parthenal seized the stoneman, grabbing him by his tunic and his bloodied arms to twist him round, before marching him over to where Huldarion stood.

He watched the pair approach – the stoneman struggling, Parthenal with his face set hard in anger and distaste. Rothir followed with a bloody sword, swivelling to check behind him. But there were no more enemies in sight; just peaceful fields once more, the waving grass criss-crossed by Riders running to aid their injured comrades.

So not really an assault at all... More likely a small company of spies, who had only decided to attack once seen.

But then why the darkburn?

As Parthenal manhandled the stoneman closer, Huldarion noted that there were at least twelve stones set into his shaven skull. An older man, a leader, then. It came as a relief. Parthenal thrust the man forward, to be instantly encircled by a ring of Riders. Both his arms bore gaping wounds, and he had lost a thumb. Fardir's stroke too had caught him after all, if

not fatally; for a bloodstain spread wide and slow across the tunic, turning it from grubby red to a shade closer to black.

"What were you and your men doing there?" demanded Huldarion, although the question seemed superfluous.

"Come to kill you," said the stoneman thickly, and he spat at Huldarion's feet.

"You were never going to succeed. A mere dozen of you?"

"Come to kill you and your Kelvhan whore," the stoneman grunted.

Thoronal drew his sword with a harsh grating of metal. "Watch your words."

"Who sent you on such a suicidal mission?" asked Huldarion.

"Someone who doesn't like stonemen," put in Solon. "Somebody who didn't care if you died in the attempt."

The stoneman turned his head and looked at Solon. Then he spat, again.

"You should know," he said.

"What should we know?" asked Uld.

"You should know," said the stoneman, and now he shook his head as if to try and clear it.

"You should know... that you can't win. Our victory is told by the stones. You can't win against the stones, you... you deformed dog... and your Kelvhan bitch..."

"What do you mean? What is told?" Huldarion demanded. "Those stones in your head say nothing."

"Not those stones, dogface. The old stones... they tell us of our victory..."

But Thoronal had bridled. Raising his sword, he repeated forcefully, "You watch your words!"

"Dogs, all of you," said the stoneman thickly, with contempt. Thoronal sprang forward, sword outstretched: perhaps merely to threaten the man, perhaps to strike him. It was not clear.

"Stop," said Huldarion: but the stoneman kicked out at Thoronal with unexpected force. Thoronal's stroke was sent awry as the stoneman lunged towards him.

Several other men immediately rushed in; but Solon was the first. He did not hesitate. With a strong thrust he buried his sword deep in the stoneman's chest. The man gasped twice, his legs already failing; and then collapsed with sudden limpness. All around fell silent.

They were waiting for Huldarion to speak. So he said,

"I appreciate your defence of my good name, Thoronal, but that wasn't necessary. I've been called worse than a dog before."

Solon wiped his bloody sword on the ground. "Not by a man who's lower than a dog himself," he said, through gritted teeth.

"He wanted us to kill him," Rothir rumbled. "He had no sword to fall on. So he picked the next best thing."

Huldarion nodded. Rothir was possibly right; for every stoneman he had ever worsted on the battlefield had killed himself in preference to being taken prisoner.

But this was not a battlefield, he thought. The man should not have been run through like that. Most likely he would have died within the hour in any case, if Thoronal had not precipitated his death so clumsily.

It was a thought he kept to himself, for he would not criticise Thoronal in front of all these Riders. Instead he looked out to the field and said, "See that Fardir is taken to the medics' tent." While Aretor was already struggling to his feet, one hand clutching his bruised and bloody head, three men were lifting the immobile Fardir gently from the ground. Parthenal hastened over to help them.

Solon looked down with disdain at the body by his feet. "Suicidal, indeed," he said. "What else could be the point of such a poor attack?"

"To test us, maybe," said Huldarion.

"No sensible commander would waste resources in that way," said Solon. "I think this stoneman captain had ideas above his station."

"He had a darkburn," said Huldarion.

"He did. But he could not have expected it to do much harm, since we all have stones."

"Not all the stones worked," said Huldarion, fingering the one within his pocket.

"Well, they're all dead now anyway," said Solon with grim satisfaction. Huldarion found that he did not share it.

Could their aim have been to test the efficacy of the Riders' stones against the darkburn? Could the enemy – or their superiors – have thought there was a chance some stones might fail?

Now he could not ask the prisoner. Neither could he demand to know what was meant by the old stones. Asking would most probably have been fruitless anyway; but it was unsatisfactory all round.

"What should we do with the corpses?" Landel asked. A soft-hearted man. Huldarion would have readily left the corpses to feed the crows and moorhounds, were they not on Olbeth's land.

"In a shallow grave," he said curtly. "Well away from the farmhouse." He delegated the task to Landel and four others. As he turned aside from them, he saw Meya a few yards away, looking shocked. So he walked over to her.

"I wish you were not here, just now," he told her. The two Kelvhan maids with her bashfully retreated; why had they not persuaded her to move back to safety? Well, Meya was not easily persuaded to do anything. But he hoped she had not heard herself being called a Kelvhan bitch and whore.

"That was... quite brutal," Meya said, sounding a little stunned. Huldarion nodded sympathetically.

"That is war," he answered.

"War? That wasn't war! That was the slaughter of an unarmed captive! It was barbaric and uncalled for." She sounded not upset after all, but outraged.

"Thoronal was a little hasty in his reactions, I admit," he said. "Solon was obliged to step in. But the stonemen were hardly blameless." He looked at the two downcast maids. "Will you escort the Lady Meya to the house? Or to her carriage, whichever she prefers."

"Yes, sir," said one of them, with an awkward bob. He recalled that she was Piril, the Kelvhan maid whose brother had lost his head in that botched assassination attempt in the music hall. No wonder she was looking so aghast at the sight of death. She had her arm protectively around the other girl, whose head was bowed – presumably in weeping, although he could not see her face. He pitied them both.

"Go, girls," said Meya dismissively. "I do not need you." As the pair hurried away, she frowned at him.

"Will there be more out there?" she asked.

"Perhaps. I think it unlikely," he replied. "This small group must have slipped through the net of our patrols."

She looked out at the fields. "The man said they aimed to kill both you and me."

So she had heard that much, then. "Yes. But they could not succeed."

"But the enemy know where we are," said Meya.

"They do. An army is a difficult thing to hide – but their army no less than theirs; and our scouts have found no stoneman army. In any case, soon we shall be gone."

"Not Aliya. She'll be staying here. What should I do? Should I stay here with her?"

So that was the real issue. Urgency made her voice high. Huldarion considered before replying with decision. He wanted Meya with him, not for his personal comfort, he assured himself, but as proof of his alliance with the might of Kelvha.

"No. You should leave; or your carriages should leave, at least, so that any spies who may observe us will believe that you have gone. They won't know about Aliya's presence. And if by chance they've guessed that she is here, they will assume that she has left with you. Once the provision sheds have been emptied and the Riders have moved out, the stonemen won't waste time on this place. Yet, even so, it will not be undefended."

"So you told me earlier." Meya stared into the distance. "What was that strange ringing note I heard before the horns?"

"That was an alarm," said Huldarion.

Thankfully she seemed to accept the explanation, for she merely nodded. "Maybe you're right. Maybe Aliya will be safer if she is not with me. But it's a wrench to leave her here. I can only do it because I know she will not miss me much."

"Oh but," said Huldarion, and stopped, not knowing which direction reassurance ought to take.

She sighed, and turned to look into his eyes. "I ask you to vow that no harm will come to my daughter. You must give me your word."

"I give you my word," he said, although even as he promised it he wondered at himself. For how could he be entirely sure of Aliya's safety, wherever she might be?

Or of Meya's support. The thought came to him that if anything were to happen to Aliya, Meya would leave him. Her troth to him was nothing compared to the love that bound her to her daughter.

And if she left him, his alliance with Kelvha would crumble. His chance of victory in winning back Caervonn would be as naught. His crown depended, it was true, on many things; but few so fragile as the well-being of a little girl enamoured of a baby pig.

Chapter 11

"What am I doing here?" Tamu asked aloud.

Luckily nobody was close enough to hear his words except Leor, who was riding moodily alongside him on his lanky horse; and Tamu did not mind the wizard hearing his self-doubts. He had already discovered that Leor had so many self-doubts of his own that he accepted the expression of such thoughts as merely natural.

"You are seeing the world," responded Leor glumly, as if such a thing were not desirable at all. And indeed the part of the world that they were currently seeing – two days from the relative comfort of the farmstead – was a stony and unwelcoming, if spectacular place.

The spectacle was provided by the narrow band of mountains that marched two miles to their left. Those hills had teeth: bare, jagged peaks of greyish rock that sprouted from the yellow slopes below. Tamu presumed that the yellow was vegetation, and hoped that the brown ants that moved across it were goats. Or possibly antelope. Surely not lions, following this long line of Riders, this great rambling herd of potential prey...

"What are those animals over there?" he asked.

"Deer," said Leor, without looking. "I expect Huldarion will send a few archers over to get some, to supplement the stores. No-one farms this land."

As he spoke a small group left the train and began to gallop over to the mountain slopes, bows slung across their backs. Tamu recognised some of the Ioben hunters – the ones who had not stayed behind at the farmstead with Veron.

Tamu found that he was learning the different elements of this army he had joined. As well as the main body of the Riders, and the Ioben hunters in their fur-lined cloaks, there was a smattering of soldiers from Melmet and its neighbours in the north. Yaret had introduced him to a pair from Gostard, a place too primitive and distant to have ever featured in the Kelvhan chronicles: a grizzled man called Jerred, and a big, loose-tongued fellow, Inthed.

And then there were the Kelvhan volunteers – not just the priest Hokiro, but also the two women. Although most of the Riders thought they were both maidservants from Kelvha Castle, Tamu knew better. He had recognised the Lady Janeya as soon as he saw her, even in her maid's plain garb and hairstyle, with a face ravaged by crying. He knew the secret that Janeya had not died but had been smuggled out of Kelvha: and he knew that Meya knew, and Meya knew he knew.

So, despite his gratitude to Meya for giving him a temporary escape from Kelvha Castle, he was staying well out of her way. He kept company sometimes with Hokiro, an educated man whom he found congenial when they kept to the subject of old books. But Tamu was wary of the priest's enthusiasm for Borgun, always close to the surface; and warier still because of their shared knowledge of the ancient bowl.

When he had recognised the recent singing of that bowl he had assumed Hokiro was responsible – or, rather, irresponsible. But afterwards many Riders seemed to have accepted the theory that the ringing was a strange fluke of the wind. Yaret had talked about a cave she knew which produced a similar echoing song; and Uld had mentioned some nearby rock formation that supposedly hummed in the breeze. Other people seemed to think it was a warning bell of Leor's making. The more Leor denied it, the more they clung to this belief.

And so the truth had been kept secret. But Tamu remained wary of Hokiro. However, he had taken to Leor, divining that the wizard was something of a fellow-misfit here amongst the Vonn. Leor was, he thought, well-meaning but awkward despite his age and accumulated lore; a man who questioned himself constantly.

So he stuck by Leor as they rode. He was not enjoying the journey. His tetchy, self-willed horse made for an uncomfortable ride; the teeth of those bad-tempered mountains snarled at him.

But it was not for Leor's company that Tamu was here. Nor was it for any wish to see the wider world, which seemed to him an unpredictable and perilous place. Once out of the city he could have made his own way back to his homeland and his mother many days ago.

Yet he had stayed on with the Vonnish army: and his despairing query had been a rhetorical one. Why was he here? He knew exactly why.

It was for Parthenal. It was to be close to Parthenal. Parthenal, to whom he barely spoke, with whom he had exchanged a whole two casual greetings in the last four days; yet who blazed across his consciousness like an extra, brighter, sun. At the very name of Parthenal – at the merest distant glimpse of him between the carts – Tamu felt those wings inside his chest unfold and beat, as hard as his heart was beating, and although he knew those wings would never be allowed to fly he could not cast them off.

All that he could do was to go wherever Parthenal went. Now and then he was rewarded – or tormented – by the fleeting sight of Parthenal on his horse, so straight and graceful, mounting or dismounting with a flexing of the hard muscles in his long thighs; and Tamu was, at rare enchanting moments, enthralled by the sound of Parthenal's clear voice as he spoke amongst his comrades.

Tamu knew that he could never be included in their number. His dreams of acquiring courage and fine sword skills – like his dreams of acquiring height and grace – were, he knew, entirely laughable. None the less he longed not just to be near Parthenal but to serve him, however unobtrusively or secretly, in any way he could. He had no idea what form that way might take.

So here he was, being jolted onward on his hastily hired horse, underneath a lowering grey sky, with a set of rocky grinning teeth on one side and a gloomy wizard on the other.

He looked across at Leor, who was stroking his long red beard with one hand as he rode. His bright hair with its snowy streaks was raised behind him like a flag although there was no breeze that Tamu could detect. A tiny magical display of vanity, perhaps. But he sympathised with the wizard's downcast spirits.

"Your magic will prove biddable in time," he reassured Leor. "You just need to practise it. Like learning to ride a horse."

"Hmm," said Leor. "But I know my horse. My horse is a loyal, steadfast beast. It has four legs and two ears and a hungry stomach like all horses." He leant forward to give his bony steed Bryddesda an affectionate pat. "Yet although I've lived with my own wizardry for centuries I do not understand it. I don't know where my magic comes from, nor how nor why. It's a problem that I've mulled over and then shrugged off in the past. But I find it becomes increasingly important."

"None of us knows where our lives come from, or why," said Tamu.

"In your case, parents," said Leor gruffly. "I didn't even have those, to the best of my knowledge."

Tamu thought, and tried again. "We don't have to understand water in order to drink it or swim in it," he said.

"But the understanding helps."

"We don't have to know–"

"Enough," said Leor. "No more analogies, I beg you. I appreciate your wish to help, Tamu, but this is something only I can solve. No-one else alive can appreciate this mystery of my magic."

"Except Adon," said Tamu.

Leor let out a sound between a groan and a grunt. "Except Adon... I wonder if he does understand it. I wonder if he even tries. I doubt that he lets that or any other uncertainty disturb him." He twisted in the saddle to gaze around. "And I wonder where he is," he muttered.

"Surely you'd know if he was here – hidden, or in disguise?"

"Not necessarily. I'm told that when I try to camouflage myself, I leave a shimmer. Adon has learnt to do his shape-shifting more effectively." Leor craned his neck around again, before resuming his position with a sigh. "Actually, I suspect we would all know if Adon were here, because he would not want to hide himself for very long. He's too fond of attention; he likes an audience. He wouldn't be able to resist some showy gesture."

"Like blowing up a sheep, you mean?"

Leor compressed his lips. After a moment he said, "I am nothing like Adon. That wasn't done for show."

"Your magic seemed to think it was," Tamu remarked. Then, feeling sorry for the wizard, he went on, "I'll take your word for it that Adon isn't in our train. I suppose any strangers would be immediately noticed anyway."

"Perhaps," said Leor. "But I think if Adon is anywhere nearby, he'll be with the Kelvhan army. He seems to have allied himself to some extent with Nerogun, if not the rest of them. It's a very uneasy situation. But I'm not sure what Huldarion can do about it other than keeping a close watch on Nerogun."

"He's hardly doing that, is he? Unless he's set spies in the Kelvhan camp."

"Not to my knowledge," said Leor, "which is, admittedly, not comprehensive."

"I thought we would have met up with the Kelvhans before now."

"Later. They aren't interested in the Place of Terns."

"Then they've probably sent their own scouts here to check on us. Are you sure there are no Kelvhan snoopers lurking behind us now?" He was partly joking, but Leor answered with a worried frown.

"No, I'm not sure. Now I come to think of it, you're right. Kelvha may well have spies close by. But I can't detect them... Curse it all!" the wizard exclaimed irritably. "Damn my stupidity! What use am I? There could be anyone out there. Not just Kelvhans. Stonemen. Even, as you said, Adon himself."

"Don't curse yourself," said Tamu, surprised at this reaction. "If Kelvha wants to keep an eye on us, what does it matter? What can the Kelvhans – or even stonemen – learn about us that they don't already know? What can they do? There's no concealment for an ambush anywhere round here."

But Leor shook his head in self-disgust and desolation. "That's not the point. My ineffectiveness is the point."

"Try not to be so hard upon yourself," said Tamu gently. He thought about how frequently he had despised his own timidity, his failures, his many frailties. Sometimes you could break through them, he reflected, but generally you couldn't. Or he couldn't. All the same, it hurt to see this tall and mighty wizard in the same despairing state.

"I have nothing but ignorance to show for centuries of effort," said Leor, his voice low. Tamu did not know what to say. None the less, out of pity for the wizard he thought of a consoling answer.

"You will have had a great effect, Leor. It's just that it's not evident to you. But it will have been evident to others. You will have made a difference. Many differences." This sounded like a feeble reassurance to his ears.

Perhaps not to Leor's ears, however; for the wizard raised his head, set back his shoulders, and spoke with more decision.

"You're right, of course. I have done some things well: and I will do more hereafter."

"Of course you will," said Tamu encouragingly.

"I will protect this train from spies, to start with."

"Will you? How?"

"My magic shall decide."

"Your magic? Like it did back at the farm?"

"This is different. I do this in consideration, not through self-indulgent anger, nor for show. No sheep will die this time."

"But, Leor, are you sure that that it's a good idea to let your—"

Tamu's sentence died out unfinished. For Leor had relaxed upon his horse, his eyes closed not in slumber but as if drinking in some deep contemplative idea.

And Tamu had the sense of his surroundings shifting.

He glanced round in alarm. What was happening? There was no unusual noise, no sudden movement, no attack of stonemen; nothing at all to cause nervousness. Yet something had just changed.

It took him another minute – during which Leor sat on his horse with closed eyes – to work out what it was. The change was in the sky: or rather, in those heavy rolls of cloud which stretched from bleak horizon to horizon.

They were moving across the mountain tops far to his left; not swiftly, but enough to be already blunting those sharp teeth in a dull foggy film. Twenty seconds later, the teeth could not be seen at all.

Bewildered, Tamu looked ahead, past all the carts and Riders. He saw the clouds there too begin to gather, to roil themselves up – slowly at first but with increasing speed – to form great heaving clumps which merged into one cloud: one long, low, heavy, reddish, opaque cloud that looked as dense as earth. The Riders were murmuring, pointing at the sky and commenting on this curious weather. Many hurriedly shook out cloaks from their packs and donned them, in expectation of hail or thunderous rain.

None fell. The cloud – no longer plural, but a growing, single, massive, sky-wide thing – was gradually descending, as if some dark grey-brownish roof were lowering itself towards the plain, above the marching army. Beneath it was increasing shadow.

Tamu felt a sudden panic lest the cloud should come right down upon the Riders like a smothering blanket, to totally conceal them – blind them – or consume them.

"Leor!" he cried out. "Open your eyes, Leor!"

The wizard's eyes flew open. He looked startled at the sight of the endless bank of cloud sinking inexorably earthwards.

"Was that me?" he breathed. "Did I do that?"

Tamu did not answer. In fearful wonder he watched the cloud continue to descend. He could no longer see the mountains. They had been completely swallowed up.

Ahead of him the long vista of the plain was becoming flattened, its sky turning to a low shadowed roof. The cloud pressed down and down, until Tamu felt that he would only have to raise his hand to touch it. He imagined that it would feel as clammy and as cold as clay.

He noticed others tentatively doing just that, putting up their hands: and realised that the roof of cloud was in fact some twenty feet or so above the ground. But even twenty feet felt far too close. How much further would the cloud descend?

Instinctively Tamu flinched, cowering on his horse, which snorted in distaste but did not seem to be afflicted with the same fear that assailed him. He dared not look up any longer in case his gaze pulled down the cloud around him like a curtain, to envelop him entirely.

"Well," said Leor's voice, sounding a little ragged: an uncertain mixture of triumph and shock. "The stonemen certainly won't be spying on us now!"

Tamu risked a glance upwards. There loomed the massive cloud above him, no longer in descent – but low, so low and heavy that it seemed to push him down. The long line of the wondering Vonn rode on beneath its rust-brown roof, as if riding into the mouth of a vast dim tunnel that led deep underground.

Chapter 12

"We shouldn't be moving on so fast," protested Rothir. "We have no idea where we're going."

Parthenal peered into the gloom. "I don't see why we need to stop. Our route lies straight ahead, and there are no obstacles, not so much as a bush for miles. So we're hardly going to walk into a tree, are we?"

"We could walk into anything," retorted Rothir. "A ditch."

"We'd see *that*," said Parthenal.

"After you toppled into it headlong."

Parthenal reached over and patted his arm. "Stop worrying, dwarf. We're not going to topple anywhere. We can still see for a hundred yards."

"Much less than that," said Rothir, who felt a sharp alarm. "Beyond that, it's like night."

"A dim brown night, though, not a pitch-black one."

Rothir thought his friend was much too sanguine about this unexpected freak of the weather. A fog-bank? It was more than that. Rothir had never seen a fog-bank descend so evenly – so menacingly – and then hover twenty feet above the ground. Was it a spell cast by their enemy?

Whatever it was, they were all riding through this dimly-lit underworld, or undercloud, with the dirty red-brown roof above them. It was the colour of earth but formless. He would have thought it was a sand-storm, but there was no wind. Most unnatural. Rothir felt as if the foggy ceiling might just fall, collapse, at any minute, like a landslide, and bury the whole Vonn army underneath it.

"I wonder what Leor thinks of this?" he said, turned round to look back for the wizard. Although he could just see Leor in the gloom, gazing upwards, he could not stop and wait for him without holding up the progress of the other Riders.

And Huldarion seemed determined to keep marching on. His horse was barely visible at the head of the train, in the shadow of the dark cloud-ceiling; yet he showed no slackening his pace despite the drastically limited view.

"We know where we're heading for," said Parthenal with aggravating ease. "And the faster we keep going, the sooner we'll be through and out the other side. Oh, for stars' sake. What now?"

Just in front of them, Yaret's horse had halted suddenly, causing exactly the sort of blockage that Rothir had wanted to avoid. Other Riders cried out in warning and reproach as they were forced to swerve around her.

She was still stationary when Rothir and Parthenal pulled their horses up alongside hers. Maeneb too had stopped to see what was the matter.

"It's Poda," said Yaret, a little shamefacedly, shaking the reins without effect. "She doesn't want to move. She doesn't like the cloud. And I don't want to whip her on, because she likes that even less, and I can't say I blame her."

"She's always been a nervy animal," said Rothir. He allowed Narba to walk up to Poda until the two horses were close enough to rub shoulders, the black beside the glossy chestnut, so that their manes combined. He imagined himself similarly rubbing shoulders with Yaret, his dark shaggy hair against her rusty brown; and immediately shook the idea off as a foolish whim.

"Give Poda a few moments with Narba and Alda. She knows them well," he told Yaret.

"When she sees them moving off, she might decide to follow. Parthenal? Keep Alda on Yaret's other side." He reflected that riding was not second nature to Yaret as it was to the men and women of the Vonn.

She rode better than Tamu, however. As he came up, his companion Leor stopped, but Tamu had some difficulty controlling his small horse: he ended up several yards away with it stamping underneath him.

Parthenal turned his head away so that Tamu would not see his smile. Rothir was glad of it, because his friend was not always so considerate. He could be cruel to those he took against. But he did not generally take against the weak or vulnerable.

"Well, this is unusual, isn't it?" said Parthenal, gesticulating upwards. "Ever seen anything like this before, Leor?"

"I... no," said Leor. He looked slightly dazed.

"Is it something we should be worried about, do you think?" Maeneb asked him.

"I... no," the wizard said, again. "I think... it is probably benign."

"Only probably?" queried Rothir.

"How can you be sure?" asked Yaret. "I've never heard of any phenomenon like this. What makes you think that it's benign? It could be some trap set by your enemy. Adon." She voiced Rothir's own concern, but Leor shook his head vigorously.

"It is not," he answered with conviction. "He has nothing to do with this. Of that I am quite certain."

"Really? Why?" asked Rothir.

"Because I know magic." And Leor raised his head to stare up at the massive cloud with an air almost of triumph.

Rothir and Parthenal looked at each other. Parthenal shrugged.

"Good enough for me," he said, and glanced over at the archivist. "Are you riding on, Tamu? Leor says it's safe."

"In a minute," said Tamu with a sort of gasp, tweaking the reins ineffectually. Parthenal turned his head to hide another smile.

But now it was Rothir who was impatient to move on; for while they lingered, most of the army had passed and overtaken them, disappearing into the murk ahead, although a number of the carts were still trundling some way behind.

"See if Poda will follow us now," he told Yaret, and nudged Narba into a slow walk.

Poda did not want to follow. She half reared and then skittered crabwise until she stood next to Tamu's equally reluctant horse.

"Whoa!" said Yaret. "She's still not happy."

"Dismount, and I'll lead her," Rothir suggested.

So she did, while Parthenal and Maeneb looked on impatiently, and Leor kept staring at the cloud.

Poda was just as unwilling to be led as to be ridden. She tossed her head, pulling at the harness.

"I expect Eled could persuade her," said Yaret wistfully.

"Perhaps," said Rothir, his mind suddenly filled with the image of Eled, the horse's original owner. Such a good-natured, brave young man, before his injury. Poda's nervousness had caused that when she threw him from the saddle. Though perhaps the horse had also saved him afterwards, by luring away the darkburn that pursued him...

All so long ago. So much had happened since. Rothir stood still for a moment while a small unseen cloud of memory enveloped him. Then he shook his head, and put it in a box, and encouraged Poda once again to *Move!* Instead the horse swung her lowered head from side to side.

"You'd best ride on," said Yaret. "She's bound to follow you eventually."

By now the carts were catching them up. Another Rider trotted over from them to offer help; although Rothir realised glumly that this wasn't a Rider after all, but Piril, one of the

maids from Kelvha Castle, who would be even less experienced with horses than Yaret. She was riding Yaret's moth-eaten hack Helba.

"Is she at a standstill? My brother always said, if all else fails, try an apple," said Piril. A quietly-spoken young woman, he thought she easily went unnoticed – a talent she had probably honed within the castle. Yet, surprisingly, here she was, accompanying the Vonn. She produced an apple from somewhere in her drab clothing.

"No, no, you don't get it yet," Yaret told Poda as the horse reached its nose out. "You have to walk for it."

Even with the apple as bait Poda was slow to move. By the time she deigned to walk, the last of the Riders up ahead were barely visible, melting into the brown shadow of the cloud. The carts and carriages were rolling slowly past some fifty yards to their left.

But having crunched the apple Poda began to strut forward, with lofty dignity, and they could all move on. Rothir was relieved. Although the trail of hoof-prints and wheel-ruts left by the army was easy enough to follow, it would be disconcerting to lose sight of the actual train itself. He strained to see into the gloom ahead; the vague outline of the hindmost Riders was just visible.

"Where's Jebil?" he overheard Yaret say.

"Languishing in the Lady Meya's carriage," came Piril's murmured answer.

"Languishing?"

"Still," said Piril.

Meanwhile Parthenal, who was riding back and forth on Alda, reported that they were travelling in the right direction. "But those carts are going off course," he added.

Rothir looked across at the carts and carriages, shrouded in a deep veil of shadow. They were now a hundred yards away instead of fifty.

"Perhaps. But not by much. We should keep following the main army."

"Maybe I should ride back over to the carts and make sure they know where they're going," suggested Piril.

"Don't do that!" said Rothir. "Poda might just stop again if you ride off. Better stay together."

"They shouldn't get lost," Parthenal reassured her. "They've got a good strong trail to follow."

"Many things can make trails," said Tamu, and then looked at the ground as if he wished he hadn't spoken.

"They can, it's true; but not out here," said Parthenal with kindly condescension.

"In any case," Yaret told Piril, "you'd probably get lost yourself, because I can't see the carts at all now."

Neither could Rothir. They had disappeared quite suddenly. When he listened he could still hear the faint trundling of the wheels, but the twilight underneath the cloud had swallowed up all sight of them.

"They'll just have to look after themselves," he said. Turning to face front again, he swore under his breath. In the few seconds that he'd looked away, the rear of the army had also disappeared into the gloom. There was nothing but the trodden grass to guide them.

Rothir felt the weight of responsibility descend upon him, as oppressive and inescapable as the cloud. He had left Kelvha with a carefree heart; but it could only ever have been a temporary respite. The habit of responsibility was ingrained in him, he was all too aware. He peered into the gloom, in vain: his view was confined to a band of shadow.

"Leor? Can't you give us a bit of light?" begged Parthenal, half-jokingly.

"Light?" said Leor, as if he barely heard. He looked quite distracted. In fact, Rothir was not convinced that light would help. He felt as if this cloud would somehow smother light: absorb it.

"Let's just keep going," he said. "We can follow the hoof-prints."

So they rode on, the seven of them close together, along the trail marked out in mud.

"This strange weather has to clear sometime," remarked Parthenal after a while. "Leor, what do you think?"

"I can't tell," the wizard answered. Tamu cast him a quick, thoughtful glance.

"Ah!" said Parthenal. "I saw that look. Tamu, perhaps you know something that we don't?"

Tamu cleared his throat. "Um, no, nothing useful," he murmured. "I've never read about anything like this in all my books."

"And I suppose that's what really counts," said Parthenal lightly. The archivist stared at the ground. Parthenal, with a faint smile in his voice, added, "Actually, any shred of booklore about this type of weather would be very welcome."

"I don't have any," muttered Tamu.

The rumbling of the carts had faded from their ears entirely now. Well, thought Rothir, the carts will find the path eventually. Parthenal is right – this cloud must clear, or lift, some time... so long as we aren't all riding round in circles.

For the hoofmarked trail ahead of them was curving to avoid a ring of low, weatherbeaten rocks, the remnants of some ancient habitation. Once they had gone round those ruins, however, the track appeared to stretch out straight again.

Until, suddenly, it didn't. There was an unexpected splash. Instead of muddy grass they found themselves floundering through water.

"What?" said Leor, as Bryddesda's hooves sprayed small fountains. "Where are we?" He spoke as if he had just been awoken roughly from a dream.

"In the water," answered Rothir curtly. He allowed his horse to walk on, but with great caution. Narba was splashing up to his fetlocks in murky shallows. At least it didn't seem to get any deeper; but it only needed to be an inch deep to completely hide the army's trail.

"They must have ridden through this," Parthenal called out to the others, "so we shall too."

"Is it an overflowing stream, or a pool?" asked Yaret.

"So far as I can tell, there is no current."

"And it smells fresh, not stagnant," Piril observed.

"Wetlands," suggested Parthenal. "Perhaps this is the beginning of the Red Roads, which as I understand are actually shallow waterways. In which case, we can expect a lot of this."

Rothir rode on ahead of the others, Narba tramping sturdily through the water. Although its surface was a dark mirror showing and reflecting nothing in the gloom, it remained only a few inches deep at most. Beneath Narba's careful tread, he could feel the ground was firm: there was no sticking of his horse's hooves. Indeed, it sometimes felt as hard as rock. None the less he was wary lest it should suddenly grow deeper.

Leor, however, charged on, splashing noisily and recklessly past him with no such fears. Rothir found himself almost willing the wizard to flounder in an unseen sinkhole, as payment for his lack of caution.

But evidently Leor's confidence was justified; for he cried out, triumphantly, "It's getting shallower! I see the end of it. Yes! Here's the shore!" The wizard turned to face the others, grinning as if he'd saved them all. Rothir could see that Bryddesda's hooves stood once again on grass, and felt a surge of thankfulness.

"The end of it?" said Maeneb doubtfully. She was staring out beyond Leor, into the broad gloomy tunnel created by the overhanging cloud. Rothir lifted his eyes from the water to look out for the Vonnish army.

No army could be seen. No living being at all. But there was something in the gloom, only thirty yards ahead, unmoving.

As he rode out of the water onto squelching turf, the thing took on a firmer shape. It was as broad as it was high, and flat-topped, uniformly grey: a looming, murky tower built out of shadow.

Chapter 13

"What place is that?" breathed Yaret.

"Is it stone? It's so smooth that I can't tell," said Maeneb.

"Perhaps it's a guard tower or a roundhouse. Only it's too tall for a roundhouse," said Yaret.

"And it's not round," said Rothir. Riding out of the water, he warily approached the tower. It looked more substantial the closer that he got.

He saw that, far from being built out of shadow, it was constructed from large, finely hewn stones, almost black in this unnatural gloom, and closely fitted without mortar. The cracks between the blocks could barely be discerned; yet the walls appeared weathered, even ancient.

The tower was, he judged, a little more than twenty feet in height. The roof of cloud seemed to hover just above its flattened top. The sides facing them were windowless and doorless. Several sides: for while the tower was not round, neither was it square; the walls adjoined at shallow angles.

"It might be a hexagon, like the towers of Caervonn," said Parthenal, echoing Rothir's own thought.

But Leor, sliding off his horse to walk up to the wall, said, "Not six-sided. Maybe eight." With that he began to pace around the building, and was soon out of their view. Rothir had the irrational feeling that he might vanish altogether; but a few seconds later the wizard reappeared, stroking his long beard and saying, "Seven."

"It's seven-sided?" asked Maeneb.

"Yes. I wonder why."

"It would be a horribly difficult thing to plan and build," said Parthenal.

"Not really," offered Tamu. "Quite simple, actually. All you need is a piece of string."

"String?"

"Use it as a compass to draw a circle. Draw a straight line from the circle's centre to the edge. Draw another circle of the same size centred on where that line meets the first circle."

"What?" said Maeneb.

Tamu went on doggedly. "Then draw a straight line between the points where the two circles intersect. Set one end of your compass at that line's midpoint, and let the other end be at one of the intersections. Starting from that intersection use that length of string to draw an arc that cuts through the circle. From that point draw another arc, and so on in the same way all around the circle until you have seven points and are back at your starting place. It's not quite a perfect heptagon but it's close. It's a technique mentioned in the Mathematical Asides of Prince Gorun."

Parthenal glanced down at him in considerable surprise. "Well, I'll take your word for that," he said. "Do you memorise all the books you read?"

"Not all. I like mathematics," said Tamu.

"And is there such a thing as a seven-sided tower in your chronicles?"

Wordlessly, Tamu shook his head.

"Did you find an entrance, Leor?" asked Rothir.

"There is no door that I could see," the wizard said. "And no windows either. It's totally enclosed, unless the top is open. Maybe one could climb a ladder to look... but there's no ladder, nor any other way to climb it." His eyes gleamed as he stood back to survey the tower, with a baffled yet curiously triumphant air. "Perhaps it's some sort of ceremonial edifice."

"But even if it is, I don't understand," said Rothir. Like the others, he dismounted and stood staring at the tower. It narrowed slightly towards the top; despite Tamu's assurance that it

would be simple to design, it would surely be an awkward thing to build, he thought, requiring much skill in the shaping and fitting of those cornerstones. "I've seen Huldarion's maps, and there ought to be no tower or any other building for thirty miles in each direction."

"Maybe the maps are wrong," suggested Parthenal. "Or too old."

"But this tower must be old too," said Maeneb. She laid her hand upon the stones, and then withdrew it sharply, with a gasp. "It's warm!"

In quick alarm, they all stepped backward. *Darkburn*, thought Rothir, immediately visualising one somehow imprisoned behind these walls.

"There's no aura," said Yaret. Rothir realised this was true: no sense of fear pervaded him. Stepping forward to the tower again, he reached out his hand to lay it flat upon the stone. It was warm indeed: but pleasantly so, not hot, the same temperature as his horse's skin, as if the wall had been basking in the sun instead of being enswathed in cloud.

"It feels odd," he said.

Yaret walked up beside him and also spread her hand upon the wall. "There's a pulse," she said after a few seconds. "A vibration. Is that what you feel?"

"I can feel something; but I thought it was my own pulse," said Rothir. She laid her fingers briefly on his wrist.

"Yours is slower than mine," she said, "but not as slow as this." He was very conscious of her cool touch, which seemed to over-ride other sensations. Such an unusual thing to feel another person's hand against his own. As she removed it, he concentrated on the wall; and realised that the deep, faint, heavy beat he felt was certainly too slow to match his heart. Perhaps it was a vibration caused by the distant marching of the army... although he had never previously experienced such a thing.

"Like a heartbeat of the stone," he said. The others came up to join him, tentatively laying hands upon the wall with various exclamations of surprise. Last of all the seven came Leor.

"I've travelled through this land before," the wizard said, "though not for many years, I must admit. And yet I never came across this tower, or even heard of its existence. It's a marvel that has been revealed to us for reasons not yet clear." He sounded almost proud as he laid his own long fingers on the stones in a proprietorial way.

At once Parthenal cried out a sharp warning. The others all jumped back a second time.

For an opening had appeared beneath the wizard's hand. A vertical slit had grown, rapidly widening, the stones on either side appearing to shrink back, or perhaps re-shape themselves, to create an entrance. It happened so swiftly that Rothir could not see the mechanism.

Yet a second later a tall, thin doorway, looking as if it had always been there, offered a way in through the wall. Beyond it all was dark.

"What spell did you do, Leor?" asked Parthenal, his voice hushed in amazement.

"No spell," said Leor, equally subdued. "That just... happened." Slowly he withdrew his outstretched hand, which rested now not on grey stone but on the empty air. Behind it, through the narrow entrance, lay a chamber full of shadow.

"Do we go in?" murmured Yaret.

"We appear to be invited," said Rothir, "for why else throw the door open? Maeneb? Do you detect anyone inside?"

Maeneb listened and then shook her head, though not with certainty. "No. At least I don't think so. But there's just a... There is something there; not human, though. Something dormant. I don't know what it is."

"Then let us find out," said Parthenal. "I'll go first. Just wait a moment." Returning to Alba, he withdrew his sword from the sheath affixed to the horse's saddle. The singing of the blade was like a call to arms; but Rothir felt strangely certain that no arms were necessary here.

Distrusting that instinct, he too retrieved his sword. Then he walked in behind Parthenal, through the narrow gap into the darkness, for he would not let his riding partner face unknown peril on his own.

The walls were a full yard thick. Inside, the air was warm. Rothir was aware of the others trailing in behind, their curiosity greater than their fear, and wondered how many of them bore weapons. But he perceived no foe in here against which a sword might be required.

What he saw amidst the shadow was a chamber, narrowing slightly to the roof, or rather to no roof: for the tower was open to the sky, or what would have been the sky were it not shrouded by that overarching mass of cloud which let in a dim furtive light. The floor was made of beaten earth, the only thing upon it – the only object in here – being a high stone plinth to one side, upon which stood a great statue, taller than Parthenal by some distance. It appeared to represent an animal, for it had four legs... Or no, perhaps it was a bird; because as Rothir's eyes adjusted to the gloom he thought he made out wings.

But he could not make out any more for the first few seconds, until Leor walked in behind him. At once the chamber leapt up into visibility, lit by a golden glow.

"Good magic," remarked Parthenal in an undertone.

"That wasn't me," the wizard muttered.

Rothir said nothing. He was gazing in wonder at the statue on the plinth. Brought suddenly to vividness, it shone and sparkled with a hundred different hues. There appeared to be a pattern of intricate stone inlays set into the statue's metal surface. Was it bronze? Or copper?

He walked a little closer. It was the statue of an animal – obviously some mythical creature, for it was made up of several elements. It had the feet and body of a lion, proudly sitting on its haunches; the narrow head of a dog or possibly a wolf, inlaid with greys and silvers; the strong wings of an eagle, half-outstretched – though greater far than any eagle's, and striped with greens and blues – and a fully outspread peacock tail whose feathers dazzled in a delicate filigree of coppery metal and many-coloured gems. The stone eyes stared out over his head: and everyone stared back at it in awe.

The realisation came to him only slowly.

"Parthenal," he said, "we have seen this thing before."

Parthenal took a step back, drawing a breath in sharply as he understood.

"But it was not like this," he said.

"No. It was burnt," said Rothir, and turning to the others he explained. "Last year, while we were riding after the stonemen who had captured Arguril, we saw a creature like this one, which we assumed had escaped its cage and had been abandoned by the stonemen. It had the feet and body of a lion, the head of a dog, and the wings of an eagle – or rather, the remains of wings, for they were burnt almost to shreds. It attacked us. It was a darkburn."

"But unlike any other darkburn we have ever come across," said Parthenal. "It was not indistinct, as so many of them are. Its shape was clear, and quite extraordinary. I remembered I had seen a picture of a similar creature, years ago, in an old story book: I can't remember its name now, but it was about a knight who travelled far to the west and met all sorts of extraordinary beings–"

"The Uirsegleave," said Tamu's voice. "That's, um, that's the name of the book."

"What? Do you know it?" Parthenal turned his wondering gaze from the statue to the archivist.

"We have more than one copy in the castle archives," Tamu said. "It's a famous book. In fact the creature here appears in several ancient tales. It's called a Semmuru."

"A Semmuru," repeated Parthenal, turning back to face the statue.

"It's a beautiful thing," said Yaret reverently. "Just look at the artistry of those inlays. That must be jet and quartz set on the head, and is it feldspar? I don't know the names of all these

gems. But surely opal on the wings, and turquoise; and maybe garnet and polished ironstone on the legs."

"Chalcedony," murmured Tamu. "Tourmaline."

"It's certainly quite remarkable. What do you know about this legendary creature, Leor?" asked Rothir.

Leor shook his head, gazing transfixed at the statue. "Nothing. I have to admit it's something that I've never heard of. What did you call it? A Semmuru?"

And when he spoke that word, the statue moved.

Slowly, its head lifted. Its chest swelled as if it were drawing breath. The great bejewelled wings that were half spread out on either side flexed, and stretched a little further. A fore-foot shifted, extending long gold claws.

The eyes, which had been staring straight out from the head like gleaming stones, now widened, blinking once, and then looked down upon the group who stood around the plinth as if turned to stone themselves. Rothir was dumb-struck. If this thing were to attack them, what use would weapons be? He let his sword hang loosely from his hand. So did Parthenal, whose mouth had fallen open. The stone eyes moved to take them in.

After a second's immobility, Piril stepped forward. Deliberately she knelt down on the earthen floor, and placed her palms and then her face upon the ground in a gesture of abject humility. Yet with her it did not look abject. It looked quite natural, as if it were something she were accustomed to.

"Lord Semmuru," said Piril, in her quiet, even voice, which seemed designed to be as unobtrusive as possible, "we pay you homage."

"Lady Semmuru," said Tamu in an undertone, "so I believe. Or maybe both. Or neither."

The great head slowly turned to face Piril. Not a wolf, but a hunting dog, thought Rothir, a hound, like Olbeth's hounds if they wore gems instead of hair.

"Arac Semmuru." The words came from the head although the mouth did not appear to move. The voice was husky, grainy, neither male nor female: it echoed round the chamber as if the cloud lying heavily above the roof trapped the sound within.

"Arac Semmuru," said Piril, lifting her head to repeat the words. "How is that you honour us with your living presence, great Arac Semmuru?"

Trained to flatter, thought Rothir; but whether through flattery or no, her supplication seemed to work. The statue answered, rising a little from its plinth, glittering with a thousand newly shining facets as it did so.

"You are one of seven," the strange voice answered huskily. "And we know you."

Piril looked nonplussed. She sat up on her knees. "We don't know you," she said.

"Yet we know you all, from your births, from your first cries," said the voice, both firm and guttural: a voice made of stone, the echoes rippling out from it to reverberate in the space like a slow whirlpool. "We know you, especially." And as the statue spoke, its jewelled head moved so that the eyes were gazing not at Piril, but on Leor.

Leor looked as nonplussed at Piril had.

"Me? You know me?"

"From your birth. From your first cry. We know you and your brother."

And now the creature flexed its wings again, so that they spread across the tower. The wing-tips almost touched the walls, the stripes of turquoise and blue cobalt flashing where they caught the light. Where did that light come from? Rothir could not tell. He felt bathed in it, warmed by it.

"What? Who-? I have no brother," protested Leor, sounding stricken.

"You and your twin. You were found together." The great wings beat with one slow single movement, creating a soft thump as if of something falling: Rothir felt the air whoosh past him.

There was a scent on the breeze that they created. Some faint spice; fresh; distant, like a pull of childhood memory, a sense of comfort and of longing.

"What do you mean," said Leor almost in a whisper, "what do you mean, we were found together?"

Slowly the wings settled again, rustling, and were still. They all waited, Leor seeming to barely breathe until the creature spoke again.

"Your mother died in bearing you," the glittering dog-head told him in that resonating voice. "She lay beside you, her flesh cooling. We took you and your new-born twin, as you lay crying next to her broken body."

"Wait," said Leor. "My mother? I had a mother? What was her?"

"Ssh," said Piril, standing up to put her hand upon the wizard's arm. "Of course you had a mother. Just listen. Let it speak, in case it stops."

Leor paused. There was silence till at last the creature spoke again. A voice of granite, or of marble – yet warm, thought Rothir; nothing cold about it.

"Because you asked for knowledge, and you have returned, as one of seven, it is ordained that you may know," it said.

"Returned?"

"Ssh," said Piril again, squeezing Leor's arm.

The statue gazed at Leor with its gleaming eyes for a long moment; then continued.

"Here you were brought as new-born babes. Here, for a little while, you both were kept, within this tower of Arac Semmuru. You were bathed in the still waters of the lake of Arac. You took the waters in. Your voices cried out and were entwined together. They cried out for a mother: so mothers were found for you. Three mothers, and three fathers."

"My guardians," said Leor, his voice barely audible. "There were six of them."

"You and your twin made seven," said the statue.

Leor frowned. "No, no; we made eight."

"You made seven. For you were joined when you were born. You were two children but your bodies were as one."

"What?" Leor's voice seemed no more than the creak of a door that did not want to open.

"You and your twin were joined," said the Arac Semmuru. "You were clasped together at the abdomen, face to face. You embraced each other. We took you up, and separated you, and healed you, with the aid of the powers of the waters of Arac. We nurtured you, for otherwise you would have died. But in the healing, you partook of the waters of the lake. It could not have been done otherwise. Thus you gained the Arac's powers."

"What?" said Leor, his voice almost inaudible. "You mean – my magic?"

There was another pause before the voice echoed around and round the tower.

"You gained the powers of Arac, you and your twin. You gained long life and health. No further could we nurture you within the tower. When you were still babes we found the guardians to care for you, as was ordained."

Leor's lips moved, but no more questions came. It was Tamu, surprisingly, who tilted his head back and asked:

"Ordained by who?"

"Ordained by time," the creature said. "By which all truth shall be revealed: from whence you came, and whither you will go."

"Time?" said Yaret.

"Whither six of us will go," said Maeneb. "Leor cannot die."

The great wings flexed once more, sending bright shards of coloured light around the chamber. Again Rothir breathed in that hint of fragrant scent like antique memory. It made him yearn for something but he knew not what.

"All living things can die, and must," the statue said. "Some further on in time than others."

"Are you yourself a living being?" asked Rothir.

Then he wished he had not spoken, for the creature – the Arac Semmuru – stood up on all four of its lion's feet. Instinctively he took a step back.

It was even larger than it had appeared when lying down. As it rose, its legs and body seemed to spark and shoot out red, gold, green, and orange fires; although, thought Rothir, all those words were insufficient, for there were so many glowing shades of each. Surely this was a thing that man had made. It stood aloft and gazed at him with jewelled eyes.

It said, "This body that you see is not alive. It is a thing created by men's and women's craft, many and many years ago. It moves and speaks through the powers that are invested in it. It serves the Arac Semmuru."

"What is the Arac Semmuru?" asked Piril.

"We are the nurturer."

"Have you always been here?" Piril had clasped her hands as if begging for something.

"For long. But the Semmuru is called on seldom. For who now knows of us? The shapers of this statue that contains us are long dead. None have called for many hundred years, till now."

"But we saw you in the west," said Parthenal, "or something like you, in a different body."

"Burnt," said Rothir in a low voice. He did not want to say the name of *darkburn* in this tower.

For many seconds the Semmuru did not answer.

"Our bodies are bereft and desecrated, filled with pain," it said at last. "Our spirits live. Yet only in this tower of Arac can we speak. This thing of stone that holds our words cannot be burnt; and so we keep it hidden."

They were all silent, digesting this, until Tamu asked, "The lake of Arac – is that the water we just crossed?"

"The lake of Arac is a lake of time. It is both within and beyond the bounds of humankind."

"I see," said Tamu. Rothir was not sure if he himself saw anything at all.

Yaret was looking up thoughtfully at the creature. "O Arac Semmuru," she said, "you opened up your tower to us. Do you ask something of us?"

"We ask for nothing," said the statue, "except that you use well the lives you have been given."

Now Parthenal took a step forward, gripping his sword. It made for a storybook picture, thought Rothir: a legendary knight confronting the great gleaming winged creature. A picture painted in gold leaf and lapis lazuli and crushed rubies.

"But what are we doing here?" demanded Parthenal. "Why did you admit us to this tower? Why have you let us in, and spoken to us?"

"Because the one in seven called to us." The shining eyes moved to fix themselves on Leor.

"What? Me? I.... I called no-one," said the wizard. He looked stunned; indeed, thought Rothir, almost horrified. "I merely let my power go where it willed."

"And it came home," proclaimed the Arac Semmuru. "It found this place where it was born. It bid you lay your hand upon the stone, and speak our name."

Leor's mouth moved again, wordlessly.

"But Leor's twin," said Maeneb. "His other half. Adon. Where is he? Can you tell?"

The immense head turned gradually, first one way, then the other, as if listening. "He is in the world."

"I wish that he were out of it," said Leor, finding his voice again fully; he sounded vehement and harsh after the slow resonant tones of the immense statue. "Adon does nothing but evil. You gave him life. Can't you stop him?"

The head stared down at him again. "Do you yourself do nought but good?"

"I try to," said Leor.

"You both are who you are," the statue said. "We are the Nurturer. We do not destroy. Time will do that."

"Time will not destroy Adon," said Leor bitterly.

"It will," the statue said. "You called upon us to reveal to you your origin: the source of your great power. Now we have told it. You are answered."

And on speaking those words the creature slowly folded up its gleaming wings, with care: the bronze legs stretched themselves and then lay down: the dark stone eyes looked steadily at each of them in turn, before becoming still, fixed on a point above their heads.

"Arac Semmuru," said Piril pleadingly. "Don't leave us."

The voice spoke with a fainter echo now: Rothir had to strain to catch it.

"We never leave you." Then it was silent.

"Arac Semmuru," said Piril, falling to her knees before the statue, which was now unmistakably a statue once again, an artefact, marvellous to look at but no longer showing any sign of life. "Arac Semmuru," she said again, her face distorting. Rothir saw to his dismay that she had started crying, in a paroxysm of grief and desolation.

Chapter 14

"Well, it's not surprising that she was upset," said Yaret. "It's the whole nurture thing."

"What nurture thing?" said Rothir.

"It's what she lacks. What she has lost." Yaret could tell Rothir was doing his best not to show irritation. She had learnt that he did not take well to tears; he felt they hampered action, were generally unnecessary; he did not know what to do about them. For that reason she doubly appreciated his almost wordless attempts to comfort her last winter, when he had found her weeping in the darkness of that far infirmary fort.

A painful, precious moment, that was often in her mind. Unwisely, perhaps. But it served to remind her of Rothir's difficulty. So she attempted to explain, while he listened with head bent, frowning and attentive.

"I know that Piril hasn't lost as much as other people: Zan, for instance, whose village was burnt down; but even so. Piril left home when she was fourteen to go and work in Kelvha Castle. She never saw her father again, because he died soon afterwards, and she hardly ever saw her mother. But she doesn't want to go back home, because she'll have to tell her mother that her brother's dead. And in such a way, too – beheaded in the music hall. Piril feels she failed to protect him. To nurture him. Not only does she lack anyone to nurture her, she thinks that she has failed to nurture. Hence her sorrow."

"How do you know all this?"

"I talk to her," said Yaret.

They were back on their horses now, riding away from the seven-sided tower. Long had they lingered in its warm interior, Yaret crouching with her arm around the quietly weeping Piril, until the golden light that had embraced them slowly faded. Nobody had wanted to forsake that jewelled presence even as its brightness dulled back into shadow.

"I don't think it's going to speak again," Tamu had eventually murmured.

"No. We'd better leave in case it decides to close the door on us," said Parthenal. So they trooped out of the tower; behind them, a few seconds later, the gap in the wall closed noiselessly and shut them out.

That brought more tears from Piril, although to Yaret she had always seemed a resilient and self-contained young woman. But the Arac Semmuru unlocked her grief. Yaret had to help her mount her horse – or rather, Yaret's sturdy packhorse Helba, who turned her head to try and nuzzle Piril's arm in sympathy.

When they first set out again, gloom both physical and mental cloaked them all; Leor in particular, thought Yaret, noting his dazed, appalled expression. She herself, like Piril, felt the loss of the Arac Semmuru as an unexpected grief. She mourned that being so beautiful and ancient, the remnant of what surely must have been a better time than now.

But there was no going back to a happier past: the only way was forward. And as they rode, the physical gloom, at least, began to lift. The cloud that blanketed the ground was slowly thinning, so that she could see a little further every minute. With the increasing visibility she realised that the ground was dotted, near and far, with the remnants of round walls, so low that they were largely overgrown with grass.

"Look: old roundhouses," she said wistfully. These were more pieces of the past, though not such a perfect and mysterious one. The roundhouses she had visited in Ioben had been damp and smoky, uncomfortable homes although the locals clung to them. There had been a few such also near her home town of Obandiro, left ruined, like old memories to be smiled at wryly. Here, there were many ancient houses. A host of circular grassy mounds outlined whole villages of unseen, unfelt ghosts.

"Ah!" said Rothir, pointing with relief. He was less interested in the ruins than in what lay between them, marked into the mud: a recent trail of hoof marks and deep wheel-ruts. "The army. We're heading in the right direction."

"The tower's gone," said Piril sadly. And when Yaret swivelled in the saddle she saw no tower behind them: nothing but a pool of water, its surface black.

"It might still be there, only hidden," she suggested. "What do you think, Leor?"

The wizard shook his head without replying. He looked almost as dismayed as Piril. His hair stood on end where he had been running his hands through it.

Yaret felt compassion for him, given what he had just learnt. Yet could it all have been such a very great surprise? She steered Poda closer to him, before saying quietly,

"It's only confirmation of what you must have suspected, Leor. That Adon is your brother."

"More than my brother. My twin! My other half! My mirror image! Conjoined with me!" Leor was distraught.

"It means you started out as equals," observed Tamu, on Leor's other side.

"And look at us now. We are hardly equals. Look at what he's done. Look at what I've failed to do."

"Exactly," said Tamu, although he did not elaborate.

"What is the Semmuru?" Parthenal enquired of the archivist. "You seem to be the expert here."

Tamu gave a small, dismissive shrug. "I don't know much. The Semmuru was quite a well-known mythical being – though evidently not mythical after all: because there it was. Or there its mouthpiece was. I wonder how many other marvellous beings are not mythical in truth, if one only knew?" He stared into the distant hills that were emerging slowly from the mist.

"How old are the accounts of the Arac Semmuru?" asked Yaret.

"In the legends it is just the Semmuru. The Arac must, I think, relate to a location; perhaps the lake it spoke of. Its origins seem unclear, but the legends go back two thousand years at least. Maybe three." Tamu's nervousness had disappeared while he spoke.

"That old?" said Parthenal in surprise.

"There were civilisations before Kelvha, you know, and even before Caervonn," said Tamu with mild reproof. Then he looked aghast at his own temerity. "That is to say – I didn't mean to imply–"

"Go on, Tamu, put Parthenal in his place," Rothir advised. "I'd be amazed if he's read a single book since that Uirsegleave you mentioned."

"Almost true. Not quite. I seem to remember the Semmuru was a benevolent creature in that story," said Parthenal.

"It did good deeds," Tamu affirmed. "It rescued people from disaster; especially children who were in trouble or in danger. It was a kindly being. But as for the lake of Arac – I've never read anything about that at all."

"Well, Leor, at least you know now where your magic came from," said Maeneb, who rode a little apart from the others. She sounded more brusque than sympathetic.

"Yes! It came to me by accident! As a by-product of being born joined to – joined to that – to the–" Leor did not finish, but clenched his fists around the reins.

"I'm sorry you didn't find out more about your mother," Piril said.

"We killed her. We killed our mother, in the act of being born," said Leor, anguished. Yaret thought he might burst into tears; and she felt that weeping aloud, though understandable in her view, would seem to him a terrible wound to his own dignity, no less than it would to Rothir.

"Don't blame yourself for that," she put in quickly. "It happens. Not just to you. It's not so rare." She thought of her own mother and her baby brother, who had died together; not at his

birth, true, but not long afterwards. A fever, she'd been told – although she remembered almost nothing of that time. Her mother was a mere haze of imagined memory, while her brother had been lost entirely behind the passing years.

"Mothers are over-rated," said Rothir gruffly, and she recalled that Rothir's mother had left home when he was sixteen. But he had had her until then; so Yaret would not allow his cynicism to go unchallenged.

"Not generally," she said. "Mothers are under-rated, if anything. Taken for granted. I expect you loved yours well enough. That's why you missed her – because she was necessary to you."

He looked over at her frowning, and seemed about to make some sharp retort; but then he nodded, answering gravely. "I beg your pardon. I'd forgotten."

"Nobody's life is simple," said Yaret, "even if it looks to be so. Leor, I think, is discovering that." She glanced across at Leor, who was no longer listening. His head was in his hands again. Bryddesda plodded on sedately without guidance, as if he were used to such behaviour on his rider's part.

"Oh, look," said Tamu. "Look, Leor, do you see? It's clearing every minute up ahead."

The shadowed trail was brightening. In a few more minutes figures became visible – the rear of the Vonnish army, a mere hundred yards away. The heavy roof of cloud had almost lifted now.

But Leor's heavy mood had not. He still rode with a wretched face and shoulders slumped. When they caught the Riders up and heard their cheerful greetings, Leor made no answer.

"What happened to you lot?" asked Ikelder, who had waited for them.

"We got lost in all that fog," said Rothir.

Ikelder nodded. "Ah well, no harm done. That was a weird freak of the cloud base, wasn't it?"

"It was."

"Never seen anything quite like it. But Huldarion's calling a halt soon. Once this weather lifts some more and we have a better view, we'll choose a campsite for the night. Are the rest of the carts very far behind you? We've only got three-quarters of them here."

"I'm not sure where the others are," said Rothir. "A few were close behind us at one time, but they were veering east. We haven't seen them since."

"They'll find us too, once they can see their way. They can't have gone too far off course," Ikelder answered confidently.

When the group of seven rejoined the body of the army, no-one enquired into what had held them up – the weather seeming cause enough – and by a mute agreement they all kept quiet about the hidden tower and its extraordinary occupant. Yaret felt that in any case she would not have known how to tell the tale. And in her opinion, it was not her tale to tell, but chiefly Leor's; so perhaps the others felt the same way too.

As for the army, it appeared that they had had an entirely uneventful march beneath the cloud. All the same they were relieved at its passing.

The uneventfulness continued. They were crossing scrubby pasture dotted with ruined houses and black pools, and abruptly cut off on the eastern side by the line of hills – lower and more distant than before, but still a daunting barrier. When Yaret looked back she could not pick out where the tower had been. And neither could she see the missing carts.

A campsite was selected, and the Riders began to unload tents. But many found themselves without a tent to raise; for they had been loaded on the lost carts, which were some fifteen in number, including Meya's second-best carriage. Yaret worried about that one, because Janeya had been in it.

After helping Delgeb and her team to pitch the women's tents, Yaret paused to rest her leg, while she gazed northward for the carts. She was not the only one. Several Riders were

scanning the horizon, muttering about bedrolls and supplies. Piril stood silently looking over to where some scouts could be seen galloping off to hunt for the missing wagons.

"I should not have left her," murmured Piril.

"I'm sure they'll turn up soon," said Yaret, although she thought it strange the carts were not in sight.

"If one had shed a wheel, or got stuck in a pond," Ikelder said, "and the others stopped to pull it out, that could hold them all up for a while. Something like that could easily explain it." His tone was kind.

Piril, biting her lip, did not answer for a moment. Then she said, "It's Jebil that I'm worried about, the Lady Meya's chambermaid. I promised to look after her – and the Lady Meya's things, and now I can't."

"There are plenty of others there who can," Delgeb assured her.

"But she's – she's not well." Piril turned to Delgeb in appeal. "May I not go out and search for her?"

Delgeb was curt. "Unnecessary," she said. "The scouts are doing that."

"Can I not ride out too?"

"Certainly not. Not on your own, at least."

"But–"

"I don't mind going to have a look, Delgeb," put in Ikelder. "I'll go with Piril, since she's so concerned." Yaret felt a rush of liking for the young man. Ungainly as he was, she knew he was an accomplished warrior, and more importantly, had good sense and good humour.

Delgeb shrugged. "Well, if you really must," she said. "No less than four of you. And clear it with Huldarion."

"Let me come, then," said Yaret immediately, because she too felt anxious about Janeya. In her former life in Kelvha Castle the girl had been so full of ardent grace. That old Janeya was dead, and she had to remain so, for her own safety – and also for the sake of the alliance with Kelvha.

But none of the men knew this. So Yaret was not sure whether to be glad or sorry when Leor raised his head and said, reluctantly, "I will accompany you too."

Had the wizard ever seen Janeya? She thought not. But Ikelder might have. Better that his discretion should not be tested: so all the more reason why she herself should go.

Huldarion's permission was swiftly granted. Ikelder came back from his chief's tent rubbing his hands and saying, "Let's set off straight away, shall we?"

He was a man who liked to be active, Yaret thought, but who did not let his wish for action cloud his judgement. She appreciated the restraint with which he led them out, checking that Piril's horse could keep up before gradually accelerating to a canter; but a gentle one, for neither Piril nor her horse enjoyed a gallop. Helba had never had much speed. Indeed, after a couple of miles they had all had enough of splashy cantering, and slowed down to a walk.

Although she thought they must have passed close by the spot where the Semmuru's tower had stood, Yaret could not identify the place. There were so many wide dark pools, no more than inches deep, their surfaces freckled with tiny skidding insects. She studied the ruined roundhouses: none had seven sides.

What sort of life would those ancient inhabitants have led? Sweetroots ought to grow well in this boggy soil. Would barley? There were no trees to burn, but perhaps there had been once; and there was peat, to judge by the ground's soft blackness. Around the water's edge grew yellow spikes of river-flax, a rarity in Obandiro.

Finding that the memory of Obandiro made her ache, she turned to Leor, who rode in silent gloom.

"Why did you come with us, Leor? You look tired."

He drew himself up. "Tired? I'm not tired. Disillusioned, maybe."

"What about? Ah, your origins, I presume."

The wizard slumped again. "Yes. I need distraction. It is a most dismaying thing to learn – that I was once joined face to face with Adon."

"Stomach to stomach."

"Whichever. I would rather have no relationship with him at all."

"Did you look like twins, when you were young?" she asked.

Leor sighed. "Perhaps we did," he said reluctantly. "Our features were, I think, quite similar, and I remember that his hair was red too, early on. But he changed its colour. He would change it often, and alter other elements of his appearance too. His face is not the same as then it was, and has not been for a long time. I might not recognise it now."

"Was he as tall as you?"

"No. I was always taller." Leor rode on, pondering, while Bryddesda whisked his tail. "I think I was the physically stronger of the two of us, from infancy."

"He wouldn't have liked that, I imagine. Being the smaller and weaker."

"I never thought about it," said Leor, so that she felt a faint impatience.

"No, you didn't need to. Being the bigger twin wouldn't have bothered you," she said. "But perhaps it should have."

"My body may have been robust, but I never felt myself to be stronger than Adon in any other way," Leor answered glumly. "His will was always stronger than mine was."

"Do you mean his will, or his selfishness?"

He looked back at her, a little startled. "I'm not sure. I suppose I tended to fall in with his plans."

"When did you stop doing that?"

"Ah.... Well. Our paths diverged perhaps five centuries ago... it's hard to work it out. It was not sudden."

Yaret tried to think of words to comfort him, although once spoken they sounded trite and obvious. "At birth your bodies may have been as one," she said, "but your minds and souls must always have been separate."

Despite the triteness he seemed encouraged, for he straightened up again. "Yes. Yes. One in body, but not one in spirit."

"Look," said Piril, interrupting them, "those scouts are veering west. Should we head east?"

"That's a good idea. Don't worry, Jebil will be found," Ikelder told her. "Carts don't just disappear."

True, thought Yaret; so long as they have not fallen in some hidden magical pool or been held spellbound in an invisible tower.

But on riding east the land rose gradually, becoming drier. They saw no pools, no towers, and no people. Only occasional swift flights of birds passed overhead.

Piril gazed up. "Some say they are the spirits of the dead," she murmured.

"Those ones are geese," said Yaret.

The jagged hills looked no more attractive close up than from a distance. Their slopes were clothed in scree: long streams of rocks, some as large as boulders, that painted them in stippled shades of grey. As the four riders approached, one thin stream of stones began to flow down the hillside with a hissing rattle, until after a few seconds it slowed and stopped again. A single stone rolled on down to the grass at the slope's foot.

And something else had been there. "See that? Cartwheels," said Ikelder.

The wheel-ruts ran in a long curve through a shallow pass into the hills. Perhaps, thought Yaret, once the carts began to swerve east underneath the cloud, the swerve had widened in the gloom, and led them here.

The horses picked up speed to canter along the rutted valley, Piril wincing with a discomfort that Yaret remembered well. As they skirted the first hill, a herd of goats, taking alarm at their appearance, scattered themselves across the rocky hillsides that were streaked with rivulets of rushing water as well as waterfalls of rattling scree. Yaret wondered how the animals kept their footholds on those shivering slopes.

And soon her own horse's foothold became precarious. The valley was littered with large stones, while tumbling streams formed noisy, treacherous gutters across their path. They all slowed to a careful walk before they rode around the next bend; and immediately saw before them a cluster of stationary carts.

"There they are," said Yaret. "Stuck in a ditch, Ikelder, just like you predicted." No magic forces, no mystery involved, she thought, with marked relief.

One cart was lying almost on its side, with two wheels high in the air, two evidently mired in a stream. The other carts were grouped nearby, their horses grazing on the sparse turf between boulders. Meanwhile a dozen men were pushing and pulling at the upturned one, trying to manoeuvre it upright.

Piril frowned. "But I don't understand. That's a Kelvhan carriage," she said.

"You mean it's Lady Meya's carriage? The one Jebil was in?" Yaret asked, in new alarm; for Jebil needed no such attention being drawn to her.

"No," said Piril. "I can see Jebil's carriage over there, with the blue awning. It looks all right. The one that's on its side is green and gold."

"We had no such grand carriage in our train," said Ikelder, suddenly thoughtful. "Come."

When they rode on, it became obvious that the toppled cart was different to the rest. Even Yaret, who had no interest in carriage-work, could identify it easily as Kelvhan. But there was no sign of any Kelvhan occupants.

Dismounting, Ikelder walked over to the Riders who were trying to heave the fallen carriage upright.

"Bramal! Cavar!" he called out. "How goes it? Can't you get it free?"

One of the men trudged towards them, panting. "Ikelder. Good to see you! How far away are the others?"

"Less than two hours, once you've got that cart upright," Ikelder said.

"That could take a while. It would help if we had longer ropes," the Rider grunted, muddy and annoyed.

"What happened, Bramal?"

"We got lost in that curst cloud. And no sooner did it start to clear – and we realised that we'd gone astray into the hills – than we heard shouts for help. But the shouts came from behind us, would you believe? That carriage had joined up with us at some point, I don't know when, in all that murk. We'd never seen it until then. It's not one of ours."

"But the Lady Meya's carriage – is that quite safe?" begged Piril.

"Oh, yes. All the other carts are fine," said Bramal. "It's just that Theol said we had to stop and wait until we got this one out of trouble. In fact, he insisted."

"That was noble of him," said Leor gloomily. "But not really necessary, surely? Where's the driver? It's his responsibility."

"It's Kelvhan, isn't it?" asked Yaret.

"It's Kelvhan all right," said Bramal with a snort. "That's why we had to stop and help."

"Because we're allies?"

But Bramal shook his head. His face was glum. "We'd have given up the attempt an hour ago, but for one thing. That's no ordinary Kelvhan's carriage. It belongs to the Lady Gaelera."

Chapter 15

Piril looked aghast. "The Lady Gaelera! Where is she? I mean – is she hurt?"

"Least of our worries," said Leor moodily. He had seen the Lady Gaelera now and then, from a distance: a stiffly over-dressed, unsmiling woman who acted older than her years. For all she was the Post-Regent's daughter, she was not of interest to him. Her presence here did not concern him nearly so much as did the knowledge he had so recently acquired. Adon! His twin! Identical to him – and worse, conjoined to him! The revelation loomed in his mind like an inner manifestation of that huge, dark, overwhelming cloud.

A cloud that Leor had created, or had allowed his power to create. So he was responsible for any consequences, to himself or anybody else. He tried to clear his head of Adon – no, it was impossible – but none the less he needed to pay attention. A Kelvhan lady's cart had fallen in a ditch. He tried to recollect his manners.

"I trust the lady has no injury?" he asked.

"It seems not," answered Bramal. "I suppose she must have been shaken up when the cart went over, but you'd never guess. She gave Theol orders to pull her out as queenly as you like. So he told us we'd better obey. Wouldn't look good to abandon her, no matter what she was doing here."

"What *was* she doing here?" asked Yaret.

The Rider shook his head. "She hasn't given any explanation. Theol asked but got no answer. I know the Kelvhans like their spies, but they wouldn't send a High Lady all the way out here to spy on us, now would they?"

"It seems unlikely," said Ikelder. "I'd better go and pay my respects. Where is she?"

"In the Lady Meya's second carriage. The only one she thinks is fit for someone of her standing." Piril made a slight, twitchy movement as Bramal went on. "Will you not give us a hand here first? Or more than a hand?" He was looking at Leor.

"Well, Leor," said Ikelder, turning to him, "what can you do?"

Leor felt worried. Had he not done harm enough already? He knew that he could easily lift the carriage – for it was not deeply buried, like the iron cart that held the darkburn, which he'd lifted from the northern battlefield. But that feat had not helped anybody in the long run. Did magic ever help anybody in the long run?

Yaret was watching him. "Better do it, Leor," she said. "It only speeds things up a little. It can't really change anything."

"The use of magic always changes things," said Leor with conviction. "Like the use of any power. It has consequences." He recalled those bloody rags that once were sheep.

Nevertheless he was conscious that, now that they had seen him here, everybody would expect him to use wizardry to help. The men beside the cart had already paused in their attempts to haul it out and stepped back in anticipation.

So Leor dismounted from Bryddesda and walked slowly over. As he approached he flexed his power with caution, feeling it stir within him, like an echo of the flexing of the Semmuru's great glittering wings.

O Semmuru, he thought, I wish that the waters of Arac had never given me this magic. I wish that you had never healed me and my twin, never bestowed upon us such long life and ungovernable power.

He knew that he lied.

It seemed to happen easily this time. Leor stretched out his arm, but only for form's sake, or perhaps to give the witnesses a warning; for before it was extended, he was already conscious of the force that flowed from him at the first instant of his bidding. It made his body

tingle. Where did it come from? Up from the earth? Down from the sky? There was no knowing. It was simply there.

Whatever its source, he had to concentrate on focussing it, on pinpointing what he wanted it to do: which was to lift the carriage gently, without damaging it, and to convey it to a flatter piece of ground.

All very simple, after all. But as he performed the task – or rather, watched it be performed, with a sense of wonder – he heard a general intake of breath, and someone even clapped. Leor felt no inclination to bow. All he felt was awe; and fear.

“Nice work,” Ikelder said. “It looks all right. Those Kelvhan carriages are strongly made. Bramal? You and Cavar check it over, while I go and give the Lady Gaelera the good news. Leor, come with me.” He looked at the others. “You too, Yaret; I think another lady’s presence is required.”

“I’m hardly that,” said Yaret.

“But you know Gaelera, don’t you? I expect you do as well, Piril, if in a different capacity. Would you care to come and greet her, or would you rather not?”

“I don’t know if she would recognise me,” said Piril. “Servants’ faces are not memorable. If she does, she may not be best pleased. But there is Jebil too... Yes, I will come.”

As they walked over, Theol greeted them with relief. “Good work, Leor,” he said. “Ikelder, glad to see you. Gaelera might listen to a captain. She won’t heed my advice.”

“What advice have you given her?”

“That we should escort her back to her own army. The only problem being that we don’t know exactly where the Kelvhans are. But she refuses. You try: she’s in that carriage of Lady Meya’s.”

The carriage stood a little apart from the others. As the four of them approached, its door opened and Gaelera stepped out, looking just as stiff and over-dressed as Leor remembered; although the embroidered dress was soiled with mud. It made it seem as if the gold and scarlet silken flowers were dying.

“My Lady,” said Ikelder with a bow to Gaelera, who stood silently regarding them, “we are pleased to tell you that your carriage has now been set upright, and is being checked for any damage. I trust that you yourself have suffered no injury beyond inconvenience?” His tone was formal and courteous.

Although he’s an ungainly man, thought Leor ruefully – just as ungainly as I am myself – Ikelder seems to have learnt more diplomatic manners in his short life than I have in my long one. Why is that? I think I have always regarded myself as someone set apart. Manners were not necessary.

However, he now recalled them sufficiently to bow, and after Ikelder had described how his wizardry had raised the carriage, he said, “My Lady, I’m most happy to have been of service to you.”

“I am most happy also,” said Gaelera, although nobody would have guessed it from her face. A closed book, Leor thought; or rather, a book always open at the same blank page. Or a page covered in some indistinguishable writing, in an alphabet he did not know.

“I trust you have been well-looked after,” said Yaret, who seemed unusually tense.

“I have been looked after. The maidservant Jebil has been attempting to clean my dress,” Gaelera said with calm disinterest. “Not altogether successfully, as you can see.” She spread out her hands in front of the soiled skirts without actually touching the elaborately decorated fabric.

“I can finish that task for you, my lady,” said Piril eagerly.

Gaelera looked at her for several seconds before she answered. “You are another maidservant of the castle, are you not?”

"I was," said Piril.

"No doubt," Gaelera said. "However, Jebil has been quite useful in her way. I may adopt her as my servant whilst we travel."

"I am afraid," said Yaret, "that is not possible, my Lady, as Jebil is in bond to serve the Lady Meya."

"Indeed? How singular," Gaelera said, unruffled. "Then she can serve us both together."

Leor had the strong feeling that he was missing something. Surely such talk of maidservants, interesting though it might be to the ladies, was of no immediate relevance.

"My lady," he put in, "be assured that we shall serve you in any way we can, to see your safe return to Kelvha's train and to your father." For he assumed that Gaelera's carriage had become lost beneath the cloud. "No doubt the Kelvhan army is not far away."

"Oh, about twenty miles by my reckoning," said Gaelera. She remained standing in that strange posture, with her hands held a little out from her skirts, as carefully posed and unmoving as a wooden doll.

"Twenty miles?" said Leor, puzzled. "How did your driver manage to diverge so far from his route?"

"I told him to," she said.

"You..."

"I had a mind to join the Riders of the Vonn. Although my father, I believe, intends to meet up with the Lord Huldarion's army eventually, I could not wait that long. Impatience drove me. I desired to join the Vonn without delay; and to see my good friend Maeneb. She invited me."

Leor became aware that his mouth had fallen slightly open and he closed it quickly. Ikelder seemed momentarily at a loss. It was Yaret who filled the sudden speculative gap.

"My lady," she said, "have you eaten? We can arrange for food to be brought from the provision carts. Who else is here with you apart from Jebil? You have a groom and driver, I presume?"

"One man does for both," Gaelera said. "Woldo, Jebil." She did not raise her voice, but immediately the awning parted and two people emerged from within: the maid Jebil, who looked even more pale and ill than when Leor had glimpsed her last, and a grinning old man with gnarled fingers, an equally gnarled nose, and several missing teeth.

"This is the driver, my groom Woldo," Gaelera said. "There is little point in addressing him directly. He is profoundly deaf. He will gratefully eat whatever food may be provided. So will Jebil, will you not, Jebil?"

"Ma'am." The maid's reply was barely audible; her shoulders were hunched miserably and her face averted.

"Then go, the pair of you, and eat. You, the other maid: Piril is your name, I think? You may bring me savoury pastries if you have them, no honeyed ones, a little cold salt meat, some figs or preserved apricots, provided they are fully ripe. I am not fussy. I shall wait here."

"I shall accompany you while you wait, my lady," said Ikelder gallantly.

"As you wish." She seemed unmoved. Ikelder motioned to Leor with his head.

"We'll go and seek supplies," said Yaret, and she bowed, so that Leor remembered to bow too. They turned away, the maids and groom in tow. The two maids clung together, looking altogether more shocked than seemed called for, in Leor's opinion, since Gaelera had been perfectly civil, and had not complained of her situation nearly as much as she might.

Meanwhile Yaret spoke to the groom, Woldo, in a loud voice, to which he responded with a gap-toothed smile.

"He's deaf," Leor reminded her. She gave him a meaningful look which he did not understand. "What?" he said. "It's a bit of a surprise to find her here, but I suppose Nerogun's daughter can do what she likes. She must have followed us on a whim."

"Leor. Come." Yaret strode off swiftly and he hurried to keep up, the groom and two girls following. "What do you suggest we do?" she asked him in an undertone.

"Well... Unless we can persuade Gaelera to be escorted back to the Kelvhans, I suppose we'll have to take her with us. It's inconvenient," said Leor with a shrug, "and I don't suppose Huldarion will be entirely happy; but I don't see what alternative we have. We certainly can't leave her alone here, in the middle of nowhere."

"No, I imagine she is relying upon that," said Yaret quietly.

"What did you say? I told you, he can't hear." She gave him a rap on the elbow. "Oh," said Leor in sudden belated realisation.

He looked back at Woldo. The man responded with a wide, ragged grin. Possibly he could hear perfectly well – and had orders to report back to Gaelera anything he heard.

Rapidly Leor went over what he had just said: nothing she could take offence at, except possibly the remark about Huldarion not being happy. Would that get reported?

As they walked he cursed his own obtuseness. The maids were saying nothing; they had more sense than he did. Now he held his tongue even when they reached the provision cart and he was questioned by a Rider about what food he wanted. He answered with a shrug.

Yaret selected pastries, figs, and salted lamb; placed them into Piril's waiting hands, and with a reassuring pat on the arm sent her on her way back to Gaelera. She handed over more salt meat and half a loaf to the waiting groom, who grinned again and nodded.

"And you?" asked the provisioner.

"We have our own supplies," she said, although Leor would happily have accepted a pastry or two. They left Woldo sitting on a carriage shaft to tear enthusiastically at his bread with his few teeth, and walked back towards their horses to retrieve their packs. Once out of earshot, Yaret spoke.

"Well, Jebil?"

"I don't know," said Jebil, her voice low and miserable. "She didn't say."

"She seems almost glad," mused Yaret.

"Yes."

"She remembered Piril."

"Yes. You're right. So she must know."

"Know what?" asked Leor. Yaret shook her head at him. Then she asked Jebil, "Do you think Maeneb could really have invited her to join the Vonn? It seems unlikely."

"Gaelera could have made her give an invitation," said Jebil drearily. "It doesn't really matter if it happened or not. She does what she wants."

"I wonder what she wants with us," said Yaret.

Did it matter? thought Leor. Gaelera was nosy and inquisitive, no doubt, like many women; and had sufficient power to exercise her curiosity.

Certainly it appeared that Gaelera would have her way, whatever her purpose was. For once they had returned to her, she announced in stately tones which seemed to leave no room for argument that she would go with the train of carts and join the Vonn.

"For now I have two maids to dance attendance on me," she said, with the surprising flicker of a smile. "My father cannot argue on that count. But you, master wizard and Captain Ikelder, will kindly ride north-east to find the Kelvhan army, and there inform my father the Post-Regent of my intention."

Ikelder and Leor looked at each other. Ikelder bowed. Leor said,

"My Lady Gaelera, perhaps it would be wiser if you–"

"It would undoubtedly be wiser for you, my master wizard, not to question my decision," said Gaelera.

Although she spoke without visible anger, or indeed without any expression at all, Leor felt himself shrivelling. Her loftiness seemed to tell him that he was no mighty wizard, no special being at all, just one ordinary man endowed by chance with long life and burdened with a power he had never learnt to use effectively – far less to understand. Feeling humbled, he bowed and walked away beside Ikelder.

“Huldarion won’t care for this,” Ikelder said once they were out of earshot, “but I believe we have no choice. We’d better find her father. Our horses are still fresh enough.”

“Let’s hope the Kelvhans are no more than twenty miles away,” responded Leor glumly, “and that we don’t spend a week wandering around this wilderness trying to find them.”

Ikelder glanced at him. “You must have travelled through these parts before?”

“Yes. But not for a century or two. It was quite different then: it was wooded, it had orchards, fruit groves; trees laden with almonds and apricots, as I remember. Also a bitter oily fruit that was much prized.”

“By whom? The people who lived in those roundhouses?”

Leor shook his head. “They were already abandoned. The people I knew built wooden houses – that was in the days when there were trees.”

“Maybe they depleted their own woodlands,” suggested Ikelder.

“Possibly,” said Leor shortly. He remembered those people well: for they were the predecessors of the stonemen. But he did not wish to speak of stonemen to Ikelder, especially in conjunction with trees, for the memory of the skeln trees that he had found for them was a sharp needle of reproach. Although they’d been a harmless people in those days, they had changed since for the worse; just as these lands had changed.

And did the modern, dangerous variety of stonemen lurk in those now barren hills? The thought troubled Leor as he and Ikelder set off north-east. Could this mission be in truth some unlikely secret ambush set up by Adon?

Reason quickly reasserted itself. His consciousness was full of Adon at the moment, but he tried hard to dismiss thoughts of his twin. Indeed, the very word *twin* was hateful to him. He scanned the landscape that they cantered through, trying to concentrate on that alone.

Ikelder did not stop to talk. He was a skilled horseman on a fast horse: Bryddesda needed to lengthen his stride to keep up, but did not seem to mind the effort as much as Leor did. They galloped through a narrow pass between the scree-striped peaks. On its far side, at last, was human life: a scattering of tiny villages came into view. Built of muddy sun-dried brick, they were surrounded by brown sheep and some long-necked, sulky-looking animals to which Leor could not put a name.

“I see they keep corarda. A few were imported from the southlands years ago; it’s interesting to see they thrive. Good fur but bad-tempered,” commented Ikelder, so that Leor felt ashamed. How was it that this Rider who was less than thirty knew so much more than Leor did at over twenty times his age? And when they passed beneath an untidy grove of the bitter-fruit tree that Leor had remembered, he was disgruntled that no name for it came to his mind. He must have known it once. Or had he? How was it he had lived so long and learned so little?

“Ah, there they are,” Ikelder said, and he pointed to the long, long line of carts and horses creeping slowly from the north. So much more numerous than the Vonn, thought Leor with a small lurch of misgiving.

As they galloped closer, a squad of guards swerved out of the Kelvhan line to ride towards them. Ikelder slowed and raised an empty hand in greeting.

“Captain Ikelder of the Vonn, and the Wizard Leor, chief counsellor to the Lord Huldarion,” he said, with an assurance that made the horsemen dip their heads respectfully. “We pay our

respects to High Prince Faldron, long may he reign; and we have an urgent message for the Arch-Lord Nerogun."

"Come this way, sir."

They were taken first to Faldron, who rode at the head of the train in a gleaming outfit that Leor realised was not golden chain-mail armour as it at first appeared, but a cleverly sewn fabric imitation. All the same it must have weighed many pounds in metallic thread, he judged; and for what – other than to impress his underlings? Of course, in Kelvha that was an essential duty of the monarch.

Those accompanying the prince – the Arch-Lord Marshal Shargun and various other dignitaries – were almost as richly ornamented. But not quite. And one grizzled commander wore no gold thread at all.

"Your Highness," said Ikelder, bowing. "My Lord Marshal. Commander Jeveran. Our salutations to you."

"Well, master wizard," said Faldron to Leor, ignoring Ikelder entirely. Leor was not sure how he felt about that. But he drew back his shoulders and tried to look as majestically knowledgeable as a master wizard should. "How fares it with your army?" the prince continued. "Have you changed your mind about your strange choice of route, and decided to come across and join us?" He seemed to be in high good humour. He glanced around with a smile, and several of his men laughed dutifully.

"At present, no, Sire," said Leor. "We are delighted to see you so well and active" – here he cursed himself, for he made it sound as if he had expected to find an invalid. He hurried on. "Our chief business here, however, is with the Lord Nerogun. Is he close by?"

Faldron raised an eyebrow. "Nerogun? He has not informed me of any business he may have with you."

"He does not know it yet," said Leor.

"How so?"

Leor did not know how much he should divulge to the Prince, and he dared not look at Ikelder for guidance. But Faldron was the master of the Post-Regent in name if not in practice. So he said, "It concerns his daughter, the Lady Gaelera."

"Gaelera? What has she to do with anything?"

"She was riding in her carriage with your army, sire, and in the fog she became separated from your train. Some of our Riders happened upon her when, um." Leor stopped at the verge of indiscretion, before he could describe how she had ended up in a ditch.

"Riding with us? I had no idea. What an extraordinary thing to do," said Faldron. "If the ladies of the Castle wish to watch the entertainment of a battle I believe they generally follow the train some way behind."

"And not until the battle's all but won," said Commander Jeveran gravely.

But Shargun let out a sharp cackle of laughter, his beard wagging. "Well, she's pulled the hood over her father's eyes and no mistake! Gaelera, eh? I don't think Nerogun knew that she was here."

"He should keep her under better control," said Faldron.

"He certainly should," said Shargun with some glee. "Let me find him for you, master wizard. Come with me."

Faldron gave a dismissive wave of assent; and Shargun, spurring his horse so viciously that it all but bolted, galloped down the long train, hooting, "Nerogun! Where are you, man? You're wanted."

Leor and Ikelder followed. There was no answer to the shouts until they reached the middle of the line – a section, Leor thought, that was thickly buffered from any possible attack.

A well-sprung carriage trundled comfortably behind four glossy chestnut horses: and the heavily-jowled face of the Post-Regent Nerogun poked out from it to glower.

"What is it?"

"Time to wake up," said Shargun with ill-concealed eagerness. "Some news for you."

"My Lord Post-Regent, greetings," said Ikelder, and saluted. Leor did likewise, very aware of the squad of soldiers that had followed him, and of Nerogun's suspicious frown.

"Captain. This is an unexpected visit. Is there some trouble in the Vonnish line?" Nerogun asked. "Do you require our help?"

Shargun let out another cackle. "Just wait till you hear," he said.

"Indeed, my Lord Post-Regent," Ikelder answered formally, "after considering the news we bring, you may wish to send some of your men to accompany us. Our army is very shortly to be honoured by the gracious presence of the Lady Gaelera, whose carriage unfortunately became detached from the Kelvhan train in the dense fog-bank that fell upon those hills, and found itself temporarily lodged in a ditch. Luckily, the hindmost Riders in our train happened on the scene and undertook to set her carriage upright. I am glad to inform your lordship that the Lady Gaelera is unharmed, and remains as serene as her ladyship is ever. However, her conveyance back to your protection might be best managed by your own troops."

Leor had glad that Ikelder was the one to undertake the explanation. He himself could not have managed it so smoothly; Ikelder must have been rehearsing as they rode.

But Nerogun appeared dumbfounded. So speechless was he that Ikelder, after a few seconds, continued to talk until the Post-Regent could recover his composure. Meanwhile Shargun looked on with a grin.

"The Lady Gaelera was, of course, not alone," Ikelder said, "being accompanied by her driver. She has expressed her wish to continue to travel with the Vonnish army, until such time as she returns to you, and is resolute in setting out with us to join the main body of the Riders. Such a gracious addition to our party is an honour indeed, and I am sure the Lady Meya and our other gentlewomen will welcome her with all due courtesies. We have already appointed two maidservants to wait upon her, until you send for her." He bowed his head, awaiting Nerogun's reply.

Still the disconcerted Post-Regent did not answer. Lord Shargun let out a sharp, brief bark of laughter.

"Didn't know she was there, did, you, eh, Nerogun? My word! She kept herself well hidden, didn't she! The things women will get up to, if you let 'em. Mad as monkeys. Always curious, always wanting to pry." His grey beard wagged in a grimace of amusement.

Leor tried not to show his distaste for the Arch-Lord. An inner voice reminded him that he himself had lately expressed a similar thought about women's curiosity; but at least he had kept it in his head. Coming from Shargun it sounded outrageously unjust.

Nerogun seemed to gather his wits at last. Reshaping his frown into a smile, he answered,

"Indeed, my daughter's inquisitive nature has led her a little astray on this occasion. I am glad the Vonn were able to come to her assistance. And, of course, that she's unhurt." It occurred to Leor that he did not sound especially glad of the last fact. "Her driver is at fault," continued Nerogun, recovering his usual manner, "and I shall see to it that the man is duly punished."

"Although the Lady Gaelera was wishful to visit the Vonnish army," said Ikelder, "and we can naturally accompany her back to you at her command, you may of course, my Lord, prefer to send your own detachment to us."

At this Nerogun looked from side to side. He does not know how to answer, thought Leor: what if he sends a detachment to bring her back, and she refuses?

"Leave her where she is," advised Shargun with a snigger. "Do you think Gaelera will adopt the Vonnish ladies' habit of wearing breeches, hey? The Vonn don't seem to mind the encumbrance of women in the train."

Nerogun, ignoring the Arch-Lord Marshal, responded with slow dignity.

"A detachment will be sent for her. You travel by the Red Roads?"

"That is the plan, my lord," Ikelder answered. "As you know, we are aiming for the Place of Terns."

"A strange choice of destination. I hope Huldarion knows what he is doing. I shall allot a company to follow you and the Lady Gaelera. But our main army need not change its course."

"I should hope not," said Shargun. By the faint narrowing of Nerogun's eyes, Leor suspected that the Post-Regent would like to fling his fellow Arch-Lord bodily from his horse if he were able.

"In the meantime, I am grateful for your hospitality towards my daughter," said Nerogun, from an almost closed mouth.

"We shall endeavour to fulfil her every wish," Ikelder said.

"For stars' sake, don't do that," cried Shargun with another abrupt cackle. "Be no end of it. My word, Nerogun, I'm glad I never wed the wench!"

Nerogun's face froze. He nodded stiffly to Leor and Ikelder in a signal of dismissal. As they wheeled their horses round to leave, he swung towards Shargun with a growing snarl of fury. But Shargun had already turned away to trot back up the line.

Leor rode behind Ikelder past the long ranks of watching troops, who looked most impressive in their decorative gear. He felt very aware of Bryddesda's ugliness and lack of adornment.

"They might have offered us refreshment," he muttered.

"Wait," Ikelder said. The two men cantered on in silence until the Kelvhan line was two hundred yards behind them.

Only then did Ikelder turn to Leor with a rueful smile. "Never talk about anyone while they're still close enough to lip-read. That's something Huldarion taught me. Do you think Nerogun really didn't know that Gaelera was travelling with his army?"

"He certainly hadn't realised she was missing," said Leor.

"I'm guessing nobody knew that she was there at all, apart perhaps from a driver or two that she must have paid off. She kept herself well hidden, I dare say."

"But why?" asked Leor in bafflement.

Ikelder shrugged. "Because if her father knew, he wouldn't have allowed her."

"And she does what she wants," said Leor, echoing Piril's words. Then he thought about Nerogun's stunned reaction. Maybe he cared more deeply for his daughter's safety than was evident.

But it was odd. Nerogun had not immediately demanded that Gaelera be returned. Instead, the Post-Regent's heavy face had shown a number of emotions. Gladness at his only daughter's safety had not been one of them. Rather, they had been a mixture of understandable confusion; shock; dismay...

... and, strangely, fear.

Chapter 16

"No clues," murmured Yaret. "She's all but mute. On the way back here I did try several times to talk with her – but it was no use. No explanation as to why she drove out with the Kelvhan army. Nor why she decided to come and join the Vonn. Though I must say, she looked quite complacent."

Maeneb groaned and covered her face with her hand. "Could you not just take her straight back to the Kelvhans and her father?"

"We offered. She declined. This act of hers was planned. Gaelera didn't get lost underneath the cloudbank; she was too far off course for that. The question is: why? Maeneb," said Yaret gently, "you might be the one best placed to know the answer."

Maeneb withdrew her hand from her face. It felt odd even to clasp her own skin in that way, so averse was she to human touch. Ought she to know the answer? She didn't – yet she had an insidious, worrying feeling that Gaelera's arrival had something to do with *her*.

"She said that you'd invited her," Yaret continued. "I'm guessing that you didn't."

"Stars, no! Of course I didn't!" exclaimed Maeneb, appalled. "Do you think she's telling Huldarion that now?"

They both looked over to where Huldarion and Meya were in conversation with the Lady Gaelera. The other two were doing the talking, while Gaelera held her head on one side and occasionally deigned to give the briefest answer.

She forced their hand, thought Maeneb: the Vonn had to offer her a warm welcome. But she sensed faint annoyance in Huldarion, whose appearance was even stiffer than usual; while Meya, for all her polite attitude, transmitted to Maeneb's senses a definite aura of alarm.

And she herself would be obliged to greet Gaelera shortly. How should she do it? What should she say? For Gaelera, odd as she was, had offered her some form of friendship, and it would have to be acknowledged.

Indeed, Gaelera shared her most oppressive secret. She was the only person in the world who knew the facts about the murder of the young lord Daravun, who had assailed Maeneb in the Kelvhan market and had been knifed for his discourtesy. Maeneb shuddered when she remembered how she had confessed the killing to Gaelera. But she had not known where else to seek help.

And Gaelera had helped. She must have done something, because the fuss around the murder had very soon died down. This despite the fact that the dead man, Gaelera had calmly told her, was a relative of her father Nerogun... An unfortunate choice of victim.

But regardless of who his family might be, the murdered man himself had gradually become significant to Maeneb. He had been nobody to her; yet in the last few days he'd taken on a vividness beyond reality. Several times she thought she'd glimpsed him in the train, although none of the Riders looked anything like that elegantly dressed young lordling with his arrogant, entitled air.

None the less, the red-gold beard, the careful yellow curls, seemed to glint in every unexpected spot: in the sun gleaming on the carriage-shafts, or on the glitter of a sword-hilt, or a windblown strand of hair. The dead man was her secret, yet strangely ever-present. And not her secret only, but Gaelera's.

"She knows about Janeya," Yaret said quietly.

"What? Oh, stars. Of course she does. No wonder Lady Meya's so horrified."

"Is she? It doesn't show. But I think Gaelera must intend to keep that knowledge to herself," said Yaret reflectively, "or she would have said something already."

"She'll be thinking about how she can use it," said Maeneb darkly. She thought: Just like she'll be considering how to use her knowledge of Daravun's death by fruit knife. Weighing up the possibilities of blackmail. Gaelera is a collector of secrets. But to what end?

"Here she comes," said Yaret.

Maeneb steeled herself as Gaelera approached. How inappropriate her dress is, she thought, how rich, inflexible and starched, no less than the woman caged inside it: how blank her expression.

Although... was that a hint of a smile as she walked up to Maeneb? If a smile of the mouth only. Maeneb could detect no corresponding emotion in Gaelera's mind. And then, most disconcertingly, the other woman put out her hand.

Maeneb had to respond. She did not clasp Gaelera's fingers but merely brushed them with her own. Luckily Gaelera seemed satisfied with that minimal mode of greeting.

"My Lady Maeneb," she said with slow deliberation, "it is a pleasure to see you. Greater I believe than it is for the Lady Meya to see me."

"I am sure... that the Lady Meya is delighted to see you." It was odd to meet Gaelera in these wild surroundings: for in Maeneb's mind she was always sitting on her window-seat within her castle tower, more walls looking in behind her through the diamond-latticed glass, her sewing in her hand. Her cupboards full of her embroidered life, their doors firmly shut.

"And I am sure that she is not. No matter. Here I am." And she smoothed down her skirts without touching them, in a gesture that had become familiar to Maeneb.

"I'll leave you to it," said Yaret, and she escaped. Gaelera's cool gaze followed her.

"A strange woman," she remarked. "A foreigner to me in more ways than one. I do not understand her."

"Why should you?" asked Maeneb.

"Why, indeed. Let me consider." Gaelera put her head a little on one side. An affected gesture, thought Maeneb. "Such understanding might make me a better person." After surveying Maeneb for an expectant moment, she smiled again, faintly. "I am glad you did not say I am already a good person. Indeed, you know that I am not."

"Do I? It all depends on how you define *good*," said Maeneb, somewhat aghast at this over-frank conversation, and at her own boldness in replying.

"To be sure. I am good in that I am effective, in my own way. And though you are not pleased to see me now, I hope that you may be, in time to come."

"Why?" said Maeneb, belligerently. Too bold, too bold, she thought. Calm down.

"Ah, well... Someone ought to feel pleased to see me," said Gaelera, "and it might as well be you. My little parlour-maid in the castle; I believe that she was generally pleased to see me. Certainly she was sad to see me leave. Possibly that was fear of being left alone. But in spite of her entreaties I would not bring her with me. She would not have known what to do outside those city walls. And in any case I have acquired a maid: in fact, I now have two."

Maeneb swallowed. "Piril...?" The girl was a dozen yards away, scrubbing down the awning of Gaelera's muddy cart.

"And Jebil. They both know the ways of the castle. Although it was something of a surprise to find them here, after short reflection I decided the surprise was not so great. And they will be of use. Please call Piril here for me, for I myself have no loud voice. I do not shout."

"Piril!" called Maeneb, aware of how loud, how harsh, her own shout was. At once the girl put down her brush and bucket and walked over to bob in a gesture that was half bow, half curtsy. "Don't do that," said Maeneb curtly, annoyed not at the half-bow's clumsiness, but because such a gesture was not required by her at all, even if it was expected by Gaelera.

"Ma'am," said Piril. She was fearful, Maeneb knew, although she hid it fairly well.

"Is Jebil still indisposed?" Gaelera asked her.

"Yes, ma'am. She does not travel easily." Piril did not lower her eyes beneath Gaelera's gaze; but neither did she quite look her in the face.

"Let her remain in the Lady Meya's carriage, then, for now. I have discussed her case with the Lady Meya, who agrees with me that the girl should stay out of the way. It will save embarrassment all round – if the girl is sick, that is." As Gaelera spoke Maeneb sensed some faint emotion in her: satisfaction, maybe. It was hard to tell. Gaelera generally cloaked her feelings so successfully that Maeneb was unused to sensing any emotion of hers at all. So it must be strong indeed to be detectable.

"Ma'am," said Piril woodenly.

"Your attendance on me will be sufficient for my daily needs. And at night you may sleep within my carriage. You worked in the castle for many years, did you not?"

"Ten years, ma'am."

"And for how many of those ten were you the Lady Janeya's maid?"

"Three years," said Piril, her voice very low. Gaelera is playing with her, Maeneb thought, like a cat with a mouse.

Yet the aura of faint satisfaction seemed to have dissolved; and Gaelera did not pursue the subject of Janeya any further. "You understand the cleaning of fine clothes?" she asked.

"Yes, ma'am. I worked in the laundries when I first arrived at Kelvha Castle."

"And your brother was, I understand, employed within the castle stables."

At this, Piril did look at her fully, with a wary and unhappy face. "Yes, my lady."

"I say *was* advisedly. A tragic end for one so young," announced Gaelera, now with no detectable emotion. "Do you know why he attempted to assassinate my father, the Lord Nerogun?"

Piril swallowed.

"My lady," said Maeneb in protest. She felt that this was an entirely unsuitable conversation, yet did not know how to stop it. Gaelera ignored her.

"I am not aware... that he really meant to do so, ma'am," said Piril eventually.

Gaelera nodded, gazing somewhere past Piril. "It had all the appearance of an assassination attempt, if a poor one," she said meditatively. "It is true, however, that it was not your brother's own idea. Shortly before he undertook it, he received a letter."

"Ma'am?"

"The letter bore my father's seal. That is not to say, of course, that my father must have sent it. Seals can be replicated. Although such replication would be extremely dangerous if discovered." Gaelera withdrew her gaze from whatever distant view had held it, and went on more briskly. "I have my own means of acquiring information, you understand."

Piril's mouth opened and closed. She did not speak.

Maeneb, wholly unnerved at this turn in the talk, managed to put in a diversion. "My lady, we shall soon be moving off again. I understand the Lord Huldarion hopes the army can progress a few miles further before nightfall. Therefore allow me to help you up into your carriage."

"How gallant of you," said Gaelera. "However, I require no help in that respect. It is possible that I will require a little company later, if I may call on you for that." It did not sound like a request, but a command.

"Piril," said Maeneb, "you may go and..." She racked her brains. "Go and attend to Jebil. Or Lady Meya. I am sure she will have tasks for you."

"But come back here before we leave," Gaelera bid her. Piril bobbed again and hastily departed.

I am treating Piril as a servant, Maeneb thought, no less than Gaelera does. I need to stop. I must not let Gaelera and her Kelvhan manners influence me.

None the less, when the army eventually set off, and Maeneb, on horseback, watched the foremost carts crawl away – so painfully slow, it seemed, that it would be ten minutes before the movement reached her and allowed her the relief of riding on – she felt obliged to stay in her place alongside Gaelera. Her horse Shoda stamped restlessly beside the carriage, where Gaelera sat at the front, behind her ancient driver.

“You may entertain me,” Gaelera said. Maeneb did not answer. She had no idea what sort of thing might entertain Gaelera. In suggesting such a notion, Gaelera was surely already entertaining herself. With relief she saw Woldo shake the reins; the carriage-horses picked up their hooves, and she was finally able to ride forward.

“I would drive my own carriage, for I am fully capable,” Gaelera said to her, over the trundling of the wheels, “but this way I can watch the landscape, not the road.”

Maeneb made no reply.

“You may ask me,” said Gaelera, “if I have seen much of the world.”

Still Maeneb said nothing. She vowed inwardly that she would not be bidden in that way. Gaelera cocked her head at her. “Ask,” she said.

“I beg your pardon. My lady, have you seen much of the world?”

“Very little,” said Gaelera. Another pause. “You may ask me if I like what I have seen.”

“My lady, do you like what – oh, for stars’ sake,” said Maeneb, “just tell me what you want to. If you please, I mean. I am no good at this sort of polite conversing. I never know what I should say.” Again she was amazed at her own bluntness.

But Gaelera did not seem to mind. She nodded thoughtfully. “I am the same. Those ruins once were peasants’ houses, I presume?”

“Those low round walls? I presume so too,” said Maeneb.

“What a strange, uncomfortable life they must have led,” Gaelera mused.

“I don’t think so,” said Maeneb. “Better than tents.”

“And yet your tents appeared quite large and airy.”

Maeneb frowned. “When have you seen our tents?” For they had all been packed before Gaelera had arrived.

“Outside Kelvha City.”

“Hmph.” For a moment Maeneb had feared Gaelera had been spying on Olbeth’s farm. Although there was no earthly reason why she should... Yet Gaelera was, she felt, an assiduous gatherer of useful facts.

Divert her, then. With useless facts that were no secrets.

“We exiled members of the Vonn have lived mainly in those tents for the last dozen years,” she said, “in various places; although some have also made their homes in Outer Kelvha, in farms and villages, the better to work or raise their families.”

“But it was not, presumably, your ancestors who once lived in these round houses.”

“The Vonn? Of course not.”

“But you do not know who did.”

Was that a note of contempt in Gaelera’s voice? Stung to answer, Maeneb retorted, “I know that stonemen, or an early version of them, used to live in the place where we are going, along the Red Roads. That’s why Huldarion chose this route: to see if the area still holds a stoneman settlement, at the Place of Terns. If so, we may find roads leading to the stonemen’s other centres.”

“I have never seen a stoneman,” said Gaelera thoughtfully.

“You should hope you never do.”

“On the contrary, I hope I do. You will prevent me from being slain.”

Was she joking? “If the stoneman army decide to attack us, it will take more than me to stop you being slain,” said Maeneb curtly.

"Are they likely to attack us?"

"No."

"Then the observation is superfluous."

Maeneb rolled her eyes at the horizon and grimly urged her horse onward. Thankfully, Gaelera seemed to have exhausted her need for entertaining talk; instead she stared around at her surroundings. Once she called to Piril, who sat within the carriage, to bring her out a pastry, and then again to take away the plate. Her driver sat grinning wordlessly throughout the journey.

After an hour the army halted for the evening, having progressed another five or six miles. Maeneb gazed back the way that they had come, hoping for some glimpse of a Kelvhan regiment galloping up to rescue her from Gaelera's presence.

None there, of course. That was too much to hope for. She saw only Leor and Ikelder, cantering swiftly to catch up with the army. The two rode over to Huldarion and his counsellors: she watched them speak, and saw Ikelder shake his head.

What did that mean? Evidently that no Kelvhans were being sent for Gaelera – for tonight at least. She turned and saw that Gaelera was looking the same way.

"Perhaps your father will dispatch his troops to fetch you back tomorrow," she suggested.

"If he does, I shall not go," Gaelera answered calmly. She turned to speak into the interior of her carriage. "Piril? You may set out my supper, and make up my bed. No, wait. Where do you sleep, Maeneb?"

"I generally sleep in a tent with several of the other women," she answered warily.

"I have a mind to experience a tent. Tonight I shall join you."

Maeneb shrank from the idea. "The others will have to agree," she warned.

"Then you can make sure that they do."

How can I deny her, thought Maeneb wretchedly, when she is practically Kelvhan royalty? With reluctance she walked over and said as much to Delgeb, who shrugged.

"If a night inside a tent is what she wants, she's welcome. So long as she doesn't expect any luxury, and doesn't mind the snoring. One night will probably be plenty for her."

If Delgeb did not protest, the other women were unlikely to. Nonetheless Maeneb sounded them all out in the hope of winning a refusal. Hilbré, however, merely said, "I suppose Huldarion would tell us to humour her," and Durba nodded her agreement. Parba and Bredla did not complain either; so there was only Yaret left to ask.

Maeneb had to hunt for her. It was already dusk by the time she found Yaret and Rothir just outside the camp, standing side by side as they gazed up at the darkening sky. Was this a romantic tryst? She approached the couple cautiously. But it turned out that they were merely comparing notes on stars; so no romance there after all.

"That group of four we call the window," Yaret was saying.

"That rectangle of bright stars? But that's the Shield, and around it is the Shieldholder," said Rothir. "I thought those terms were universal."

"Well, we know that name also. And the dragon and the cauldron. But they are Standard names, not Bandiran. So the dragon we call the River."

"A small river," commented Rothir.

"Well, everything in Obandiro is small. Our biggest river is the Dondel brook. Such a sad thin moon there is this evening! I hope it shines a little brighter on Veron."

"The moon shines the same everywhere," said Maeneb as she came up to them. "Yaret, you don't want Gaelera to join us in our tent tonight, do you? It will become very crushed."

Yaret looked at her. "She has asked to, I presume."

"But only if everyone agrees."

"If everyone else agrees, then I agree," said Yaret. She was smiling. "It can do no harm."

"Except to our sleep," muttered Maeneb.

But Yaret had already turned to gaze up at the sky again, saying to Rothir, "The River in your parlance is, I know, the whole long sweep of stars that we call the White Roads."

"White Roads above, Red Roads below," said Rothir. "It has a pleasing symmetry."

"Which would you rather travel?" asked Yaret.

Maeneb did not wait to hear Rothir's answer. Somewhat disgusted with such fanciful talk, she returned to Gaelera and unwillingly informed her that her Ladyship would be most welcome to join the women for one night.

So there were eight of them in Maeneb's tent. Maeneb could not help wondering if Gaelera would actually remove her decorative robes to sleep – the heavy fabric seemed so much a part of her.

But she appeared at the entrance wrapped in a dressing gown; embroidered, it was true, with lilies and long grasses; but not so densely as to prevent her sleeping in it. She lay on her back on a spare bedroll with her eyes closed, as if she were practising to be a corpse. At least she didn't ask to be talked to.

However, Maeneb found some difficulty in going to sleep herself. The wind sneaked underneath the canvas walls to tease her. The lantern with its single candle swayed and wavered, its uncertain gleam disturbing her even through her closed eyelids. She could not shut her mind off from the other minds around her as she usually contrived to do at night. Instead she lay awake, listening to the various grades of sleeping-sounds – Delgeb snored the loudest – and wondered at Gaelera's presence here with the Vonn. It had to have a motive. But what could it be?

Beyond the tent, the further sounds disturbed her: a man coughing, a horse whinnying; and she was aware of many minds still turning as their owners turned inside their bedrolls, trying to find some point of comfort in their situation, as fretful as the flickering lantern.

She reached out further, for Olbeth or Veron, wondering how they fared. She had been aware of Veron's torment for the early part of this ride; but he was now too far away for her to sense him, or else the minds close to her blocked him out. She could easily detect the colour of Parthenal's restlessness, two tents away. However, of Gaelera's mind, only odd wisps of sensation came to her and none of them meant anything. Just dreams.

But someone several tents away, Maeneb became suddenly aware, was having a bad dream. Very bad. Although she could hear nothing, she felt the discomfort: rising rapidly to acute fear, pain, terror–

And then nothing. No awakening. Just a total blank.

Chapter 17

Maeneb sat up abruptly. What had happened?

Delgeb was instantly awake and sitting up as well. "What's wrong?"

"Someone's in trouble," said Maeneb curtly, and grabbing her long knife which she kept by her side even in sleep, she scrambled to her feet. Clad in her shirt and underbreeches, she shoved her feet into her boots and made for the entrance. No sooner had she dived out of the tent than she heard the scream.

It was almost instantly cut off. But now the whole camp was awake. Men and women began to pour out from the tents into the feeble moonlight; despite their varying degrees of undress, all were armed.

And after a very few bewildered seconds those arms were needed. At first Maeneb could not make out what was happening in the mottled darkness. Then something leapt at her out of the shadow: she swiped at it instinctively with her knife, before realising that it was a man and that her blade had sliced across his chest.

He staggered back a step. His sword-blow missed her and slashed through the tent's wall with a harsh rip. A second afterwards, the longer sword of Delgeb found his throat.

The attacker slumped to the ground. Only then could Maeneb see the moonlight glimmer of his head and its four stones.

"Stoneman," rasped Delgeb, and she roared out – quite unnecessarily in Maeneb's opinion – "Battle stations!"

Someone produced a lamp, creating a confusion of leaping shadows. Riders were running everywhere, swords in their hands. Then the flame was blown out by the wind. From every side came warning shouts and the metallic clash of blade on blade. Maeneb, peering into the shadows between the tents, saw them writhe and then boil over, turning into the dark figures of more stonemen, charging.

With a furious yell Delgeb thrust her sword into the foremost, who crumpled. While she struggled to withdraw the blade, Yaret and Hilbré between them dispatched the next one neatly, their swords slicing from either side like a pair of giant scissors across his throat.

Maeneb lunged out to stab the third attacker with her knife. When she felt it grind past the man's ribs to the heart, there was no consciousness of pain in him. Nothing but a kind of unfocussed fury. So strange, that lack of agony or fear. So inhuman.

But it made the job easier, she thought, as she swivelled rapidly to defend herself against another knot of stonemen who rushed in, shouting, from her right. As she stabbed one in the neck she became aware of Gaelera, standing motionless and watching at the entrance to the tent.

"Get back in!" she yelled. For although Gaelera held a sword – Maeneb's own – Maeneb had no faith that she would know how to use it. She feared, not so much for Gaelera, but for the consequences if she should be injured.

Gaelera did not move. She gazed steadily upon the scene as three more stonemen waved their axes clumsily – almost haphazardly – before being felled.

No more attackers followed. Elsewhere in the camp too the assault seemed to have diminished. The shouts and clashes faded, and Maeneb realised that this had been a most uneven contest: for the enemy had been outnumbered and easily overcome. She saw Rothir fell two last stonemen with sure, successive strokes; as they collapsed, no others charged in from the dark to take their places.

She found that she was panting, but more from agitation than from effort. Around her, Riders lowered their swords and looked at each other in the unworldly moonshine.

"Everyone all right?" said Delgeb.

"Yes. That was too simple," commented Parba.

"It was just a test," said Yaret. "Or possibly a distraction, designed to keep us sitting up awake all night in case they might attack again. They did that repeatedly in Melmet. It worked, as well."

Delgeb kicked the limp body of the nearest stoneman. "Well, I'm not losing any sleep on their account," she declared. "There were only a handful of them and poor fighters at that."

"True." Yaret bent down to look at the nearest body that lay distorted in the shadows. She straightened up with a grimace. "Three stones."

"So? What does that have to do with anything?" demanded Delgeb.

"Nothing," said Yaret. A pool of lamplight swayed its way over to them, held aloft by Uld.

"Is anyone here hurt?"

"No. Not even scratched. What news do you have, Uld?" said Hilbré. "Where did they come from?"

"The south-east," said the oldest of Huldarion's counsellors, who in the shuddering lamplight looked older still, and tired. "They killed the sentries on that side. Crept up in the dark and ambushed both at the same time. They strangled them."

Delgeb made a noise of disgust. "So what was this, Uld? Just a suicide mission, or did it have some deeper purpose? Yaret here thinks they simply want to make us worry."

"They've certainly succeeded," Uld answered sombrely. "Our sentries should not have been so easily overcome. It's as if these men came out of nowhere. I don't think there can be many others in the area, because our scouts surely would have found them. But it only takes a few to cause a lot of trouble. Do you know where the Lady Gaelera is?"

"I am here." Gaelera stepped forward, the bloodless sword held in her grasp.

Uld bowed. "The Lady Meya is most concerned for your well-being, and begs you to stay the remainder of the night within her carriage." Gaelera did not immediately respond. "My lady?" said Uld.

"No. I shall stay here," replied Gaelera. "I have been well-protected."

"You are sure?"

"Quite sure."

"If you change your mind..."

"I shall not."

Uld hesitated, bowed again, and left them. Gaelera raised the sword with an effort, and offered it to Maeneb, point up.

"For stars' sake, don't hold the thing like that. Just put it on the ground," said Maeneb.

She was immediately conscious of her own rudeness. However, Gaelera obeyed her without comment. Meanwhile the others began to drag away the bodies. Rothir and Landel came over to assist them; Gaelera made no attempt to help.

"Three of my wishes have now been fulfilled, and all in one night," she announced thoughtfully.

"And what are those?" said Yaret, pausing beside a corpse.

"I have held a sword: an ambition of long standing. I have slept inside a tent, if only for a curtailed period of sleep. And now I have seen stonemen."

"Dead ones," Delgeb grunted. "The best kind."

"I am fortunate," Gaelera said. "I feel it is a good omen." Maeneb sensed a faint haze of pleasure, before it was shut down.

Rothir was gazing at Gaelera in astonishment. "Stonemen are never a good omen," he said. "This just means more attacks can be expected. It means they have been watching us."

“Good omens can be chosen,” said Gaelera. She stepped aside to avoid the carriers of the corpses, and re-entered the tent.

Maeneb, picking up her sword, muttered, “Well, at least the stonemen have given us a warning. From now on we’ll be on our guard.”

Yaret looked at Rothir. “It does mean that if they’re here, they’re less likely to be near your farm.”

“I hope you’re right,” he answered grimly.

“The farm? Why would stonemen be interested in that?” said Delgeb. “There’s nothing there worth their bothering with. We practically emptied the provision stores.”

Yaret shrugged. “I was just thinking of Rothir’s sister and her baby. And the others in the household, and of course Veron. But if the stonemen are focusing on us, at least the farmstead should be safe.”

Chapter 18

"Come on, Mister – Mister Veron," said Aliya from the doorway. "Wake up and eat your breakfast." She remembered just in time not to call him Mister Wolfman, although that was what she called him in her head. But when she had called him Mr Wolfman yesterday, he had thrown the bowl of porridge at her.

No, not at her. At the wall, which was not the same thing. Olbeth had pointed that out, and Aliya decided that Olbeth had been right, because the bowl had gone nowhere near her although the porridge had splattered her a little bit. But she was still wearing old clothes so a bit of porridge didn't matter.

"He just wanted to throw something," Olbeth had said. "It's because of the pain, and the medicine he has to take. It makes the pain better but it also makes him angry. He didn't mean to hurt you, Aliya. But he might hurt you by accident, without meaning to, so best stay out of his way."

Aliya had thought about this. Should she obey? She was a Lady, or almost, so she didn't need to do what Olbeth said.

But then the wolfman had thrown a chair at the other hunter, Edrik, the one with the frizzly grey hair, and had shouted at him. And Edrik was his friend. When Edrik walked away from the wolfman's room he looked very sad. If Edrik was not safe from the wolfman, maybe Aliya would not be either. Moreover, she decided that she liked Olbeth and wanted to please her. So she stayed out of the wolfman's way.

Sort of. Three times, she ran around the outside of the farmhouse and into the cobbled yard so that she could peek in through his window. He sat on his bed, with his head in his hands, and once was pacing the floor to and fro, to and fro, limping and groaning horribly, with low groans like tearing cloth.

But there was no cloth. He had thrown the blankets on the floor. Olbeth had cut his breeches off above the knee and his legs were covered in red lines, as if they had been painted, or lots of dark red stringy worms had stuck to them. It didn't look nice.

When he turned towards the window Aliya ducked down out of sight. It felt like playing a game but she knew it wasn't really. He might throw something.

All the same she wanted to keep an eye on the wolfman. So here she was, offering him another bowl of porridge, having persuaded Camburé to take her to the chamber door. She didn't like Camburé as much as Olbeth, for she had sharp eyes despite her jokes, but Camburé had said all right so long as they both stayed safely in the doorway.

"Mister Veron?" Aliya called out. "Here's your breakfast." Better not to mention porridge, she thought. Breakfast sounded better. "It's nice and hot," she added.

When she peeped into the room the wolfman was lying on the bed, his legs stretched out. Camburé said he could not bear to have a sheet on them, let alone a blanket. They looked just as red as yesterday: or worse, perhaps, because the red was turning into purple. Although Aliya did not know what that meant, she thought it was not good.

When he opened his eyes and looked at them he seemed different to before. More far away.

"How was your night?" said Camburé. "Did you manage to sleep without the Athelid?"

"No." His voice came from very far away as well.

"Do you want some Athelid now, Veron?"

"No."

"But it will–"

He cut across her. "No. Rather pain. Than turn into a stoneman."

"Athelid will not turn you into a stoneman."

"Almost did. Bring porridge. Won't throw it." His words were hoarse and short as if it hurt to speak.

"Me," said Aliya to Camburé, and before Camburé could object, she carried the warm bowl across the room and set it carefully down upon the little table. The wolfman did not sit up to reach for it. She looked at his legs and then away again, because they really did not look nice. They looked quite ugly, as if purple vines were growing up them. It made her anxious. Olbeth had told her that the thing that hurt his legs wasn't catching; but all the same Aliya felt worried, because she had an idea that the wolfman was important and she didn't like him being ill.

"Mister Veron," she said, "shall I tell you another story?"

"No."

Well, at least he hadn't shouted it. Or thrown the porridge.

"I could sing you a song," she suggested.

"Later." He croaked like a frog. She thought of telling him this, to cheer him up, and then decided not to. A wolfman might not like being called a frog.

But he was not so scary any more as he had been. He was staring at the ceiling and sometimes he closed his eyes and all his face pulled tighter.

"Come away now," said Camburé. "We'll leave him to rest."

"Hah," said Veron.

Aliya did not want to leave him. She felt it wasn't good for him to be alone. When she had been sick just after her fifth birthday she had wanted Flodda to stay with her, to sit by her bed and smooth back her hair and talk to her gently. Flodda had told her a story about a magic well and although it wasn't a very good story it had been better than lying alone and thinking about feeling sick.

"Do you want Edrik?" she asked, although Edrik didn't look like the sort of person who knew many stories. "You could talk about wolves together."

"No." Another croak.

"Come away," said Camburé again, and this time Aliya allowed herself to be led away.

"Is he not having his medicine any more?" she asked, and Camburé shook her head. "Good. He's nicer when he doesn't," said Aliya.

Camburé didn't answer. But when they returned to the great hall where Olbeth and Wiln were, Camburé hurried over to them and they began to talk in whispers, frowning.

They were talking about the wolfman. Aliya went over to the fireplace where Flodda was playing with baby Doval. He was a nice baby. She liked the way his eyes scrunched up and he laughed and showed his two little teeth that were growing at the bottom of his mouth. He sat on the hearthstone on a blanket with his legs wide and when he saw Aliya he waved both arms in excitement.

Aliya waved back at him. "I'll come back in a minute. First I'm going to look at Lally," she told Flodda, and then she ran outside, past the two big dogs. She always tried to get past them quickly. They lifted their heads to her and seemed sort of friendly but she didn't try to pat them. They were very big dogs and might bite her by mistake. They might be as big as wolves. The wolfman must be very brave to hunt wolves.

In the yard she stopped running for a moment while she thought. Maybe it was brave to stop taking your medicine if it meant your legs hurt more. Which was worse, to feel really angry, or to have really hurting legs?

She tried to puzzle this out. Whenever she fell over and skinned her knees it hurt horribly but not for long. It would not be nice to have them always hurting. But she decided that maybe it was even worse being angry all the time, if you were a person who killed wolves, because if you got too angry you might kill other things instead.

With this thought decided, she skipped across the farmyard to the big barn where the cows were huffing in the darkness. They had calves beside them in the straw but they didn't like people interfering with them. Olbeth had told her that. Olbeth knew lots of useful things.

When Mama had brought her here Aliya had been worried that she wouldn't like it and thought she might have to pretend. She knew Mama wanted her to like it here and she wanted to please Mama. But it was all right because once Olbeth took her out to see the ducks and told her where to find some eggs and then helped her cook them for the wolfman, Aliya knew already that she liked it here and she wouldn't need to pretend after all.

She hadn't wanted Mama to go. Mama always sorted problems out and Aliya felt safe with her although she had a growing idea that other people found Mama quite scary. But she knew that Mama would do almost anything Aliya wanted.

Not quite everything, though. Aliya had wanted Mama to stay and look at all the animals with her, but she knew Mama would have to leave soon anyway because she always had to leave. It was because she was important and now she was going to be a queen. She was going to marry the man with the funny face, who was a bit scary too, but Mama said he was a good man and he was going to be a king. Aliya didn't know why he wasn't called a prince but Mama didn't seem to mind.

Now she ran past the calves and past the window by the corner of the farmhouse where the wolfman was, without stopping to peek in at him this time. She almost ran out of the farmyard to find the ducks, but then she remembered why she was here. She had something more important to see about than ducks. It was her piglet, Lally.

She was sure that Lally already knew who she was – even though Flodda said it was only because she gave the piglet food and they were greedy little beasts. But when Lally came scampering across the pen to her in a flurry of straw Aliya felt sure it wasn't simply out of greed. Lally was a very nice-looking piglet with her orange fur like a frizzly fire and her nose as pink as a mouse's and one floppy ear. But she was a messy piglet too. Her pen needed cleaning out again.

"Flodda?" said Aliya as the nursemaid came hurrying over to her. "You need to clean out Lally's pen."

Flodda stopped and put her head on one side with a puzzled expression. This was something she had learnt to do from Olbeth in the last few days; and Aliya had learnt what it meant.

She pulled an impatient face. "Please," she added. She had never needed to say *Please* to the servants at Lord and Lady Hapligan's house, and she didn't understand why Olbeth thought it was important. Perhaps it was because Olbeth didn't really have servants. There were people who helped on the farm and in the dairy, but they sat at the table to eat with everybody else, and Olbeth said *please* and *thank you* to them too. So were they servants or not?

"You can help me clean it out this time," said Flodda. She didn't sound much like a servant any more either. "We'll go and fetch the straw together."

As they fetched the straw and shovel and cleaned up the pen Aliya decided that if she wasn't a princess she might have liked to be a farmer, although she knew that this would be a shocking thing for her to say aloud.

"I want to be a farmer," she said, to test it on Flodda.

"You'd be a good one," Flodda said. "You're a busy little miss." Aliya stood still and frowned at her because that was what Mama did when a servant said something that they shouldn't.

But Flodda didn't seem to notice. So Aliya had to let it go and instead she said,

"Do you think the wolfm – do you think Mister Veron would like a drawing of a piglet?"

"I doubt it," Flodda said.

"Because I can't draw wolves. I've never seen a wolf."

"Lucky you," said Flodda.

Aliya brushed flecks of straw off her sleeves. She was glad now that she didn't wear her proper clothes here because they would have got so dirty. And she was getting used to the braids pulling at her hair. It was worth it to be allowed to run around outside like a servant girl.

At Lord and Lady Hapligran's she hadn't been allowed to run around outside very much, although sometimes she would escape Flodda and run off to her favourite tree. It was a very wide tree and very low down, so that Flodda had to bend right down to follow her. It was supposed to be an apple tree but Aliya had never seen any apples.

"I will draw Veron a picture anyway," she announced. "Can you get me some paper and some charcoal? Please." And she smiled at Flodda, who looked startled.

"Since you ask so nicely, I expect I can," she said.

So once Aliya had finished playing with Lally she didn't go and visit the ducks as she had planned but instead ran back inside the house past the two dogs and sat on the bench at the long high table in the great hall, underneath the little windows, drawing her picture for the wolfman. It was meant to make him feel better so she drew her favourite tree and tried to put some magic into it. She wasn't sure how magic worked but as she drew she recited a spell that she made up: "Whuddy duddy fiddy fuddy. Obby duddy whibby whubby."

As soon as she had finished she ran off to the wolfman's room and knocked and went in before he could say no.

"I drew you a picture to make you feel better," she said, although when she looked at his legs and his face she felt worried that it wouldn't work after all. It wouldn't be enough. His face was a funny colour like a rainy sky and all stretched tight as if he wore braids like her, although of course he didn't. His hair and forehead were damp with sweat although he hadn't been running.

All the same, she was here now, so she might as well give him the picture.

"Sit up," she commanded, and then thought to add "Please." But he stayed lying down and she had to hold her drawing in front of his face. He looked at it and then closed his eyes.

"What is it?"

"It's a tree," said Aliya. That should have been obvious. "It's an apple tree but it doesn't have any apples yet."

He sighed and opened his eyes again. "The sticks?"

"That's you," said Aliya, "lying underneath the tree. It's nice to lie down underneath a tree."

"Too many arms," he said after a moment.

"Those aren't arms. Those are your fingers." A person had to have fingers. She was surprised he didn't recognise them. But at least he didn't ask what the sun was.

Another sigh. He closed his eyes again.

Then he opened them abruptly. "What's that?" he said.

"I don't know," said Aliya, because he wasn't looking at her drawing any more. Then he sat up and swung his ugly purple legs over the edge of the bed.

And now she knew what he was talking about. There was a noise going on outside: a sort of distant shouting, a bit like the pigs arguing over food, but it wasn't the pigs.

"I'll go and see," she said.

"Don't go anywhere," said the wolfman fiercely. "Stay right here." And he stood up on his ugly legs and pulled his shoes on and grabbed the belt that lay over the back of the chair and strapped it round his waist, over his cut-off breeches, and she saw that it had a sword hanging from one side and two knives and some things on a chain on the other side.

She began to feel afraid. "I want to go and find Flodda," she said, but then the door burst open and Flodda came shooting in and grabbed her by the arm.

"They're out the front," said Flodda. "They came hidden in a wood-cart. Calenir went out to meet it and they—" She stopped short. "Where can we go?"

Then Olbeth ran in too, carrying baby Doval.

"Cellar?" said the wolfman to her.

"No time," said Olbeth. "Use the window. Left through the yard, down the lane past the forge and along the field-walls. There's a place to hide. Wiln and the others will hold them off."

He nodded and turned to open the window. It didn't open properly and he put his shoulder to it and wrenched the whole window out with a crunch of splintering wood and dropped it on the ground outside. Now Aliya could hear the shouting much more clearly. It sounded angry.

The wolfman picked her up and sat her on the windowsill. "Edrik!" he called. Edrik was running over to them across the yard outside. He was tying on a sword-belt as he ran.

"I can jump down," she said, but Edrik stopped by the window and lifted her down. Then Veron helped Flodda to climb out and she took baby Doval while Olbeth climbed out too.

Veron climbed out last. They all began to run across the yard, past the cow barn, past the pecking chickens, past Lally in her little pen. Aliya wanted to stop and pick up Lally but Flodda dragged her on.

"She's safe," she said. "They don't want pigs."

Aliya wondered who *they* were. But it was quite clear to her that if *they* didn't want pigs, they did want people. So she ran as fast as she could, which was not fast enough to keep up with the others. Before she could tell them to wait, Edrik stopped in front of her and hunched himself up.

"Climb on," he said, and Flodda lifted her up onto his back and she rode there clinging round his neck with both arms. He ran with her down the track past the forge, which she had not been allowed to go into. She thought they might be going to hide in there but the wolfman did not stop. Instead he ran on to a gate and putting one hand on it he jumped straight over, so that Aliya thought his legs could not be hurting all that much after all.

Edrik put Aliya down, opened the gate and pushed her through. He was gasping and panting.

"Back's not up to it," he said. The wolfman turned round in mid step and scooped Aliya up in both his arms and set off at a run again. His hair was thick and dark against her face and his knife hilts were cold upon her legs. He was squishing her but she knew better than to complain, because by now she was very frightened even though she did not know what they were all running away from.

Twisting her head around she saw Flodda hoicking up her skirts and baby Doval bouncing up and down in Olbeth's arms, with a startled face. She was glad Doval wasn't crying because that might have made her want to cry as well. She wanted to cry anyway, a bit. Behind them Edrik was looking over his shoulder and he had drawn his sword.

But nobody was following them and she hoped that nobody would, as they ran on, alongside one big muddy field and then another. She twined her legs around the wolfman's body because of all the jolting. Carrying her did not slow him down.

"Through the gate," said Olbeth, breathless, and Aliya reached down to unlatch the next gate so that the wolfman wouldn't have to do it. When he carried her through, ahead of them there was a great big tree – bigger and wider even than her favourite apple tree that had no apples – and she wondered if they were going to hide under it somehow or maybe climb up into the branches. If someone lifted her up to start climbing she could probably manage that.

It was dark under the tree except for a patch of tiny flowers like a pool of white across the grass. It was quite pretty.

But Olbeth said "Stones," and the wolfman swerved away from the tree and went uphill towards a big stone – house – thing – Aliya did not know what to call it. It had a roof and walls made out of giant flat stones but no windows so it was not a proper house. But it had a very narrow door.

The wolfman put her down and thrust her through the door. She took a few steps in and stopped. It was quite dark apart from two long thin brilliant strips of light at the far end. They weren't wide enough to be windows although they might be arrow slits. She knew about arrow slits. But this wasn't a castle, it was only three great big stones propped up together and another great big stone on top.

Flodda and Olbeth followed her in. The two men stayed outside. Olbeth handed the baby over to Flodda. He looked too surprised to cry.

"Sit down at that end, in the middle of the wall," said Olbeth, so Aliya sat down with her back against the furthest stone. It felt gritty. Now the slivers of light were on either side of her and the bigger slice of light that was the entrance was in front. But it was blocked by Olbeth. She stood in the entrance looking all dark against the light, and Aliya realised that she too now held a sword. Flodda stood in the middle of the stone room clutching Doval. Olbeth threw something backwards onto the ground so that it landed in front of Flodda. It was a knife.

Aliya wondered where Olbeth had been keeping the sword and knife within her skirts, but there was no time to wonder any more because she heard loud yells and people running and then a clashing sound like when Flodda dropped the tin bathtub on the flagstones. Aliya tried to tell herself it was a tin bath but she knew there was no bathtub here and it could only be the sound of swords. She didn't know who was doing the shouting but they made a horrid noise. They sounded fierce and angry and she remembered what Olbeth had said about the wolfman's medicine making him angry. But he hadn't sounded anything like this.

Where was the wolfman? Some of the shouts and crashing noises came from behind her now, through the stone slits on either side. And an instant later it was not just noise – a long curved blade all of a sudden came pushing through the slit on one side of her, sticking out into the air. Then a second blade came through the slit on the other side of her. But the slits were too narrow for the swords to go anywhere but straight ahead. They sliced up and down while Aliya sat quite still in the middle between them and did not move and then there were scuffling sounds and grunts and crashes and the two swords went away.

Aliya thought she wanted to cry but that might make the baby cry and at the moment he was still just looking surprised. So she didn't. But then Olbeth was suddenly moving backwards and forwards and Aliya realised that there was somebody else on the other side of her trying to get in through the stone door and Olbeth was fighting him.

Flodda turned round and put baby Doval down in Aliya's arms. Then she snatched up the knife and stood in front of them both. Aliya held on tight to baby Doval and tried to sing him a song but the song had gone out of her head, she had forgotten how to sing and Olbeth was still fighting somebody she couldn't see and the clashing and shouting outside was still going on as well.

The someone in the doorway fell down and tried to crawl a bit, and then he stopped. Olbeth did not move him although he was blocking up the doorway. Aliya could not see much of him apart from a shaved head which had stones stuck to it. Beyond him someone else was moving and Olbeth suddenly stood up on the bald man's back and there was more clashing and a second man was almost inside the stone house but he couldn't quite get in and Olbeth was fighting with him and then Flodda ran over there with the knife.

Aliya did not want to watch. She held on tighter to baby Doval who was trying to pull her braids. Then he reached out with his little curly hands and grasped at something in the air. It was only a shaft of light that came in through the narrow window and tiny dots of dust that floated there. But Doval laughed and waved his hands at the floating dots. The stone felt very solid behind Aliya's back and for an odd moment she felt that the shaft of light might be solid too, that it was like a sword of brightness and would keep her and Doval safe.

So she held on to Doval and did not look at what was happening in the doorway, although there was a horrible scraping of swords hitting stone and awful gruntings, much worse than pigs. And then Olbeth stepped back inside the stone house.

Aliya looked up and saw another man lying on top of the first. Outside there was a scream and then suddenly it stopped. Again she wondered where the wolfman was. But she did not want to move. She wanted to stay here and hold on to Doval with the shaft of brightness keeping them both safe.

Olbeth climbed over the two lying-down men and went out of the stone house. When she came back a few seconds later she said, "All right."

Aliya just looked at her. Doval buried his face in her neck and tried to burrow there and had a little wail. He was getting ready to cry now.

"It's all right," said Olbeth. She didn't come over to take Doval. Instead she leaned against the narrow doorway. She looked very tired and there was blood on her face and on the sword which dangled from her hand.

"Are you hurt?" said Flodda, but Olbeth shook her head. Then after a minute she stopped leaning and said, "Come on."

Flodda took Doval from Aliya's arms. He didn't want to go and Aliya didn't want to let him go. While she was holding him she could not stand up and she didn't want to stand up yet. But now Flodda had Doval, so Aliya had to stand up although her legs still didn't want to and then she walked through that bar of light and floating dust and went to the doorway. She had to climb over the men to get out of the stone place and it felt very odd. Part hard and part squishy.

Outside was very bright even though the sun was not really shining much and she had to screw her eyes up. She couldn't see the others straight away but then she saw Wiln hurrying over from the gate and some of the other people from the farmhouse behind him. There were quite a lot of men lying on the ground and she hoped the wolfman wasn't one of them but she didn't want to look too closely to find out. So she peeped and pretended she wasn't peeping and saw that they all had stones stuck to their heads.

Edrik was there too and he was bending over so maybe his back was hurting him again. But Olbeth went over to him and ripped a bit of her skirt off – it was torn already anyway – and said, "Hold out your arm." Edrik held out an arm which was dripping blood. He looked over at Aliya but did not seem to see her.

She looked round for the wolfman but he was not there. Then she saw more men lying down underneath the big tree, where the tiny flowers were, and they were all lying quite still so she ran over to them. Flodda tried to stop her but she was too slow because of holding baby Doval.

So Aliya ran right underneath the tree where it was dark and there were four men lying there, no five, no six, amongst the little white flowers. Although now that she was close she saw that they weren't flowers as she had thought. They were lots of little criss-crossed threads like tiny cobwebs, and not really very pretty after all.

Most of the men lying underneath the tree had stones around their heads but then she saw that one did not. It was the wolfman, next to the huge trunk. He was on his back with his eyes closed and some knives and swirly bits of chain were lying next to him.

"Mister Wolfman," said Aliya. "Mister Veron." She could hear her own voice sounding quite strange and she didn't know what to do.

Then he opened his eyes. He didn't look at her but just looked up at the thick dark branches over his head. He lay quite still. She noticed that his legs were covered with pale cobwebby threads just like the earth around him. They made his skin look whitish.

She took a few steps closer and saw that the cobwebby stuff was spreading. She couldn't see any spiders and it seemed to spread all on its own. It was growing over his legs from one side to the other, white and frizzly, and underneath it there was no purple any more.

Was the wolfman too hurt to get up? There was blood on his clothes but maybe he was just lying down to have a rest. He didn't seem to mind the cobwebby stuff because as he lay and looked up at the tree his face was not pulled tight like it had been before.

"Veron? Are you badly hurt?" That was not her but Wiln who had stooped down underneath the branches. He put his hand onto Aliya's shoulder.

And at last the wolfman spoke. "Never better."

But still he did not move or get back up. He just lay there underneath the huge wide tree with the cobwebs growing over both his legs.

Then he stretched his arms out as if he was lying in sunshine and not cobwebby shadow, and heaved a deep slow sigh.

And then another sigh, and then another; until all at once she realised he was laughing.

Chapter 19

The Riders were once more on the move, although without the jokes and carefree talk of previous days. The mood was much less cheerful.

Huldarion too was sombre. He had expected an attack by stonemen at some point; and the Vonn had got off lightly. Moreover, so far there had been no follow-up assault.

But he was perturbed at the attack's surprising suddenness. The stonemen had come upon them completely undetected by the sentries; no warning chime had rung out from the bowl – not that he had thought it would – but the scouts had not reported any stonemen lurking near. So where had they sprung from? The sentries had been lulled into carelessness, most likely, by the quiet of this place.

Now, in daylight, there was nowhere for ambushers to hide. For the hills were shrinking, their sharp angry peaks becoming blunt, and finally flattened as if an enormous mallet had been at work. The few low patchy shrubs became still fewer; and since the dissipation of the strange cloud, the air had remained clear, giving them a long view across this empty land. The ruins that threatened to trip their horses only added to the sense of loneliness.

Yet it is not lonely here, Huldarion mused; for the land feels full of... what? Not ghosts, despite the long abandoned houses. It is not haunted, except maybe by itself; it feels complete, a place where human presence can add nothing.

He paused his horse and sniffed the breeze. Was that the cold tang of the sea? He drew it in, anticipating.

"Another day's march," he said to Thoronal, "and we'll be there."

Thoronal gave a snort in answer.

Huldarion studied him. "You have no hankering to set eyes on the sea again?"

"I had no great love for it the first time," Thoronal replied.

To his dismay, Huldarion realised that he felt like shaking his chief counsellor. He bit back the reproach that sprang to his lips. But could not Thoronal pretend some eagerness? They were taking a roundabout route to Caervonn, it was true; yet he could show more enthusiasm than this.

While he held his tongue, Huldarion pondered. Was he wise to keep the man so close just because he was a cousin? This was still not the confident Thoronal of old, for he had seemed sunk in doubt and gloom ever since his errors on the battlefield beside the Darkburn forest.

For all his worries, Huldarion felt glad that soon he would behold the sea. Perhaps it was because of all his worries: the sea promised renewal, rest, a place to lay down burdens for a while. He would have welcomed some gesture of fellow-feeling from Thoronal.

Glancing round, he guessed that Rothir shared his pleasure: he was looking more content than he had over the last year or two. Perhaps he should demote Thoronal and put Rothir in his place.

But no; a sulky temper was not sufficient reason for demotion. Moreover, Rothir had countermanded him. Huldarion's displeasure at the raising of the darkburn was still strong, and bred a lurking wariness about what else Rothir might see fit to do without permission.

Parthenal, then? Astute enough, yet he had never been as thoughtful as Rothir. Parthenal's concerns were chiefly for himself; his relationships brief and dispassionate; sometimes Huldarion found himself amazed at the man's consistent dedication to him. However, he was grateful to have the loyalty of such an excellent warrior, and one whom he had always regarded with affection.

Right now, though, Parthenal seemed as discontented as Thoronal, if from a different cause. Huldarion recognised his restless air. Parthenal is hunting, he thought wryly; having been a full month celibate, he is once more on the prowl; and then he wondered at his own acute sensitivity to this mood of Parthenal's.

At least the expression of such desires did not matter now. There were no Kelvhans in the line to be outraged by Parthenal's roving eye – except Gaelera. But he did not wish to think about Gaelera. Instead, having touched on the image of a hunter, he thought about Veron.

How was Veron? That anxiety hung over him like a memory of the low depressing cloud. He trusted that Olbeth's ministering would hold the worst at bay; but he did not know what the worst was.

And the child, also left behind there at the farm. A pert little girl, though she seemed bright enough. He hoped that Olbeth did not mind her. He hoped, more generally, that Olbeth did not mind anything: he prayed that life with Wiln was good to her. No doubt it was. What had she thought of Meya?

No point wondering about that. The two women had certain traits in common – a practical efficiency, intelligence – but otherwise seemed far apart. He would reward Olbeth after all this was over. But no, perhaps he would not, in case Meya were to remark on it.

And he should not be thinking about Olbeth in this way at all. He was breaking his own rule. Why think of Olbeth, now that he had Meya? Turning round he looked for Meya's carriage: in vain, for it was invisible within the line of carts and Riders.

Instead something else caught his eye. A moving blur far to his left.

"Solon," he said abruptly, turning to the man on his other side, "what is that? It's not a darkburn; it's too big. I think it's a body of men. Stonemen?"

Solon craned his neck to look. His sight, always sharp, seemed to have grown sharper with age.

"No," he said, "there are horses, and some carriages. I see green and gold. They're Kelvhans. A largish troop, I'd say."

"So they have sent a company to fetch away Gaelera." It came as a relief.

"Good," said Solon. "She's a liability." But his frowning glance alighted not on Gaelera, but on his own wife Tiburé a few yards distant.

Another counsellor with a problem. Huldarion sighed inwardly. Still, so long as Solon's resentment of Tiburé did not cloud his judgement, it should not concern him.

"I will not stop and wait here for the Kelvhans," he decided. "If they want to join us, let them send an emissary over, or else go fast enough to catch us up."

Despite his words he slowed his horse a little, and then marvelled as always at how the whole army slowed behind him to his pace. His Riders were truly at his beck and call. It sometimes seemed extraordinary, the trust they placed in him: he must not take their faith for granted.

"Honour, care, fidelity," he murmured.

Solon glanced at him. "You're thinking of that bowl?"

It was not an unreasonable assumption. Earlier that morning they had paid a visit to the priest's cart, to check on the safety of the great bowl that was inscribed with those watchwords of the Vonn. The bowl was silent, swathed thickly in its cloths. When the priest unwrapped it reverently, Huldarion had to resist the urge to touch – to awake that singular, many-layered song. Hokiro had assured them that no-one else was permitted to view the precious thing.

"We shall have to keep it hidden from these Kelvhans," said Huldarion now to Solon, "and pray it doesn't ring – even to warn us about stonemen."

"You think it rang last time as an alarm?"

"Perhaps it was only a coincidence."

"But a strange one," Solon said, as Tiburé rode up to join them.

"A strange what?" she asked.

"Nothing that concerns you," said Solon, so dismissively that Huldarion wondered if he was right to ignore his counsellor's manner to his wife. Ex-wife.

If I demote Thoronal, he mused, then really Tiburé should replace him, as the most senior of the women. But only if she and her husband can settle their differences; and that looks unlikely. If they cannot either repair their marriage, or end it civilly, they will not work together.

"There are Kelvhans to our left. Should we acknowledge them?" asked Tiburé.

"Let them approach us first," he replied, eyeing the tiny figures.

"And there's something else ahead," said Tiburé.

She was right. Obtruding from the empty plain it rose before them in the distance, still tiny to the eyes but surely massive in reality. Tall but not a tree. Too straight, too solid. Was it a building?

They rode on, the line of Vonn snaking behind, while the object gradually grew into its full stature. It was a tall stone spire.

No, *spire* was the wrong word, thought Huldarion; for that implied something built of many pieces. This was a monolith; a single slab or shard of rock, perhaps first formed by nature, though it must have been erected by the hands of men.

Although he'd seen such stones in several regions – he recalled that Olbeth had mentioned some monument on her own farmland – this was the tallest he had come across. It must be forty feet in height, he judged: a blade of rock, almost rectangular, but with its top cut at an oblique angle where it pointed to the sky.

He spoke his instinctive thought aloud. "A marker stone. But what is it marking? What boundary is this?"

"The boundary between nothing and more nothing," muttered Thoronal.

"Let us ride on."

The ground before him had an odd appearance; it seemed almost to shine. He soon saw why. Although the stone rose up from solid ground, with long grass clumped around its base, on either side of it thin layers of water sheened the grassland. Water seeped up from the earth in several places, and pooled, gleaming, before starting to flow both left and right, in shallow streams that curled gracefully away towards the south. Swirling streaks of orange and red-brown coloured the slow waters. So gentle was the flow that he heard only the faintest of liquid notes.

Springs, he thought; there are springs beneath our feet, that feed those leisurely shallow streams. Maybe fed by the hills behind us; but here the land falls into place, and settles in a gentle blur of sky and water. I wonder if the streams flow all the way to the sea? A very gradual downhill from here. And there must be coloured clay, or iron, in the soil to cause that reddish hue.

The blade of stone, he now perceived, stood on a long peninsula; for far ahead, the twining streamlets met and melded. But it was no lake that they made. Rather, they formed a maze of gleaming waterways, from which rose a multitude of low, grassed islands, like the backs of huge nearly-submerged animals: a vast green herd of them, for as far as Huldarion could see.

Between these islands groups of long-beaked, spindly birds looked up to assess the intruders. They did not fly off; perhaps they were too unused to humans to regard them as a danger. Certainly no human settlements were in sight. Yet on some of those humped islands, edifices stood.

"More standing stones," Huldarion said, "if my eyes serve me."

"They do," said Solon. "I wonder if they bear any inscription to explain their purpose?"

"We shall have to wade to get close enough to tell."

"We shall have to wade to go any further on at all," commented Uld.

"Let me try the depth," offered Parthenal. Dismounting, he stepped into the languid orange-swirling stream. The water was only an inch deep; just enough to test his boots. He put his hand down and checked the submerged ground beneath. Evidently satisfied, he nodded and remounted Alba. The horse seemed steady as he rode on. "It's solid underfoot," he said. "Stone beneath a bit of gravel. I shall go ahead, if you permit."

Huldarion nodded. So all the horses moved on into the water with a gentle plashing of their hooves. Parthenal paused to check the depth of each new channel that they entered.

With his eyes on the swirling orange streams – which were remarkably beautiful in their own way – Huldarion did not look up for a while. It was the murmurs of the others that alerted him.

He raised his eyes. More humped islands, like green whales. On the next, a group of three stones stood: not quite so tall as the first stone, but with the same thin angled blades directed at the sky. Beyond those were another five, set in a rough circle; and further on, beyond those five, stood seven more – then many more – some isolated, others in small groups or larger circles, with the red streams winding like a leisurely fire between them.

"They seem to mark the higher ground," said Thoronal. "To show the way for travellers, perhaps."

"If that were their only function, they would hardly need to be so tall; and why the groupings?" said Huldarion.

On they rode across a world of water – but a gentle, tranquil world. No sudden depths dismayed the horses. When they neared the group of three stones, Huldarion rode up to inspect them. Their edges were slightly notched, presumably with age, and their surfaces dappled with lichen, in russet and gold patches that seemed to reflect the waters rather than the other way around.

He caught his breath at the vista that now lay before him: the slow and sinuous intertwining of the glowing ropes of water; the stones that reached up skywards from the smooth grassed mounds, some like stone reeds, so tall and slender were they, others broader but still flat; the sky behind them that displayed a dozen shades of feathered grey until it merged with the horizon in a violet haze.

"So these are the Red Roads," he murmured. "Our path must lie along the water as much as the dry ground."

"More. Not much dry ground here," said Uld. "And most of it crowned with stones."

"Indeed. A remarkable place – and yet I knew nothing of it."

"Not surprising, when we're in the middle of nowhere," grunted Thoronal.

"A beautiful nowhere," said Huldarion in reproof. "And once it was an important site, that much is clear. It would have been a great work of labour to erect these stones."

"I wonder who did, and when?" said Uld.

"I expect Leor would know. Where is he?"

"I'll go and fetch him," announced Thoronal.

"No, there's no need."

But to Huldarion's slight exasperation Thoronal had not waited for his answer. He had already turned his horse and was calling officiously for Leor. The wizard appeared, shambling up on his unkempt horse. However, he proved to be little wiser than Huldarion himself.

"Those rocks? They've always been here. No, I don't know who put them up. How would I? Long before my time. Ask Tamu. He's bound to know." The wizard sounded disgruntled. He stared at the landscape gloomily.

"Tamu!" bellowed Thoronal, again without waiting for Huldarion's request. When the archivist rode up, he addressed the small man accusingly. "What do you know about these stones?"

"If you please," added Huldarion.

Tamu gazed at the stones with interest and awe. "They were mentioned in travellers' tales of two or three hundred years ago," he said, "although of course they are much older. One chronicler said they'd been pulled up from the earth by giants, as you'd pull up a root, and set on end to make a ladder to the sky."

Thoronal laughed. "Giants!"

Tamu gave him a look of mild reproach. "Old legends often have a seed of truth. Maybe not literal giants, but some powerful race of people must have ordered these to be erected. It would not have been a swift or simple matter."

"They may have played some part in worship, I suppose," Huldarion mused. "Or have acted as a calendar."

"Yet these stones don't appear to be aligned to the sun, as are the old winterstones in many areas," said Tamu. "I wonder what variety of rock this is? Several chronicles mention a fine-grained form of granite called Terzen, which was widely used for monumental works." Huldarion noted how much more at his ease Tamu appeared when talking of old records. His breadth of knowledge was remarkable; he found himself wishing that Caervonn's own archives could have such an assiduous co-ordinator.

"Well, you shall have some time to study them more closely," he told Tamu. "We'll halt here while those Kelvhans catch us up." There was ample space to camp here; for a little further on the largest mound held a lengthy double avenue of stones, with room between them on that swell of grass for all the Vonn, including carts and horses. Huldarion imagined his army parading up the avenue in a kingly progress.

A powerful people made these, he thought. And where are they now? All gone, as we shall one day be. But I feel drawn to this place.

He turned to address the Riders. "We shall camp here tonight. But respect the stones. They have not stood for a thousand years to be defaced by us. Touch them with no more than your hands."

"More than a thousand," murmured Tamu, who promptly steered his horse towards a nearby island. Others were doing the same, fording the slow shallow streams and then abandoning horse or cart to walk along the grassy turf and lay their hands upon the monoliths. The urge to touch them seemed irresistible for many.

Huldarion felt that urge himself. But he declined to act on it, instead standing where he was while he waited for the Kelvhans to arrive. Five carriages were approaching, their gilt-work blazing forth even as it was splashed by the wheels. Plenty of work there this evening for the servants, he thought: for many Kelvhan serving-men drove the carriages or trudged on foot. Besides them, there were two dozen horsemen; and he recognised the leader.

"Rhadlun," said Tiburé in an undertone. "Could have been worse. Could have been Nerogun himself."

Huldarion nodded. Although Rhadlun had some faults of pride he was a competent commander.

But Meya gave a start. "Oh no," she murmured in quiet consternation. "That man behind him! That's the captain who held up our carriage when Aliya was hiding underneath the seat. I forget his name. I'm sure he's loyal, but even so...."

"Aliya is safe," Huldarion reminded her. "My dear, these men have come to fetch Gaelera. Let's hope that Rhadlun can persuade her to go back with them."

"I wouldn't count on it," said Tiburé. "She seems determined to experience a Rider's life, the stars know why. Possibly she is enamoured of Maeneb—"

"Huh!" said Solon.

Tiburé continued as if she hadn't heard: "—although personally I can't imagine Gaelera being enamoured of anyone. So maybe she's here to spy on us for her father; in which case he won't press her to leave."

"I would much prefer it she did," said Huldarion, as Gaelera came gliding over to them in her heavy skirts. Was that a different outfit to yesterday's? The dense fabric was immaculately clean. A strange place to exercise her vanity – if vanity it was. All motives are obscure where this woman is concerned, he thought, as he bowed to her in greeting.

There was no responding curtsy. Gaelera merely dipped her head a fraction. She did not so much as glance towards her fellow-Kelvans. "An interesting place," she said. "I presume it serves a purpose."

"My lady. We were just discussing that," Huldarion replied. "I imagine that the stones were the expression of some religious concept."

"I did not mean that sort of purpose," said Gaelera. Although not loud or strident, her tone of voice seemed to permit no argument. "These stones have been erected for the exercise of power."

"You mean as a demonstration of power," said Solon.

But Gaelera shook her head once, with a slow and graceful movement. "That is not what I mean. Although it also applies. It is evident that these avenues and circles form a conduit, a channel for some power, no less than these channels of red water that flow around our feet. I expect your wizard could explain."

She looked at Leor, who cleared his throat uncomfortably.

"I wish I knew," he muttered, "but I don't."

"A pity." At last Gaelera turned her composed gaze to the rapidly approaching horsemen. "I see my wardens have arrived," she said, without any change in tone.

With much jangling of their gear, the Kelvan troop splashed up to them. It seemed to Huldarion that Commander Rhadlun looked less at ease than usual.

"My Lord of the Vonn," he said, saluting. "My Lady Gaelera. I am most glad to find you here."

His gladness sounded muted. With a surprising lack of fluency he requested – with repeated protestations of respect – that the Lady Gaelera should accompany him back to the main Kelvan army.

He must have expected difficulties; delay; outright refusal; but Gaelera did not honour his halting speeches with a reply of any sort. Her absolute immobility while Rhadlun spoke did not assist him. Huldarion would have been amused had he not also wished for Gaelera's departure.

As it was, he reflected on the power of silence in the right place. For some moments after Rhadlun had finished speaking she gazed at him unmovingly, until he felt obliged to start again.

This time she cut across his opening sentence. "Commander Rhadlun," she said with slow deliberation, "you may inform my father that I have accepted the hospitality of the Vonn, and that I will remain with them until I wish to leave. I am surprised that he has sent you out on such a mission when he knew quite well what the result would be. Your talents would be more usefully employed elsewhere."

Rhadlun looked at Huldarion, who felt forced to speak.

"Of course the Lady Gaelera is welcome to accompany us," he said, annoyed, "if she does not mind the many unavoidable discomforts of our journey south."

"I mind them not at all," Gaelera said.

Rhadlun frowned. Huldarion pitied him, caught as he was between a forceful master and an intransigent daughter. He expected Rhadlun to be primed with more arguments, or possibly bribes, to persuade Gaelera to return to her own people. He did not expect the Kelvhan's next words.

"In that case, my Lord Huldarion," said Rhadlun with sullen formality, "I beg the indulgence of accompanying your Riders with my own carriages and men, whilst you travel the Red Roads to your destination."

Huldarion caught his breath. Why such swift and unquestioning submission to Gaelera's will? Why send a provisioned squadron to look after one woman? A woman, moreover, who appeared very well able to look after herself.

This has been planned between her and Nerogun, he thought at once; but a few seconds' reflection reminded him that Nerogun could have sent a detachment to accompany the Vonn in any case, without all this fuss. In fact a week ago Huldarion had expected it. Had it been forced on him then, he would not have felt so put out as he did now.

But he had to show willing assent. Even as he expressed his pleasure, he was silently cursing the fact that he would now be under so many Kelvhan eyes.

And such eyes! Rhadlun he did not mind so much, for he appreciated the commander's abilities if not his lofty manner. And the captain whom Meya had pointed out he recognised from the castle combats: a disciplined, efficient warrior. Huldarion had admired his calm demeanour in victory no less than his skill.

But he did not care for other faces that he saw smirking further back. That man Jaul, for one: that equerry with the sliding eyes. He was the minor lord who had tried to entrap Parthenal in Kelvha Castle. Jaul was no soldier, so what was he doing here?

Huldarion glanced over at Parthenal, who was studiously ignoring Jaul. He felt a deep misgiving.

But Jaul was not the worst. Behind him was the castle armourer, Iajo: a coarse and brutal-looking man who inspired neither confidence nor trust.

Jaul and Iajo were Nerogun's men. Perhaps their role in staying here was simply to protect Gaelera. Perhaps.

Or, all too likely, it was something with more sinister intent.

Chapter 20

"Keep still, can't you, Parthenal?" begged Tiburé. "Stop pacing up and down. You're making me jittery; and I had enough of feeling jittery in Kelvha. I don't need it in this peaceful place." Even as she spoke, she knew that she was not being fair.

It isn't Parthenal who's setting all my nerves on edge, she thought. It's not those Kelvhans either, unwanted though they are. It's Solon. What should I call him? My husband? My worst enemy? Better half? Unwilling ally?

"You think it's peaceful here?" said Parthenal, sounding grumpy. "I think it's soporific. Static. A piece of nothing, stuck in time. And we're stuck with it." He slapped his hand against the nearest stone – one of eleven that made up the large circle that they stood in.

"Why beat the stone?" Tiburé asked, half amused, half puzzled. "It's not the stone's fault."

"It is, if it makes Huldarion want to stop an hour before we need to. And it's the stone's fault if it makes Gaelera stay here with us; which means we're lumbered with those star-forsaken Kelvhans."

Rothir laid a hand upon his shoulder. "Don't worry about Jaul," he said in his quiet rumble. "He won't try anything out here. And if he does he won't succeed."

Parthenal gave a short, brief laugh.

"He's lost status," Tamu murmured. "Probably because of that, I mean, the thing, in the castle. You know."

Tiburé did not know, although Rothir was nodding. Evidently something had gone on in Kelvha Castle which they were conscious of and she was not. Something that embarrassed Tamu; so she could make a guess. She gazed over at the man they were talking about – an elegant young Kelvhan noble, all long hair and legs. The hair was carefully curled, the legs fashionably clad. Not really Parthenal's type, she would have thought, a little too languid; but then what did she know?

Jaul was standing apart from the select group of Kelvhans who were talking to Huldarion. So perhaps he was not sufficiently high-ranking to join in. Her eyes were drawn to Solon, standing next to Huldarion: his dignity and stature. Her eyes were always drawn to Solon. A fine-looking man. Had that misled her from the start? Looks were not a dependable measure of suitability as a mate. They should not influence her; yet they did.

She and Solon had thought they were each other's type, at first. They'd seemed well-matched: both handsome, strong and clever. Too strong, perhaps. Although Tiburé thought she was still handsome, it was after the fashion of a wilful ageing woman, which was not what Solon wanted. He could probably have put up with the ageing, but not the wilfulness.

And Tiburé knew that she had been at fault. Her current liaison with Theol was only one of many through the years. She had had reasons for her faithlessness, but it had been too much, too soon. She had hurt that dignity that was so great a part of Solon, even if she hadn't hurt his heart; for had he ever truly loved her? Whether or no, he would not forgive her.

Parthenal frowned at Jaul for a few seconds before he turned to frown at Tamu. "Jaul's lost status? How can you tell?"

Tamu shrugged. "Changes in his clothing. He's wearing fewer rings. No hair adornments. The question of which ranks can wear what is very tightly regulated."

"But he doesn't need adornments here. He's riding with an army," said Rothir.

"Not by his choice. Jaul has never been a soldier," Tamu said.

Parthenal groaned. "Then he can only be here for another purpose."

"Punishment," said Tamu thoughtfully. "For his former failure."

"Now don't go feeling sorry for him," advised Rothir, with a smile.

"Oh, I won't," Parthenal assured him. "Don't worry, dwarf. I have no sympathy to spare for Jaul. I shall avoid him altogether." That made Tiburé certain that Parthenal had failed to avoid Jaul in the past; no great surprise there. What puzzled her more was that Tamu seemed to know about it.

In fact the number of things that the archivist knew was proving, she reflected, quite eye-opening. She had heard him talking to Leor in the train, with an enthusiasm which the wizard did not match. Leor was moody for some reason and she thought that Tamu was trying to cheer him up. Not always successfully; for Tamu's breadth of knowledge, particularly about history or languages, made Leor look even more despondent. Yet Leor had had vast opportunities for learning. Perhaps they were also opportunities for forgetting.

Yaret came up to the group, limping slightly.

"Nice stones," she said. "Did anybody know that they were here?"

"They're mentioned in our Chronicles, though those aren't too reliable," Tamu said apologetically. "The chroniclers wrote down any travellers' tales they heard, without attempting to investigate their truth. All sorts of unlikely legends found their way in – like that of giants building this ladder to the sky." He put his hand gently on the nearest stone, caressing it where Parthenal had slapped it.

"I like that idea," said Yaret.

"Symbolic giants, though," said Rothir. "Intellectual giants, perhaps."

"Or these stones could be needles, sewing the sky and ground together," she suggested.

"Now there's a weaver's metaphor."

"Of course. A fine soft silk the sky is," said Yaret.

"The ground is evidently burlap, then," said Rothir, smiling. Tiburé looked at him suspiciously.

"You seem very happy, Rothir," she said.

"He's annoyingly cheerful at the moment," said Parthenal. "I can't adjust to it. I'm used to gruff monosyllables."

"Am I using too many long words for you?" said Rothir.

"Too many words altogether, dwarf. It's most unsettling."

"Ah, it's because we're finally on our way towards Caervonn," replied Rothir. "I feel it beckoning."

"A very slow, roundabout, digressive way," said Parthenal grumpily.

Rothir actually laughed. "Why not enjoy the slowness while you can?"

"But those old tales," said Yaret. "They must have called this stone a ladder for a reason. A ladder climbing up to what?" She hobbled over to the tallest stone, beside Tamu, and laid her hand upon it.

"Your leg's hurting," said Rothir.

"Just stiff." She looked up the length of the stone. "A ladder to the stars," she said. "It feels similar to the stones of the Semmuru's tower, if not as warm."

"How can you know that?" demanded Parthenal. "All stones feel much the same."

Tiburé was puzzled. "The Semmuru's tower? What's that?"

"Just an old building we came across," said Yaret vaguely.

"The same ancient people built both places, maybe," said Rothir. "Is Piril still mourning for the Arac Semmuru?"

"She's mourning for her brother," answered Yaret quietly, "and also for the life she's lost."

"Not much of a life," said Parthenal.

"Maybe not. But better than most women of her class ever managed to achieve. Handmaiden to one of the highest ladies in the kingdom. And I think she loved Janeya," said Yaret, withdrawing from the stone.

"Poor girl," said Rothir. He still had no idea. But Tiburé felt worried by the mere mention of Janeya, who was in fact so nearby, hiding in the carriage. How long would it be before one of the men saw her close up, and put two and two together?

The girl should have left our train, she thought. We should have made her leave; both her and Piril. But it's too late now.

"Where is Piril?" she asked.

"On the next island."

Tiburé looked across at the long mound which held the avenue of stones. Carts were being drawn up round its edges, and the horses, released from the shafts, began to graze. Piril was trudging up the avenue, the stones' great height making her look smaller and more fragile than she really was.

A lonely girl, thought Tiburé, watching the Kelvhan maid walk slowly from one stone to the next. She stopped at its base before leaning forward to rest her forehead on the stone's grey surface. There she remained. For some reason Tiburé was reminded of her sister Camburé, to whom she was not close: although much older, she was another plain-faced, unobtrusive woman, self-contained and difficult to read. Though I never really tried, thought Tiburé: after this is over, I should seek her out.

"She's looking for that ladder," said Yaret softly. "Looking for some solace."

Tiburé almost asked, And where do *you* find solace? But she refrained, because it would not be tactful. Tact was something she found difficult. She ought to cultivate it.

Especially just now. For here came Solon striding through the stream towards them, ignoring the splashes on his boots and breeches.

My husband is a man without vanity, she thought with the remnants of sad pride; at least where his appearance is concerned. Or maybe he is simply so confident in his own body that physical vanity is superfluous.

"What's the joke?" she said to him, for he was smiling.

"Huldarion wishes us all to pitch camp on that area with the double row of stones."

"Very well. But what's funny about that? You look amused."

"Ah. We were just talking about that girl, Gaelera."

"Hardly a girl," Tiburé remarked. "She's an independent woman and has been for some years."

"Yet still unmarried, which is certainly unusual for a Kelvhan woman of her rank," said Solon more coolly. "An odd female. Iajo is of the opinion that marriage would soon cure her of her foibles."

"That thug? Have you been obliged to talk to him? What a very unpleasant man he is."

"A powerful one, however."

"He shouldn't be. And I still don't see the joke."

Solon raised his eyebrows. The smile had entirely gone since he had started speaking to her. He really dislikes me, thought Tiburé with sad regret. She moved away so that the others would not hear his chilliness.

"I was merely thinking about how people act with Gaelera," he said, coldly offhand. "Tiptoeing around her."

"She is Nerogun's daughter."

"Yes; but only his daughter, not his son. She has no power and never can have. Yet even Thoronal talks to her as if she's made of glass and will shatter at a word too loudly spoken. But then Thoronal seems over-cautious of everything in general."

"I don't know what's wrong with him these days."

"He's lost his self-belief, and he always had more of that than brains." Solon studied her with narrowed eyes. "Did you know that Huldarion is considering making you a counsellor in

Thoronal's stead? Now that Huldarion is free of the restraints of Kelvha regarding women, I think he'd rather have you at his side than Thoronal."

"Oh... Really? He hinted something of the sort." In fact it had been more than a hint; but Tiburé was trying to exercise that tact she had just vowed to cultivate.

"However, I told him that he could not have us both," Solon continued distantly. "That wouldn't work."

Tiburé wanted to retort that it could work if he allowed it to. She said, "I expect I could deal with Gaelera more effectively than Thoronal does."

"Gaelera? She doesn't matter. I think they over-value her importance."

"I don't think they do at all," said Tiburé, and then immediately condemned her failure to practise tact, for Solon's lip took on a pronounced curl. He did not like to be disagreed with. That was one of her faults – her many faults; she would insist on having loud opinions that did not tally with his own.

"What I mean is," she amended, "I don't think anyone knows enough about her to be sure what she is capable of. She keeps herself and her thoughts so well concealed."

"If only other people did," said Solon, and he strode over to Crade to pass on the message about pitching camp.

Tiburé felt like lashing her own back as she set off to find her horse and gear. Why could she not be quiet and biddable with Solon? Why could she not just nod and smile, and echo his own words back to him to keep him happy? Or happyish. She had told him that she wanted a divorce; and she still did, but she wished that he would grant it with regret, not refuse it with ill-hidden anger. What a fool she was where Solon was concerned.

Picking up her cloak she splashed heedlessly across the shallow water to where other Riders were assembling – too heedlessly, for she tripped, and fell at full length in the water.

It was deep enough to soak her but annoyingly not deep enough to break her fall. She landed heavily on the hard rock just beneath the surface. When she stood up, spluttering and rubbing her bruised hands on wet clothes, Uld came hastening over to offer his assistance. Closer by, that unpleasant armourer, Iajo, was doing nothing to help but instead stood sneering.

"Not used to those riding breeches yet, my lady?" he said. Now, too late, he offered her his outstretched whip; but Tiburé would not take it. In fact she had a sudden but distinct idea that it was the whip that she had tripped over. When she turned away she saw her husband Solon standing on the far bank, smiling.

So she turned again to accept Uld's kindly hand, and hauled herself out of the shallows. Her sodden clothes were heavy and uncomfortable. And she felt herself frozen by her husband's mocking gaze.

I will catch a chill, she thought, my limbs will ache; I am an old bedraggled fool.

Yet am I really old at all, except in Solon's eyes?

If I am old, yet still I am a fool, she thought: a fool for wanting him to want me, when in truth I don't want him.

Chapter 21

I want, I want, I want, said Parthenal underneath his breath as he rode through the dawn's dark glow. The sky shone like a bluish-purple jewel lit by the unrisen sun: the black streams glimmered: the dusky stones were tinged with silver, glittering as if they held a myriad miniature stars. It was a lovely landscape, and it did not cheer him.

I know what I want, Parthenal thought wretchedly, and I know I cannot have it. He had to marry, I have always been aware of that; but why does he have to spend every night with her inside that carriage?

I want, I want, I want. If I can't have him, it almost doesn't matter who. I wish Jaul were not here to remind me. Although I wanted him before, I won't make that mistake a second time. I dare not gaze at any of those Kelvhan soldiers, although it would be easy enough to want some of them.

And I have always avoided wanting my own kin amongst the Vonn. Too complicated; especially if we have to ride in the same train together afterwards. The truth is I have never wanted anyone for long. Apart from one: that one, that one, the one I cannot have. The others I let go. Forget them. I need them not to matter to me.

He sighed and nudged Alda to make the horse move further up the line. The long procession of Riders and their carriages had set off as soon as it was light enough to see. As they rode down the avenue, the glinting stones on either side appeared like tall, still, watching figures draped in cloaks with pointed hoods: then they seemed to glide away, receding as the train moved past them. With the approaching dawn the streams were slowly turning red and the sky too held a pink veil of cloud up to its violet face.

The army was already making good progress south, but Parthenal was restless. He envied the high flocks of birds that so easily outstripped the Vonnish army – skeins of geese, and others, nameless, swifter, slender-winged. No matter how fast the army marched, he wanted to go faster, like those birds, to be somewhere else.

Somewhere that Huldarion and Meya weren't. Yet he had sworn to devote his life and service to Huldarion, and he would not withdraw that fealty now just because of his own weakness. Especially not because of his own weakness. He had to pretend that he had strength. So he gripped the reins more tightly until Alda gave a snort of protest and he slackened them again.

As he passed a group of fellow-Riders, Rigal called out. "In a hurry to leave, Parthenal?"

"I've had enough of this forsaken place," he answered.

"I'd like to stay," said Landel wistfully. "To me it doesn't feel forsaken, only peaceful. It's a nice change."

"He wants to loll around on those grassy banks with a fishing rod," said Rigal.

"And a cheese pie, and a mug of ale," said Landel. "My perfect day. There are lots of minnows in these streams. Nothing bigger; it's too shallow. And probably there's too much clay, or whatever it is that makes those colours in the water."

"You've really been looking for fish?" said Parthenal. He had not bothered to gaze into the streams.

"He likes fishing," explained Rigal. "And a minnow counts as a big catch for him."

"It would count as a big catch for me too, just now," said Parthenal, and he rode on, leaving them behind.

He wondered what exactly he had meant. Was it true that anyone would do? Any minnow? If he would not lie with any of the Vonn, that did not leave much option. Although the Kelvhans were in sight, riding apart from the Vonn, he would not consider them. And there were only a

few within the train who were neither Vonn nor Kelvhan. Parthenal went through them in his mind; a purely academic exercise.

The loben hunters. No. He could tell that none of them inclined that way. Nor did the few men of Melmet who still trailed doggedly behind the army of the Vonn: men who liked adventure, but not that species of adventure.

The priest Hokiro? He had some attractions – but no, no, not a priest. Tamu? Parthenal had been convinced he'd seen a flickering of longing there, but maybe he'd been mistaken after all, for Tamu had shown no sign of any interest since.

In any case, I'd terrify him, Parthenal thought wryly. The very idea would send him into stuttering shock. If he's nervous just talking to me, imagine what he would be like... No, no. I can't. I couldn't. I want, but I don't want Tamu, although I like him well enough. Poor little minnow.

With these thoughts he rode on up the next long grassy mound and down its avenue of stones. Gazing ahead he saw that there were many similar avenues – too many – each on its isle amidst the sluggish streams, all leading south for some reason that was lost in time.

As the light increased, the ranks of stones discarded any sense of watchful sentience, becoming mere lumps of inert rock. But the mood around him also seemed to lighten. Amidst the tread of hooves and intermittent splash and gurgle of the water, Parthenal heard soft laughter.

Somewhere behind him a man began to sing: a slow, ruminative Vonnish ballad. It suited the tranquillity of this place if not Parthenal's own mood. Other voices joined in, lifting in harmony, until the song came from several areas at once, yet still in perfect unison. Someone began to strum a lutine: one of Thield's handful of part-time bards, no doubt, as no-one else would bother lugging such an instrument to war. But the result was anything but warlike. It sounded like a soft hymn to the coming dawn.

How strange to hear this comfortable, tuneful army; he admired its skill. Yet even while he felt the music tugging at some region of his soul, Parthenal wondered at the urge to sing. Although he normally enjoyed singing he felt no inclination to join in. Instead he rode on faster, to get away.

The voices followed him as he swiftly passed a rumbling, jolting carriage; Meya's. But there was no sign of her, nor of that constantly sick maid, Jebil. Travel sickness, homesickness, revolt against the rations – whatever it was that afflicted her, it kept her hidden out of sight. He wished that he could use the same excuse.

He drew alongside Piril and Yaret, who were gazing over at the stones. He remembered seeing Piril last night leaning against one of those tall rocky knives as if she would like to become part of it. He wouldn't mind being turned to stone himself, he thought morosely.

"I like the singing," said Yaret. "Is that a traditional ballad?"

He nodded. The voices shifted in fine layers, dividing and re-joining. He thought of the music of Caervonn: of songs uprising from the leaf-clad terraces at dusk, along with flutes, to vie with the piercing calls of darting swifts above. Amongst the carefree harmonising voices, he heard that voice, that one beloved voice, the young Huldarion's, always more clear to him than any other. Would Caervonn still be so precious to him, with Meya as its queen?

Oh, I want, I want, and I can never have.

Desperate for distraction, he turned to Piril.

"What secrets did you hope to learn from those dead stones?" he asked her, without any real wish to hear the answer.

"I don't know," she said soberly. "But when I look at them I keep thinking that I see my brother standing underneath them."

"Your brother?" Then Parthenal remembered that young would-be assassin, so deftly slain in Kelvha's music hall. He had felt sympathy for the youth. A salutary lesson about Kelvha.

"I see him staring at me. As if to remind me: as if I could forget."

"That's odd. I thought I saw my grandfather standing underneath a stone a little further back," commented Yaret. "Looking at me. It was only for a second. My imagination. But it was strange."

"A trick of the light," said Parthenal. But even as he spoke he glimpsed a face drawn clearly on the lichen of the nearest stone, a random pattern abruptly given meaning by her words. A sudden and unwanted memory tugged at him.

A Rider, a serious man a little older than himself, eight or nine years ago. A desire as brief as all of his desires. It would have been forgotten totally had the man not drowned soon afterwards; some said that it was suicide. They did not know of Parthenal's short liaison with him. Suicide had seemed to him unlikely – rivers being dangerous things – yet that was the last time that Parthenal had looked amongst the Riders for a partner.

He thought of that man now, with a wince of his heart. The face had been quite vivid, briefly. But it was only lichen.

"What does your brother say to you?" he asked Piril.

"Nothing," she said flatly. "Nor do the stones. They cannot speak. I ask of them, but what I want is something that they cannot give."

"Why, what do you want?"

"A place."

"What sort of place? Where will you go?" He had not expected Piril to stay with the Vonn this far, assuming she and Jebil would disappear into the villages and country manors of Outer Kelvha. There were places there for maids presumably.

"I want a place where I can fit," she said.

Parthenal looked at her thin face and skinny body. Could I? he wondered. Could I bend the leanings of a lifetime and go with a woman? She's boyish enough.

He glanced round at Yaret, who was listening intently to the song that still drifted through the air as if she were memorising harmonies. He remembered seeing her for the first time: that slight young man with the broken nose and easy manners had sparked his interest, until he learnt her real identity.

Could I pretend that Piril is a boy? he mused. But she may have heard about the way I lean. And in truth I haven't been attracted to boys since I was a boy myself, in the gardens of Caervonn. And then it was chiefly one boy. That one. Always that one. Every lover I have ever had, I wished it were that one.

He wanted to ride over to the nearest stone and beat his head against it. Why was he even thinking about any of this? It was all impossible.

"Where do they lead, these stony avenues and streams?" asked Piril, and he was thankful for the question.

"The Red Roads? They lead down to the sea. Water always flows towards the sea," he explained, with both compassion and faint derision for her ignorance.

"They pull me to follow them."

"People cannot see a path without the urge to follow it," he said. "They always long to know where it will end."

"True," said Yaret. "And here we are, being pulled by the stones, by our desire to find the end."

"This route was Huldarion's plan, before we knew the stones were here," he pointed out. But he thought, was it a wise plan? Such a long way we are from Caervonn still. It is so far behind us and before us. And yet I cling to that city, to that youth, that now is gone.

"What's wrong?" Yaret asked him. So he must have sighed.

"Just keen to get the job done, that's all."

"I like this place," she said. "A land between lands. I'm not surprised the Riders sing. It's very calming."

"To me it feels abandoned."

"By people, maybe. But it's not blighted. See all those weeds that swirl within the streams? The cresses and the mosses by the banks? All full of insects."

"I hadn't noticed," answered Parthenal, weary with himself, weary of the familiar shackles of desire. Gazing down he saw a host of star-like flowers, pale greenish white and blue, peeking from short rush-like stems. He discovered that the air smelt sweet and fresh although the flowers were surely far too small to cause such fragrance.

"And those little bobbing birds are everywhere," said Piril.

One darted past at ankle-level, quick and drab. Twenty yards away a small flock rose and whirled, then settled, piping. He did not know their names.

"Their songs are taking over from the Vonn," said Yaret; and indeed, there was a high-pitched chorus rising all around him, twicking and weeking and swiking. "And overhead. High flights of birds."

"I know," said Parthenal. Long lines and arrowheads of birds were dark against the sky; which was filling up with colour now, azure, lilac, rose. They were travelling south, just like the Vonn. These Red Roads pull us all, he thought, along the shining waters to the sea.

"Lin!" exclaimed Yaret. "Just over there! I saw a lin. It's gone now."

Piril looked puzzled. "What's a lin?"

"Creature of folklore," Parthenal said. "A spirit of the land, that nobody can see properly."

"Durba says she's seen a few out here," said Yaret. "In Kelvha I believe they are called bunnoes."

"Oh! I know about bunnoes. Though back home we called ours a bodno," Piril said. "It lived in the woodpile and we used to leave out bread for it. But it was just a story. I thought I saw it twice or thrice but only from the corner of my eye."

Yaret nodded. "That's a lin. A relative of darkburns."

"Only according to your unproven theory," said Parthenal. The freedom of the birds above him made him jealous and impatient. He felt abruptly uninterested in lins or any other intangible creature. He wanted something he could see and touch: some solid welcoming flesh. He was angry with himself for harbouring such thoughts and hated the tearing strength of this intolerable yearning.

I want, I want, he thought. And I cannot have.

He grunted a farewell and rode on up the next long avenue of stones to join a pair of Riders near the top: Rothir and Ikelder.

Rothir looked at him keenly. "What's the matter?"

"I want to get somewhere," muttered Parthenal.

"Take it easy. We are getting somewhere."

"Stars knows where, though. And only slowly. I don't know how you can stand it. We're barely crawling."

"Well, give us a chance! We've only been riding for an hour," Ikelder said. "And look: the sun is coming up."

In fact the sun must have risen some time previously, but had been obscured by the band of rosy cloud along the eastern sky. Now, at last, it dazzled as it climbed above the haze to shine out on the land.

Ahead of them, Huldarion's horse reached the summit of the rise, and halted. The whole train stopped, although they could not see the reason.

The risen sun now turned the clouds to soft, pale gold; the colour of the jasmine that curled up the ancient walls above the terraces of Caervonn. He remembered standing on the south-east wall one sunset, waiting for a lover, as yet unknown; breathing in the jasmine's pale sweet odour. The scent of yearning. He seemed to smell it now.

Something was happening to the stones. Second by second they were being transformed by light. They began to glow – not golden, like the sky, but red as embers. The long slow curling waters started to glow likewise, with a radiance that increased as the Riders watched.

"Rivers of fire," said Rothir softly.

"I have seen too many fires this last year," said Ikelder equally quietly, "but never one so harmless and so beautiful."

"Pretty," conceded Parthenal, although the luminous sky did not bring him any joy. It felt not like a new beginning but rather like an end: an end of hope.

And yet I never hoped to win Huldarion, he thought. Not realistically. Maybe I hoped beyond hope, but now, with Meya come, I know that hope is gone. Sunk as the sun rises.

"What's that?" He ducked, by instinct. But the swift rush of wind across his hair came from no flight of arrows. Birds? Yet where were they? When he looked up he saw only distant skeins, too high to cause that breeze.

"A pulse of many wings," said Rothir, staring up. "They seemed to brush my head."

"Invisible geese," Ikelder said. "Flying south, very fast."

"And very silently, for geese," said Rothir. He laughed, and rode a few yards further up the rise. There he paused. "You want us to get somewhere soon, Parthenal? Well, I think we are about to."

Parthenal rode up beside him and looked out. The Red Roads flowed on to a fresh horizon: a wholly unexpected one.

A skyline built of stone... But not of single monoliths, like the ones they had been passing. Parthenal discerned great slabs clasped together. Some were leaning, partly toppled; others upright and intact, like massive shelters.

A city built by giants, he thought in wonder. The Roads swirled on, as if another world were set aflame beneath their surface; and the sun ignited the construction to a blaze upon the burning waters.

Then the marvelling Riders took up their reins again, and rode towards that city made of stone and fire.

Chapter 22

Meya sat very upright at the front of her carriage, watching the vast stone structures creeping closer. She felt as if she travelled on the back of some enormous eagle; for as they rode, the Riders had assumed a defensive formation, spreading their ranks apart with impressive smoothness into two wide wings, one on either side of her.

To her left, she could see Yaret and Maeneb at the end of a curved line of archers, riding with bows in their hands. Another line of archers swept round to her right, like neat feather after feather set along the wing. Between them, Huldarion and his retinue formed the eagle's head.

This symmetry, both beautiful and fearsome, had almost a ceremonial aspect. Yet the precaution seemed to be unnecessary. Not only was no enemy apparent, no sign of human life was visible at all.

"Ah, there's smoke," Janeya murmured softly, just behind her shoulder.

Meya reproved herself twice over: firstly, for not noticing the smoke, thin as it was; and secondly, for labelling the girl Janeya. She must learn to think of her as Jebil, a humble maid-servant, and currently a reclusive one, supposedly unwell.

In fact she seemed to be emerging from her grief-stricken torpor. And she was right about the smoke: for Meya saw a thin blue pall above the gathered stones. Elsewhere, two or three weak trails rose wispily from deep within those huge half-fallen monuments.

Although the stones still seemed to glow with fire, that blaze was waning slowly with the lifting of the sun. The surrounding landscape grew more ordinary, yet the structure became more extraordinary to Meya's mind as she approached. Incredible; the vast gathering of stones looked as big as the main body of Kelvha Castle. Not so well made, naturally. Completely primitive. But she felt an indignant tremor on the castle's behalf.

On they rode and still saw nobody. Two hundred yards short of the stones, Huldarion called a halt. Meya admired the way it took only a single motion of his hand raised in the air for the whole army to instantly respond. She hoped the Kelvhans riding behind her took due note of the Vonn's impressive discipline.

He is a man well worth marrying, thought Meya, before she pondered the tenor of her own thoughts. Was that how she measured a man's worth? Even Nerogun could do the same thing with a lifted hand, and she despised Nerogun and feared him.

But none of these Riders despised or feared Huldarion. That was the difference. The Vonn feared only to displease their chief, because of their respect for him. Now that she was away from the formalities imposed within the castle, such innate respect seemed all the more praiseworthy.

I am not sorry to be free of those constrictions, she realised, with a certain sense of guilt. But I do this for Kelvha as well as for myself. For the glory of the Kelvhan kingdom.

Yet what do I do, exactly? Apart from sit in my cushioned carriage with my bogus chamber-maid; and provide some nightly comfort to Huldarion, and no doubt cause for gossip and possibly resentment to the rest? Am I anything more than an encumbrance?

For a few seconds she contemplated leaving her carriage and riding on horseback with the others, to show that she could mingle with them on more equal terms. A few seconds' contemplation of it was enough. She did not sit easily on unfamiliar steeds, and in any case did not enjoy long spells of riding, especially in skirts; and she would not resort to breeches. No, better to stay aloof.

All the same she wished that she could be of use. She watched while Huldarion selected a handful of senior men to accompany him – Uld, Solon, and Crade in preference to Thoronal,

which was interesting – and then swiftly commanded a small troop of Riders under Parthenal to escort them right up to the tallest building. If it could be called a building, and not just an accident of ancient leaning stones.

Despite the smoke she could not envisage permanent inhabitants here. Vagrants, more probably; goatherds and the like. So she thought it superfluous for Huldarion to call out so formally to any listeners within the broken slab-like walls, requesting them to reveal themselves – which he did first in Standard, then in Kelvhan, and finally in that rather lovely melodic tongue which she now knew was Vonnish. She was shocked when in response a small group of people emerged from a gap between the stones.

They appeared to be unarmed. And they appeared to all be women. Huldarion gave a signal at which the lines of archers immediately lowered their drawn bows. Meya had not even realised that the bows were drawn.

I need to pay closer attention, she thought, I need to learn to look; and she frowned as she studied the female delegation.

No, delegation was too grand a word. This was just a bunch of half a dozen women, gesticulating, their speech inaudible to her. Their clothes from this distance looked drab and their hair roughly dressed. And they were displeased; for they were evidently vehement, and their gestures were not friendly.

She saw Huldarion consult his counsellors. Then, turning to the women, he bowed, and retreated with his men back to the main army.

He rode straight up to her carriage, his face thoughtful.

“Are we moving on?” she asked. “Are they vagrants who have occupied the place?”

“I believe not,” said Huldarion. “But they refuse to talk to us, because we are men.”

“I don’t understand.”

“They’ll only talk to other women.”

“Why?”

Huldarion shook his head. “That I don’t know. But I’ve told them I will send a group of women out to speak with them, headed by my queen – that’s you, my dear.”

“Me? But what am I to say to them?” asked Meya, a little dismayed at the prospect of confronting those unkempt and argumentative women.

“To start with, I want to find out who they are, and who their leader is. They won’t answer any of my questions, but they might answer yours. They speak Standard, so that’s something.”

“Well!” This was her chance to be of use, Meya felt at once. She must not show hesitancy. But she was apprehensive. “Who will you send with me?”

“Tiburé, Delgeb and Hilbré: three of my most senior Riders. And also Yaret, the northern archer, because she is not of the Vonn. She may see something we cannot.”

Meya did not understand this, but did not dispute it. As she climbed down from the carriage Huldarion added, unexpectedly, “And perhaps also your maid behind you there; Jebil, is it not? Because to see another person who is clad neither as a soldier nor as a royal lady might be reassuring to them.”

“No, not Jebil,” she said instinctively.

“Why not?” he asked, with a slight frown which made her realise that he must put her unwillingness down to snobbery. He presumed that Meya did not think a servant worthy of the task.

“She is shy,” said Meya, and was put out to hear the girl correct her.

“Not really. I don’t mind,” said Jebil-Janeya from the shadows of the cart.

“Oh, very well, then.” Meya immediately heard the pettishness in her own tone. “Come with me, my girl,” she added graciously. Was that too patronising now?

But it was good that the girl was showing an interest in something beyond her overwhelming grief. Meya felt that grief had been overdone. After all, Janeya had scarcely known the man, who was only a low-born southerner at that.

And so, some minutes later, Meya found herself walking majestically over to the stone structure with Janeya-Jebil and the rest of her female retinue, while a dozen female archers led by Maeneb followed a little way behind. Meya felt very aware of all the eyes on her. Although she had never suffered from self-consciousness, or a lack of confidence, she wondered now if she could truly do what Huldarion required. Even though all he asked was that she talk to these women. Find out who there were. That should be easy enough, surely. And she was used to dealing with the servant class.

But these were not deferential castle servants who were waiting underneath the massive stones to meet her. More likely wanderers, as she had at first assumed.

There were six of them, to match her group of six. Meya noted that their clothes were coarse and grubby if not actually ragged; their surly faces were suspicious; and as she marched closer she became aware that they smelt. Chiefly of smoke, but still. With all this water around, surely they could wash themselves and their clothes more often?

Assuming all her accustomed hauteur, she announced, "I am the Lady Meya of Kelvha Castle, affianced to the King Huldarion with whom you have just spoken. I greet you in the name of the great kingdom of Kelvha and on behalf of the Riders of the Vonn."

They did not look impressed. No bow, no smile, no outstretched hands. Meya did not feel inclined to stretch out hers. She drew herself up with dignity. "And you?" she said.

"Hmph," said the foremost of them. "You are all women?" She walked up close to Meya's group, and looked each of them carefully in the face. Her own face was deeply lined, yet by her upright stance she did not seem to be too old. The smell of smoke grew strong; it was as if these women had been rolling in burnt leaves. "You four dress like men," she said with scorn.

"We are soldiers," answered Delgeb. "As well as women."

"Hmph. And are you mothers?"

"I am," said Meya, surprised by the question.

"I too," said Tiburé.

"And I," said Delgeb.

"I am not," said Yaret.

"Nor I," said Janeya. Jebil.

"I was once," said Hilbré, "but she died." At the sound of those words spoken in the Rider's low, calm voice, a new world opened up for Meya: a new conception of the quiet Hilbré – to whom she had previously spoken all of three polite sentences – and a sharp new vision of the terror of living with a daughter's death. Horrific. Unimaginable. It made her unable to think properly for a moment.

"You had a girl?" the smoky woman said. "And you mothers, are your children girls also, or boys?"

"I have two daughters, and no son," said Tiburé.

"I have one child, a most beloved daughter," Meya added. The words felt thick in her throat. How was Aliya now? Was she still safe? Was she happy?

Meanwhile Delgeb said, "I also have one child, a son." This too was news to Meya. It appeared that it was bad news to the woman, who frowned with disapproval.

"A boy? How old?"

"He is thirteen," said Delgeb.

"You may not enter. Go back to your people." The woman was addressing only Delgeb, who bowed and with a glance at Meya turned and walked away. "The rest of you can come with me."

"May we know your name?" asked Tiburé. Meya was annoyed: she should have been the one to ask that.

"I am Ombue. Come." She turned, and with the other brown-clad, smoky-smelling women, led them through the gap between the towering stones.

The entrance was long, effectively a tunnel gripped by walls of rock; longer and taller than the entrance through the walls of Kelvha castle. Splinters of sky were visible high overhead, and Meya was conscious of the massive weight of granite that surrounded her. For some reason it again made her think of Aliya, so that the image of her daughter pulled at her heart.

But she must pay attention. So she concentrated on the scene that was revealed as they emerged from between the stones; stones, which, it now became clear, might once have been some kind of vast monument but now acted chiefly as a protective wall for the village held within. For beyond the massive entrance-stones was no well-built city, but rather a collection of small, crude, round structures – low, and with tiny windows – the likes of which she had not seen before. She imagined that the ruined roundhouses they had passed might once have had a similar shape; but these rough houses were not built of stone.

"Turf-houses," murmured Yaret. "How interesting. I see they use long reeds for reinforcement. Well, I suppose there is no wood round here for them to build with."

"They appear to have wood enough to burn," said Meya, somewhat grumpily, for the smoke was sticking in her throat. Dark plumes of it wafted from the centre of most of the circular, gently sloping roofs. They too appeared to be made of slabs of turf.

"That's peat smoke," said Yaret.

Meya did not answer; for a surprising number of women were emerging from the primitive turf houses to stare. None were armed, unless a bucket counted as a weapon; most held babies. Many children too ran out, to hide behind their mothers, or gaze boldly at the newcomers with grey-smeared, frowning faces.

"Young boys and girls, and women of all ages," commented Tiburé. "But no men."

"So it would appear," said Meya stiffly. She hoped that Tiburé was not going to try and take over the role of negotiator. But Tiburé stood aside for her as Ombue led them to an open space between the houses. Here was set a single line of long stone benches, enough to seat forty or fifty people, and curved so as to form almost a full circle.

"Ah," said Yaret, in a tone of recognition.

"What?" said Meya. But Yaret merely shook her head.

"Sit," said Ombue. They sat in a curving line on one of the benches. The smoky women sat down opposite. Hard, deep-etched faces stared at them. Ombue remained standing in the centre of the circle, and Meya wished that she had remained standing too. She felt at a disadvantage. But she could not stand up now.

"Be assured that we mean you no harm," she said with all the authority she could muster whilst seated on the uncomfortable stone bench. "All we ask of you is information. If you can give us that, we will leave you and move on. Who are you, and who is your leader?"

"We know who you are," said Ombue darkly, "you Kelvhan despots and enslavers of the northern lands. We know you and we do not want you here. We may answer your questions if we choose and only if we choose. Then you must go."

"We are neither despots nor enslavers," answered Meya, ready to launch into a defence of Kelvha and even a eulogy of its long and civilised existence: but Ombue, dismissing her reply with a wave of her hand, was already continuing in a voice made harsh, not just, it seemed, by smoke, but also by resentment.

"Maybe you women are not despots, but undoubtedly your men are. All those soldiers. And three of you dress as your menfolk do – so do you regard yourselves as men?" Ombue sounded hostile.

"We do not," said Tiburé, "but sometimes we ride and fight as men do."

"Hmph. Our men ride and fight as well, against your men. Or should I call them men, for are they not children? On both sides. They are all children together, unruly, wilful, hateful, cruel."

"Who are your men?" asked Meya, "and where are they? I do not see them here."

"Of course not. We do not allow them here. If there were no men in the world at all it would be a better place. The men are far away across the plains and in the woods and by the sea, doing the only thing they care about: which is fighting. Their armies march across the lands like ants, overrunning and destroying anyone in their path." Despite her expressions of contempt, Meya thought that Ombue spoke with a fierce pride.

"Are they called stonemen?" asked Tiburé abruptly. Ombue drew back and frowned more deeply. Meya, leaning forward, put the question a different way.

"Do your men wear stones around their brows? Set into their heads?" She touched either side of her own brow to demonstrate.

"You know them, then," said Ombue.

"We call them stonemen," Meya said. "Do none live here?"

"We would not let them if they wanted. But they do not want. We left them many years ago, but they still come back two or three times a year, to snatch and rut and curse. They slap our faces and they steal our children, and they leave again. We're glad to see them go."

"They steal your children?" repeated Meya.

"Who are their children also. They take only the boys."

"At what age?" asked Yaret.

"When they are seven."

"Where do they take them to?" asked Meya.

Ombue snorted. "You think they tell us? They give us nothing except curses. You ask who is our leader? The men would be, if we allowed them. We do not."

"And have things always been this way here?" That was Hilbré's quiet voice.

"Farsu remembers when things were different, when we lived and worked together, men and women. Nobody else here remembers that time well." Ombue turned towards one of the other smoky women, who stood up stiffly. Bent and hunched, she looked at least eighty.

"I am sixty-two," she said, alarming Meya, "and those days are still sharp in my mind." Her voice creaked.

"What changed?" asked Meya.

The woman looked over at her from eyes so deep-set in the creased face that they appeared no more than small black pits.

"The men changed. They used not to have stones set in their skulls. They bound their heads in leather circlets set with gems. Copies of the old stones that they worshipped. Children's trinkets." Her voice creaked like an antique door. "How those men loved their stones and incantations. They did no good that I could see, but at least back then they hurt nobody either. That all changed."

"How? Why?"

"How?" Farsu threw a hand up loosely at her face. "As I just told you. They said they would become true men of stone but instead they became eaters of clay, angry and stupid. They no longer spoke to us except to curse and to command. When we protested they beat us. So we ran away here, to this place worshipped by our ancestors, these stone ingathers built so long ago. The men dare not slaughter us here, because they still hold the ancient stones in awe. So the old stones protect us. But we dare not move away from this place either."

Meya was taken aback at the fierceness with which these words were uttered.

"And then, fifteen years ago or maybe more, our children changed," said Ombue, her voice changing somehow at the same time, "and that was worse."

"Your children changed? What do you mean?" asked Meya.

"They grew up," said Farsu grimly. "And the faster they grew, the sooner they were taken by the men, and the sooner the men came back for more. And to make more children. We do not invite the men but they are stronger. You think we want all those infants, growing up too fast?" Again she swept her arm round loosely, as if to signify the whole settlement.

Meya was a little puzzled by this. There were certainly a lot of children; and all children grew up. Perhaps these resentful mothers, knowing their children would be taken from them, did not wish to see them leave their infancy.

Hilbré shifted on her stone seat before speaking, her voice soft and distant. "Do you not love your babes?"

"Some women do," said Farsu harshly. "But I say, how can you love a child that is made by force, and why would you love a child that will be stolen from you? And that one will learn to curse and spit at you moreover?"

"Can you not teach them differently?" asked Hilbré, very gently.

"It will all be untaught. Why bother?"

"But the girls..."

"What can we teach them except that this is what their life will be?" Farsu was bitter. Meya tried to feel compassion for her, and found that she did not.

"Sit down," said Ombue to the older woman curtly; so perhaps she did not care for Farsu either. Then she went on, "Yes, of course we love our children. Farsu has forgotten, now that she has no children left to love. But as she says, what is the point? This is all they have and all that they will be."

"There are many hundreds of you here," observed Yaret. "Perhaps a thousand, maybe?"

"Hmph! I don't know."

"But there are, perhaps, other stonewomen who live elsewhere?"

Farsu interjected. "The men say they have more women, over east. The ones who did not escape like us. According to the men, they live in thrall, within the forest."

"The Darkburn forest?"

"How should I know what it's called? They're slaves," said Farsu with contempt. "Their own fault, because they did not choose to leave, like us. We had the sense to bring the old stones to protect us."

"You did not bring these stones we see," said Meya sternly.

"Of course not," said Ombue, irritated, with a frown at Farsu. "But this place gives us protection."

"Have you never left here since?"

"Why should we?"

Meya was about to explain why, when Janeya – no, Jebil – spoke unexpectedly.

"May we please see inside your houses? Or one of them at least?"

"Why?" demanded Ombue.

"Because I have never seen houses like them," answered Jebil.

Meya glared over at her, willing the girl to keep her mouth shut. Yet at the same time the sound of the clear voice – that high-born accent – wrenched a little at her heart. She had heard it so often previously with joy vibrating in its note. And why should Jebil not speak? These female Riders all knew who she was.

She is a secret we have hidden from the men, she thought, if with the best of motives; but Jebil makes a chasm between us men and women none the less. Between myself and Huldarion. At least he hides no corresponding secrets of his own.

Ombue was staring at Jebil in suspicion. Then she snorted. "Hmph! Have you no houses, that you are so anxious to see ours?"

She spoke disparagingly, but Jebil answered with sad mildness. "I have no home," she said. "My home is lost."

"And we Riders of the Vonn, we are in exile, and live in tents for the most part," added Tiburé.

"My home is a pile of ash," said Yaret quietly.

Meya wondered what to say. My home is a fine castle bedecked with tapestries and cushioned settles and wardrobes full of silken robes: my home has many rooms and everything I could desire. She stayed silent.

"Hmph," said Ombue. "If you really wish, you may see inside my house."

"Thank you," said Jebil, as the woman motioned to them to stand up.

Meya was glad to see how the others waited for her to rise first. She already felt as stiff as the stooping Farsu, even from so short a spell perched on that cold seat. They walked past a crowd of watching women and children, who scattered at their approach, to one of the bigger houses – which was not saying much, for none of them was large. This one sat squatly in the shadow of a giant stone. Its turf sides were unevenly cut and its roof sagged. A hovel, Meya thought.

She made herself ask, "Why are your houses round?"

"They are built after the manner of our ancestors," said Ombue. "Before we left the men, we used to live with them in stone houses, but we have not the tools to break up stones. So when we came here we remembered the old tales and made our houses the old way, out of earth and turf."

"My own people used to build similar shaped roundhouses," observed Yaret. "The turves must give good harbour from the weather, although the great stones should shelter you from winds in any case. I expect the winter winds across this land are cruel."

"Not just in winter," Ombue agreed, nodding.

"What sort of food can you grow here?" asked Yaret, in a tone of genuine interest.

"We have fish aplenty," the woman said, "and we grow cresses, roots, and foggy-barley."

"What's that? I'm not familiar with foggy-barley."

Meya was already impatient with this line of questioning. And Ombue did not answer. But on entering the low doorway of the house, she bent down just inside it and picked a few stalks from a basket on the floor. Each stalk held a cluster of fat, tight flowers.

"Ah. Similar to spearweed," said Yaret, again with that note of recognition, although neither the plant nor name meant anything to Meya. "And your clothes? They are not wool."

Ombue looked at her sharply.

"I am a weaver," Yaret said pleasantly.

"Hah! River-flax."

"I see. A useful resource." Once Ombue had moved away, Yaret pulled a face. "No wonder they're so bad-tempered," she murmured to Meya, as they entered the darkness of the turf house. "River-flax is the scratchiest thing around. Fine for sacks but not for clothing."

Meya had no interest in what those drab brown clothes were made of. "They might wash them more," she muttered in reply. "They stink."

"They'll always smell of smoke, in this place," answered Yaret.

Perhaps that was true. Meya, as she stood within the hut's shadowy interior, was dispirited. A shabby hovel. What was to be learnt here? Nothing. A floor of strewn and broken reeds, a jumble of rough pots against the wall, a central fireplace that was pouring out as much earthy smoke into the living space as up the chimney – if that hole in the roof was worthy of such a grand title. It was depressing.

There was a girl in there, squatting down to scrape at roots. Meya found herself envisaging Aliya in a gloomy, ruined hovel, surrounded by the stink of smoke. But there was no reason to imagine that, she told herself. Aliya was safe and comfortable; the farmhouse was no hovel. She was letting her fancy fly away too far.

"I have two daughters living with me," Ombue said. "The older one is out digging with her children, but this is my younger one, Habue." The sullen-looking teenager picked herself up slowly, roots in hand, her shoulders drooping.

"Good day to you," said Jebil to her. Habue stood there lumpenly and stared at them. No curtsy. Meya reflected that the girl had probably never been taught how to curtsy – or anything else.

"Do you have a school?" she asked Ombue.

"A school! What for?" Ombue was sceptical; incredulous.

"So that your children may learn to read and write, and calculate their numbers. Or merely learn to sew and cook and clean." There certainly wasn't much evidence of that last activity, Meya thought disapprovingly.

"Why would they need to read and write? The men don't learn that," said Ombue with another snort.

"All the more reason for you to," Meya said, but with the sense that it was a lost cause.

Yaret walked over to the girl who still clutched at her bunch of roots with one hand, her knife in the other.

"I see you are a helpful girl. How old are you, Habue?" she asked her quietly.

The girl stared with widened eyes. "Seven," she said. Meya looked at her with sharp suspicion. Was she being insolent? She was the same size as Yaret.

"Do you mean seven years?" said Yaret, her voice still gentle. Far too gentle in Meya's opinion. "Or do you mean seven of something else?"

"What's something else?" the girl replied, her voice high as if she was upset. "I'm seven years. Winter, summer, that's one. Winter, summer, that's another. That makes two."

"And how many more winters and summers to make seven?" asked Meya severely.

The girl gawped at her with her mouth open and did not respond. Meya thought that even Aliya would be able to work out the answer. Oh, her wonderful, bright Aliya; her demanding, exhausting little girl; but how beloved.

Meanwhile Tiburé stood with pursed lips. "How many stonemen are there?" she enquired of Ombue.

"I don't know that."

"If you understood numbers, then you might know," said Meya. Clearly these woman had no understanding at all. Why, she could see that many of the boys around the place must be at least twelve. So the stonemen did not take them all away at the age of seven. Maybe Ombue was lying about that.

"The men don't tell us," said Ombue sullenly. "And we have no interest in them. Are you finished here? It's just a house. I don't know what you want. I've answered all your questions. Now you can leave."

"I have one more question," stated Tiburé. "Do you wish to be rid of your hated menfolk?"

"Well, of course we do! If we could."

"Then would you help us to defeat them?"

Ombue looked at her with something of a sneer. "We wouldn't help you if you paid us. We don't care what you do. Fight them or not, it's all the same to us. Just go away. Leave us alone."

Tiburé nodded and walked out of the house.

Meya followed her out into the brightness. Whatever Huldarion had hoped for, it was certainly not this. As she gazed up at the huge stones – which seemed to hit the eye with their grained weight, to fill the consciousness – Jebil spoke again.

“These stones. The old woman called them ingathers.”

“So?” said Ombue.

“What does that mean?”

An idle question. Meya already knew the answer: clearly, it meant an area where people gathered.

But Ombue said, “They pull things in.”

“What things?”

“The spirits,” answered Ombue.

“The stones gather spirits here?” asked Yaret, her face oddly serious. “They collect the spirits somehow?”

“Not here. They collect them further up the roads. The stones lead them on towards the sea.”

“They channel them?” said Yaret.

“Exactly what sort of spirits do you mean?” asked Meya, hearing her scepticism loud in her own voice.

“Don’t mock the stones,” said Ombue, her face tightening.

Yaret said quickly, “No, no, we don’t mock. I know the spirits that you speak of – or some of them, at least. Those smaller stones your menfolk wear around their heads: they repel the spirits of the earth. So do these great stones attract them?”

Ombue stared at her for a few seconds in silence, before muttering, “They’re not just of the earth.”

“The sky also,” said Hilbré in her low musical voice. “We felt wing-beats pass overhead, as we rode here. Yet there were no birds that we could see; and it was not the wind.”

Ombue nodded, briefly.

Meya frowned. She had felt no wingbeats inside her carriage, although it was true that her driver had been muttering something about flying creatures. She had taken little notice. He was always muttering about something. Now she was ready to ask more, but Ombue had already begun to march back towards the gap through which they had entered the village.

“You will go now,” she said determinedly, “and tell your menfolk to move on. Tell them it’s pointless for them to attack us. The old stones will protect us as they have always done.”

“I am sure they have no wish to attack you,” Meya said.

“One more thing, please, Ombue,” said Yaret. “Farsu said that your menfolk had become eaters of clay. What did she mean?”

“Just that. Now, go.”

“We thank you for your hospitality,” said Jebil, quite unnecessarily. The woman merely snorted.

Meya dipped her head regally and began to lead away her little deputation through the tunnel. Only Yaret lingered to speak a last time to Ombue.

“Things that have changed, can change again,” Meya heard her say. “Everything changes all the time, and not always for the worse.”

“Hmph! Usually for the worse,” said Ombue.

“That is partly up to you,” said Yaret. She bowed and followed Meya.

What a waste of time, thought Meya as she emerged from the wall of stones. The waiting line of female archers at once advanced to enfold her little group like a protective cloak. When they began to trudge back towards the army, she could see Huldarion there, watching. What could she tell him? What had she discovered?

A town of stonewomen whose knowledge of their menfolk was exactly zero – their interest in the stonemen even less. A degraded tribe in muddy huts, with no redeeming features: a swarming, over-breeding rabble whose superstitions prevented them from bettering themselves. They had no idea of civilised hospitality. The children were filthy. The adults were sulky, illiterate and ignorant. Why, the stonewomen could not even count.

And all the time, despite herself, her mind kept straying from this place to another: to her own child, to Aliya.

Aliya is safe, Meya assured herself for the tenth time, she is safe, she is happy with her piglet and the ducks: she is well cared for on the farm, she is comfortable, no doubt she is indulged.

Yet she found she could not push her anxious thoughts away.

Chapter 23

Aliya knew why they had to move, although the others didn't know that she knew. It was something she kept to herself because she thought she ought not to have been listening.

After the fight around the big stone house they had gone back to the farm. But it didn't feel the same any more. All the animals were upset. One of the big dogs was dead and the other one was hurt, although Lally was all right. But even Lally was jumpy and cross, nearly as bad as Flodda. The piglet wouldn't come to her but ran around her pen as if trying to escape.

Inside there was lots of hurrying around as well. There had just been a whole day of footsteps running to and fro around the farmhouse, and people talking in intense quiet voices in the corridors and sometimes in louder voices too. Aliya heard these louder voices arguing in the kitchen, while she was in the pantry hunting for neglected biscuits. The door was open just a tiny crack so she crouched down silently behind it to listen.

It was Camburé's voice that was so loud. "But they know where she is," Camburé said, quite fiercely.

"Has someone given us away?" That was Wiln. "Does that mean there is a spy within the Vonn?"

"That seems hardly likely," answered Camburé. She sounded angry. "It would not need a spy within the Vonn to find her presence out. We were not sufficiently secret bringing her here, that much is plain. She was targeted by that last attack: it was no coincidence."

"Then they'll try again," said Olbeth.

"Yes. She isn't safe. We need to move her."

Aliya, listening to this from behind the door with half a biscuit in her mouth, paused in biting it to think.

She understood who *they* were. They were the bad men who had chased her. She had assumed that Veron and Olbeth and the others had killed them all. But maybe they hadn't. Maybe there were more bad men waiting with their swords outside the house, waiting in the woods and fields and pig-pens to jump out and start chasing her all over again.

Aliya put the biscuit down. Her appetite had gone. There was a faint sickness in her throat because now she understood who the *she* was as well. *She* couldn't be Mama, who was the most important *she* in all the world; because Mama was not here. Aliya tried to tell herself that *she* meant Olbeth. But Olbeth had always lived here and it wouldn't have needed spies to find that out.

No, *she* meant her. Aliya. They wanted *her*.

"Where can we take her?" That was Wiln again. "Back to Kelvha? She'd be safe within the castle."

"She ought to be." A smaller voice; her nursemaid, Flodda. Her voice was always small, just as she herself was. Flodda was afraid to shout, because maids must never shout or they would be whipped. "But without the protection of her mother – and now that Melegan and all his family are disgraced... well, I don't know."

"With her mother, then?" said Wiln.

"That is no place for a child," said Camburé. "Riding in the battle train."

Aliya knew what a battle train was. It was lots of soldiers all marching in a line. Her father had been a great soldier – so Mama had told her, many times – and her grandfather had been a famous general. He had had his own battle train to follow him wherever he went. Or maybe to go ahead of him, with trumpets: she wasn't sure.

She liked trumpets, and thought that riding in a battle train would be all right. But it seemed the other speakers didn't think so. They agreed with Camburé.

"Can we go somewhere else?" suggested Flodda. "Is there another farm nearby where they would take us in?"

"Nearby would be no use." That was a stern, still slightly husky voice: the wolfman. Veron. He had not been back into his chamber since the cobwebs covered up his legs. When he had stood up underneath the big low tree, still laughing, and brushed off the white cobwebby stuff, nearly all the fierce red lines had gone. Olbeth said the tree had cured him.

Aliya did not know what to think. The picture she had drawn for him had been left on his bed: she'd been into his empty room to take it back, awed that it had worked. The tree had cured Veron. She found it was a scary thought. Had her drawing been that powerful? She hid it in a corner of Lally's pen, underneath the straw.

Now she hoped that Lally hadn't eaten it. What would it do to a pig? But the voices in the kitchen were still talking.

"We could go to Outer Kelyha," Flodda said. "Don't you have allies there?"

"We do," said Camburé, "but I cannot think of any who would be willing or well enough prepared to fight off a company of stonemen."

"There must be somewhere!" Flodda said, in a sort of quiet wail.

"And some of us must stay on here," said Wiln. "We cannot leave the farm defenceless."

"Bruilde," said Olbeth, as if she'd just remembered something. "We'll take her to Bruilde."

"Bruilde?" said Camburé. She did not sound pleased. "But the place hasn't even been rebuilt yet since the fire."

"Exactly," Olbeth said. "Since Deloran got burnt out, the stonemen haven't troubled it. They think it's derelict. Bruilde is being very careful to make sure that it continues to appear so."

"Well. I see your point. All right," said Camburé. "Bruilde it is."

That seemed to be agreed by all. But Aliya had no chance to learn any more about who or where Bruilde was, because after that, the voices moved away into the hall, and then she thought it best to wait for a while before venturing out of the pantry with her foraged biscuits.

The kitchen was empty. The first person she saw, alone in the echoing great hall, was Veron. She tried not to think of him as the wolfman any more because when she had called him Mister Wolfman earlier that morning he hadn't thrown anything but he had said he didn't like it.

"Wolves are wolves and men are men," he'd told her. "They can't be half and half. Some things can, but wolves can't."

"What can, then?" Aliya had asked, genuinely curious; but he hadn't answered. She didn't argue with him, because even though he didn't take the angry medicine any more he still didn't seem like someone you should argue with. She was very careful with him now that he was no longer lying down.

Now, in the great hall, Veron was laying out knives upon the table. They were not dinner knives. They were all made in different sizes and some weren't knives at all. Aliya looked at them and at Veron and he looked back at Aliya.

"How are your legs now?" she asked politely, although she knew that they were better. His face was different too. Less tight; though always watching. Sometimes he even smiled, which was a little scary. But he wasn't smiling now.

"They're all right. How do you feel about moving house?" he said, as if he knew that she'd been hiding in the pantry to listen.

"I don't mind," Aliya said, because she was not sure which was the right answer. "But how will Mama know where I am? How will she come and find me?"

"We'll send a messenger to tell her," said Veron.

"Where will we go?"

"Wait and find out," he said.

Aliya thought about this. "Can I take my pig?"

"Better not. It won't enjoy it."

Aliya frowned. But she felt that this was probably true. Even if she would allow herself to be caught, Lally didn't like being carried anywhere, even across the yard. She squealed. So she would squeal even louder in a carriage.

"Will there be ducks?" she asked.

Veron gazed down at her with a slight frown as if he hadn't really seen her before. Yet he had seen her loads of times.

"You need ducks?"

"They don't have to be ducks," she said. "But something." Something she could hold, hang onto, that wasn't Flodda: something small that she could feed and scold and look after. She could help look after baby Doval but he wasn't hers the way the piglet was.

Veron nodded. "There will be something." He began to gather all the knives up off the table, very carefully, and put some in his belt and some in a big leather bag and some he curled up into a long chain like a bristly snake.

"Can I have a knife?" she asked.

He turned around and looked at her again. "Have you had one before?"

"No."

"Better not, then."

"All right." In fact she was slightly relieved. "Will you be coming when we move?"

"I will," he said, and she found that answer was both worrying and a comfort. Then Flodda came in and hurried her away.

Unlike Veron, Flodda said nothing about anybody moving and Aliya did not ask. Neither did she ask why everyone was bustling in and out in such a hurry. But later on, in the middle of the night, when Flodda woke her and she was lifted out of bed in the dark and quiet, she knew at once what was happening.

"We're just going on a little trip," said Flodda softly in her ear as she carried her from the room wrapped in her blanket. "You can sleep in the cart."

So Aliya pretended to fall asleep on Flodda's shoulder because that was easier than having to walk or talk. Once she had been laid down in the cart she pretended to fall asleep in there. Despite the jolting, soon she really was asleep, and when she woke up the cart had stopped and she was in a wood, although she could see the edge of it and fields beyond. A bit of sun shone down between the trees and there were birds singing everywhere. So it was morning.

She sat up straight. "Is this where we're staying now?" she asked. She couldn't see a house or even a hut, only trees.

The others were sitting up already in the cart as if they hadn't slept. Even though there were only a few of them – Flodda and Camburé and Olbeth and the baby – the cart was not big enough for them to all lie down in. It was a cart that Wiln used for carrying sacks or sometimes sheep around the farm. It only needed one horse. Aliya didn't know why they hadn't brought the big cart. But she thought it might be fun if they lived here by the wood and had to sleep beneath the trees.

"We're staying here today," said Olbeth, "and in the evening, when it's dark, we'll set off again and go to a house where my friend Bruilde lives." And then she explained how she was worried about bad people attacking her farm. "We want you and baby Doval to be somewhere safe," she said, as she helped Aliya climb out of the cart.

Aliya nodded. Olbeth was very sensible so she knew that there must really be a problem. But she felt quite safe here. Veron and two of his hunter men were walking by the edge of the trees where it was bright. They carried bows.

Camburé and Flodda were looking at her with serious faces. The baby was the only happy person. He sat up on a mossy bit of ground with a pile of leaves in his lap and his fat legs curled round them, and flipped and flapped them with his hands, making wubwubwub noises. He was so excited that he slowly fell over sideways onto the moss. Olbeth picked him up and settled him around the leaves again.

"Does my Mama know?" Aliya asked.

"She will know by nightfall," said Camburé. "Meanwhile you can play in these woods today."

"But first, breakfast," said Olbeth.

So Aliya got dressed – she didn't need Flodda's help – and ate her breakfast of bread and cheese and dried grapes in a hurry. She wanted to explore the woods. Flodda and Camburé seemed to expect her to be upset, and kept offering to play with her. Flodda had brought a soft leather ball, while Camburé suggested that they play hide and seek.

"No thank you," said Aliya. "I'm going to find out about these woods."

"Don't go far," begged Flodda – who looked quite unhappy – so Aliya said, "No, I won't go far." And when she set off through the wood to explore and Flodda kept following her, she decided not to show Flodda that she minded.

But Flodda didn't get too close. She stayed apart if not quite hiding, as if she was pretending to be there by accident. She didn't get in the way nor ask silly questions about why Aliya wanted to feel the bark of all the trees and burrow with her fingers in the moss. There were a hundred little creatures in there. Lots of them were spiders, and tiny glittering spiderwebs hung on the little bushy plants that stuck up through the moss. The plants had lime green leaves edged a little bit with orange and Aliya decided that those were her favourite colours.

As she rubbed her hands up and down the trees feeling the bark tickle she listened to all the birds and tried to work out what they were saying. She had never heard so many birds all at one time before. Where were all their nests? She peered up into the trees whose leaves were bright but she couldn't see anything that looked like a nest.

It was a nice wood, though. Lally would have liked these woods and Aliya felt a pang of regret. She told herself that Lally had her picture of the tree to keep her safe. So long as the piglet didn't eat it.

Something here had chewed some of the trees and she thought about that for a while before deciding that there might be deer. So she wandered a bit further – aware that Flodda was still following her – until she found a small place that was nice and bushy and looked as if it could hold deer. Baby deer, at least, or rabbits; or even wild piglets, although she knew that grown-up wild pigs were fierce and smelly.

But it didn't smell of pigs here. It smelt of moss and earth. A good place for animals to hide. So she hid herself behind a tree for a few minutes to give the animals time to come out and then she peeked out very quickly to see if there were any.

"Oh," she said, because there was something there, just for a second, but it was not an animal. It had been something, but now it was a little stumpy bush with only a few leaves.

Aliya hid again behind her tree. She counted to twenty and then she peeked suddenly again.

There it was! And there it wasn't. She laughed, and ran over to hide again behind another tree, and counted and then popped out to peek and this time it was a little person with big ears, or maybe arms, only when she looked harder it was just a piece of wood.

But it had been a little person, she was sure. Almost sure. Maybe not a person. A little something that lived in this wood. It was trying to hide from her but it wasn't very good at it. It didn't know when she would pop out.

"I'm friendly," said Aliya. "Don't be afraid."

Behind her she heard Flodda call out softly. "Who are you talking to?"

"I'm looking for rabbits," called Aliya back, and then she laughed and put her finger to her lips at the little something that was pretending to be a piece of wood. Next time she looked she saw another one, from the corner of her eye, that immediately turned itself into a mossy stone.

Aliya walked up to it but she didn't touch the stone. That would not be fair.

"I'm not going to hurt you," she said, more quietly this time so that Flodda wouldn't hear. "I'm only staying for one day. I'm going away tonight. I like your wood."

Indeed, she thought she would quite like to live in this wood herself, so long as it didn't rain. There were lots of bits of loose wood around that weren't little somethings but only twigs and branches, so she could always build herself a hut with those. She ran around collecting some of them and then hid behind a tree and peeked at the pile to make sure that she hadn't collected a little something by mistake.

She hadn't. But the little somethings that she had already spotted were there again before they flashed back to bush and stump and stone. It struck her that they looked quite damp. Maybe they would like a house. The twigs she had collected weren't really long enough to make a proper house for her, but they were big enough for the somethings.

So Aliya found a flat spot with a mossy carpet underneath a tree and began to pile the sticks up into walls. She collected little stones to make a doorway, although it kept on falling down and ended up too small. So it could just be a window and she would leave the other end open for somethings to creep in and out. The walls looked a bit wobbly so she undid some of them and tried again, stuffing gaps with lumps of moss. She found that she could peel great wads of moss right off the stones. They felt like thick damp velvet although they smelt nicer. They smelt wet. She was very happy.

"Who's that for?"

Aliya turned round and sat up, startled. She hadn't heard Veron walk up to her although she had heard Flodda every time she breathed or shuffled. She was so startled that she didn't answer.

"It's a bit small to shelter you," said Veron.

She thought of telling Veron that it was for rabbits but she knew he wouldn't believe that.

"It's for anything that lives here," she said, "that needs a little house."

"What sort of anything?"

She didn't want to give away the little somethings if he didn't already know about them. She didn't want them to be hunted. So she just said, "Will you be hunting anything in this wood?"

"No," said Veron.

"Good." She turned back to building the roof that kept falling off. She needed to weave the sticks together somehow. But she could feel Veron still watching her.

"What sort of anything?" he said again.

"Anything that doesn't want to be seen," she said. "In case it rains."

Next time she turned round he had gone although she hadn't heard him go. She kept on building her house, and while it wasn't very good it gave her some ideas for how to build the next one. So after Flodda had made her eat a lump of barley cake and drink some water she started on the next. It didn't fall down, or not very much.

Then she decided she would build a bridge across the little stream which they had drunk their water from. The water held swirling pools where there were tiny creatures swimming and she watched them for a while. When she looked up there was another something that turned itself into a shapeless weed and she was glad that the things that lived here hadn't been scared off.

"Nobody is going to hunt you," she said.

"Who are you talking to?" asked Flodda.

"They are my pretending people," said Aliya. She had prepared this answer while she was eating. She knew that Flodda would think she was pretending, when actually it was the somethings who were pretending to be something else. In her opinion this was a pleasingly clever answer.

All the exploring and building and looking at creatures kept her busy and content. But after another meal of cheese and fruit she felt suddenly very tired. She lay back against Flodda's shoulder sitting on the grass and must have fallen asleep because next thing she knew it was dark and she was in the cart again, being jolted away.

"My somethings!" she thought. "I didn't say goodbye!"

She wondered if she should have brought one with her. But sleepy as she was, she knew that wouldn't work. Like Lally, it would not enjoy it. Or Flodda might have thought it was just an ordinary lump of wood or stone and might have thrown it away into the wrong place.

Instead, her somethings right now might be sheltering in the house that she had made. She hoped that they were comfortable.

It wasn't comfortable in the cart but she snuggled into Flodda and made a nest there with a warm tangle of blankets and Flodda's thin but reassuring arms. When she woke up again the woods were gone and she was in another farmhouse altogether.

Chapter 24

"Have you never been this way before, Novesnu?" asked Rothir.

The Riders and the Kelvhan company had left behind the great stone structures, which had diminished to mere pebbles far behind them. They continued to march or rather amble along the Red Roads, their horses plodding peaceably, sometimes in and sometimes out of the gentle waters.

Those waters' redness was less obvious now, diluted by numerous new springs and streams; the slow meanders across the flat lands appeared more silver, gleaming like wet fish-scales, with an occasional ruddy swirl as if a giant paintbrush had been dipped into them. The streams were never deeper than Narba's hocks.

The wiry Kelvhan who rode his grey horse alongside Narba shook his head.

"There was never any need for us to come this way. It's too peaceful: nothing happens here. I've spent most of the last decade on the western borders, fighting tribesmen. The Hallots were in a permanent state of revolt a few years ago."

"In the western hills? Difficult terrain," said Rothir nodding. "I remember it: full of caves and thornbushes. We took part in a skirmish there ourselves against the Hallots and their princeling. That must be going back six years. Which was your regiment?"

He had set out deliberately to cultivate the captain, aiming to pick his brains about the Kelvhan army. But Rothir found that he liked Novesnu for his own sake. On their first encounter, back in Kelvha City's tilting-ground, he had much admired the manner in which Novesnu had won his combat against Aretor. It had been a swift and skilful victory, but Novesnu had not made too much of it: no swagger or triumphal flourishes. Rothir thought the captain was less haughty than his Kelvhan colleagues – less full of himself, as Parthenal peevishly put it.

And Parthenal was very peevish at the moment. He was not good company. Even now that they were on the move again, Parthenal remained short-tempered. Rothir had tried to talk to him, first lightly, then more seriously – although he had, naturally, stopped short of interrogating him – but Parthenal had shrugged off all good-natured comments with a grunt and scowl.

Rothir would almost have imagined that his friend was languishing in love, or desire rather, were that not so unlike him. But Parthenal did not languish in love. He just beckoned, and then he took. Rothir guessed that frequently he didn't even need to beckon.

But he could not probe beyond a brotherly enquiry; and though he'd always loved him, he found that Parthenal's unusual moodiness did not fit well just now with his own equally unusual optimism. Rothir knew that such contentedness was abnormal for him; but since it was welcome, he did not question himself as to its cause in case it went away again. Some of it, doubtless, was relief at Veron's recovery: they'd just received that news. Rothir was determined to enjoy this sense of a light heart while it lasted.

So Novesnu's companionship was welcome. As they rode past the dwindling lines of stones the two of them exchanged reminiscences: from battles fought on horseback, to rivers crossed and the methods of those crossings, and then to boats and carriages and horse-breeds, and so back to cavalry again. Rothir was careful about what he gave away. Despite his liking for the weather-beaten Kelvhan, he was always conscious of the need to be discreet. So he spoke only briefly of his long allegiance to Huldarion, and was surprised and a little moved when Novesnu said,

"You esteem the Lord Huldarion greatly, I can tell: your manner says what your words skim over. Yet he is young, as leaders go."

"Not so very young," said Rothir. "He's over thirty-five – and older still in the trials that he has undergone. You do not know the pain that he has suffered, both in his loss of Caervonn, and in his body: which was ravaged by the darkburn that set fire to that city."

The other man nodded.

"Having seen the darkburns at their work," he said, "I do not underestimate Huldarion's courage. Yet he has still largely been untried in battle. Yes, I know about the many smaller battles he has fought and won. But now he'll have the force of Kelvha on his side: instead of two thousand men, there will be over twenty thousand to command. Such a great army is unwieldy. It takes experience as well as skill to properly direct such numbers."

"He will, I hope, have the aid of your commanders," said Rothir, although he wasn't sure whether the Kelvhan command would be a help or hindrance. If the Arch-Lord Marshal Shargun were in charge, definitely the latter.

But Novesnu said, with surprising bluntness, "Our troops hope that the Lord Shargun will be left out of this affair. He's currently not in the highest favour with our Post-Regent, Lord Nerogun, so he may not be present on the battlefield. Or if he is, Nerogun will not be. But Nerogun generally has the upper hand."

"Shargun's out of favour? How is that?" asked Rothir, intrigued that Novesnu would mention such a matter to him, and so openly. Presumably the matter was no secret.

Novesnu shook his head. "I'm not sure. Some minor disagreement, I expect; they're both proud men, and I have learned that Kelvhans do not forgive slights easily." This confirmed Rothir's impression that Novesnu himself was not of Kelvhan origin. His name indicated southern roots. Although that did not make him a mercenary, it might set limits on his loyalty to Kelvha. "But Shargun inherited his military post," continued the captain, "and he has not lived up to expectations. I hope for better things from Jeveran, although he too stands low in Nerogun's favour. However, that's purely through his lack of birth, not lack of talent."

"Then let us hope that Jeveran will have command."

"I do hope it. He's a careful man, but not a timid one. It's a pity that the greatest general I ever fought for is now dead." Novesnu sighed. "In any case he'd be an old man now. Borovin was his name: far-thinking, decisive, he could perform miracles of organisation. No detail was too small for his attention: no soldier too lowly to catch his eye. Yet he had a wide grasp of the whole."

"Those are indeed great qualities in a general."

"He was the Lady Meya's father," said Novesnu. "Her late husband too, Inigun, was a notable soldier. Taciturn, but a fine strategist and the most upright of men."

"I am sorry not to have met him," said Rothir courteously, before reflecting on the idiocy of his words. If Inigun were alive Meya would not be here; Huldarion would have needed to find some other woman with whom to forge his alliance with Kelvha. Suppose he had chosen that pretty young Janeya, only to have her throw herself off the castle's highest tower to her death... What a disaster that would have been.

"Inigun was a man of high intelligence," Novesnu said. "I expect their daughter is the same. You have seen the Lady Meya's child?"

"I have not," said Rothir, immediately on his guard.

"Nor I," said the Kelvhan. "On the occasion when we met recently, while you were escorting Lady Meya from the Hapligan estate, I thought the missing child must easily be found. But when I caught up with Lord Hapligan two or three days later, he swore he had no knowledge of her whereabouts."

Rothir began to wonder if all Novesnu's friendliness had this as its basis: that the man was only riding alongside him to try and tease out information. Even though he himself was in part doing the same thing, it seemed a shame.

"Where was Lord Hapligan when you found him?" he asked.

"Northern Kelvha. I expect he's now confined to some country manor. I don't know what happened to the Lady Hapligan. The last I heard, she had still not been traced."

"Then presumably the child is with her."

"Presumably. I find it strange that the Lady Meyra has not gone in search of her."

"I am not in the Lady Meyra's confidence," said Rothir cautiously, "but perhaps someone else has undertaken that search on her behalf." He was conscious of throwing this out as a hunter might cast a scrap of meat upon the ground, to see if a predator would head that way.

"I would gladly have undertaken it myself," said Novesnu sombrely. "I owe both my life and my position to the General, the child's grandfather. I would do anything within my power to protect the child from harm. You understand me?"

"I understand you," said Rothir, although he did not. Was this Novesnu's own casting out of bait? Was he hoping Rothir would spill out everything he knew about the child's location?

But even if he'd felt inclined, there would have been no chance of saying more, because Sashel pulled up his horse to wait for them. He and Novesnu saluted each other with grave respect; a combat between those two would be worth watching, thought Rothir, before withdrawing from the idea in self-disgust. Even a mock combat had no charms for him at present.

Sashel said, "Huldarion says we'll stop soon. The stones are coming to an end at last."

The stones, indeed, were ending – those parts of them that were still visible. Many lay half underwater, for ahead the Red Roads broadened to create a maze of curving, shining, wide wet ribbons. Only one group of taller stones stood sternly silhouetted on the pale horizon.

"Still no sign of any inhabitants. Yaret was telling me earlier about the stonewomen at the last settlement," he said.

"A strange place," said Novesnu.

"Uninviting, to be sure," said Sashel. "And those women sounded an embittered lot."

"Yaret told you too, then?" asked Rothir. A needless question, he immediately thought. What did it matter who Yaret talked to? Of course she spoke to Sashel. She'd dined with him in Kelvha city, maybe more than once. No reason why she shouldn't.

But Sashel shook his head. "Hilbré. She said the women were determined to resent their situation, yet equally determined to do nothing about it. What did Yaret say?"

"She talked of their beliefs. Apparently the women think the lines of stones create some sort of guide, or channel: almost like a fish-trap, I imagine, but for spirits, not for fish, carrying them down towards the sea."

Sashel laughed. Novesnu did not.

"What kind of spirits?" he asked. "The dead?"

"No. Well, in truth I'm not quite sure, but I think they meant those unseen birds we felt passing overhead a little while ago. If they were spirits." The memory of that bright pulse of unseen wings still puzzled him. So he added, "To be honest I don't understand it. Maybe at the end of the Red Roads we shall be provided with some revelation."

"That would be nice," said Sashel.

Novesnu, gazing out to the stones poised on the horizon, did not speak for a moment. Then he said, quietly, "I've seen the dead at times here. Men that I have killed. I see them fleetingly, in passing, here then gone; but despite the swiftness of the vision I know who they are."

"I have never had that experience," said Rothir, "fortunately for me."

"Oh, there is no terror in it. Their faces just appear, as if to say, *this is what was done*. I expect it's my own conscience coming to the fore in this empty place, reminding me of what my life is. Of what it is to be a soldier. Yet I have killed no man without a cause... The cause generally being that they have wanted to kill me."

"Well, that is good enough cause," said Rothir.

"I think it is the only cause. It's strange, though, to see those visions in this peaceful haven, which ought to lay all fears to rest," Novesnu murmured. "I never saw them on the battlefield. Did you?"

Rothir thought about this, then shook his head. "No. Though I remember once being made aware of the Riders I had lost. It was in the infirmary just after battle. They seemed to stand around me. I was not involved directly in their deaths, and yet I felt responsible." Then he wondered if he should be talking of such things in front of Sashel, who had lost his twin around that time: an appalling death by darkburn.

"Your dead ride with you still," Novesnu said.

"I have not seen my brother," said Sashel, his voice low. "I do wish, sometimes, that I could. I do wonder where he is."

Rothir had no response for this. He grasped with some relief at a distraction.

"Ah, look up there! Not spirits this time, just ordinary birds."

A huge, high flock was scudding from the north: long-winged, pale and graceful – too lithe and elegant for geese. Some sea-bird presumably. Although Rothir could neither feel nor hear the wingbeats, their brief, high, stuttering calls seemed to spill towards him in a rain of sound.

"Travelling south," he said, watching the flock overtake them; hundreds knifing through the heavens, almost languid in their effortless speed.

"Terns," Novesnu said.

As the cloud of birds receded, the Vonnish train began to move a little faster, following a gently-winding path that seemed to have been laid across the silver waters. It was a causeway, evidently made by human hands; for soon cobbles were clunking under Narba's hooves. Wide enough for five or six to ride abreast, it led towards the final standing stones.

They caught up with Parthenal once more, but did not speak. This felt like a ritual, almost religious progress.

"A pilgrim path," said Rothir at last.

"I wonder who might walk it with us," said Novesnu.

"Perhaps our wizard could tell us," said Rothir.

"I doubt it," grumbled Parthenal, "given his ignorance about everything else."

Rothir looked over at Leor, who was riding with a strange expression on his face, wary and baffled; but then Leor had looked that way since the encounter with the Arac Semmuru. It was true that the wizard's knowledge seemed often accidental. Why, even those lin in Kelvha City had been revealed by chance...

As he thought of lin he saw a flicker in his vision, a quick flash, in and out. He turned his head: no, just a clump of grass.

But Leor's head turned too. So, he thought, I was not the only one to notice it. No doubt Yaret will be murmuring those words she says on seeing lins. Not a prayer exactly. More a greeting. How are you today, you lin.

Then he ceased thinking, and merely rode, experiencing the heavy lift and sway of Narba's gait, the gentle splashing of his hooves; the familiar warm smell of his horse mingled with the sweetness of the air, the luminous reflections from the water shifting all around him. He heard the high song of the breeze, and watched the slowly sailing clouds match his own pace while arrowing strings of birds outstripped them. The stones grew ever closer.

A set of eight, these stones stood in a circle barely higher than the surrounding waters. Further on, the streams merged into a shimmering surface dotted by flocks of wading birds. Their piping calls were like an orchestra of small flutes tuning up. Some miles away to either side the land rose gradually again to form long cliffs; but straight ahead, beyond the stones, a shifting line of white showed where the Red Roads finally became the sea.

Rothir's heart seemed almost to stop. Why did the sea produce such yearning, such a sense of need?

It is the endlessness, he thought, it is the endless beat and sway that carries us in imagination to unseen horizons. It is a thing of eternal movement and yet a promise of boundless peace. Of the forgetting of our weary selves. It is a symbol of our lives, of time and change; though timeless, changeless. We shall all be changed by time. Hopefully not for the worse.

Huldarion and the foremost Riders were already entering the stone circle. As he rode up to its border Rothir saw another flicker before it resolved itself into an inconspicuous brown rock. He smiled as he rode on.

They stood within the grassy, sandy space: the mild wind blew between the stones, and seabirds called. Did these stones draw the sky down to the land, pinning them together against the tapestry of light and wind? But the sky was as it always was.

"I feel no spirits here," he commented to Novesnu. "Nothing but the salty air." Novesnu did not answer: he looked deep in thought.

So Rothir followed Parthenal across the circle to its sole inhabitants – not living beings, but artefacts, although they might, he thought, be called long dead. Certainly it must be a long time since they had last been used. They were the remains of a pair of wooden two-wheeled carts, that now, like shipwrecks, leaned askew on rotten shafts.

As he came closer he saw that each cart bore – or once had borne – a cage. Around the carts the sand was trodden by a host of footprints. He knew those footprints, with their curious rope soles. A multitude of stripes had bitten deep into the earth: wheeltracks, which led out of the circle on both sides.

"Stonemen," he said. It was a grim reminder of reality.

Parthenal said quietly, "But that's not a darkburn cage."

Rothir studied the cages more intently. One was in ruins, the other almost so. Both were stained and lichen-dappled. But for all their decaying state he saw immediately that Parthenal was right. A wooden cage could never hold a darkburn – it would be burnt to ash in moments. The cages on these carts were made of withies, or some other slender tree stems, woven close upon a wooden frame. The nearer one had almost disintegrated whilst the second was a mess of rotten stalks around a gaping hole.

"So what were these made to carry?" asked Rothir.

Parthenal shook his head.

A strange idea came into Rothir's mind, as if blown there by the breeze amongst the birdcalls and the ocean's aromatic heady tang. It was the thought that, however spirits might have travelled down the Red Roads to this final harbour, they had found themselves being carried out again by quite another means: within a woven cage.

Chapter 25

Leor frowned uncertainly in one direction, and then the other. The tracks of rope-soled feet and wheels led off on either side, both east and west, parallel to the shore. The seabirds' cries were pulling him straight on, towards the white blur of the waves; but that was not an option. He had to choose east or west, without knowledge, without confidence, without any clear memory of this place.

"I vote for east," he said at last. "The tracks are heavier that way. They've beaten out a lane. So that's the way most of the traffic has come and gone."

Huldarion looked as if he did not like this answer.

"Uld? What is your opinion?"

"East is certainly the busier route. Yet I'm intrigued to know what can lie westward that the stonemen think worth visiting," the dry, grey-haired man said. "The Kelvhan maps, I know, label the area west of here the Place of Terns. So it must have had historical importance."

"I believe there used to be a stoneman centre there," Huldarion said. "These recent tracks imply that it's still active. Our scouts have reported a large construction on the cliff top only a few miles away."

Solon said, "Then seeing we have come this far, we may as well continue a little further west. It won't take too much time."

"I agree," said Uld.

"I would go east," said Crade. "Follow the road to find the enemy's main stronghold: that is what we came for, is it not?"

"In part," Huldarion said.

"We can send a detachment to check what lies to the west. It doesn't need our whole army to do that."

Huldarion nodded, slowly. Then, turning to Meya who stood beside him, looking grave, he asked, "What do you think, my dear?"

"You know what I think." Her voice was low.

"She's quite safe," Huldarion said, putting his undamaged hand on Meya's arm. "Be reassured by the message, not alarmed. It means that all possible precautions are being taken."

Leor was not quite sure what this meant; but then he had not been present when the messenger – one of the loben hunters – had come galloping down the Red Roads to find them, his spare horse as weary and foam-flecked as the one he rode.

Of the message he carried, Leor had been told only that Veron was fully recovered. That news had been a great relief, for he'd felt a nagging, anxious guilt at his inability to cure Veron. But evidently some other piece of news had been brought from Olbeth's farm as well.

Meya made no response to Huldarion's touch. She said distinctly, "I would prefer to see her sooner rather than later. Therefore I would prefer to travel east, as was your plan."

"Bruilde will look after her," said Thoronal, in his rather patronising manner. It was a small shock to Leor to hear the name of Bruilde. What had she to do with anything?

"That still is my plan," said Huldarion, with a frown at Thoronal – so perhaps Bruilde ought not to have been mentioned – "but it was always my desire to explore this region first. And that is what I wish to do."

"Then I must fall in with your wish, it seems," said Meya coldly.

"Afterwards, we'll meet up with the body of the Kelvhan army before marching on. You'll be reunited with her soon enough. But first I wish to see what place lies west of here."

"I thought you always voted on such matters," Meya said, still cool.

"So we do. Uld and Solon vote for west; Leor and Crade for east. You, Thoronal?"

"East. Why waste time here?" Leor thought Thoronal's tone was singularly undiplomatic. However, Huldarion merely nodded and then looked at the three women present.

"Delgeb? Hilbré?"

Delgeb voted east. Hilbré declined to choose.

"Tiburé?"

"West," she said, "if that is what you want."

"I do. That makes four votes each way. We shall go west," Huldarion said. "Solon, will you inform the Kelvhans of our route?"

As the Riders dispersed, Meya said quietly to Huldarion, "So, you have the casting vote, while I have none."

Huldarion looked at her in some surprise. "My dear, you are not of the Vonn."

"Neither is this wizard," said Meya. Some emotion seemed to risk choking her. "And please do not *my dear* me."

"If it is any help," offered Leor, "I can change my vote to west, because I really have no strong opinion on the matter."

"It is not of any help," said Meya, and she stalked away and climbed into her carriage.

Huldarion looked at Leor; an inscrutable look, but then all his looks were. "If you can find Tamu," he said, "please ask him to bring his documents with any maps to me."

"I expect he'll be with the priest," said Leor, but Huldarion too had turned away.

So Leor set off to hunt down Tamu, aware that the word *Women!* although unspoken, resonated in his mind, and probably in Huldarion's. He knew it was unfair. No doubt Meya had good reason for her annoyance; certainly she might have expected her preference to be taken into account, and not summarily dismissed.

But; *women!* He would not want to marry Meya. Indeed, he felt that every relationship that he had had with women had ended because of their dissatisfaction with him; which it seemed had never been properly expressed until the final moments, when some feature of his behaviour became suddenly wholly intolerable. That also was unfair. If they had dropped him hints, how was he supposed to notice? Why was he supposed to change?

No, not every relationship. But Bruilde.

"You make too much of being a wizard," she had said. "You never let it be forgotten." Yet how could he have denied what he was? It was not as if he boasted of it. Rather, he had a tendency to chew over his many failures, to fret over where he had gone wrong. Maybe that was the problem. Too much fretting and not enough confidence. Women liked confident men. Or did they?

"Tamu," he called, on seeing the archivist outside the stone circle, by the priest's cart. Hoki-ro, the young priest, hardly ever left the cart's vicinity. He might have been padlocked to it. He stood beside it now, staring at the stones.

"What do the stones say to you?" Leor asked him, curious to know how he would reconcile such ancient monuments with his avid worship of Borgun.

"Their purpose must have been of huge significance," the priest said meditatively. "Yet the setting of them here surely involved the hard labour of many hundred men. I expect some died in their transport and raising. So to me the stones speak chiefly of exploitation and enslavement."

"You can't be sure of that," said Leor, unreasonably annoyed, for he had expected a more mystical answer.

The priest gave him a look that might have been pitying. "You think they volunteered for such work?"

"They might have," said Leor, although he instantly knew that he himself would run a mile before expending weeks or even months on such exhausting toil. And exhausting it must have been, he realised now. He felt depressed. Had he in truth been hoping for some revelation, some exposition of the divine?

"Of course it's possible that magic may have played a part in the creation of the circle," said Tamu thoughtfully. "Would you be able to detect that, Leor?"

"I don't know," he said. That too was depressing; that he had so little understanding of his own magic. Which was not even his own magic, which was the result of no special virtue, but which was entirely accidental.

I do not want it, he thought, this unwelcome gift. Yet at the very idea of giving it up his soul rebelled in terror. What, to have no special quality at all? To succumb to the indignity of age and death? To have no distinction from the common herd? No, no, he was no common man; he was a wizard, and would behave as one.

"Huldarion summons you, Tamu," he said loftily. "Take your maps."

Tamu dived into the cart and emerged with a bundle of documents under his arm, to hurry away, avoiding the crowd of Riders that milled within the circle.

His special quality is knowledge, thought Leor, watching him; despite his shyness, his dedication to learning is impressive. And this priest: what is his special quality? Compassion, I would guess. It should be, for a priest. I have that too, I hope. Yet I would not devote my life to it.

I have devoted my whole life to magic. But not successfully. I have not been an effective wizard. To a large extent, the gift of wizardry was wasted on me.

This was the most depressing thought of all. He sighed and looked around, to see the sympathetic brown eyes of the priest fixed on him.

"To admit the limits of your knowledge is knowledge in itself," Hokiyo said.

"I daresay." But Leor did not believe that. Ignorance was simply ignorance.

And after so many hundred years, I ought not to be ignorant, he chided himself. Tamu asked if magic might have been employed in building this stone circle. Why do I assume that I cannot find out?

He nodded curtly to the priest and strode away, towards a stone where no Riders lingered. Not until he'd walked around it did he see the thin Kelvhan maid Piril facing it, one hand pressed to the stone. So many hands had been pressed to so many stones these last few days, as if the things attracted human flesh. Why did people feel compelled to touch them?

He heard Piril whisper.

"Protect the innocent, O Arac Semmuru. Protect the children as I was not protected. As I tried and failed to protect my brother."

The murmurs were quiet but heartfelt. Leor wondered if he should offer her some comfort; but what could he say?

If I have compassion, he thought, I don't know what to do with it. I am less use than this old lump of rock.

Walking further round the monolith he paused and gave in to the universal urge, and laid his hand upon the stone. The surface felt rough and gritty, slightly sun-warmed.

Immediately he thought of that chilly day, a few months previously, when he had met Bruilde at her burnt-out farm. She'd been annoyed with him for trespassing although he'd only come to bring her some news or other. He remembered how he'd made an ostentatious effort to repair her charred and shattered wall, breaking the skin of his knuckles on the stones as he picked them up to clunk them heavily into place. When he'd stopped the bleeding, out of habit, he'd sensed that that annoyed Bruilde even more – quite unreasonably. Surely there could no

more innocent employment of his magic than to heal his hurts? He could not heal anyone else's, but why deprive himself of the small relief of allaying his own?

Yet some hurts would not be healed. Forget Bruilde, he told himself. Impossible, once. But it should be easy now she's old and wrinkled... And there, there is my failure of compassion. I admit it. Admitting it is not a virtue.

He was angry with himself, with the stones, with Bruilde for dismissing him – for all the world as if he were the one who had grown old, and not her – and with Piril for her faith that something in this ancient clump of stones would hear her.

He marched around the stone to Piril. "It doesn't live here, you know," he said.

"What doesn't?"

"The Arac Semmuru."

"Maybe not. But something does."

"Really? Spirits may have been gathered here, supposedly. But I don't see any now."

"I have, if you mean those things that Yaret calls the lin, and that I call the bodno. I thought I saw one further back. But then it turned into a rock. Yaret believes the lin have been collected here, and caught, and taken far away," said Piril.

Leor wondered if this might be true – if stonemen could have used this ancient spirit road to catch the lin, and had then carted them away to... somewhere. For some reason. Perhaps for no more than a religious quirk.

Only stonemen did not have quirks. There was no subtlety in them these days; any more than there was in this huge stone. He raised his eyes up its stained and pitted length.

"Oh, look," he said. "There's writing."

"Where?"

"High up. Those marks carved in the surface. Hard to make out under all the lichen."

"Wait a minute," said Piril, and she ran over to one of the carriages that stood outside the circle. A minute later she came back with a long-handled broom. Wetting the bristles in the nearest waters, she raised it to the stone.

"Let me," said Leor. "I have a longer reach." He took the broom from her and scrubbed. With arms extended he could just stretch to the marks. It became apparent that they were letters.

But even once cleaned, he could not read them. Although the angular shapes looked runic, they were not a type of rune he knew. Different scripts for different times, he thought, as he squinted, stretched, and scrubbed some more.

By now his movements were attracting the attention of others, who left their own huge stones to gather around his.

"Didn't know you were so handy with a broom, Leor," remarked Parthenal. He peered up at the stone. "Is that writing? How old is it, do you think?"

"As old as the stones themselves," said Theol.

"Not quite," said Piril. "The letters look too clean and sharp. They're old enough to have grown lichen, but if they were the same age as the stones then surely they would have worn away a lot more than they have."

Leor scrubbed again and stared up at the inscription.

"Oldish," he said. "A century or two. Or three. Or maybe four."

"That's it, is it?" inquired Parthenal. "That's the culmination of your own centuries spent acquiring wisdom? Impressive."

"Well, can *you* read it?" demanded Leor tetchily. He felt annoyed at Parthenal, but even more annoyed at himself.

"You need Tamu," said Yaret. "He's the one for ancient scripts. Where will he be?"

"Huldarion wanted him," said Leor.

"Really? He's more in demand than the rest of us," said Parthenal gloomily.

Leor did not answer. He felt too gloomy himself. It's true, he thought: the archivist is more valuable to Huldarion than I am, for all my magic. There is Tamu consulting with the rightful ruler of Caervonn, and here I am scrubbing an old stone with a broom. And then failing to decipher it.

He put the broom down. "Better call Tamu, then," he said, but there was no need; for Huldarion and his retinue along with Tamu were already walking over to the crowd that had gathered by the stone. The other Riders parted to let them through. Leor did not want this sort of audience.

"What's going on?" asked Solon.

Leor gestured. "There's a carved inscription up there," he said grumpily. "Written on the stone. Runic. Unfamiliar. I can't read it."

Thoronal took a sharp inward breath. "Written on the stone," he repeated. "Do you remember, Huldarion, the stoneman that we captured at the farm? He talked of the old stones. He said, *Our victory is told by the stones.*"

"And then you killed him before he could explain," Huldarion said.

"It was Solon who killed him," objected Thoronal.

"Yes; and you who caused it. Never mind that. It would be useful to find out what this writing says." Huldarion, Leor sensed with some surprise, was anxious. Yet he was not a superstitious man. "Before Kelvha gets here," Huldarion added; for the Kelvhan troop, a few hundred yards away, were making their way over.

"Why? If we can't read it, they can't either," said Thoronal, stiff and sulky.

"We can't be sure of that." Huldarion frowned up at the inscription. "That first word is repeated further on. Tamu? Can you help? Is it familiar to you?"

Tamu frowned up at the stone. "It appears to be a variety of north-eastern Runic, a script long out of use. I can read the words phonetically; but whether I can translate them is a different matter... Give it another scrub, Leor."

Like a dutiful footman, Leor raised the brush and scrubbed diligently at the etched surface. I could use my magic to do this, he thought; or no, perhaps not. For my magic might decide to uproot the whole stone and fling it in the sea to be washed clean.

Tamu stared upwards. Then he began to read.

A breathy tongue, that pulled at a memory deep within Leor, as if these were words he once had known... but no, the memory was gone, like so many others, too distant, too insubstantial: as light as thistledown, soft hushing words carried on the breeze. From the blank faces around him, he guessed that none of the Riders understood it either. Tamu stopped. Nobody spoke.

Then Yaret said, "Could you read it out again, please," and Tamu complied. More thistledown; this time it almost lodged, clinging to Leor's thoughts. And then it was blown away down to the sea and took all sense of meaning with it.

"Can you translate, Tamu?" Huldarion asked. The Kelvhan commander Rhadlun was very close.

Tamu stared upwards, his lips moving, but gave no audible answer.

"Now would be good," said Solon after a few more seconds; but it was too late, for the Kelvhans were walking up to join them.

"Ah! an inscription," said Rhadlun with interest. "Primitive lettering, I see. Is it of consequence?"

"It could be," said Thoronal, "since the stonemen think their victory is written on the stones."

Leor could almost feel the crackle in the air, although Huldarion's face barely changed. Solon raised an eyebrow, while Uld was visibly appalled.

"Written on the stones!" said Rhadlun. "Do they indeed?"

Thoronal seemed to be about to say more. But Uld, next to him, must have kicked his ankle, because he suddenly clamped his mouth closed and stared into the distance.

"Runes, I see," said Rhadlun, all easy arrogance. "Can you read them, master archivist?"

"One moment," said Tamu. "This is an old tongue, little known. I am just working it out."

Rhadlun laughed. "The Lord Huldarion enlisted you in his service for your learning, I assume? Do not fail him now."

Leor's faint jealousy of Tamu's expertise dissolved, to be replaced by profound relief that he himself was not the one on test.

"Well?" said Rhadlun, looking amused. "Whose victory is it to be?"

Tamu licked his lips, and announced in a clear if hesitating voice:

"Triumph comes to the just and righteous; triumph is won... by those... who... who... honour that which they... both rule and serve. I think. There are a couple of words that I am not sure of, but that is certainly the gist of it."

"Triumph to the righteous! No doubt the stonemen interpret that to suit themselves," declared Huldarion. "Doubtless they see their cause as just and righteous."

"Those of them that can read," said Uld.

"I think we need not fear this stony oracle," said Huldarion. "Thank you, Tamu. My lord Rhadlun, will you join us in refreshment? I would like to discuss my plans with you. Uld, Solon; accompany us, if you will." As he moved away he did not look at Thoronal. Much of the crowd dispersed too, their curiosity fading.

"Phew," said Delgeb. "A nice meaningless inscription. I think we dodged an arrow there."

"We did," said Rothir. "Thanks, Tamu. Is that really what those runes say?"

"To the best of my knowledge," Tamu answered.

"Well done, Tamu," said Parthenal; and he smiled down at the little archivist.

"My broom," said Piril curtly to Leor. He handed it over, receiving not a word of thanks.

No word of thanks from anyone. But then why would there be? He had done nothing. He felt as low, as pointless, as superfluous as he ever had in his long life.

Without my magic, I am worthless, Leor thought. Without my magic, I am nothing.

Chapter 26

Yaret was deep in thought. In front of her Tamu and Leor rode on side by side. On previous days she'd seen the two men talking eagerly. Now not a word was exchanged.

She supposed they had as much to think about she did. But then all other thoughts were overtaken by the scene that opened on their left.

A flatness like a cloth stretched tight across a giant loom. At first, a mere grey ruffled fringe along its front. Then as they came closer lacy shades of white appeared; a vast shivering sheet of silk flashed greenish-grey behind. The haze of felted wool on the horizon.

And she could hear it – whisper, whisper; then a long roaring sigh as if some enormous animal were settling down to sleep. Once heard, it was there always. It was like wind in the trees, but there were no trees. She held her breath until the sound returned. Whisper, whisper, sigh.

The Vonnish train had turned west from the standing stones with their interesting inscription, to ride along low sandy cliffs made sharp by grasses and dappled with green dials of some hairy flat-leaved plant. Further on, the cliffs reared up dramatically: on their top a dark uneven outline stood.

Initially Yaret took it for a rocky outcrop, but gradually the shape transformed itself into a building – a large one; very large. By the time they were within two miles of it she guessed it had at least three storeys, and perhaps had once had towers, although its ragged top displayed its ruin.

Despite its impressiveness the Riders did not increase their speed. Instead they slowed, drawn rather to the sea. Huldarion, at the front, pulled up his horse to gaze out at the grey rippling fabric. When he dismounted his councillors did likewise, and they began to scramble down the sandy slope towards the water.

Then the whole army halted, fragmenting into scattered groups who left their carts and horses to meander west along the shore. Like stray invading beasts, they wandered here and there upon the silver strand, while between them small unobtrusive seabirds scooted anxiously away and then rose up in curving flocks to skim the waves and circle round in wide arcs before settling down again.

Yaret walked over to the sea's nudging, whispering edge. The shore was long enough for there to be no sense of crowdedness. Behind her birds swung effortlessly on the breeze: above her, pile on luminous pile of thick white cloud climbed up like layered branches of snow-laden trees: and in between, just this, a shifting world of subtle cloth transformed to water. She stood on pale sand, watching pebbles being drowned and buried and refound a dozen times a minute by the murmuring sea.

All other things were gone, washed out of mind. Her current nagging worry, about that giant stone, had lost its urgency. If her dead had stood behind her shoulder for much of the long journey, on this wide shore she felt them step aside and look out, as she did, upon the endless grey. Together they put aside their burdens of resolve and grief, and watched the evasive pliancy of water, both wide awake and dreaming. The melding hues tugged at her gaze, drawing themselves back and back until she was not certain which was sea and which was sky.

She felt her breathing slow to match the soft unhurried pulsing of the waves. For her and her imagined gazing dead it felt like journey's end. Obandiro slept. She knew there was still far to go; yet to this place and to this moment she belonged, and it to her, and so she felt her mind relax at last. The water spoke to her and though she did not know the words she understood the meaning. *Here I am. This place is now. This time is always.*

After a while she turned her head and saw Rothir was watching her.

"It's so flat," she said, although the surface was tufted with white feathers where the wind plucked at it, and further out the extraordinary plain of sea swelled as if some submerged hill were waiting underneath.

Rothir smiled. "You like it?"

"Like is the wrong word," she said, "but yes."

"Look at them," he said indulgently, "those children," and he nodded to the group of Riders twenty yards away. Theol and Sashel and some others were stripping off their shirts and boots, and finally their breeches, so that clad only in their linen underbreeches they ran towards the waves and dashed themselves in. She heard their cries, as staccato as those of the seabirds wheeling overhead.

"Is it allowed?" she asked.

"I don't think Huldarion will try to stop them. He doesn't seem to mind, as far as I can tell from here."

"It's good to see Sashel looking happier. He's romping like a nine year old," she said, for Sashel was trying to duck Theol, unsuccessfully. "They remind me of the boys in Obandiro. Mind, Sashel isn't much more than a boy himself."

"You think so?"

"Are you going to join them?" Yaret asked.

Rothir shook his head. But then he bent, pulled off his boots, and rolled his breeches up above his knees before he waded off into the shallow water.

She watched his legs, strong against the gleam of waves. Then she pulled off her own boots and hose and stuffed them in her saddlepack before she walked into the water after him. The wooden foot was not exactly ugly, but it was odd. Not quite a foot; more like an elongated hoof, she thought, as if she were half human and half some peculiar beast. A chimera.

Once she was standing in the waves, however – so cold, and surprisingly forceful in their heave and pull – that hoof was hidden, from anybody else, at least. Looking down at it she saw around her mismatched feet another set of waves: the underwater ripples of the sand picked out in silver laced with charcoal. There was an impelling rhythm in that pattern. It would look good in cloth, she thought, if only you could weave it in. But difficult to replicate those curves, those waves, the way the ocean did so effortlessly. A twill, maybe, but with variable stepping, if you could just work out how to modify the harnesses.

"I wonder how you could set waves on a loom," she said, but thankfully Rothir did not hear through the swish and hiss of the real sea.

Further down the beach more Riders were discarding garments and starting to wade in. Zan and a couple of loben hunters were egging each other on loudly: Zan, who had suffered the same deep loss as she had, was now seen laughing for the first time in her experience. Even Tamu stood ankle-deep with shoes in hand. Felbe pushed Nerobe, who pitched in fully clothed and then leapt out to chase Felbe with enthusiastic glee and pull her down into the waves in turn. There were shrieks and splashing arms. A welter of new sea-creatures.

Elsewhere, others hunted for flat stones to skim across the water. A herd of horses, now let loose, trotted experimentally along the water's fringe, seeming to enjoy the wet smack of their hooves: Poda, freed of duties, tossed her head and frisked with Narba on the sand.

There was no lack of space for all this revelry. The splashes and the shrieks were lost amidst the cries of countless seabirds and the shifting vastness of the sea. A hundred yards along the beach, Huldarion stood next to Meya, looking back at his Riders, apparently indulgent of their play.

Nearer by, small flocks of birds were pecking at the shore, almost invisible until some boisterous human came too close. Then the flock would snap abruptly into view, scuttling to

the shoreline before all the birds took off and as if connected by invisible threads swirled just above the waves, wingtips almost touching, to land again a little further on. An endless dance.

She looked down at the world beneath the water. A tiny crab terrorising tinier fish. Shells: pretty things. She scooped them up and watched the water drip from pink and orange whorls. Once they were half-dry she put them in her pocket. Sea shells were unknown in Obandiro, so these would be rare treasures for the children.

And such smooth pebbles! Even smoother than the river pebbles that collected underneath the Dondel Bridge, their colours livelier. She plucked out one: an oval, crimson-grey with a white band running round it like a belt.

"Look," she said to Rothir.

He looked and smiled. "You'll find better. That one's not perfect."

"It doesn't need to be perfect," she replied, "just interesting." She put it in her pocket with the shells. But she kept searching for a better one; or for one that Rothir would consider better.

"Look," she said again after a moment, "this one is like an egg. Pure white. Laid by some sea monster far out in the deep, no doubt, and washed up to the shore."

Again he smiled. This time he took the stone and turned it in his hand. "I wonder what it will hatch into."

"A stone serpent, about this long. It will bite holes in your pockets."

"I'll risk it."

She watched him slide it in his pocket. The sea brushed past them like a cool breath, a warm wind, a kindly memory. She wished the moments could be hours; the hours days; the days forever.

"It's odd," she said, hearing her words be washed by the waves. "How it sinks into you."

"It is odd," said Rothir, gazing out across the flecked grey-blue and silver. "I seldom come to the sea and yet it always feels like home."

"Home is where," said Yaret, and stopped.

He looked at her. "Home is what?"

"Nothing."

He turned to look away again, seeking the horizon. But she heard the sentence carried on the waves, an echo from that stone sea inside the Uin-Buin Hills, in the heart of the Fioronhall; the shimmering voices that had circled round the cavern.

Home is where you are. The words washed in and settled round her like a flock of birds. So many meanings held within them.

Home is where you are, Rothir, she thought. Home for you is here, and nowhere. Home for me is nowhere too. But it is where you are. The sea sinks into me, and so do you. You are written on my heart and eyes and ears and body, though you do not know it.

I have known it for a long time. And now, here, on this abandoned shore at the end of the Red Roads, I have to face it. You are the reason I am here, so far from my own people. I told myself that it was for the dead, but it was also for the living. For one man.

Home is where you are. Without you where would I be now? Alone and lost.

The waves washed over her feet as if performing some insistent service. She had no idea what Rothir was feeling. But it was unlikely to be anything like her. Dreams of Caervonn, maybe, some glowing long-anticipated future that did not have her in it. She could not stay in Caervonn. She had to go back. And even if his feelings were the same as hers, he could not desert Caervonn for Obandiro.

So there it was. And how absurd to think she would be lost without him. She wouldn't be alone; she would still have friends, a purpose and a future. She would make her future for herself. Nothing had changed.

Yet everything had changed. Was continually changing. And here she was, standing with him at the world's end, at the border of unfathomable mystery.

At last he sighed and turned away.

"Look," he said, "even Gaelera is joining in the fun."

She looked across to where Gaelera stood, having waded a few yards into the sea. Oddly, she had not bothered to lift her skirts, which lay resting just beneath the surface; unheeded waves lapped at the embroideries.

"Like a jellyfish," said Rothir.

"What's a jellyfish?"

"Although on second thoughts, anyone less like a jellyfish than Gaelera is hard to imagine. A sea-turtle maybe, with her carapace."

"I suppose she's enjoying herself," said Yaret doubtfully, for Gaelera stood quite rigid in her sodden, floating skirts and gazed out to sea with a perfectly blank face. Behind her, on the shore, Maeneb jiggled and winced as if she felt she ought to follow her and didn't want to. "Maeneb won't like the sand between her toes," she added.

"Do you like it?"

Yaret nodded. While her feet were hidden he had probably forgotten that she only had five toes, not ten. So let him forget, she thought, forget all troubles, all responsibilities, for a while. It was a joy for her to see him so at ease.

"Weird, isn't it? This sea thing."

"What?" She turned towards the new speaker. Her heart sank; for it was Inthed, her least favourite of all the men of Gostard with whom she'd ridden into battle.

At least there was no risk of him trying to put his hand down her breeches here, in Rothir's company – and moreover in the presence of his burly captain, Jerred. Him she was glad to see. Jerred managed to look more like an old soldier every time she met him, even with his boots thrown round his shoulders by their laces and stout scarred legs planted firmly in the waves.

"Weird, isn't it?" repeated Inthed. "And it's only water. Moves about a lot, though."

"It's known for it," said Rothir, with amused civility.

"How are you, Jerred? Inthed?" she asked the pair.

"We're good enough," said Jerred. "Apart from wondering what we're doing here, dibbling for crabs at the land's end. You wouldn't happen to know the answer, would you?"

"You must think me very close with Huldarion if he would tell me that. No doubt he has his reasons," said Yaret, and she looked at Rothir, who merely looked inscrutable.

"Ah well," said Jerred. "Not that I'm complaining. Just not what I expected."

"Think I'll sign up for a soldier, if this is all there is to it," said Inthed, grinning.

"Enjoy it while it lasts," advised Rothir.

"Oh, I will, I will. A little paddle and a nice hot dinner, that's the life. A long way from the mud of Melmet, aren't we, Yaret? A long way indeed."

"Don't worry, Inthed," said Jerred, "your debtors back home won't have forgotten you."

"But I thought Yaret might have. She's hardly come over to say hallo since then. Me and Yaret, we've got history together," announced Inthed to Rothir. "I saved her life once."

"I'm not sure about that," said Yaret.

"Ah, how can you deny it? And after you told me that I fought well! Don't you remember how grateful you were?"

"It's true you fought well when you weren't busy making a nuisance of yourself," she said, and Jerred laughed.

Rothir said, more seriously, "How did he make a nuisance of himself, Yaret?"

"It's not important." Because Rothir was giving Inthed a long, hard look. In one way it was gratifying. But she wished Inthed would leave.

Inthed held his hands up. "All right! I know when I'm not wanted. Until you need me to save your life again. You might do, with that wooden leg."

"As I remember, we all saved each other's lives several times," she answered a touch wearily. "And Jerred saved the most."

"My pleasure," said Jerred, and winked at her. "Ignore the turnip-head. He's actually slowly turning into some semblance of a man. Make a good scarecrow one of these days."

"I'm sure," said Yaret, although other epithets for Inthed sprang to mind. But there was no need to insult him.

Jerred looked at Rothir. "You don't need to worry about my idiot friend."

"I don't," said Rothir.

"Good. Hang on to that one," said Jerred. "Peg leg or no. Come on, hero."

The two men wandered off, kicking sand at each other, and left Yaret feeling embarrassed. Staring out to sea again, with all its undeniable weirdness, she both wished and feared that Rothir would make some comment. He did not.

"Oh, there's Parthenal," she said. "Enjoying a swim." Parthenal had stripped off and thrown himself into the water behind Theol and the others, but without their laughter. He swam with fast and practised skill, up and down the line of waves, before returning to the shallows and emerging dripping. Yaret glanced at that well-honed body and the clinging under-breeches. Parthenal undressed was a banquet for the eyes.

Not that Parthenal himself would care. He was glowering as he strode back up the shore and picked up his shirt to dry himself. So he had not forgotten all his troubles, whatever they might be.

"What's he so cross about?" she asked.

Rothir gazed over at his friend. "I'm not quite sure," he said, "but I expect he'll sort it out. He usually does."

"Perhaps you should talk to him."

"I do. Quite frequently. But I can't solve his problems for him."

"Do you even ask him what they are?" she countered.

"I've a fairly good idea what at least one of his problems is," said Rothir drily, "and I have no intention of solving that one for him."

Again she was embarrassed, and turned her head away. "There's Tamu over there, looking lonely," she said. "I'll go and say hallo. I like Tamu."

She walked towards him through the water. Rothir did not follow, but strolled over to Parthenal who was pulling on his wet shirt with angry jerks. She saw Rothir say something casually; to which his friend snapped out some sharp reply.

As she waded through the shallows, the water now felt almost warm. Its pull at her legs was like the tugging of an eager dog. She noticed that Tamu too was surreptitiously watching Parthenal, although as soon as he saw Yaret he looked down at the frilled ridges of the lapping waves. He bent to touch one as if stroking it.

"It's hard not to think of it as alive," she said, when she was close enough to speak. "Have you visited the sea before?"

"Once. When I was a boy," said Tamu. He was not as shy with her as with some others. "It was far west of here. But that was a rocky, even dangerous beach. It wasn't like this one."

It occurred to her that Tamu had led a rocky, even dangerous life; especially if she was correct in her surmises. Kelvha would have been a perilous place indeed. He would have grown extremely used to subterfuge.

She splashed over to stand next to him. "About that stone," she said. "The inscription you read out for us." Nobody was within earshot. Even if they had been, the waves would have drowned her words for anybody else.

"What about it?" said Tamu with caution.

"How old do you think it really was?"

"Oh... it's hard to tell. Certainly not as old as the stones themselves. Those sort of runes were in use three to five hundred years ago. So somewhere in that period."

"Three to five hundred," said Yaret.

"Yes."

"I see." The thought that had been worrying her since they had left the stones now returned with force. She tried to frame it into a question. "Tamu, when you read the runes—"

"What's that over there?" Tamu raised his head and was staring out to sea. She thought: he's trying to change the subject. But when she stared out the same way, she was baffled too by what she saw.

"I don't know," she murmured. "But I don't understand the sea. Maybe this is something that it does."

"Swelling up like that? Is it a wave?"

Some distance out, she could not tell how far – a half mile? a full mile, maybe even two? – the surface of the sea had risen in a bulge. A thin mist drifted just above it as it heaved and streamed, a shining hill of water.

"Could it be a whale?" she asked.

"I don't know. I suppose so."

Several Riders stood up straighter to look out. Rothir and Parthenal gazed together, shading their eyes. A burial barrow, thought Yaret, but made of water, not of earth. Around it the waves flickered like brief ashen flames. A flock of seabirds that had been resting on the surface took flight and swept up in a long dark smoke above the swollen sea.

"I've read about giant waves," muttered Tamu. "Very destructive. If that's one, we should retreat."

Some of the bathing Riders were already retreating, wading to the shore with backward glances. Like Tamu, Yaret stepped back out of the water. Her feet felt oddly heavy on the sand – even the wooden foot that always made Rothir flinch.

But there she paused; for the mound of water was gradually falling. The surface stilled, rippling only with small ordinary waves. Whatever had been beneath it remained as yet unborn; they looked out on a level field of sea that stretched back to the sky.

"A whale, I suppose," said Tamu, sounding a little shaken. "The sea is a strange place." He began to trudge away from her, shoes in hand.

"Tamu. Wait. Please. There's something else I need to say, about that stone."

He took a few more steps before he paused and waited, still turned away.

So she spoke to his back. "When you read those runes, Tamu, you made up the meaning."

It came out more bluntly than she'd planned. Tamu spun round to look at her with shock and fear.

"No, I didn't."

"Yes, you did. I don't blame you, Tamu. I would have done the same. They were all waiting for you to translate the carving, and it needed to say something harmless."

"That is a baseless accusation," he said forcefully. "You're guessing."

"I'm not guessing," said Yaret. "I know it. Because when you read the runes aloud, I understood the words."

He stared at her. "What? How could you? It was a completely unknown language. Nobody there could understand it – that was obvious."

"Oh, they could have," she said. "If the Ioben hunters had been there, they would have recognised it. I'm surprised that Leor didn't, because I think he knew it once. It was Bandiran, or a language rather like it: an antique version."

Tamu's expression was one of pure dismay. "Bandiran?" he breathed. "Your tongue?" She nodded.

"What did it mean? What did the inscription say?" He was apprehensive.

So she hastened to reassure him. "Don't worry, it said nothing dreadful. Nothing about victory to the stonemen, or to the righteous either. That was a good attempt you made, but it was off the mark. You translated *Wolathu* as *triumph*, didn't you? But *Wolathu* was a person."

"A person?" said Tamu blankly.

"The stone said: *Wolathu is the owner of these lands. To Wolathu is due tribute from those who wish to travel north of this mark and west of the hills.* Effectively, the inscription's just saying *Watch out, Wolathu lives here.*"

"Who's *Wolathu*?"

"I don't know. I'm guessing some tribal chief four or five hundred years ago."

Tamu let out an audible breath, almost a groan of relief. Then he said, "I had to tell them something. Inscriptions can be very dangerous things. I've been made all too aware of that... Don't tell anybody else!"

"No, I won't. But Tamu, what worries me is not the meaning. That's mundane enough. But why is it in Bandiran? How is that possible? The Bandiran live hundreds of miles northwards – and we migrated there from further north again. How could any of my kinsfolk have been so far south, here at the end of the Red Roads, by the sea?"

Chapter 27

Parthenal had thought the sea-water would refresh him. He wanted to be cleansed, rinsed free of all unneeded troublesome desires. Instead the swim had left him with a faintly sticky feeling; his skin felt dry and salty, and there were grains of sand inside his breeches and his shirt, and especially his boots which he had already emptied twice since departing from the beach. What should have been a pleasure had unwanted consequences.

Now all the Riders had dried and dressed themselves and were leading their horses westward atop the slowly rising cliffs. Previously they'd only been three yards above the sea; now they were twenty. And still the Riders climbed while the waves crawled down beneath them. Every so often Parthenal looked out at that moving tapestry of blue, green, grey, white: but it reared up in no gradual swelling mound as it had done before.

"Landel says it was a whale," said Rigal, also looking out. "He got quite excited. I hope it rises properly. I've never seen a whale."

"Hmm," said Parthenal. He didn't believe the whale theory. The phenomenon had most likely been some trick of the waves over hidden rocks; probably needing a certain set of tides. He was unsure how tides and currents worked and didn't really care in any case.

"Look, there it is!" Rigal pointed eagerly: not out to sea, but along the cliff.

"I know," said Parthenal, glancing unimpressed at the large edifice, a mile away as yet, which had unmistakably become a building. "Did stonemen put that up?" he asked sceptically. "A thing of that size and complexity would be beyond them."

"I'd guess the stonemen were more capable back then, before they learnt to drug themselves," said Tiburé.

"Back when?" demanded Parthenal. "How old is this place supposed to be?"

"I'm not sure. Huldarion might know; or Tamu."

Parthenal found himself upset to hear the two men spoken of as equivalent in wisdom. He liked Tamu, certainly, and it seemed that everyone had started turning to him for odd bits of information; but to compare him to Huldarion!

However, Theol was already saying, "There's Tamu, over there. Let's ask him. Hey, Tamu!" He waved and beckoned. Tamu, who had been following a parallel path further from the edge, rode over reluctantly. Parthenal wondered if it was the cliff the man was anxious to avoid, or Parthenal himself. He still had an idea that the archivist admired him. Well, many men admired him. He felt a vague awareness that he did little to deserve it.

But it happened. Therefore he smiled on Tamu and saw the involuntary flicker of his eyelids. So his power had not deserted him: the power to draw men, the power to ignite desire.

It caused an inward grin; that fierce, familiar anticipation. All the same, his power was best not exercised on Tamu. Look for another recipient...

He glanced past Tamu, to where the train of Kelvhans followed their own path some fifty yards inland. There was Jaul. No, not him. If Jaul were to approach him he would laugh in his face; and then would turn his back with proud contempt.

But some of the others. That soldier he had noticed yesterday, with the scar along his cheekbone: that scar spoke to him. If the man were but a poor substitute for Huldarion, what of it? Everyone was a poor substitute. He sighed.

"How old is that building, Tamu, do you know?" Theol was asking.

Tiburé put in, "Your ancient merchant wrote about this settlement, did he not?"

Tamu nodded. "Yes, yes. It's the, it's what he called the Place of Terns. My merchant – that is, the Kelvhan merchant – reported it four hundred years ago."

"What sort of place was it?" asked Tiburé.

"A town, it seems, but centred round a, round a monastery and with at least one temple. Several temples. Maybe, maybe, a temple complex."

Parthenal wondered, is his nervousness because of me? It is my presence? When he looked back at the archivist he saw how the man's brown eyes dropped to stare at his horse's reins.

"So that's where the early stonemen lived," mused Rothir.

"And somewhere round here must be where they found the ingredients for Athelid," said Yaret. "Tamu's merchant said they dug it up from drains and ditches; I remember that."

"I don't feel inclined to dig in any drains and ditches at the moment," said Parthenal.

"Not before bedtime," agreed Theol. "Perhaps we'll sleep tonight with a roof above our heads, instead of having to put up the tents, or lie underneath the stars."

"I like the stars," said Yaret.

"Stars won't keep the rain off. Look at those clouds out to sea. That's a storm a-brewing."

"Then let us hope this monastery has a roof," said Tiburé, "or it won't keep the rain off either."

Theol grinned at her. "Ah, but it's bound to be cosier than a tent." The two of them exchanged a look of some shared knowledge.

Parthenal could not bear it. Leaving the group, he steered Alba to a less level path where he didn't have to talk to anyone. He studied the building on the cliff as it drew closer: the long curve of the bay allowed a good view of its seaward side. It was a much longer building than it had appeared at first. The vast wall that faced the sea was dotted with numerous small windows. Although its roofline was broken, much of the structure appeared to be intact. Certainly it was not derelict.

But now as they swerved inland he could see more ruins. A whole phantom town was gradually becoming visible – for these walls were no more than outlines on the ground, mere shadows of the buildings that once stood there. Few of the walls were more than a foot high. Between them were broad walkways, their cobbles almost totally concealed by grass.

The army dismounted to progress along these ancient cobbled ways, some taking one track, some another. But all paths ended at the centre of the ruined town, where there stood the foundations of a large building. Here the broken walls were in some places five or six feet high: enough remained to hold the shapes of former windows, or at least their bases.

To Parthenal the ruins had the sense of a lost grandeur. This had once been an important place. A palace, or a temple? Who might have walked here? Priests or kings?

No people now. Instead, inside the stony frame were four shaped stones, appearing small after the recent monoliths that he had passed although they were each longer than a man. Three lay flat; one leaned askew amidst the grass and thistles which were made both trim and odorous by nibbling goats. A warmish, wettish wind blew indecisively.

In the midst of these ruins Huldarion paused to gaze around. He seemed imperturbable, though Meya, alongside him, looked disconsolate.

This is no court for a king, thought Parthenal: what is this place that he has brought us to, this heap of stones at the dunce's corner of the world?

It crossed his mind with shocking speed that the setting was entirely suitable for such a king – crownless, landless, ruined, exiled. Appalled at himself, he thrust the thought away.

"I think this place has been deliberately demolished. It was a very fine temple once, well-built; it wouldn't have fallen down all on its own." That was Leor, who had ridden up to him.

"Demolished by who?" growled Parthenal, miserable and tetchy.

"Its former owners, I presume, who had no further use for it."

"So they destroyed it."

"Their modes of living and beliefs had changed," said Leor sombrely. He looked out past the shattered walls. "There were once farms here, around the town. Oats and barley. I see the fruit groves have all disappeared."

"You've been here before? But you didn't recognise the Red Roads?"

"I came around the coastline. So I missed the standing stones." Leor's terseness told him that the wizard's discontent was equal to his own.

"What happened here, Leor? Why was the place abandoned?"

"Oh... Too far from everywhere. And too much salt here for the farms to thrive. They would insist on growing the wrong types of crop. They'd have been better off with rye and cabbages. I told them so."

"I expect that went down well," said Parthenal. "How long ago are you speaking of?"

"Over a hundred years. More like two."

"We're talking about the stonemen, aren't we?"

"Yes. In the days when they simply wore their stones in headbands and not drilled into their skulls."

"And did they back then coat the stones with resin from the skeln trees?"

"So I believe," said Leor.

"Yet there were no darkburns for the resin to repel."

"They valued skeln trees none the less, although I really don't know why. I just know they used them in their worship," said Leor mournfully. "There used to be a grove of skeln just over there, beyond that wall."

Parthenal looked. "I can't see any."

"No. They all died long ago. The people cut them down and buried the dead branches with great ceremony in this very temple." Leor sighed heavily. "Everything was different then. It's all changed."

"I can't imagine stonemen worshipping anything," said Parthenal, "apart from blood and death. I don't see why Huldarion has brought us all this way to nowhere."

Again, as he spoke, he was horrified at his own disloyalty. Ever since the exile from Caervonn a dozen years ago he had followed Huldarion unquestioningly; his faith in his chief's wisdom had never been in doubt.

Keep faith, keep faith, he told himself in desperation. Huldarion will have his reasons even if he does not choose to tell them.

And indeed Huldarion did not seem to be dismayed – unlike Meya. He saw her speak to Huldarion: saw him shake his head, and reach out one hand to take hers, while the other hand pointed to the sea, to the long building on the cliffs. Parthenal imagined that conversation:

And have you brought me here to camp with goats and seagulls?

Patience, my dear, my new-beloved. For there is a palace awaiting on the cliff-top, where we may rest in one another's arms...

"Some palace," he muttered.

"Mm? What was that?"

But at another gesture from Huldarion, several Riders mounted their horses to head towards the building on the cliff-top. At once Parthenal retrieved Alda and cantered after them, desperate for activity.

The long building rose before him, darkly imposing underneath its shattered roof. A monastery, Tamu had said: Parthenal supposed that it was possible, although it was hard to imagine stonemen requiring such a place. Apart from its topmost course of ragged stone it was mostly still intact. Well-built, he acknowledged, and standing in a good position: from the roof-top, one would have a long and sweeping view of both the sea and land.

He pulled his horse up next to Ikelder's while they scanned the building. It was constructed of large blocks of a reddish sandstone. Three storeys high, it had two wings set at right angles, dotted with many small, square windows. Seagulls wheeled overhead with wails like grieving ghosts. Parthenal had never liked the sound of seagulls. They did nothing but complain.

"A handsome place," Ikelder said. "Let's take a look inside."

They walked up the wide flight of steps that led to the frontage, the broad stones underfoot planed into hollows by the tread of countless feet. At the top they were confronted with a choice of doorways: one at each end, and one in the centre. Since other Riders were venturing in at either end, Parthenal made for the central doorway. Its door was still present – a splintered slab of wood on rusty hinges that leaned crookedly open.

"Careful," said Ikelder from behind him. "The place may still be occupied."

"By mice, perhaps," said Parthenal. "I don't think anyone has been here for a while."

Just inside the door he found a large porch, or small lobby, partly open to the sky, with a sand-strewn floor: he pointed out to Ikelder that there were no footprints on the sand, merely a liberal speckling of gull droppings.

Then he crossed it, feeling the fretful wind tug at him, and entered another doorway into a short passage. This quickly opened out into a larger hall lit by high windows and scoured by a stiff breeze. On either side of the hall were long straight corridors that stretched away in both directions; at their far ends he glimpsed spiralling flights of stairs.

As he walked down the corridor to his right his feet echoed softly. He passed further entrances, some still with doors and some without. Peering into one of these, he saw a little room – perhaps once a monk's cell, empty but for a drift of sand upon the floor. A window looked onto the Riders gathering outside. There was Huldarion, very small and distant, framed by the thick stone wall.

He went out again and tried a doorway opposite: this had a closed wooden door, cracked but still solid. It opened more easily than he expected, as though it had been in recent use. He stepped inside and looked around.

The cell had been occupied in the last year or two, he thought. It held a bed – a straw mattress on a roped frame. A wooden cupboard, empty. On the cupboard, a large bowl made of rough brown pottery, slightly crazed, but clean and dry.

It was like a parody of his over-decorated bedroom back in Kelvha Castle. That room where he had so nearly accepted Jaul's alluring invitation...

But he had not succumbed. He had not failed Huldarion. And this room was nothing like that one. No rugs, no fine mosaic wall, no spyhole. It had a window – unglazed – that looked out south on to the waves: so thick were the walls that the small square view of sky and sea appeared very far away, seen down a tunnel of stone. But he could hear the breathing of the sea.

And now he heard voices. Leaving the room he found the other Riders opening doors and poking into cells.

"This could well have been a monastery," remarked Ikelder. "What worries me is that it doesn't seem to be too long deserted. Those straw mattresses must be this year's: they smell fresh."

Parthenal nodded. "I agree. Though I wasn't aware that there were monks amongst the stonemen," he said drily.

"I think we need not look for monks." Huldarion stood at the end of the passage. Meya was beside him, gazing around keenly. "The days when this was a monastery are long past. But I think trainees of some sort, perhaps, could have lived here... Young stonemen, maybe. Scour the building. Make sure there are no inhabitants remaining."

Parthenal nodded and joined in the search. Along with half a dozen others, he explored the central section. Three dozen cells, all empty. Most held mattresses: he sniffed at them, with caution. Ikelder had been right about the straw. But there were no other signs of recent habitation.

He went to the right-hand staircase and ran up the stone stairs. On the next floor was a chain of interconnecting chambers, all completely empty but for a few warped benches and a number of flat bluish stones lined up against the walls. Each was half the size of a man, and carved with lines and intersecting spirals. Perhaps they had been used in some long-forgotten ritual.

Another stair, another floor. Here was a further series of long chambers, many of them roofless and empty, the stained floors thick with bird droppings. He looked up at a haze of blue and a circle of high-wheeling birds. The neighbouring rooms on this level, however, still had some roofing, perhaps recently repaired: for these had evidently been used as dormitories. Each held up to thirty rudimentary beds, slatted wooden bunks and truckles – free of mattresses and despite the space none of them looking as comfortable as the small cells lower down. The windows were too high to offer any view.

To his surprise, in the largest of these dormitories he saw beneath a bed a mildewed book. When he bent down to retrieve it the pages were damp and pulpy, the faded writing barely visible.

“Who would have thought stonemen could read?” he said, turning to the group of Riders who had come in after him. One of them was Huldarion. He felt his heart turn over.

“May I see?”

In the act of passing him the book, their fingers touched. Another roiling turn of the heart. It made Parthenal feel sick.

“It’s old,” he said.

“Indeed. Some sort of prayer book, I suspect; presumably a relic of those early days before the stonemen changed.” Huldarion leafed carefully through the damp pages, and then laughed involuntarily, before he winced and shook his head.

“What is it?” Parthenal asked.

Huldarion held out the open book. Someone had been drawing in it, in charcoal: grinning faces with big eyes and wide smiles. A whole set of them. They were carefully yet crudely drawn, like children’s pictures.

“Hah,” said Parthenal. “Those look quite fresh. No artists, are they?”

“No.” Huldarion turned the page. Another face, with two stones sticking out; no grin. A bird with unfeasibly straight wings. A fish; no, possibly a dolphin. Lots of scribbling.

“That looks like someone trying to write, without understanding how,” commented Parthenal.

“It does.” Huldarion closed the book and placed it gently on the bed. So gently.

Parthenal turned away. He needed to do something, anything. Striding back to the staircase he ran up the last, narrow flight of stairs, which spiralled into increasing daylight until he came out on the roof.

A flagstoned walkway led around its edge, appearing sound for much of the roof’s circumference although the towers along it had been toppled. He walked a little way and stood looking down over the battered parapet. The air was still and sultry. Beneath him the sea clawed idly with long white fingers at the cliff’s base, growling as it did so. The birds mewed sulkily in answer. Was there a path down that steep rocky slope? If so, it was not visible. Whoever had once lived in those dormitories could no more escape from the high windows than they could see from them.

But no-one lived here now. It felt abandoned. He ran back down the flights of smooth-worn stone to the bottom floor. Here he lost his way out and unexpectedly found himself in a long low-ceilinged dining hall. Plain stone pillars formed four aisles, running parallel to the great fireplace set into the wall. On either side of the hearth were benches, some stacked or even thrown on top of one another, several broken; as were many of the trestle tables pushed against the wall. Piles of pottery stood in the fireplace – chipped plates and bowls.

The plates were empty but for grime and mouse-droppings. The fireplace was cold. But there was a cauldron hanging forlornly from its chains above the ashes; and Meya was prodding in it with a wooden spoon.

She looked up at him. “Long-congealed,” she said. “I think it was once a stew of beans and barley and some sort of fish. There are fishbones. It’s at least a few weeks old, more likely months.” She held up the wooden spoon, with a dried unappetising lump of something sticking to it.

“Tasty,” answered Parthenal with a grimace. In fact it sounded disconcertingly similar to their own rations; substitute mutton for the fish and add a few impromptu greens, and it was much like the meals that his company’s designated cook would serve up nightly.

“Serviceable food,” said Meya. “But there is a lack of ovens here. I should like to see the kitchen, if there is a separate one.” She sounded, not depressed and impatient as Parthenal expected, but interested. “There must be pantries,” she went on. “I wonder if there will be any food remaining in them?”

“Now that would be worth finding out,” said Parthenal, and he began to scout around for a kitchen. It was quickly discovered through a side door and down several steps. There was one main kitchen and three pantries, each a few steps further down, so that the last was underground.

The kitchen held a set of ovens and shelves of more brown pottery. There was only one cooking pan, which was full of some burnt food.

“They must have taken all the other pans,” Meya observed. “Pans are essential for a travelling army, of course. Whereas pottery is just dead weight.” She bustled down the steps and Parthenal hurried after her in case of lurking stonemen, or simply an uneven floor.

“Take care, my lady,” he cautioned. Although he did not much like Meya, he did not want to be responsible for any injury to her.

She halted in the lowest pantry. “Very good,” she said approvingly, peering into the shadows. “A well-appointed larder. It smells as if both meat and fish were here, some time ago.”

“And rats,” said Parthenal, noting their traces. Rats had been in both the other pantries too; their droppings decorated empty shelves. A limp sack on the floor leaked a last few husks. No grain remained, nothing edible at all except a pair of cheeses on a stone shelf which Parthenal approached and then rapidly retreated from.

“Whew. It’s not just fish that’s causing that appalling smell. Even the rats won’t touch these,” he commented, “although I expect Yaret would eat them up with glee.”

“The foreigner? Strange tastes,” said Meya. “I’m afraid there’s nothing here of any use to us.” She stood in the middle of the pantry, looking a little sad.

“We did not really expect it,” said Parthenal. “We’re not short of provisions.”

“No. We stocked up well at Olbeth’s farm.” Meya stared at the empty sack. “I do hope she’s all right.”

“Olbeth?” But Parthenal immediately corrected himself. Of course she was not thinking about Olbeth. “Your daughter is being well-looked after,” he told her reassuringly. “Olbeth is a very capable and kind young woman.”

“Of that I am sure,” said Meya sadly.

"And now that Veron is recovered, your daughter has another capable protector. I would back Veron against a whole company of stonemen."

"And yet," said Meya, "they have now seen fit to move her, to some other place, some other farm, one called Deloran."

Parthenal was silent. He could hardly argue that Deloran was a suitable home for a small soon-to-be princess. Burnt out and roofless as it was, by all accounts, would it be any better than this place? Probably much less comfortable.

Meya sighed. "Huldarion seems to think this building may have once housed children," she said musingly. "I don't know why he thinks so."

"Upstairs there are dormitories, with bunks and truckle beds."

"Are there?"

"If this was indeed a monastery, they were for novices, perhaps."

"Ah. Yes. I wish that I could see her," she said softly.

"Soon," said Parthenal.

"Maybe. I have no idea. I do not know exactly what Huldarion plans."

"Whatever his plans, they will be wise ones."

Meya turned to look at him. "You are a good and loyal soldier, Parthenal. My father would have admired you, I think. Huldarion is fortunate to have you as a henchman. It sounds as if more carriages are turning up outside. Those Kelvhans have arrived, perhaps; I'd better go and see."

She nodded and left Parthenal standing in the shadows amidst the smell of ancient cheese.

I know all that, he thought, I know that I am a good and faithful warrior; though I am surprised that she acknowledges it. Generous of her. A soldier's daughter. An eye for detail, for how things are organised. In other circumstances I could possibly grow to like her.

But, *but*: a henchman. I am a henchman. A squire, a bodyguard, a hanger-on. I hang on and on and what for, in the end? Huldarion will marry Meya and I will always be a henchman.

Chapter 28

The new home smelt of smoke. Aliya was not sure why, because there was no proper fireplace.

There was no proper anything. She was in a house inside a house. The outside house was made of stone, all black and cracked and ugly. It had high thick walls but no roof on top.

The inside house was much smaller, and it was made of wood, in a hotchy-potchy sort of way. It was a bit like the house she had tried to build for the little somethings, only bigger: it looked as if parts had fallen down or were about to fall down. The walls were planks and sticks with mud crammed in the cracks, and tiny windows made in funny shapes. The whole house was a funny shape. It was high at one end and low at the other as if the person building it had forgotten what they were doing. It made her giggle.

"Well, I'm glad someone's happy," said Flodda.

"I like this house," Aliya said. She hadn't paid attention to it until now, because she'd been too tired yesterday after a long time of being shaken in the cart. All she had wanted to do was eat and sleep. She hadn't taken any notice of the strange arrangement of the houses, one inside the other.

Her bed was not inside the wooden house. It was tucked against the wall of the old stone outside house, where the smell of smoke was strongest. She thought she might have been sleeping in a kitchen fireplace, although she didn't know why, except that it was quite big and had a chimney bit to cover it. There was enough room for Flodda to sleep in there with her.

But right now she was inside the hotchy-potchy inside house, where Olbeth and Camburé were sitting on two little stools. Olbeth was nursing the baby. She turned round and said,

"Hello, Aliya. Did you sleep well?"

"Yes, thank you. Is my bed an old fireplace?"

"It is."

"Why?"

"Because you're the little rabbit, cooking on the fire," said Camburé. Aliya did not think this was at all funny so she gave her a sternish look.

"Because this wooden shack won't hold all of us," said Olbeth. "If it rains, you can squeeze in here, underneath the roof." Aliya looked up at the roof. It was cloth, like in a tent. "But while it's dry, there's more room in the old farmhouse."

"Why is it called a farmhouse?" demanded Aliya. "Where are all the animals?"

"They're a bit further away," said Olbeth.

"Why?"

"Because they're not here," said Camburé, which was not a proper answer at all. Aliya gave her another look. Then she decided that she would explore later and find out for herself. There might be ducks but she did not ask in case they said No.

So she said, "Is there any breakfast?"

"It's here," said someone new. This was an old lady stooping to come in through the door. She had grey hair. But when she stood up again she was quite tall and straight.

"Hello, Bruilde," said Olbeth.

Aliya looked at Bruilde curiously. She knew that this was Bruilde's house, but it was a very strange house to want to live in. Bruilde was carrying a pot which steamed. She held the handle with a brown rag.

"Porridge," she said, and setting the pot down on the floor of straw she began to spoon the porridge into bowls for everyone except the baby. The porridge was very hot so there must be a cooking fire somewhere close; just not in the house. Not in Aliya's bed.

"Fires in wooden houses are a bit tricky anyway," she said, because that was something she remembered Mama saying once. The thought of Mama made her suddenly want to cry. She wished Mama was here. But she didn't want to cry in front of the tall old lady because it was her house and she might think Aliya hated it, which was not true.

So she sat and looked at the porridge and waited for the lump in her throat to go away.

"I'm just waiting for it to cool down," she said, when she saw all the women looking at her. "I like porridge." This was true, but she also said it because she was aware that they had had to move here, to this smoky house-inside-a-house, because of *her*. Because some bad people wanted to chase after her. She imagined the men sneaking through the woods looking for her. But they would not find her.

"Where is mister Veron?" she asked.

"He's outside with his hunters. He prefers it out there."

Aliya nodded. That was reassuring. She began to eat her porridge. After a while they stopped watching her so much. When she had finished the porridge Flodda hustled her outside to wash; there was a trough with a pump.

"This is a horse-trough," said Aliya.

"Good enough for you," said Flodda.

"I'm not a horse. Why are they chasing me?"

"Who?"

"Bad people."

"Who says anyone is chasing you?" said Flodda. "Wash your face."

That was not an answer. Aliya stepped forward and dipped her head right under the cold surface of the horse-trough to show Flodda that she was not afraid. But she was afraid. When she shook the water off her hair and opened her eyes Veron and Edrik were there.

"Why are they chasing me?" She addressed the question to Edrik. But he didn't answer either. He looked at Veron.

"Unclear," said Veron. "Either to capture or to kill. We're not sure which."

Flodda gave a sort of gasp of horror, putting her hands up to her mouth. Aliya wondered if she ought to give a gasp of horror too. She wasn't sure what being killed was like. She knew you went to sleep and didn't wake up again. But she could very clearly imagine being captured, because it would be a bit like being chased by Flodda when she wanted to do her hair or like Aliya chasing her pig. Only no cuddles at the end of it, only shouting men with swords.

She looked at Veron. "I think I would rather be killed than captured," she said.

Flodda gave another sort of gasp. Veron's eyebrows rose.

"We'll make sure neither happens," he said.

"How do you know the bad men aren't following us?"

"We were careful," said Veron. "And we've set sentries."

"How many sentries?"

"Six."

"Six is a good number," said Aliya. "I am nearly six."

"And there's a man on look-out," Edrik said, "up in the cedar tree."

Aliya's heart gave a little leap. "In a tree? Does he have a rope ladder?" She had seen a rope ladder once, in Lord Hapligan's hay barn, and it had been a wonderful thing.

"He has a knotted rope," replied Veron.

"You may take me there," she said to Flodda, because she didn't think she could order Veron around any more, now that he wasn't ill. But Flodda was supposed to do everything she said.

"What's the word?" said Flodda.

"Please."

"Later on," said Flodda. "We have things to talk about first."

That sounded boring. But it turned out that Aliya didn't have to join in with the talking. They left her in the house-inside-a-house with Edrik and the baby while they all went outside.

Baby Doval was trying to crawl. He lay on his stomach on a blanket and did swimming things with his arms and legs, grunting all the time. He wanted to get onto his hands and knees but did not seem to know how. When Aliya tried to help him he collapsed onto his stomach again and began to cry.

Edrik went to pick him up.

"I can do it," said Aliya, although she could only just manage to lift the baby. Then she couldn't stand up with him in her arms. He was heavy. She had to instruct Edrik to take him after all and then once she was on her feet she commanded Edrik to hand him back.

"No, the other way round," she said. "Please." Doval seemed even heavier now that she was standing up holding him but she was not going to admit it. So she walked around the little house with him, telling him all about how it was made, from the twiggy walls and straw floor to the roof which seemed to have branches laid over the cloth. She could see the shadows so she went out to make sure. Edrik followed her. Yes, there were leaves dangling over the roof edge. It was all very untidy.

Standing holding the warm wriggly weight of Doval, she could hear the voices of the others coming over the black wall but she didn't want to listen. Just sitting and talking was a boring thing to do. So she set off walking through the outer house to discover what was there, with Doval heavy in her arms, and Edrik following her. As well as the kitchen with the bed in the fireplace there were several other rooms, all roofless, some with burnt furniture inside them, and puddles and lots of bird droppings. In one room there were grey-black lumps that might have been a bed and a chest. They were the right size but not the right shape. She touched one with her foot and a bit of it fell off.

Edrik tried to get Doval off her again and this time she let him. The room gave her an anxious feeling. She didn't know much about fires except that you needed to be very careful with them, but somebody must have been very careless here because you could see that it had been a huge great fire. Once the gardener at Lord Hapligan's had built a bonfire and it had got quite scary, with the wind seeming to pull up flames that jumped higher and higher and smoke everywhere, until Lord Hapligan had come running out shouting and then buckets of water were thrown until the fire went down again, and the flames and everyone stopped jumping.

"Come this way," she said to Edrik. "Bring the blanket. Please." She led him right outside the house, not to the place where everyone else was talking, but to the little courtyard on the other side, where the pump was. She walked around the yard peering in the sheds for animals but there weren't any. The sheds were burnt as well. There was a stable with the black remains of stalls and grass growing in some of them and more puddles on the floor. But no horses.

So she went back to the middle of the courtyard, which was dry, and ordered Edrik to put down the blanket so that Doval could practise his pretending-to-crawl and play with bits of straw. Edrik objected. He seemed to think that even bits of straw might hurt the baby.

Aliya did not agree. She was annoyed when Edrik started going on about eyes. He took the straw away. Then she had to find something else for the baby to play with. So she played finger games and tickled him and told them both stories about different pets and their little houses until Doval began to cry.

The others came round to find them and Olbeth scooped Doval up.

"Thank you for looking after them," she said.

"Hard work," said Edrik, wiping his forehead.

"Yes, babies are very hard work, aren't they, Flodda?" said Aliya.

"Some are," said Flodda.

Aliya looked at Veron. "You said there would be animals here. I can't find any."

He shrugged.

"I am very disappointed," said Aliya, because that was something else Mama used to say, although usually to servants. She felt very bold saying it to Veron and immediately wondered if she had gone too far. He wasn't a Lord but even so.

So she turned round to face her nursemaid so that he might think she had really been talking to Flodda. "I am going to explore," she said.

"Not on your own," said Flodda.

"Of course not," said Aliya haughtily. She looked at Bruilde. "Where may I go?" she asked, because she thought this land must be Bruilde's even though the house was burnt.

Bruilde shrugged. "Go where you like," she said, "though you won't get far in places."

"Go with her, Edrik," said Veron, and Edrik groaned.

Aliya took his hand, which was big and knobbly. "It's all right," she said, "we won't carry the baby with us this time. You can help me build some houses."

"Who for?" asked Veron.

"For baby pigs," Aliya said, although she actually intended to look for little somethings that might be hiding. She had never seen any at Lord Hapligan's estate but that had all been very neat and square. There had been a little square wood with pigs in it but she had not been allowed in.

This place was much wilder. She walked with Edrik huffing alongside. For a hunter he was rather noisy but she didn't tell him so, because she quite liked Edrik. She found some fields but they were boring, with no animals in them.

So she headed for the trees at the fields' edge, and plunged in. Soon there were trees all round her, some tall and thin, some short and bushy. In many places it was so tangly that there was no path through at all.

But there were lots of hiding places in the trees for little somethings. There were lots of twigs and branches lying around as well. And although Aliya couldn't see any little somethings at the moment, if she built them nice new houses, they might come.

Chapter 29

The monastery had room enough for several companies of Riders. The captains of each company drew straws for their quarters; an activity that seemed to surprise and amuse the watching Kelvhans, who had been offered the use of the monastery's east wing. They drew no straws but allocated rooms by rank.

Parthenal was one of the lucky captains. His company won the right to sleep on the lowest floor, with its ranks of little cells along the corridor. So, privacy if not huge comfort, he reflected glumly; better than the dormitory upstairs, at least.

His Riders expressed their gratitude to him for drawing the longest straw, although he found that he did not greatly care. He would as soon sleep looking at the stars. Or not sleep at all, but pace the beach and listen to the pounding sea rush at the cliffs. Though even those tremendous heartbeats could not block out his own.

"Lucky you," said Rothir, who had drawn one of the short straws and would encamp his company outside, amongst the ruins of the temple. "Comfort and a dry bed."

An empty bed, thought Parthenal. "You'll be all right out there," he said. "It's not going to rain."

"No? Have you not seen those clouds gathering out to sea? They're looking black."

"They're a long way off. Anyway, you'll have the tents."

"If there's a storm, then it's the wind that will be the problem." But Rothir wasn't really grumbling. He still seemed quite happy. As they sat together on a bench amidst the thick stone columns of the dining hall, Rothir was even eating with enjoyment – although their supper was only barley broth with mutton, and some random greens that Theol had harvested.

"Let's hope Theol didn't find these weeds in any drains or ditches," Parthenal remarked, holding up an unappetising strand of soggy green. "I wouldn't want to find myself eating Athelid by accident."

"I think this might actually be seaweed," said Rothir, munching his way through a mouthful. "But Yaret's already been poking round in ditches to see what she can see."

"Warn her not to eat any strange plants that she digs up." His gaze wandered over to Theol, sitting opposite them on another low bench with a group of Kelvhans. Not a bunch that Parthenal would have chosen to sit amongst, for that handsome, sly equerry Jaul was one of them. But Theol got on easily with anyone; Rothir's second in command was well-liked by all. Including women.

"I wonder if Theol would rather have a cell," he said.

"Hmm?"

"Nothing." But if Theol and Tiburé... Parthenal sighed. It was none of his business. Any more than Meya and Huldarion was his business. They would take one of the larger chambers. Share one of those straw beds. He felt his limbs begin to burn, his skin to stiffen.

Forget, forget. Relax. But while he was unthinkingly staring over at Theol laughing with the Kelvhan group, Jaul must have thought his gaze was directed towards him. For now Jaul stood up gracefully and walked over to him. So smooth his movements, and his manner. Sly. Elegant. Attractive. To be avoided.

But the man had been his attendant at the castle. He could not be ignored. It would look strange.

"My Lord Parthenal. Greetings to you," Jaul murmured.

Parthenal gave him the merest nod.

"You are fortunate in your quarters, my lord Parthenal. My own, just by the middle floor of the east staircase, are not so luxurious. They are right underneath the stairs. You would have to stoop were you to enter."

He would not answer that even with a nod. How unsubtle. Show nothing but a face of stone.

Jaul hesitated. "I hope that you keep well."

"We all keep well, I thank you."

"I'm glad," said Jaul. "Did you enjoy the journey here?"

"It was uneventful."

"Of course, you are well-travelled. I have never been so far from Kelvha."

This begged some courteous comment. Parthenal did not oblige.

Again Jaul hesitated; it seemed he did not want to leave. Something crossed his countenance that Parthenal recognised. It was longing.

Oh, I know, thought Parthenal grimly, I know what you want. You have been told to trap me, and now you find you want me. I have caught you, just as you tried to catch me in your net. You have your deserts there, Jaul.

"Good evening to you," he said curtly, though not without a certain satisfaction. At last Jaul bowed and walked away.

Rothir turned his head to look at Parthenal. "You won't, will you?" he asked quietly.

"Of course not," said Parthenal, his tone dismissive.

"Hmm. Jaul was a bit obvious, wasn't he? Not given up yet. Our little friend is watching us and looking quite concerned. Remember his warning. Spies are not limited to Kelvha castle."

Parthenal glanced over to his right. There was Tamu, sitting next to Leor. The wizard was staring into space. Tamu was looking very carefully at the bowl in his lap.

"You needn't worry," said Parthenal grumpily. He didn't need to be reminded what and what not to do. Had he not always guarded his behaviour? "I'll be a paragon of virtue, dwarf," he told Rothir. "I'll stay inside my nice dry cell enjoying my solitude, while you enjoy your storm."

During that long evening, however, the threatened storm did not arrive. Nothing seemed to arrive, not even nightfall. Parthenal lay on the bed in his small cell and watched the square of sky through his deep window, waiting for it to turn to dusk; waiting for night, and sleep, to come. They usually did in spite of everything.

But at this time of year it was a long wait. Endless. The light was still as golden as a pear. He could hear the softly remote murmurs of the sea. Still no storm, then, to annoy Rothir. Within the cell there was no sound except the rustle of the straw beneath his cloak as he turned restlessly on the low bed. He had not even undressed, in case he had to leave his cell at short notice. In case Huldarion called him to arms. Anything. Any reason to get up.

Huldarion would not call for him. Maybe he never would again. Yet there was another straw bed, under the staircase of the east wing, where he would be welcome... but he would not think of that. Except that he already had.

He turned over again; and heard a knock on the cell's door. A light, tentative knock.

Jaul, he thought immediately, I will not answer; but then a second thought occurred to him. It might be merely one of his own company with a problem. Most likely was.

And if it were Jaul, he would turn him away. Although he might linger first. Yes. He would make the man wait, and want, and suffer; as Parthenal had to wait, and want, and suffer. That was only fair.

So he strode over to the door and opened it almost with eagerness; and at once Tamu burst in.

"Please close the door," he said breathlessly. In his surprise Parthenal did so without remark. This time, Tamu bore no ancient musty volume spilling bookmarks to explain his presence.

"Tamu. What's wrong? How can I help you?"

Tamu took several short, gasping breaths.

"If you want me," he said, between gasps, and Parthenal saw that he was trembling, "then you can have me. I just thought you might want someone. And so, so, so I'm here."

Parthenal was filled with pity and a faint dismay. After his first guess about Tamu's feelings for him, he had subsequently wondered if he might have been mistaken; but now he saw it fully in the other man's open, vulnerable, pleading face. How had Tamu known which way he leaned? Sheer instinct, maybe... or he could have learnt it from Thoronal, his undiplomatic cousin. He saw how desperately Tamu wanted him. Or maybe simply wanted to be noticed by him.

He would have to turn the little man away, of course. No matter how strong his own need, he could not accept this offer. And his own need was not that strong. Not for Tamu, at any rate. But he would have to be both kind and careful.

He stood and faced him, with a hint of a bow.

"Tamu," he said, "I am honoured. I am grateful. Believe me. I know how difficult it must have been for you to come and say this."

Tamu raised his head to look at him. In the soft evening light that came through that deep window, his face was set in anxious determination. "It's only difficult because you are so much higher than me. So much more—" He made a vague, despairing gesture. "So much more everything."

"I am only a man, the same as you." Yet even as he said it, he saw himself as he knew that Tamu saw him: an amazing sculpture of muscle and sinew, some kind of god of supreme male beauty; a potent being with power to delight or blight by uttering a single word.

Although Parthenal did not consider himself vain, he knew what he looked like. He knew the power he wielded by virtue of those looks. The sense of that power was slightly intoxicating. It was certainly his.

But how could he wield it now? How should he wield it? The sea whispered, sighing as it embraced the cliff-edge down below his window. He had a sharp sense that Tamu stood now on some narrow precipice, and that if he gave the wrong reply – or replied in the wrong way – he would send Tamu tumbling down that cliff into humiliation and despair.

He would have to be very careful how he rejected Tamu. Or else he would have to accept him. He was aware that he was already beginning to feel some arousal, and had to remind himself that this was Tamu, the bumbling absent-minded bookish little friend, as he had been labelled by the Vonn. The reminder brought a surge of compassion.

"Tamu," he said.

"I don't ask anything," said Tamu. "I am just here. In case you want me. Or if you don't. In case you just want somebody. Shall I go?"

Parthenal could not bear the tension in the man's voice. His pity for Tamu was too great. Tamu's need, not his own, was too desperate to be resisted. After all, how bad could it be?

In two weeks' time he might be dead in battle. But that was no reason for him to accept Tamu's offer. Parthenal had faced death before, and he was accustomed to the idea by now. In two weeks he might be dead or he might not. If he were dead he would not know and it would not matter. Yet it might matter very much to Tamu. He could give Tamu this gift in what might possibly be the last days of their lives.

But it must be a gift. It behoved him to be careful, very careful. He did not know if Tamu had ever lain with anyone before: it seemed unlikely. He did not want to hurt the little man in any way.

Yet now he did want him. Or, rather, not him, but he wanted somebody. And Tamu was there.

He took two steps towards him. Tamu did not move, but stood and trembled. Parthenal did not know what to say. So instead he bent his head and kissed him.

"Oh," said Tamu. He put up a hand, so light, so tentative, to touch Parthenal's shoulder. Parthenal put an arm around him and kissed him again, for a little longer. Tamu smelt faintly of spice and soap. Parthenal gave him the time to pull away. When he did not, Parthenal bent and put his other arm around his thighs and effortlessly lifted him. He was not heavy.

He carried him over to the bed and laid him down. There he began to undress him, slowly, slowly, although his own body was now telling him to get a move on. He put his own desire to one side. It had nothing to do with Tamu, and he did not want mere haste to scare the little man away. So he gave him plenty of room and time to resist, time to make excuses and escape, in case he changed his mind.

Tamu did not resist. He was passive, staring up at Parthenal with lips parted and a wondering, dazzled look in his eyes. As Parthenal gently stripped away his shirt and breeches he let out an involuntary sigh; but that was all. No words. He reached out a tentative hand again to Parthenal's chest. His touch was as light as a sheet of paper. Only when Parthenal began to undress himself did Tamu aid him, fumbling at a button. His hands were shaking.

Parthenal held his hand and kissed it. Then he held his head, gently, and kissed it. Tamu sighed again. Parthenal had the increasing sense that Tamu was a precious thing and easily broken, so he did not take off his own underbreeches. He did not want to alarm him by seeming to demand too much too soon.

Instead he applied his hands and lips to the other man's naked body, gently stroking his arms, his chest, quite different to the scarred hard-muscled bodies that he would usually prefer. Tamu's skin bore no marks of battle or even much exertion. It was soft and smooth, and almost hairless, until Parthenal moved downward to his stomach and beyond.

Tamu's breathing stopped and started, grew husky and urgent. He gripped Parthenal's shoulder, as he began to push himself against his hand. It did not take long. Tamu shuddered and let out a small cry which he immediately stifled. When eventually Parthenal looked up, he lay staring at the ceiling with his mouth open. There were tears on his face.

"It's all right," said Parthenal, and he moved to lie beside him, one leg enwrapping his, one arm embracing him. "It's all right, Tamu." He guessed that this was the release of years of tension and concealment, of suppressed desire and fear that must have seemed unending. No wonder the man wept. He gently brushed the tears away and kissed his face again.

He was so fortunate, himself. He had never felt all that different from the others of the Vonn, except that his opportunities for love were different. He had never had to hide or fear discovery amongst them. He could curl up against Rothir for warmth on a cold night underneath the stars, and Rothir would not mind. He was lucky.

Tamu wiped his wet face with his thumb and slowly reached his hand over to trace Parthenal's features.

"I never thought," he said.

"You never thought what, little friend?" Parthenal could have bitten his tongue off as soon as he said it. But Tamu did not appear to mind.

"I never thought that you would want me."

"Oh, I want you," said Parthenal, because by now it was definitely true. But this might be the point at which Tamu would want to back away. So again he waited.

After a while Tamu felt for his breeches, trying to unfasten them. Parthenal had to help him. And then he feared that his full nakedness might scare Tamu away; although he strongly hoped that it would not.

Tamu looked at his body and seemed almost to stop breathing.

"How do you...?" he whispered. "What do you like...?"

"I like everything," said Parthenal. "It doesn't matter how." But the other man was so tentative that it was clear that he was going to have to guide him. At every movement he constrained himself to be slow and careful.

But it was not difficult after all. Tamu's body was warm and welcoming enough, in the spaces between thigh and thigh or arm and body or just against his softly yielding stomach, which was where Parthenal ended up, pressing Tamu to him with his hands. As they lay in stickiness and sweat, he thought, well, that could have been worse. I don't think I hurt him. And my own need was greater than I realised.

Tamu's hands wandered over his back.

"I'm crushing you," said Parthenal.

"I like it."

"But you need to breathe." He moved aside and Tamu drew a long breath. Then he smiled, to Parthenal's relief. He would not have known what to do with more tears just then.

"What now?" murmured Tamu after a moment.

"Now I wash you," Parthenal said. He got up to fetch the rough pottery bowl which he had filled with water ready for the morning, and a cloth. Tamu shuddered as Parthenal wiped him down with steady, careful strokes. He did not look at the ceiling any more, but at Parthenal's body leaning over him.

"Oh dear," he said.

Parthenal glanced down and was surprised, and then amused. So once was not enough.

"So soon?" he said. "You'll have to wait a little while, my friend, while I catch up and catch my breath."

"I can do things while I wait." Tamu knelt up on the bed opposite him and cautiously began to run his fingers over Parthenal's body. His touch was like feathers. It made the skin tingle.

"Nice," said Parthenal. He lay down on his back and let Tamu, kneeling over him, do it some more. Such delicate fingers. "Are those words you're writing on me?"

"Oh.... Yes."

"You write well." It was very pleasant. Relaxing. For most of his body, at least. In one area it gradually began to have the opposite effect.

"Oh," said Tamu breathlessly. "What do we do now?"

He almost laughed. "You choose."

"I would prefer you to choose," whispered Tamu: so Parthenal chose. Hands and thighs. Tamu was not so passive this time, clinging to him as if his life depended on it. Still Parthenal was careful not to hurt the other man, but when his body began to make leaping demands he allowed himself to be a little more forceful. And Tamu seemed to like it.

And afterwards he lay limp and sighing in Parthenal's arms. He was not heavy enough to be a burden. Parthenal, languorous on the bed, embracing him, watched the dusk enter the room at last and tiptoe round it, shadowing the corners. The sea outside breathed great sighs of relief.

After a while it became clear that Tamu had drifted into sleep. There was a faint snore. Parthenal was touched by this sign of trust: but he had to first nudge and then heave Tamu off his chest to wake him up.

"Sorry," said Tamu, blinking in alarm, "sorry, sorry. I need to go. You don't want to risk one of your friends finding me here." He jumped up and began to wipe himself down with the cloth again, before pulling on his clothes.

"That wouldn't matter," Parthenal assured him, although a part of his mind said that it would. *What? Little Tamu? How desperate were you?* Not that any of his friends would put that into words. But he cringed at the knowledge that they might think it.

In his guilt, he said, "Tamu? That was welcome. Thank you."

Tamu's face lit up. "Was it really? I am glad. I didn't think that..."

"That I would ever want you? You were wrong."

Tamu simply said, again, "I am glad." Then he ducked and bobbed, and left. The door closed quietly behind him.

Parthenal lay stretched out with one hand behind his head, as the light through his window finally faded into violet dusk. He was very aware of his own body, the length and firmness of it in the dying light. The body of a warrior god in Tamu's eyes; all-powerful but languid now, at rest. He was feeling more relaxed physically than he had been for some weeks, but also faintly anxious.

That had not been nearly as bad as it might have been. In fact the second time had been surprisingly pleasant. He realised that he had not thought of Huldarion once, which in itself seemed a kind of victory. He hoped he had made little Tamu happy. He hoped he had not seemed too patronising.

But would Tamu expect it to occur again? Surely if you made love to your god, once was sufficient. He wasn't sure if he wanted Tamu enough to have him in his bed a second time. The little man was so unlike his usual choice.

Ungrateful god, he said to himself. Don't be so mean-spirited. You might be dead in two weeks' time, and so might he. Yet he came here to give you satisfaction, release, relief: and it worked, for now, at least.

So sleep.

Chapter 30

Tamu walked along the corridor in a kind of dream. It had happened. For days now he had seen Parthenal's increasing discontent; maybe no-one else had noticed, but it pierced Tamu with love and sympathy and the urge to help.

And then that evening, when he watched Parthenal's glances towards Jaul, his heart had seemed to stop. He did not blame Parthenal for his desires; for how could someone so like a god not want to give expression to his splendour? Thoronal had called him promiscuous. The very thought of it – of Parthenal's many lovers – filled Tamu with wanting; and with fear besides.

For even though they were outside the castle, they were still within the influence of Kelvha. Jaul had not given up. But Tamu knew that dreadful danger lurked that way.

So he had followed Parthenal, at a discreet distance, to see where his room was. Then he had gone upstairs to the sad abandoned dormitory and sat on his bunk bed, unable to lie down, unable to speak to anyone, perusing a stray piece of paper in the pretence that it was a letter so that no-one would disturb him. He had found the paper underneath the bed; there was nothing on it but a crudely drawn picture of the building that he sat in, with sharp waves at its base.

There was he, sitting at the top. There was Parthenal, two floors below. Was he alone? Where was Jaul? What was happening? What might happen? Tamu began to rock to and fro, trying to summon up his courage until he panicked that it was all too late, and then he dropped the paper and half ran, half tumbled down the stairs, his limbs clumsy and disobedient as if he were falling apart.

He scuttled down the corridor and knocked on Parthenal's door at once, before he could lose heart and run off again. None the less he expected to be turned away with cool disdain and was already anticipating his own extreme and crippling shame. He would have to go away forever or hurl himself off the highest point of the cliff, in secret, so that nobody would know.

But Parthenal had let him in. He had permitted him to stay. And it had happened. His god had not rejected him, or laughed at him, or found him disappointing. Parthenal had been more than he could ever have imagined: more beautiful, more strong, more tender, a thing of gold and ecstasy and liberation. Tamu had written words of love and worship upon Parthenal's dazzling body. He had been allowed. Now as he walked back down the corridor he found that tears were running down his face again; yet he was not unhappy. He did not know what he felt. His heart was so full that it left him dazed and blinded.

He stumbled towards the eastern staircase that led up to his quarters. Through the broken roof he saw the glimmer of the dusk, and felt a waft of warm air kiss his cheek. He could hear a faint, soft hissing sound: was that rain, falling on the sea?

Joy has shone into my soul, it has rained down onto me, he thought as he slowly climbed the stairs, I hear joy surround me in a shower of gentle sound to bring new life to the world; and in the half-dark he walked into someone.

"Well, hello," said Jaul. "Where have you been so late at night?"

"I got lost," said Tamu, as the first thing he thought of. It was also true in a way.

"Easily done here. I can help you find your room again." There was something in his voice, constrained, like hidden anger.

"I don't need help," said Tamu.

"But I can keep you company. Would you like that? A bit of company?"

"Go away," said Tamu, and he practically ran back up the stairs to his own quarters.

Chapter 31

Aliya threw another stone into the little lake. It made a very satisfying splash.

"Can I paddle?" she asked Edrik, for a second time, and again he shook his head.

"People have to drink that," he said.

"I'm not dirty. Not as dirty as the water is." The water was cloudy where all the stones had gone in. Aliya picked up another one, large and smooth, in both hands, and looked at it carefully to make sure it wasn't a little something – although she had seen no somethings yet.

Then she heaved it into the pool, which went slurp and clunk in a very pleasing way. There was a nice bit of soft gritty shore to stand on and she spent some time making footprints to and fro along it. Then she drew faces with a stick, and a house with lots of chimneys that were bigger than its door.

"Have you finished building that house yet?" she asked Edrik, busy with her stick. When she turned round, Edrik was squatting back on his heels staring at the water and not doing anything at all. The house was still not much more than a pile of twigs.

"What's wrong?" she said.

"Nothing," said Edrik. "This just reminds me of somewhere else, when I was young."

This was a new idea, but hard to grasp: that Edrik might once have been young. She had no idea how old he was. Much older than Mama.

She grasped at another idea, even more unlikely, and asked, "Have you got children?"

"Two. Grown-up now," said Edrik, sounding wistful.

"Oh. Where do they live?"

"Up north."

"Near a little lake?"

He nodded.

She digested this. "What games did they play?"

"I can't remember. Tag chase. And hide and seek."

Aliya nodded. "Those are both good games for hunters," she said, pleased at her own wisdom. Again she walked along the squidgy shore, but this time as carefully as she could, the way a hunter might. She was trying to make no footprints at all. When she looked behind her there were hardly any marks. As if she was hardly there.

Like a little something. How nice it would be to be able to disappear, she thought. To sit in the bushes and grass and nobody would notice you. How nice to not have Flodda or someone always watching you. And bad men would never find you.

"Can we play hide and seek?" she asked.

"No," said Edrik. "You might be too good at it. I can't risk losing you. Veron would have my guts for garters."

"What does that mean?"

No answer.

"Lord Hapligan had garters made of golden silk," she said thoughtfully. "Where did Lord and Lady Hapligan go?"

"I wouldn't know. You'd better show me how to build this house of yours," said Edrik.

"I think we need more mud," Aliya said. "The twigs aren't sticking together properly." It was surprising because the mud was very sticky. It stuck everything else together except the twigs. It stuck all her fingers together and after a while she held up her hands to show Edrik. "Look," she said. "I've got bear paws!"

"So you have," said Edrik.

"Have you ever hunted bears?"

"At times," said Edrik.

"How big are they?"

He stood up and held his hand a foot or so above his head. Then he spread both hands wide. Then he snarled. It was a very good snarl, and Aliya laughed, but she felt a little nervous.

"Are there any bears near here?" she asked.

"I doubt it," Edrik said, and another voice said "No," behind her. It was Veron, again.

"How do you do that?" demanded Aliya. "I didn't hear you. Is it magic?"

"No," said Veron.

"Yes," said Edrik at almost the same time.

"No," said Veron, with a narrow-eyed smile at Edrik, "she has nothing to do with it."

"I didn't mean anything," said Edrik, sounding a little scared. "It's just that you're..."

"I am. That's why she took me on. Cause, not effect." Veron turned to Aliya. "Better wash your hands," he said. "They want you to eat."

Aliya obeyed. While she was drying her wet hands on her muddy skirts, she said, "Are you sure there are no bears?"

"Quite sure. None for forty miles or so."

"What are the worst animals that live here?"

Veron tilted his head. "Lions, a dozen miles away, over on the plateau. They won't come here. Wolves, a little closer. They might have come here while there were still sheep. But they won't bother now. Moorhounds, likewise."

Aliya nodded and licked her lips. There was another question waiting, one that she had been wanting to ask ever since she had arrived here, and had not dared to, because she thought the answer might not be a nice one.

She found she did not dare to ask it now. Instead she walked between the two hunters back to the burnt farmhouse with the question bouncing round inside her head.

What set this place on fire?

Bruilde was the one that she should ask. But she was a bit scared of Bruilde, the same way Edrik was a bit scared of Veron. She tried to summon up the courage to ask her question while she ate her flatbread and cheese and some smelly leaves that Flodda had picked. The leaves weren't very nice and she saw that Camburé had left hers.

"Finish those off. You need to eat your greens," said Flodda.

Aliya was about to protest when she remembered, again, that Flodda and Camburé and everybody else were here in this burnt place because of her. So she just said, "They're a bit chewy," and then she spat the chewed leaves out a moment later and put them in the grass behind her when Flodda wasn't looking. She saw Bruilde watching and felt scared again. But Bruilde said nothing.

After eating she wanted to play with Doval but Doval was tetchy and Olbeth said it was nearly his bedtime. Camburé said she wanted to talk to Veron and Aliya didn't mind because she would rather play with Edrik anyway.

But Edrik said it was his bedtime too, although it was still quite light. Perhaps it was because he was so old.

Aliya looked at Bruilde. "Do you need to go to sleep as well?" she asked.

"Not just yet," Bruilde said.

"Can I go exploring in the woods before I go to bed?"

"If you go with Flodda."

"I've got washing to do," said Flodda, "quite a lot more of it now. What happened to your dress? You'd better change into your other one."

"I'd better not," Aliya said, "because I'll only get more muddy. Please."

"Oh, all right," said Flodda. The power of *please* on Flodda was astounding.

Aliya turned to Bruilde. "Please can I go in the woods with Flodda? I would like to see the lookout, please."

"I'll take you, child," Bruilde said.

Aliya stood up and curtsayed, because although she didn't think Bruilde was a proper Lady – at least, she didn't dress like one – this was her house, and you were always polite to someone when you were in their house.

Bruilde didn't curtsy back. But then she was old so bending might be difficult.

"Come along," she said, and she stood up too, becoming very tall, and took Aliya's hand. That was all right, because an old lady might need help walking. But in fact it turned out that Bruilde was the one who strode along and Aliya had to patter quickly to keep up.

"Where are your horses?" she asked.

"Three miles away," Bruilde said. "I moved them all out when the fire came through last year."

"Good. What," said Aliya, and then did not dare, after all.

"Some people," said Bruilde. "They came and set it all on fire and then they marched away."

"Where did they go?"

"A long way," said Bruilde. Although this was not a very satisfactory answer Aliya decided it would have to do. She hoped it was a very long way.

"But the fire didn't burn down all the trees," she said, because they were entering a woodland, and it looked all right. Everything was growing, too much if anything, for it was extremely thick and jumbled underneath the trees. There was bracken and brambles and lots of other prickly frizzly stuff. You might be able to stamp your way through and maybe tunnel underneath but it would all be very scratchy. It was way too scratchy to explore. Even the path was prickly on each side.

As they walked along the path she had a good look for little somethings but she couldn't spot any. Perhaps Bruilde was too tall for them.

Aliya decided that if she was a little something she wouldn't choose to live here in any case, because it was so very prickly. She thought she didn't like these woods much after all, but she wouldn't tell Bruilde that.

So she said instead, "I like your twiggy house," because that was a more polite thing to say, and true.

"I don't," said Bruilde, "but it serves. I don't live here much these days. I just keep an eye on the place."

"You could always build your house again," suggested Aliya. "The big one, not the twiggy one."

"I will, I expect. Just not yet. Not while... Here we are. This is the lookout tree."

It was a good tree but not as good as the big apple tree at Lord Hapligan's, nor as wide and dark as the one at Olbeth's farm. It was very tall but not very friendly. All the branches were high up. Aliya looked carefully at the thick knotted rope.

"Can I climb it?"

"You can try," Bruilde said.

She hung on to the rope and tried. When she lifted her feet up off the ground the rope swung and spun her round and she couldn't get beyond the first big knot.

"How are you supposed to go up?" she asked. "It won't let you. It just keeps going away."

As if in answer the rope began to shudder violently. Aliya jumped off in a hurry and landed on her bottom. Legs appeared high up, descending from the lowest branch. She watched how the legs did it: slide down, stop with a foot on each side of a knot, wait for hands to come down, slide again. It looked quite easy. But how would you do it going up?

The legs landed on the ground, and the man on top of them let go of the rope and said to Bruilde, "A troop of twenty. About four miles east, I'd say."

"Which way are they heading?"

"North. We'll be all right if they don't change direction."

"Horseback?"

"Mostly on foot. Three carts. They're not moving fast."

Aliya thought they might be talking about bad men, but then she told herself they might just be talking about anybody, like a group of travellers. Yes, that was more likely.

She picked herself up and while they were talking she got onto the rope again. Which did you slide first, feet or hands? She tried feet and it didn't work. So she tried hands, and once she had slid them up, she hung on tight and slid her feet up, feeling for a knot. The rope swung her round again. It wasn't easy.

"I'll tell Veron," Bruilde was saying. "You go back up and stay on watch till nightfall. Give the usual signal if there's any change in their direction. Or if you see any more."

"A rope ladder would be better," Aliya pointed out.

"Will do," he said. "But, Bruilde."

"What?"

"Those carts," the man said. "It looked as if they might be smoking."

"You mean..."

He nodded. Aliya had reached the second knot. As she perched on it, with the rope slowly turning, she was on a level with his head. Before the rope spun her around she saw his face: pulled tight and creased, a bit like Veron's had been when he was ill.

He barely said the word. But she could hear it anyway.

"Darkburns."

Chapter 32

She has ruined the sea for me, thought Maeneb. My first glimpse of it in seven years – and now I shall never be able to look at it again without visualising her standing there like a dress-shaped rock, rigid in her sodden skirts, blocking the view. What did the woman think she was doing? Trying to stop the waves?

“That dress will take three days to dry out,” she informed Gaelera shortly. The dress lay draped wetly over the sand close to where the group had built their fire.

“Then it is fortunate that I have others with me,” Gaelera said composedly. She was wearing a new dress now, appropriately sea-green, its skirts enlivened with twisting golden threads like baby eels. “Jebil; you rinsed the skirts in fresh water, did you not, to avoid unsightly salt stains?”

“Ma’am,” said Jebil in the lowest of voices.

“Which water did you use, Jebil?”

“The stream back there, ma’am, where the horses are drinking.” Jebil barely raised her hand to indicate the area, let alone her eyes.

“The water there is sufficiently fresh? Did you test it, Jebil?”

“Yes, ma’am.”

At least the girl was staying in character, thought Maeneb, even though there was no-one round this fire who did not know of her previous identity as Janeya; for they were all women of the Vonn.

But the next fire, a few yards away, was a different matter. That was a more raucous fire, for around it sat the men of Melmet and a few other non-Vonnish members of the army, all talking loudly. Gaelera’s toothless groom was in that company, sucking on a mutton-bone. Yaret was sitting with them, deep in earnest conversation with the northern vagabond called Zan. Well, he looked like a vagabond. Probably none of those men would care about Janeya; they would shrug if they knew the truth, but it was better that they should not know.

And Gaelera? Does she know? Of course she does, thought Maeneb. That’s why she’s questioning Jebil. She is enjoying this.

“Gaelera,” she said abruptly, “Lady Gaelera, I mean. Are you quite sure you wouldn’t rather join the Lady Meya inside the monastery tonight? Or be with the Kelvhan nobles in the east wing? There you could be comfortable and private.”

“I like it here,” Gaelera answered calmly. “I like it here, sitting by a camp-fire as the sun goes down, with the sea nearby, hearing the waves push and pull at the shore. I am warm and dry and full of an interesting broth. And I have my friends beside me. What more could I wish?”

“Your friends?” said Maeneb curtly, choosing to ignore Hilbré’s widening eyes and faint shake of the head.

“A mere serving-maid cannot be my friend, of course,” proclaimed Gaelera. “We are too far apart in rank. But I count you as my friend, Maeneb, and by extension your companion Durba also.”

Durba made a small noise in her throat that might have been assent or equally protest.

“And as for the rest of you, you are surely not my enemies?” enquired Gaelera, her head tilted: which meant that Hilbré had to answer courteously.

“Indeed, we wish you well, my lady. We are in no way your enemies. But as Maeneb says, you may be more at ease within the shelter of the building than out here with us.”

Gaelera was silent for a moment. “I am not in communication with my father,” she said deliberately, “if that is what you fear.”

"I am sure your father would want to hear from you," said Hilbré.

"Oh, I am quite sure of that," Gaelera said. "He would very much like to know what my intentions are. But as yet I have not quite decided them myself."

Over at the other fire somebody began to strum a lutine. It was Yaret, playing a wandering pattern of chords, alternately major and minor, followed by a faint murmuring of song. Probably some ditty, Maeneb thought, by that ancestral bard she'd mentioned. Madeo. It was plaintively attractive; annoyingly so. Maeneb was not in the mood for soothing music.

"That is pleasant," commented Gaelera. "A traditional tune, I doubt not. Shall you sing?"

"I'm going to sleep," said Maeneb abruptly. She had had enough of Gaelera's play-acting and posing.

"It's, it's not dark yet," said Durba. In the last day or two her stammer had returned a little, although Maeneb thought there was no reason why it should. There was no bloodshed here, no conflict to return her to her state of speechless shock. Nothing but the hypnotic, tranquillising murmur of the sea. Maybe it was the strain of Gaelera's presence.

She retorted brusquely. "The days are getting long already. If I wait till dark I won't get enough sleep before the dawn wakes me again."

She stood up and without any bow to Gaelera tramped back towards the tent pitched on the grass-tufted dune, well above the tide mark. The pegs, set into deep sand, would not hold against a strong wind; but at present it was almost windless. When she looked out to sea a dull grey haze enveloped the horizon. The ominous piling clouds which she'd seen earlier had gone or were obscured. The blue was fading from the sky; the air was warm and still and humid. The sea was hushed, as if it too was readying for sleep.

Maeneb crawled into the tent and lay down on her bedroll. It was airless in there, almost stifling. She was aware of the smell of other bedrolls close around and wished she had a tent of her own. It wasn't as if the others stank. But they smelt of people; all too close, too intrusive, too oppressive. It made her itch and twitch.

And Gaelera. So irritating. Why did the woman make those ponderous statements in that way? Why did everyone hang on her words and treat her as if she might burst into flames if she were not deferred to?

They are afraid of her, of course, thought Maeneb; and so I am. They are afraid of her because of her father – and Janeya. She might betray the one to the other. Yet I don't think she will. She doesn't like her father enough to do that. She just wants to keep everyone guessing and deferring to her.

She turned over, feeling the bedroll stick to her clammy shirt. Her forehead was damp. Her innermost, unwanted thoughts crept out into the humid air.

I am the one who should be most afraid of her, because of that man I killed. The one whose face I kept seeing all the way down the Red Roads. That golden beard. The sneer. My knife stuck in his throat...

Against her will, the scene replayed itself: the armoury stall with its high glinting shields, the nobleman's arm abruptly round her neck, his other hand trying to pull her shirt off. What could she have done differently?

Nothing, she thought. At least I did it properly. I killed him. He did not speak again. He never named me. But I shouldn't have gone running to Gaelera. That was my mistake. I should have walked away and they would not have caught me. Probably. I panicked when I didn't need to.

I put myself in Gaelera's power. Well, let her do her worst, because I won't submit to her. And what's the worst that she can do?

Tell the Kelvhans about the man's death. Would that disgrace Huldarion? Would it throw the whole alliance in jeopardy? I'm not important enough, surely, to do that. Unless the

Kelvans chose. They could use me as an excuse. Maybe I should leave the Vonn, in case. I could saddle up and ride away, at dead of night. Desert the army.

And where would I go?

Farwithiel...

That weight of trees that holds the world at bay. The light that falls between them like clear water: a separate, self-sufficient world. So much space there.

Well, maybe. But not yet.

She heard the others come in and lie down, murmuring and rustling. They gradually fell quiet, yet still she could not sleep. She rolled over and tried to let her thoughts drift off.

But they were very odd thoughts, and Gaelera seemed to be in the middle of them all, in her long damp skirts, hands spread out by her sides, a faint smile on her face. Oh, go away, thought Maeneb, as she turned over yet again. She was all too aware of Gaelera lying next to her.

Gaelera slept on her back, her mouth closed – how did she manage that? Most people's mouths fell open – yet she did not snore. Previously it had been impossible to tell if she were asleep or not: on waking up, she didn't yawn or stretch. Her eyes opened and that was it. She was fully there.

Was Gaelera asleep now? Whether she were or no, Maeneb could bear it in the tent no longer. Sweat was running from her forehead again. She was too warm. She was being suffocated, by the humid air and by her thoughts. There was a faint, persistent hissing from outside; thin rain on the sand perhaps, or falling on the sea. Those veiled clouds far out must at last have come to shore. It seemed to grow still warmer and clammier, until with a stifled groan she threw aside her cloak and crept out of the tent to try and cool herself in the fine rain she could hear.

But it was no cooler outside the canvas walls; and it wasn't raining after all. The hissing must be distant rain upon the sea. Yet the air seemed full of moisture – heavy, clinging, like the steam-filled cabins some of the tribes in Outer Kelvha favoured. Pointless things, in Maeneb's view. Why would you want to sit in a hut and sweat?

Now Maeneb stood by the tent and sweated. It wasn't fully dark. The faint lightening of the eastern sky informed that she must have slept without realising it. But not for long enough, she thought grumpily; for it still lacks an hour to dawn.

In that thick leaden sky the stars had disappeared. The moon was a slender shimmer beyond the misty veil. Veron came to her mind: did he stand somewhere to look up at this frail moon? How were they all faring? She reached her mind out to Olbeth's farm; but no, she could feel nothing there. They would all be asleep. And she remembered now that they weren't at Olbeth's farm in any case; there was a rumour they'd moved on. She did not know to where.

Farwithiel, she thought. Should I ride off to Farwithiel? That would take the wind out of Gaelera's sails. But the Farwth might not let me in. And such friends as I have are here, in these grey humps of tents. Although I don't like many of them much, I still don't want to leave them.

The tents, just visible, slept like giant seals parked on the beach. Further off was the much longer, darker body of the monastery sleeping on its cliff. The sea was haze and shadow.

Maeneb walked towards it, her legs immediately weary with the effort of wading through this heavy atmosphere. When she came to the sea, the muted lapping of the waves grew hardly any louder. The hot damp air was stifling. Only that faint hissing sound persisted: she wished the rain would come to shore and fall on her.

The rain falls nightly in Farwithiel, she thought: such sweet, cool rain, called down by the Farwth. Or else the Farwth arranges its green realm so as to attract it. That roof of mist that hides it always...

She gazed across the shrouded waves, thinking of that misted canopy above the trees. Mist lay heavy on the sea here too. Bring me rain, she thought. I don't care if it needs a storm. Bring me some rain to cool my body and my mind.

Through the constant hissing a faint dull roar grew, out to sea. Was that thunder? But there was no lightning. Instead, in the dim moonlit grey she saw, to match the swell of sound, a slow swelling of the ocean's surface. It was the same heaving movement that the sea had made the previous day – but now much closer, bigger.

"What?" said Maeneb, staring through the dark. The hiss grew louder: the damp and heat grew more intense, as if she were standing amidst a hundred boiling kettles. The mound of swelling sea became a hill, a liquid tumulus, gleaming in uncertain moonlight, water streaming down its sides. As she watched it in bewilderment, it gradually subsided; the mound sank down, the noise grew less intense. Maybe some strange habit of the sea.

"What is that?" said a voice beside her. She turned and saw Gaelera, still, bizarrely, wearing her eel-laden dress. Of course, there was no maid at hand to help her change.

"What are you doing here?" demanded Maeneb.

"I am looking at the waves, as you are. What is that?"

And then Durba was there, running up behind them in her underclothes. "I'm, I'm, I'm s – sorry," she said. "I c– I c–"

"She couldn't stop me," said Gaelera calmly. "What is that?"

"It's water," Maeneb said. "It's the tide, or currents, or something." The sea was all in motion now, its slack surface breaking up, torn into shreds of grey and black and blacker in the dull quarter-light.

And then, as they all watched, the sea rose up again. The mound swelled slowly; ten feet up, then twenty, maybe thirty, and surely it must be eighty, no, a hundred feet in length. It was become a hill once more, pouring water from its slopes; an intense hissing pierced the air; a hot wind steamed past her. Was this an outsized wave like those that she had heard of? Would it come crashing in to shore? Ought they to run? She felt a tug of fear.

"I think we should–"

Her words were lost. For abruptly the hill began to rise again, rearing up into a mountain, shedding rivers, impossibly steep; and as the water rushed down it with a noise of thunder it turned into something else.

Something huge, dark, twining, coiling, steaming. Maeneb caught a glimpse of gleaming scaly skin before the clouds of steam enveloped it. The mass of hissing water began to move towards the shore.

"Get back! Get back!" she shouted. "Wake the others!" Her shout was eaten by the sound of the sea – now not so much a hiss as a huge roaring snarl.

But the other two did not need telling. They were already running back across the sand, Durba scampering swiftly, Gaelera hampered by her dress. Maeneb grabbed her by the arm and pulled her along, cursing. Briefly she looked back over her shoulder.

Beneath the billowing steam the water seemed to boil. And then the vast grey cloud of mist turned black. A shape emerged from it and resolved into something more solid than water yet in perpetual motion, writhing, undulating, convoluting in tortuous, rippling coils.

It was coming faster than they could run. Within a few more seconds it was at the water's edge. A gigantic bunch of black coils landed on the beach with a huge juddering thump that made the sand around her leap and shiver.

The creature writhed again while steam as thick as smoke poured from it. Then it twisted and rose up, the coils behind it expanding. A long sinuous body reared up from the coils and thudded down again upon the hissing sands. It was as thick as a dozen tree trunks. She felt the

earth shake with its falling. Then it lifted itself up, twining serpent-like, before plunging down upon the shore a third time, further from the sea. It was advancing.

"Pick up your skirts," Maeneb yelled at Gaelera. Had the woman no idea how to run? She tugged her along frantically until Gaelera fell, stumbling and slumping on the sand. "Get up! Get up!" she shouted furiously, and tugged some more, cursing that useless dress.

The air was hugely hot. The vibrations of the heavy body beat through the sand behind her. She heard the shouts of sentries: a horn blew, and then another, thank the stars, and she was aware of movement by the tents.

The hissing grew a little less. But now there was a dreadful smell, a familiar smell, a stench of rotting flesh; and a familiar feeling. It was not just fear of the writhing monster that filled her limbs with sudden weakness and made Gaelera struggle to stand up. This was an aura that Maeneb knew too well. The thing behind them was a darkburn.

But that was unthinkable. How could it be? It was so vast – and it had risen from the cold, deep ocean. How could it emerge so hot that it made the waters steam?

There was no time to think about the matter. The great black coils were continuing to heave along the beach towards them. One end reared up – head or tail, she could not tell – before plunging itself earthward in a heavy shower of sand and water. Maeneb was spattered with hot sandy rain.

Again the head – or tail – upreared itself. Gaelera was on hands and knees: it seemed she could not move. The black coils looped towards them and thudded down again just yards away. The long neck swung towards them. They could not escape.

Maeneb threw herself on top of the other woman, pressing her down into the sand. She saw the creature looming over her, and felt a rush of heat – so scalding that her skin seemed to be burning through her clothes. The great coiled body thundered down just next to them, less than two yards away. Shards of burnt scales fell off and hissed upon the steaming sand.

"Get up, get up," yelled Maeneb, and as the coils contracted she fought against the weakness and horror that assailed her and wrenched Gaelera to her feet. "Come on!"

Gaelera's face was blankly startled. She tried to brush sand from her dress, appalling and exasperating Maeneb.

"Will you stop that! *Run!*"

The coils were pumping out appalling heat as they lifted from the sand again. And now at last Gaelera managed to run, staggering as if drunk while Maeneb dragged her up the beach. They could see a row of Riders forming a defensive line: bows were raised; a whine of arrows shot across the air. One of them narrowly missed Maeneb and buried itself in the sand. More arrows fell around the monster. None of them seemed to penetrate its burnt scaly hide. Did it even notice them?

But it had noticed *her*. Her and Gaelera. Maybe it was just the movement that attracted it. Again it raised what must be its head – a blunt, charred snout, eyeless, earless. It turned towards them, seeking them. The heat was horrific. Where could she escape to? How could she protect Gaelera?

She ran: not up the beach towards the tents, but along it, tugging Gaelera by the hand and hearing behind her the thump of the immense pursuing body.

Then Durba was beside her, shouting something. Maeneb could not hear what. The hiss and boom of the serpent deafened her and the flying sand half-blinded her and the fear and heat all but immobilised her.

But she saw that Durba was holding a long knife. It was Maeneb's own knife, which she had left inside the tent. What earthly use was that against this monster?

"Run," Maeneb shouted at her. "Get away from it!"

Durba said something else. Still inaudible. Maeneb shook her head and shouted, "Run! Run!"

Durba turned and ran. But she ran the wrong way. How could that be by accident? How could she make such a dire mistake? Maeneb was open-mouthed as Durba ran up to the undulating, stinking, steaming coils.

They convulsed again; Durba was almost knocked over. But she dodged the sweeping blow of the body and as it moved past her like some giant rotting rope she thrust the knife into it, through its hide. The blade went in right up to the hilt.

There it seemed to stick. Durba tried to pull it out. Her clothes were steaming, smoking. The knife-hilt was wrenched out of her hand as the thick body lifted itself in a high arching loop. The burnt head swung round again, this time away from Maeneb and Gaelera, to face Durba.

"Run!" yelled Maeneb, although her voice had gone. Then she was dragged away, against her will: this time it was Gaelera doing the dragging. They both floundered along the beach through flying sand and spray – too slow, too slow, her feet were bogged down and entrapped, the spray was scalding hot. Glancing over her shoulder she saw Durba caught between black scaly coils, one arm free and flailing.

The coils closed in round her and tightened. Durba disappeared.

Maeneb wanted to scream. Half of her brain was saying, no no, this is all impossible, Durba has slipped out the other side and got free, she was not there, it has not happened: the other half told her that it had, and that it would happen to her too if she didn't get away.

They ran. No longer holding hands, they stumbled inland now, through longer tussocky grass that made them stumble. Maeneb had some vague idea that the grass might hide them; certainly there was nowhere else to hide.

But the massive thuddings did not follow. The heat receded. Risking another glance over her shoulder she saw that the coils had slackened and that the creature was now lower to the ground and slinking steadily towards the tents. Beneath it, the sand fizzed. Behind the snaking body lay a shred of something, crushed to red and black, unrecognisable as human but for one arm; unmoving but for the smoke and steam that curled up to the leaden sky.

A few bold Riders ran over: another volley of arrows was released, without effect, before they had to turn and flee. The blunt head swung round, searching.

But as the thing thumped down again upon the shore, there were three swordsmen standing ready. She recognised Rothir's bulk in the gloom, and maybe Sashel: and was the third Ikelder?

Not again, she said aloud, *no, no, not again*. Let them not die as Durba had.

She saw the three swords slash as one, the swords rebounding: they struck again. Then Sashel stabbed as deep as he was able, before the burnt seeking head hurtled at them like a battering ram.

The three men ducked and ran in different directions, so that the head did not seem to know which one to follow. Thus all escaped, leaving Sashel's sword buried in the creature's flank. Somewhere there too was her long knife. Oh, Durba, she thought; I should not have left my knife behind, I never move without my knife. Why did I choose tonight of all nights to forget it? Why did I leave it there for you?

Other Riders were fleeing to the tents and beyond, small frantic shapes in the dim light. Some raced over to the ruins of the town, while others headed for the black outline of the monastery. More horns were sounding. Torches flared up, bright against the grey, while several monastery windows were abruptly lit.

And again over the shrill horn-blasts and the heavy sighing of the waves came the hiss and thud of the enormous darkburn. The ground shook where Maeneb and Gaelera crouched in the long grass.

She saw the squirming coils reach the tents, rear up and fall upon the nearest with a heavy crunch. After a few seconds the creature raised itself again. The tent was unrecognisable: completely flattened, its remnants black and smoking. Maeneb trusted that no-one had been in it. Surely everybody must have run?

Somebody was running now towards her, pounding through the sand. A horse was galloping close behind.

It was Rothir. He stopped, gasping for breath. His clothes were charred. "Lady Gaelera! Thank the stars you're safe," he panted. "Climb up on my horse. I'll carry you to safety, over to your father and the Kelvhan army."

"No," Gaelera said.

"Yes," insisted Rothir. "I'm going there in any case. We need to warn them."

"Does Huldarion command it?" Maeneb asked; for she could not believe that Rothir had been to the monastery and back.

"I haven't seen him. But there's no time to waste. This thing could swim with speed along the coast. And there may be others like it. Lady Gaelera--"

"No," Gaelera said. "You may tell my father I refused."

"My lady, please! The danger that this darkburn brings--"

"A darkburn? That is a darkburn? I thought it was a linwyrn," said Gaelera. "The sea serpent of the stories. I did not believe in them till now." She sounded, if anything, exhilarated.

"Gaelera," said Maeneb, in exasperation: for what did the name matter? Linwyrn, darkburn, infernal fiery serpent... Whichever it was, it was destroying Thield and would destroy them all if they allowed it. "Gaelera, get on Rothir's horse!"

"No," Gaelera said, her voice high and sharp above the growl of waves and harsh crackle of the burning tents. "I will not go with you. Here I shall stay, amongst the Vonn, where Durba died to save me."

Chapter 33

Huldarion took too long to wake.

That was his immediate thought, as he leapt up to don his clothes and a modicum of armour. Beyond the banging on the door he could hear the shrill cry of the wake-horns. He should have heard those earlier – but with his arms wrapped around Meya, his head against hers, his body luxuriating in her soft warmth, his consciousness had somehow shut the horn-cries out.

It would be easy to blame Meya for it. But also wrong.

Nonetheless his voice was sharp as he instructed her, “Get up. Get dressed. We’re under attack. Naydor here will lead you to a place of safety.”

“I’m not sure where is the safest place just now, sir,” said one of the pair of Riders who had roused him. “Something has come up the beach. It’s burning down the tents. If it’s a darkburn it’s... big.”

Huldarion buckled the straps of his leather breastplate – no time for more – and seized his swordbelt.

“Take Lady Meya to the Kelvhans,” he said brusquely.

“I do not wish to go to the Kelvhans,” Meya said. She was sitting up in bed, the blanket drawn around her, looking both furious and bewildered.

“And Lady Gaelera,” added Huldarion. “Find her and deliver her to Kelvha too. She’s their responsibility.”

“But I am my own responsibility,” said Meya. He ignored her and strode out.

Accompanied by the other Rider, Audril, he ran along the passage to the staircase, up the worn stone steps to the top floor of the monastery and thence onto the roof, where several of his Captains stood already to look out. Although so many sections of the roof had fallen in, this end was sound – he hoped. Had these shattered half-walls once been battlements? Or a lofty walkway for the monks?

Whichever it was, the narrow path inside the broken walls afforded a far-reaching view of both the sea and land. The air was warm and steamy, and though day-break was close, sea-fog dimmed the sky and obscured the distant waters. Beneath the cliff, through swirls of mist, he glimpsed a pair of fins break through the surface, moving fast. Dolphins. A second later they were gone.

He turned to view the land. Even in the dusky light the tremendous furrows ploughing up the beach were plain to see. Riders ran, scattering, away from a group of four burnt tents. There was a large black cloud of smoke enveloping a fifth... and then, as Huldarion looked on, the smoke writhed strangely before beginning to rise up like some dark, swift-growing tree. From it emerged a long black neck, the blunt head turning, as if to smell out something.

“Dear stars,” he breathed in disbelief. “Is that a darkburn?”

“Yes. A great serpent from the sea.” It was Orbrel who answered. A stolid man, not one who normally showed any fear; but now his voice was shaking slightly. The tree of smoke’s thick trunk dissolved, to reveal a heap of pulsing, tightening coils below the blindly seeking head. The thing was throttling the remains of the tent and any of its inhabitants.

“Are there Riders in there?”

“We think they got away. Nearly all. Some have already come to join us here.”

“They have their stones?”

“They should have. But that – the – the serpent – doesn’t seem to be deterred,” said Orbrel. “Perhaps it’s too big to be affected by the stones. All the tents must have contained them. Yet it does not falter.”

Huldarion was silent for a few seconds, gazing down at the smoking border of his tented city and its destroyer. The coiling creature filled him with loathing: his hatred of all darkburns was instinctive, but in those black undulations it seemed to concentrate itself into something very close to terror. He felt his stomach writhe in time with the burnt thing below.

He must not allow his hate to turn to crippling fear. He needed to think clearly, to act with decision – and to be seen to do so.

“Very well. If we cannot save the tents, so be it,” he said crisply. “Tents are expendable. Riders are not. Orbrel: go to the provision carts, and make sure that they are ready to drive further inland. Crade: take half a dozen men and tether the horses at a distance before too many panic and run off.” He knew that the horses would take flight if that monstrous darkburn came too close. “Solon: gather your company outside this building. Stay close; tell Uld to do the same – these stones at least cannot be burnt.”

Solon nodded. “And the rest?”

Huldarion tried to think. Parthenal was running towards them: a welcome cause to stop for a few seconds, gathering his whirling thoughts.

“Parthenal. Are your company all up?”

“Ready and armed,” said Parthenal.

“Good. Where’s Rothir?”

“I don’t know.”

Huldarion fought down a moment of exasperation. “Well, if you see him, tell him to go to the ruined temple in the centre of the old town. Take your own and any other companies you can find, and go there too. It needs but a few of us to stay here at the monastery: the rest of you stand further off, but be on the watch, and prepared for any action.”

Parthenal nodded and departed. Huldarion took another frowning glance towards his smoking tents: the blackened coils were now obscured by leaping flames. The smell of burning was dreadful to him but he commanded himself to pay no heed. Let the monster eat the tents. They did not matter.

“Where’s Leor?” he demanded. “Audril: go and find him. Let us all go down.”

His captains were already hurrying ahead of him, to descend the spiral stairs. Huldarion told himself not to run – indeed he felt he could not hurry, for his legs seemed to be unnaturally weak. This feebleness horrified him as much as the darkburn did. But it was out of sight for now: and as he descended, the weakness passed.

Half way down the stairs he met the Kelvhan commander Rhadlun running up.

“Did you see the linwyrm?” Rhadlun asked, breathless.

“I have seen the darkburn,” said Huldarion sternly, not pausing in his descent. “What is a linwyrm?”

Rhadlun turned to accompany him back down the staircase. “That thing on the shore. It’s a beast of Kelvhan legend, a giant serpent that lives deep beneath the sea. I never thought to see one in the flesh.”

“I doubt if that one out there has any flesh. It is a darkburn, but in a linwyrm’s shape, it seems. How are linwyrm’s dealt with, in your legends?”

“They aren’t,” said Rhadlun heavily. “They emerge from the depths only to pull ships back down to the seabed. They never lose their grip. Once caught, a ship is doomed.”

Huldarion felt fear grasp at him again. He turned it round and looked at it, reshaped it; it was not fear at all, but sheer annoyance. What use were superstitious old wives’ tales to him right now?

“Well, we’re not a ship,” he told the Kelvhan crisply. “Gather your men.”

They were on the first storey now; but Rhadlun stopped on the landing. Kelvhans were running out from the east wing, some crying out in panic, while others, more disciplined, were

trying to organise their comrades. And all around was the smell of smoke and the muted roar of the sea.

"We need to send word to our army," Rhadlun said. "We need to warn them of the *wyrm*."

Huldarion paused. At the very word *wyrm* his stomach had again made its own convolutions. "It is, of course, your right to send word if you wish," he said, although his only thought was for the here and now. "Get your troops in order. And look after the Lady Gaelera. I have ordered her to be sent to you."

He left Rhadlun at the east wing and ran on down to the bottom of the staircase without waiting for an answer. That insolent armourer, Iajo, was lurking in the passage doing nothing. Huldarion felt repulsion and vexation: both were preferable to fear.

"Armourer," he said curtly, "find all the men you can who are equipped to fight, and join with your commander."

"Whatever you say." With the sketchiest of bows he walked away, not in any hurry. Huldarion inwardly cursed the man, and Kelvhans in general. He momentarily deplored the necessity of allying himself to such people.

Then he saw little Tamu, who had been cowering underneath the stairs as if he dared not venture out while Iajo had been there. That was one Kelvhan, at any rate, that did not fit the mould.

"Master Archivist!" he snapped. "What do you know of linwyrm?" He knew he sounded fearsome and he did not care. Being fearsome was better than trembling, which was what the archivist was doing.

"I – I know the stories," Tamu stammered, "but as to facts, I know of nothing that is, that is, that is verified–"

"Do you know how they may be destroyed?"

Tamu shook his head mutely.

"Very well. Where's Leor?"

Tamu pointed up the stairs.

"Find him," said Huldarion, "and send him to me by the west wall."

"I'll try, sir." Tamu fled back up the stairs.

As Huldarion strode on down sand-strewn passages to the main door, he reminded himself that not all Kelvhans were arrogant layabouts. Indeed, very few were: and as if in proof, as he stepped out into the smoky haze, another Kelvhan soldier ran up and saluted. The wiry man whose prowess he had admired in the castle tournament – a long time ago that seemed, in another world than this. For an instant, while he sought his memory for the soldier's name, he longed to have those strong impregnable walls beside him. But he was in a monastery already semi-derelect.

"Lord Huldarion," the Kelvhan said. "I have a dozen men here waiting for command. What would you bid us do? Would you have us fight the serpent?"

Huldarion recalled the name just in time. "Captain Novesnu, is it not?"

"It is." The man bowed.

"Let us look again upon this creature," said Huldarion, and he strode forward. Behind him more Riders were spilling out of the building, but in good order. It was Parthenal's company; they ran swiftly in a double line towards the temple. His own discipline must not be less than theirs.

Next he saw Ikelder and Sashel and some others hurrying from the tents – and there too, thank the stars, was Gaelera, being dragged up the broad staircase towards him by Maeneb and Ingebré, each of them gripping an arm firmly. Maeneb looked furious. She seemed eager to speak; but he did not want to hear any complaints about Gaelera's stubbornness, not now, not in front of this Kelvhan captain.

So he said to Maeneb, to forestall her, "Take the Lady Gaelera to Commander Rhadlun, who is expecting her in the east wing." Then he strode on down the broad stone steps – each one a long, dipping wave – until he stopped abruptly half way down the flight.

The darkburn had come into view around the far end of the building. It was perhaps four hundred yards away. Even so, a wave of repulsion and despair washed over him. It is the aura, he told himself, it is nothing but the usual aura. So strong. But it means nothing.

Above the shoreline, seven tents were burnt or burning now. Amidst the smoke, Huldarion saw thick coils wrapped snake-like round an eighth. He swallowed down his nausea and tried to think dispassionately. A shame to lose so many of the tents; but better tents, by far, than lives.

So he spoke to the man beside him with brisk authority.

"I think, Captain Novesnu, that we need not attempt to tackle this thing for the moment. If it is content to feed upon our empty camp then let it. We'll take swift counsel on the best means of disposing of it: our wizard has been sent for and should be able to advise us. While we await him we'll join Solon and his company under the west wall."

He turned to walk that way. He was in command. Then, at a shout – a series of loud shouts – he started, and spun round again.

The serpent was on the move. It was untwining itself from the tent it had embraced, sinuous and hideously graceful for its vast size. Leaving behind a smoking skeleton, the darkburn lifted up its head that was not a head as if to test the air.

Then the long body rose, impossibly high – how could it balance? – before descending with increasing swiftness, thumping with a boom onto the ground. Huldarion felt the earth shudder even where he stood. A cloud of steam spread round the thing as it rose up again, its body heaving in black ripples. A snake grown to the size of a river, he thought; but a river of heat, of dark, destroying fire.

"It's coming this way," Novesnu muttered. Indeed, as the huge darkburn coiled and thudded down again, it was clear that it was heading directly for the monastery.

Huldarion felt paralysed. He could smell the darkburn now, that dreadful stench of burning and decay. Although he was too far away to feel its heat, his body began burning down one side, his scars remembering their genesis twelve years ago in the agony of the fight against that first horrific darkburn amidst the raging fires of Caervonn. Thus had his wounds burned, for so many months afterwards, while he had slowly healed.

The ruins of Caervonn. His last house. His first darkburn. He had learnt to fight the things since then, to overcome the dread and nausea they always brought; but this great monster, this was something different. Huge waves of horror washed over him until he feared drowning. He was aware of the sea's irregular pulse behind him, as the creature pulsed across the juddering sand. As if from far away, he heard the voice of the man next to him.

"I think we need to move," Novesnu said. "My Lord Huldarion."

"Yes. Yes. To our troops under the west wall. We can escape that way." Even as he spoke he realised that he was no longer thinking of standing strong to fight the thing. Only of escape. A darkburn of that size could not be slain by men with swords. Would it even be possible to injure it? To slow it down? His whole body rebelled from waiting there to face it. He wanted to escape now, *now*.

Yet his body did not want to move. The burning was growing more intense: it was verging now on agony to even stir his limbs. His legs seemed turned to blocks of red-hot stone. He saw Yaret running along the sand and up the monastery steps along with Delgeb and he thought distractedly, I wish I had two wooden legs, that would not feel this pain, that would not be transfixed with burning agony and terror.

He stood and waited. He had no choice.

"Huldarion," panted Delgeb, "is the monastery empty?"

"Our Riders should all be out," he answered. "The Kelvhans are still in the east wing." He was amazed that his voice worked so well.

"They need to leave. Because if that thing attacks the building—"

"A building of stone can withstand darkburns. It will not burn."

"But it can be crushed," said Delgeb, "and that thing is enormously heavy, and enormously strong."

A shock of realisation went through him. She was right – of course she was; and he had not even thought about it properly. "The Lady Gaelera," he said. "I have sent her in there."

"Then we need to get her out."

"And Meya," said Huldarion. "Meya."

The thought of Meya in danger filled him with new and closer panic. Meya! She seemed to symbolise his future crown. Despite the pain, he found his legs were freed from immobility by this fresh terror; they carried him back up the steps and through the eastern door. Yet he hardly knew what he was doing.

Novesnu followed him. Huldarion tried to gather himself, to think what action he must take, to speak calmly. He had made the wrong choice, a possibly disastrous choice: he must repair it. But he could not show his anguish.

Long habit came to his aid. Prioritise. Be logical. As two Kelvhan soldiers came hurrying down the stairs he addressed them firmly.

"The Lady Gaelera?"

"Upstairs, my lord."

"I'll go there. You two, check this lower floor of the east wing," he commanded. "Tell anyone still here to get out."

Delgeb and Yaret had entered too; and Delgeb said, "We'll check the dormitories, and make sure everyone has left."

He nodded and they raced off, Yaret nimble even with her wooden foot.

Now that the darkburn was again out of sight the pain abated. Although he wondered at this, he was chiefly grateful. He ran up the stairs to the landing of the east wing, with Novesnu close behind.

On the shadowy landing he turned to Novesnu. His mind too had grown a little clearer. "Check this middle floor, please, Captain."

"My Lord."

No argument. On impulse Huldarion reached out and clapped him on the shoulder. "Speed well," he said; he hardly knew why, except that he wished the man's steadfast impassivity to rub off on himself. Then Novesnu hastened off and Huldarion was running up the worn slippery stairs towards the upper floor.

And there, thank all the stars, causing his heart to fold over itself with passionate relief, were a handful of Kelvhan soldiers and Gaelera, along with Maeneb – and the Lady Meya. She was expostulating with the Kelvhans.

"Meya," he said, the force of his own voice surprising him. "Meya."

She turned to him. "I want to leave this place."

"Indeed you must," he said, "we must all leave it, now, as quickly as we can. Do not wait."

"Why?" asked one of the Kelvhans. "It's as strong as any fortress. Is this not the safest place to—"

The words were interrupted by a rumble: a close and heavy thunder, directly underneath them. Huldarion's legs shook. Something had just made the whole long building judder.

Chapter 34

At once Meya dashed out of the chamber. She was already at the top of the staircase when Huldarion caught her arm.

"Not down these stairs," he said, remembering that the creature had been approaching the east wing. "We'll go the length of the building, and down the staircase at the far end."

She nodded, and Huldarion, trying to hurry while still appearing calm, led them all across the landing into the main body of the monastery.

As he entered the first of the dormitories, there was another deep, vibrating rumble. The floor lurched underneath his feet, and then a crash soon followed – slow, drawn-out, and ending with a noise of falling rocks.

He stopped. That sound came from below, on the western side.

Running towards him, fleeing past the empty bunk beds, were Delgeb, Yaret and several others: Tamu, Herval, Ingebré and lastly Leor.

Tamu immediately began to pour out a stammering apology to Huldarion. "So sorry, I'm so sorry, I was trying to get him to come but he kept saying that he wanted to go up on to the roof and I couldn't–"

"I want to see this serpent," Leor said.

"Never mind that!" said Delgeb. "You'll see it soon enough. Huldarion, the floor of one of the dormitories has just fallen in. We can't get out that way."

"What shall we do?" Gaelera asked. She sounded, not alarmed, but merely interested. Huldarion inwardly cursed her and all her race of Kelvhans: for were they not the reason he was trapped here?

"Back to the stairs," he ordered. "If the creature's on the west side of the building, the east stairs may be safe." He took Meya's arm and hurried them back – only to see Novesnu running up the staircase with the other pair of Kelvhan soldiers.

"No way out down there," Novesnu said. "It's blocked. My Lady. My Lady." And he took the time to bow first to Meya and then Gaelera. Such are the constraints of Kelvhan rank, Huldarion thought distractedly.

"We'll go up on the roof," he said. "There's a walkway going round the walls. Up there the darkburn cannot reach us. Once it leaves the building we can decide on the safest route down."

"If there is one," Delgeb said. He gave her a look.

Back up the spiral stairs they ran, a large group now, Huldarion feeling like a small clay figure in some game of catch-cat where the pieces were shuttled busily around the board. He was the first to emerge on to the roof; the long slurred rush of the sea came to his ears. From the other direction there came the sound of screaming.

"Stay here," he commanded Meya and Gaelera. "Leor, you shall have your wish: come with me." He walked briskly with Leor and Novesnu along the section of the tumbled walkway that led to the front of the building. He steeled himself and prayed his legs would hold him as he looked down.

The air was hot and full of smoke. The screams came from a Kelvhan, with burning clothes and hair, who lay writhing on the steps. A little further down, the steps were littered with the bodies of three more, crushed and smoking. Probably the very men whom he had just ordered to evacuate the building. Amidst the bodies and the scattered rubble, like a vast log, lay a long black tail emerging from the monastery: it thrashed, once, with a heavy beat, and hit the injured Kelvhan. The man flailed and then was still.

The nausea. Fierce, helpless loathing. The dread, despair, the horror. It bid him fling himself off the high parapet into black oblivion. *Die, just die.* There was no other escape.

So his mind told him. Meanwhile his body told him that it was on fire. Reeling with the smell, the heat, the darkburn aura, he fought his way to will-power as if through a thicket of thorns and managed to take a step back. He heard his own voice saying, "Where is the rest of it?"

Delgeb leaned far over the parapet – he had not even noticed her follow him, and felt that he should reprimand her, except that he had not the will, no ability to organise the words; and in any case, to pull her back he would have had to lean right over and he could not do that.

So he said, "What do you see?" and was thankful that he could speak.

"Its head's inside the building," Delgeb pulled herself upright, with an effort. Her face was taut and grim: so were the others' countenances, reminding him that he was not the only one to suffer these effects. Even if the bodily pain was his alone, they all endured the mental anguish. They relied on him, and he must command himself.

"We will go back and follow the walkway to the other end," he said. "Leor. What do you know of this monster? What can you do about it?"

"It's a sea-serpent," Leor said, his voice hoarse with apparent shock. "I know nothing about sea-serpents."

"But about serpents, yes? About darkburns, yes? This one seems happy enough to be on land." He was sharp. "Think," he said. "And now walk back. Don't run." His body was a torment; each step a battle with his muscles. Yet he tried not to show it.

So he walked – did not run – back to the others where they stood on the south-facing parapet, overlooking the long fall to the sea. His stomach turned again at the sight of that crawling, curdling surface, an echo of the serpent's coils written in foam and restless water. He noticed that Yaret looked ill.

"Are you all right?" he said.

"It's the drop," she said, her mouth barely moving.

"Of course. I understand." Why should someone's else's clear distress make his own a little easier? It seemed a curious and shameful thing, yet so it was. He felt better knowing that she felt worse. And of course the darkburn was once more shielded from his sight. "Delgeb? Stay next to Yaret. Go carefully."

This last instruction was partly to himself, as he tried to ignore his unwilling limbs and set out to lead the way along the parapet, conscious of the grasping fingers of the sea below. The walkway was wide, if uneven; and although its bordering wall was broken, nobody was likely to fall over it unless completely overcome by vertigo or fear.

So do not be overcome, he thought. Command. Command.

Meya was directly behind him, with a long chain behind her: Herval, Ingebré, Gaelera, Maeneb and the Kelvhans, then Delgeb and Yaret, and lastly Tamu and Leor, who was tugging at his beard. A useless wizard, thought Huldarion with a surge of impotent anger, he has nothing to offer. Yet he knew that his anger was really directed at himself.

"Courage," he said to Meya, who was stepping carefully just behind him. "We are already half way there."

"If the staircase at the other end is not blocked," she said. How did it help anyone to say that? Again he felt anger surge up in him. Unfair, unfair. Control it.

But in what felt like a horrifying embodiment of his emotion, the floor beneath him abruptly surged up too. His feet rocked, sending a jolt through his body. At first he thought it was some betraying weakness of his muscles; but a second later, it was repeated, a shuddering thrust of stone beneath his feet. He clutched at the low wall, and then at Meya, grasping her gown tightly. She was starting to say something when the roof began to tilt.

For several yards on either side, the parapet was rising. The stones parted: the old wall gave up easily, and crumbled. Behind him, a Kelvhan cried out in alarm. Meya stumbled,

lurching sideways so that her gown tore in his grip. For a dreadful moment he thought she would go over the edge onto the rocks below.

He grabbed her by the nearest part of her that he could reach – her hair – and pulled her upright, seizing her arm whilst somehow keeping his own balance as the stone walkway rocked and swayed beneath them.

“Back! Back!” he cried, for he feared that the whole remainder of the roof was now about to fall. The long line staggered backwards towards the eastern end, Yaret collapsing on her hands and knees as they reached the staircase they had come from. There was a clatter and thunderous rumble of loosened stones; but the monastery roof did not fall in.

Instead, it rose. Grinding and clashing, the remains of the parapet, thick stone beams and pavers all heaved up into the sky, seeming to form an impossible tower – a flying path of tumbling stones – until he realised that behind them was a long, uncurling, thrusting neck: an eyeless head that twisted, seeking.

It was Huldarion’s turn to stumble to his knees. Novesnu helped him up. He looked at Meya, who seemed bewildered and indignant – oddly unafraid. Yet he was afraid. How could he save her? Save all of them?

For even if the serpent couldn’t reach them here, the walkway was in danger of collapse: the roof beneath their feet, the staircase, all of it. The world roared around him, sea and stones together in a terrifying chorus. Everything was trembling, and so was he.

“Leor!” he cried out. “Do something!”

The wizard’s mouth was open. He looked stunned. He will do nothing, thought Huldarion wildly, he is as witless and useless in the face of this monster as I am.

“Back down the stairs!” he ordered. The Kelvhans were already trying to usher Gaelera down the staircase, although she seemed reluctant. She was staring at the darkburn.

Huldarion turned his head. More of the serpent was emerging from the roof, its long neck reaching higher and higher, stones bouncing from its black scaly flanks as it rose. He glimpsed tiny, rudimentary legs. They were as nothing next to that thick twining body, which shed flakes of soot or charcoal as it ascended. How long was it? Surely it could not bear its own weight. Soon it must collapse...

And then it did: the long neck quivered and at last began to fall.

“Go,” said Huldarion, shoving Meya towards the staircase. He had never experienced an earthquake, but that was surely what he felt as the long body thumped down on the parapet. The vibration echoed through him, trying to shake his joints loose and remove all power from his muscles. Stones were sent hurtling through the air as if on wings and then began the long trajectory down the cliff face to the rocks below: he heard the clatter and splash above the roar of waves.

He pushed the others over to the staircase. Gaelera stood transfixed, but not with terror – almost with excitement. Maeneb tried in vain to drag her on.

“Go!” shouted Huldarion, and the Kelvhans, thankfully, herded Meya down and ran down after her, just as he felt another juddering deep thump reverberate right through his bones. The thing was on the move. It had hauled more of its body onto the parapet, shedding great stones as easily as gravel down into the sea.

Another heave, and the serpent pulled its entire body out of the monastery, like some huge revolting parasite that had been lurking there whilst eating its host from the inside. Now it lay at full length along the roof in steaming, twitching undulations. The heat was intense – as was the almost incapacitating aura.

Before Huldarion could prevent her Delgeb pushed past him, sword in hand. She ran up to the blunt twitching head and hacked it with her sword. The steel bounced off, recoiling

sharply: but she took the hilt in both her hands to stab the thing, and this time the blade went in.

The head reared up and writhed. Delgeb leapt back, leaving her sword buried in the creature's neck. Huldarion saw that hers was not the only sword-hilt visible there. There were already two others.

And an instant later there was a fourth: as Delgeb retreated, Ingebré ran up to take her place and do the same, stabbing at the neck. But although the creature pulsed and reared Huldarion thought the swordstrokes could be little more to it than pinpricks. All the same, he was wondering whether to risk his own sword in the same way – and his own life, but he was not dispensable – when he was flung backwards into Novesnu.

It was by no action of the darkburn. He was momentarily blinded and half-stunned by the dazzling crackle of a bolt of lightning. It came from Leor's outstretched arms and hit the darkburn in the middle of the body. The creature squirmed, before it flung its head a few yards closer to them with another heavy thump.

Huldarion was exasperated. How could lightning wound a thing that was already burnt to cinders? The wizard was more likely to roast the Riders than destroy the serpent. "Fire is no good!" he yelled at Leor, who was looking bemused at his own effort. "Retreat! Get down the stairs!" For everyone was standing here too long, gaping at the convulsions of the darkburn.

"It wants to die," said Yaret wretchedly. "It wants us to kill it."

What nonsense. He had no time for this. Yet in another, inward, flash as if of self-made lightning, the scene before him was inverted. He was himself a giant wyrm, blind and writhing in the darkness – scorching, excoriating, constant darkness – looking for an end. For relief. For death.

He was shocked. But then the scene abruptly switched back to reality. He was a man in trouble on a rooftop, trying to save his people from a monster.

Again the head rose: the body coiled its bulk against the stones, as if bracing itself to rise up again. But it seemed to struggle. A spasm pulsed along its body. Could it after all be wounded?

"Maybe it can't support its own weight," said Tamu suddenly. "Maybe it can only survive out of the water for a while."

"It's been out too long already," Maeneb snapped; and she drew a short knife and ran forward to attack the darkburn as the other women had.

"No, no!" cried Gaelera. Finally she moved – but not to safety. She rushed after Maeneb. Nobody was close enough to stop her except Yaret, who made an attempt to put herself into Gaelera's path.

Gaelera shoved her aside as if she were made of straw. Yaret fell over: Gaelera ran on after Maeneb, her wide skirts stiff, her arms outreached as if in pleading.

Maeneb raced up to the darkburn and plunged her knife deep into its neck. Before she could retreat, the huge body heaved in a new convulsion. With a harsh loud crack, more of the parapet collapsed.

Not just the parapet. Suddenly the whole building underneath their feet was quaking, as the darkburn flailed along its edge. It raised its neck and brought it down again with a crash of masonry. Then Huldarion heard a great rumbling roar that at first he thought came from the creature's mouth: but no, it was the cry of the monastery itself as its stones were ripped asunder and the whole south wall began to tumble.

The long neck whipped round with devastating swiftness. It caught Maeneb and Gaelera; it flicked them, in a hurtle of legs and arms, and threw them both far out, beyond the swiftly crumbling wall. Huldarion, in mute horror, saw the pair of women – separate now – turn in the air like discarded dolls and then begin the long drop to the sea.

A second later the wyrm itself began to fall. Its head reached out towards him even as its body descended amidst an avalanche of falling stones, in a thunder of destruction that blended with the roaring crash of waves.

The tumult echoed in his ears. He stood there stunned. The thing was gone. But Maeneb and Gaelera – lost. Maeneb, his trusted friend, his faithful Rider.

And Gaelera. Her disappearance filled him with appalling horror, because of the consequences. She had been under his protection. All the Kelvhans but Novesnu had already fled down the staircase and had not seen their Post-Regent's daughter being flung into the sea. How could he excuse it to them? What could he do?

He could not speak. He could not move. A sickness of horror and shame invaded him, a dreadful serpent eating his insides.

But Novesnu, next to him, said tersely, "They can survive. They got thrown out far enough. If they can swim."

"Maeneb can swim," said Delgeb. "Can Gaelera?"

"Most likely not. But I can," said Novesnu. He was pulling off his cuirass and boots as he spoke. Two seconds later, he had taken a run at the remnant of the parapet and leapt out.

Still Huldarion found himself speechless; immobile. If he tried to move he would fall over. He could not look over the side. He could not bear to see the man's body dashed against the rocks.

But Delgeb, less squeamish, stepped to the ruined edge to peer down. "He's in the water. And I can see Maeneb too. She's swimming."

"Gaelera?" He heard his own voice croaking like a raven's.

"No... Oh, yes, yes! There she is. I see her head."

He forced his limbs to walk across to the now precarious edge, and looked. Three heads were bobbing in the water: out beyond them, the swelling and steaming of the waves showed where the darkburn had most likely gone, submerged once more for now.

It ought to have been me who leapt in after them, thought Huldarion. And yet I could not have helped: my scars will not allow me to swim well enough: that thing would drown me.

Nobody else showed any inclination to hurl themselves into the sea. Yaret was on her knees and throwing up.

Yet Huldarion himself began to feel a little less sick with fear. Gaelera was alive. Now, with the darkburn invisible underneath the waves, he was able to pretend a self-command he did not feel. Had anybody guessed his helplessness?

"Unless the darkburn swims away, the seas round it will boil," said Tamu urgently. "We need to fish them out."

"Then let us get down to the shore as fast as possible," Huldarion said forcefully. "There must be some exit that isn't fully blocked. We need to find it."

"We need a boat," said Leor mournfully.

"Well, you can conjure up a boat for us, can't you, Leor?" he demanded tersely. "Any sort of raft would do."

"I don't know," said Leor. Huldarion mutely cursed the wizard as doubly, triply useless. But he himself could act now: and he needed to get everybody out of the collapsing building.

"Down, down," he shouted, shepherding them down the staircase to the first landing where Meya and the Kelvhans waited.

"Where is Gaelera?" Meya asked him with a frown.

"With Novesnu. No time to explain. Move on, quickly." Thankfully she did not argue as they ran on down the next flight of stairs.

Below that, in the shadows, his heart sank; for the bottom of the staircase appeared at first glance to be blocked with fallen stones. But light was seeping past the barrier, and on coming

closer he saw a narrow gap where, if they could move some of the rubble, they might scramble through.

"Help me shift these blocks," he told the Kelvhans, and helped them heave and roll away the biggest of the obstacles. More light appeared: the gap grew wider. Eventually it would grow wide enough to let them out.

But not yet. This all took too long. He himself felt scarcely able to lift even the smaller rocks; for he was grimly conscious of the continuing pain down his left side. Every movement needed gritted teeth.

He was exasperated with his own body. Why could it not do his bidding, when his people needed him? How many had died while he was running up and down the stairs? Did Gaelera live, did Maeneb? How many more would die, if the darkburn came ashore again?

And here he was, still sick with shame and fury at himself, and trapped within the monastery.

Chapter 35

Maeneb spat out a mouthful of salty water and pedalled herself around. The surface rocked with liquid hills; steam rose in puffs and wisps. It was warm, this water, so she guessed the serpent was somewhere in there with her, although she couldn't see it.

It had caught her round the waist, burning through the leather jerkin – but only for an instant. She had been fully conscious when she was flung in. But what a fling! She had thought it would go on for ever, that soaring flight and fall, until suddenly she'd been underwater and battling her way up. At least no shock of cold disabled her. She had shrugged off the burnt jerkin and prised away her boots to make it easier to swim.

Now she trod water. Where was Gaelera? What did the stupid woman think she had been doing? What had she intended – to poke the serpent with a pin?

But there she was, thank the stars above: her head was bobbing not too far away. As Maeneb began to swim towards her she saw another small dark figure leap out from the building's ruined top, a shower of stones following. The stones fell clattering against the bottom of the cliff, but the figure plunged into the sea.

Then she lost them both amongst the rocking waves which threw her to and fro like a piece of flotsam. She feared that every fretful swell of water was the serpent: but it did not reappear. Maybe it was deep beneath her, an uneasy thought.

A moment later she caught another glimpse of Gaelera, this time with a second head close by hers in the water: it was that Kelvhan captain. Gaelera seemed to be endeavouring to fight him off before she sank beneath the waves. Was he trying to drown her?

Maeneb swam over, the waves swamping her from second to second. But when she reached Gaelera she saw that the Kelvhan was trying to hold her up. It was her dress that was trying to drown her.

"Take it off," yelled Maeneb, getting another mouthful of warm salty water. "Take it off." The dress was burnt. But of course Gaelera could not take it off, it would need a maid and a full quarter-hour to undo all the tiny hooks and buttons down the back of the bodice. "Hold her up," she yelled at the Kelvhan, and she grabbed the back of Gaelera's dress in both her hands and ripped.

What an oddly satisfying thing. But Gaelera screamed and thrashed at her.

"Oh, shut up," yelled Maeneb, and she began to pull the sleeves down, Gaelera kicking her underwater all the time. But Maeneb tugged furiously at the seams until half the skirt was loose. She ripped it off and watched it drift away, sinking, like some wallowing sea-creature heading for the bottom. And then Gaelera herself pulled off the stiff bodice, to reveal her under-linen – embroidered of course, but much lighter than her overclothes.

Yet despite losing the weight of her skirts she began to sink again and was dragged up to the surface by the Kelvhan.

"Keep still, my lady," he shouted over the roar of the sea. "I'm going to hold you up." He grasped her underneath the chin and began to swim on his back, dragging her along. Gaelera did not thrash and flounder any more, but lay quite passive, drifting in her petticoats, hair streaming on the water.

"Stay away from the cliffs," the soldier cried to Maeneb; and she understood. The waves would dash them on those rocks. They needed to find a shallower beach and hope they would wash up on it.

She knew there was a beach to the east, for she had walked along it only yesterday. But the current would not let them swim that way. It pushed them west, so forcefully that they had no option but to go with it. The Kelvhan stayed on his back, towing Gaelera, who had ceased to

struggle except when from time to time a larger wave crashed over them and sent them underwater. Each time, the Kelvhan pulled her up again. He seemed a strong swimmer; but Maeneb already felt herself tiring.

The steam around them grew thicker, and the water warmer: yet Maeneb, surfacing and gulping hot air, still could not see the serpent. The choppy waves and billowing steam hid any tell-tale bulge upon the surface.

She hoped it had swum far out to sea – but the water told a different tale. It was definitely heating up. The darkburn must be somewhere close, she knew. Where was the shore? Nothing was visible in this fog of steam.

Above the crash of waves she thought she could hear distant shouting. Rescuers? That brief hope was immediately gone. For from close on her left there came a more ominous noise: a hiss. Huge plumes of steam rose up as if from a colossal kettle.

And then, no more than twenty yards away, she saw it: the mound rising in the sea, silver and green until it shed the water from its flanks and turned to steam and then to blackness. She saw the swell of the long body. Where was the head? Could it see them, smell them? Which way was it facing?

Too close, too close, was her immediate thought. The water now was not just warm but growing hotter with each wave that surged towards them. In her mind she saw the helpless Durba caught in the creature's coils, to be left a burnt and mangled wreck.

We're about to follow her; we're going to be broiled like cabbages, thought Maeneb in blank dismay. I had rather let myself drown first.

And next to her Gaelera suddenly began to struggle.

Too hot, too hot. No doubt the heat was what Gaelera fought against: but Maeneb felt a lethargy that made her limbs slow down, the legs want to cease kicking, her face turn up and gasp for cooler air. How long would it take to drown? Could she force herself to let go and do it? Soon she might have no choice. She drank in gulps of steam which did not satisfy her lungs. Her body was protesting. She thought she saw a sheen, as if of long hair floating on the surface; was it Durba's or her own?

Durba, she said into the over-heated water. Where are you? Where did you go?

Another hot wave submerged her. It took an effort to come up. She threshed and gasped in sweltering steam. Her heart was pounding now, her brain was thick and heavy, she needed some relief, some cold cold rock to cling to...

And there, suddenly, bizarrely, there it was. A sheen held the water's surface still: it looked like a thin layer of glass. She swam into it, and it immediately broke up into fragments. But there was another, a thin slick sheet that cracked and shattered as her flailing arms made contact with it. It was wonderfully cold.

Ice. Ice floating on a heated sea. For a moment Maeneb did not even question it, just floundered to the next shimmering sheet and lay on it feeling it crumble to dissolving shards beneath her body – but it was cool for those few seconds, so blessedly cool!

She breathed great gasps of air – that, too, had cooled a little – and saw another thin slab of ice take shape before her eyes. First, that oily sheen upon the water: seconds later, it solidified, with a faint sound of cracking, sending out long strands of icy hair to bind the surface, becoming a sheet that grew rapidly out and down into the water. This one was soon two inches thick, a whitish raft of ice.

It must be Leor's work. No other explanation came to mind: no natural force could do the work of a freezing winter week in seconds. She looked up through the mist to the monastery's parapet – or what was left of it: an uneven silhouette atop the cliffs. No-one stood there looking down. All the same, this must be Leor's work. She blessed him to the stars.

And then withdrew that blessing; for as she looked around she seemed to see that sheen of drowning hair on every side. It was all ice. Crystals were continuously growing from small specks into long pointed fingers that reached out for her: the ice was spreading rapidly across the sea, poking at her skin with sharp cold nails. She must not get trapped under it.

"Watch out!" she shouted at the Kelvhan, who was still swimming on his back with Gaelera in tow, pushing his way against new sheets of ice. "Don't stay in the water! We need to get on top of it!"

For the thin sheets were now linking with each other, trying to form a continuous plane. Despite the frequent cracks and splits as the restless sea fought back, the ice was winning – and at an extraordinary pace. Already the sea felt slushy. The sheets of ice swayed less. The nearest one to Maeneb was bigger than a mattress, and as thick, and still growing visibly: it nudged her knees as she trod water next to it.

She had to board it. Not an easy task. She slipped and slithered as she tried to find a handhold: and when she had gripped at a numbingly cold crack, it took several attempts before she could haul one knee up onto the slab of ice. But then the other knee followed, and she lay sprawled on top, trying not to slide off as the glistening raft beneath her tilted.

Stay in the middle, she told herself. Spreading out her arms and legs she laid her cheek upon the ice to feel the chill run through her face and body. It was a huge relief. She closed her eyes and savoured the delightful coolness. Durba's hair, turned to fine white crystals: Durba's skin, a giant naked body drifting, clear and cold.

Why had Durba done it? The picture turned over and over in her head: Durba running at the darkburn across the steaming sand. So brave, so foolhardy. Having stabbed the thing, why had she not just run away again? Had she not been able? Had she not wanted to?

Maeneb rested her forehead on the slab as if it would tell her something. But Durba was a mangled corpse upon the shoreline. She was not here. There was no answer in the ice.

Think of now. What about the Kelvhan and Gaelera? Raising her head, Maeneb saw the soldier ahead of her; somehow he had managed to push Gaelera up onto another slab of ice and now he was struggling to heave himself up after her. Gaelera sat rigidly, doing nothing to help him. She was probably afraid of sliding off: Maeneb felt that she herself could not have stirred, precariously laid out on her slab as she was, like a lump of chilling meat. One sudden move might tip her back into the water.

The Kelvhan's strength must be great, however – for with another heave he drew himself right up onto Gaelera's slab, crawled a yard and lay there panting next to her, his chest heaving.

Gaelera ignored him. She sat up with her lips slightly parted, her linen underdress torn and bedraggled. What was she thinking? Impossible to tell. She was staring out to sea.

Of course – she was looking for the darkburn. Which Maeneb had momentarily forgotten in her effort to mount the ice. Now she gazed around to check how close it was.

At first it was not visible. For a hundred yards in each direction, sheets of ice swayed and broke into jagged upward-pointing blades that grated and then fused together in fresh, irregular sheets: a newly made white sea that did not seem to know quite what to do, how to behave. The steam was clearing rapidly and the waves were muted, their rush and roar replaced by a sullen shallow swell and a constant throaty groaning.

And then she saw the darkburn. That sudden upthrust of the ice, about seventy yards away. The head emerged, followed by the long black neck: it did not rise as high as it had previously, but instead flopped down upon a slab of ice that instantly began to hiss and steam. The darkburn's heat must have cut through it – yet not immediately; for only slowly did the neck sink down into the channel it was forming in the ice.

Then both head and neck vanished underwater for many seconds, until they emerged once more in a shower of water: she felt a gust of warmer air before the serpent's snaking neck thumped down a second time on to another slab of ice and began to slowly melt its way down through it.

Maeneb watched, transfixed despite her own predicament. Durba would have liked this, she thought. Could she see it now? She seemed to glimpse Durba, sitting, long hair loose, on a nearby block of ice. Tricks of the steam and her own befuddled brain. A mermaid of the mind, watching the instrument of her death. Had that really happened?

Around the thrashing darkburn the ice was taking on strange, other-worldly shapes. Hollow curving domes and caves and columns were being sculpted, melting and refreezing as she gazed, as if the thing were assiduously creating some fellow monster out of ice. Was it trying to attack the ice-floes with those writhings? Did it know what ice was?

Death is cold, said Durba.

And it occurred to her that in its repeated thrusting at the ice the serpent might be endeavouring to cool itself. A strange idea and surely one that could not possibly be true. Yet to cool a darkburn sufficiently might be to kill it.

Death is cold. She remember Rothir describing darkburns he had seen submerged in the stagnant pools west of the Gyr. Not fully dead, but dormant.

At least this huge foul serpentlike darkburn was not attacking them, for now. Maybe her stones repelled it: for when she checked, she still had two inside her inner pocket. But no; she reflected that on the monastery roof all the stones in many pockets had failed to repel the thing.

Whatever the reason, it kept its distance for the moment, twining, carving slowly through the ice. She turned her head to assess her own position.

The ice rafts, drifting slowly westward, were now well past the section of the cliff on which the monastery stood. The cliff's end, where it lowered itself again to sea level, was not too far ahead. Eventually they might drift there – but only gradually. For the whole sea had become sluggish with ice.

Her raft and Gaelera's were only a few yards apart; more chunks of ice were filling up the space between. The swaying of her slab had become much less intense as it had grown in width. And it was very cold. The glad relief of coolness had now gone: Maeneb was shivering. She sat up, like Gaelera, to minimise the contact of her skin with ice.

How had Leor managed this? It was an extraordinary feat, one she would not have thought him capable of. For still the ice was thickening, the plates breaking less frequently, tightening together more securely. Would ice spread right across the seas and hold them all fast in its grip? Would it spread up the rivers? The thought chilled her mind even more than her cold platform chilled her legs.

Carefully she stood up, her wet clothes sticking to the ice. She pulled them free. The slab barely shifted underneath her as she got to her feet and looked around.

There was the darkburn, within its own ice harbour. She saw a flash of a dark coil appear and disappear amidst the white. Beyond it was more white – but it did not extend too far. Well before the horizon she could see the dark swell and shifting glint of waves.

She frowned at the diminishing line of cliffs. Although the end of them was close now, the steady drift of her ice raft had slowed almost to a complete stop. The slabs and chunks of ice that had been grinding together, sometimes with almost deafening rasps and groans, were now joining forces: fusing to create one vast white rocky sheet that went right up to the shore.

"See there!" she shouted at the others. "We can walk to land."

The Kelvhan stood up cautiously and gazed around. Maeneb walked gingerly across her slab, on stockinged feet that were rapidly becoming numb: although it dipped a little

underneath her weight, it did not move enough to tip her off. The edge was frozen fast to the next slab, so she stepped across the icy joint. With every step her path seemed to feel more solid.

"Gaelera!" she called. "Stand up and walk. We need to get to shore."

Gaelera, dismissing the Kelvhan's offered hand, was already getting to her feet. She did not walk gingerly; without hesitation, without a pause to test the ice, she set off marching as if she expected a royal trackway to have been laid out for her. Maybe it had been. Maybe that was part of Leor's plan; for as they crossed the ice floes, parallel to the cliff, the ice beneath them scarcely stirred. Twice Maeneb slid and fell, but without injury.

Thus the three of them walked beside the shrinking cliff – Gaelera never faltering – until they came round a final projection where the edge plunged down to sea-level. And there beyond it was the shore.

Maeneb had expected to see someone looking for them, Riders or Kelvhans reaching out to greet them with relief. Where was everybody? She paused atop the frozen sea and wondered. Had the army frozen too? She could hear nothing but the creaking of the ice.

And she herself felt frozen. Not in body, apart from her feet, which had progressed from numbness to throbbing pain; but in her mind. She looked back, searching for a fourth survivor, somehow miraculously brought back to life by ice.

But she could no longer see even those strange glittering strands of crystal hair. Only a cold hard sea with a giant darkburn making and remaking some ever-changing form. Durba was dead. She knew that. She simply did not feel that it was so.

I would prefer Gaelera to have died instead, she thought, despite the trouble it would cause. Kept alive she will cause trouble anyway. I do not trust her: she is too like me.

Gaelera had stopped now also, poised like a statue on her raft, looking to the shore. The Kelvhan soldier stood watchfully behind her. Maeneb began to run, heedless of her painful feet, skidding and leaping so that she would arrive at the ice's edge before the others did.

She jumped off the ice onto the wet stones of the beach, on which she could not run but only walk with caution. Although the steam had lessened, a rise of grassy dunes prevented her from seeing inland. But now she could hear distant shouting.

Gaelera and the Kelvhan followed her on to shore. She turned to address them curtly.

"I don't know what's been happening. I'd better go and check it's safe. You two stay here."

"I shall, indeed," Gaelera said. "It is my wish to view the serpent before it disappears."

"If it disappears," said Maeneb grimly. "I need to find Huldarion."

The Kelvhan nodded. "I will guard the lady," he told her.

Gaelera ran her hands down her wet skirts, and turned her face towards where the sun lurked, a mere glimmer behind the mist. Sleek, wet, basking like a seal, thought Maeneb.

She turned away and trudged across the stones until they turned to sand and grass. Then she could run.

And for a disconcerting instant she saw Durba running alongside her, dripping, smiling in anticipation of excitement.

"What were you doing? This is not a game," said Maeneb.

"But it is an adventure," Durba said, eyes bright. Her voice had no sound.

"It is not! It is not an adventure!" Maeneb muttered furiously. "Go back! Go back! Just go away!"

"Ohhhh," said Durba, with a long sigh of waves on shingle. Her image slid apart and was dissolved into the sea.

Chapter 36

As Maeneb ran over the dunes she was still thinking about why Durba had done it. Or, rather, she was trying not to think, but the thoughts revolved and would not rest until she looked at them.

A will to die? Some need to impress? Had Durba thought she could actually succeed in disabling the great darkburn? Sheer stupidity?

You did the same yourself, one of her revolving thoughts reminded her.

Not the same, she thought back. *I was not reckless. I withdrew. Why didn't she?*

She was running east towards the monastery, its broken top just now becoming visible. As she climbed the final dune and looked out from its grassy dome, all other thoughts retreated. She gaped at the scene.

What had happened? Battle? Ambush? Her heart was jumping wildly. In vain she ordered it to calm, and told herself that all those corpses looked like stonemen. And that there weren't that many of them after all. A dozen, maybe fifteen, scattered, seeping blood: an attack, but small and quickly overcome.

She stepped closer. None of these men's stones had yet been harvested. No Riders lingered here to do the grisly job although in the distance she could now see groups of them were gathered, and heard raised voices wafting on the breeze. Were the Riders arguing about the darkburn; or did they expect another ambush?

One of the dead men made a gurgling groan. Maeneb walked over to him, feeling for her knife, which of course was not there. The stoneman was twitching; a short man, five stones in his head, a gash across his throat, another opening up his belly. She picked up a knife that lay nearby and dispatched him by widening the first gash. He didn't seem to notice her before he died.

Then she inspected the knife – a typical stoneman's, plain and crude but sharp; it would do for now. She stuck it in her belt.

Better check for other survivors. She walked around the group kicking at the bodies. They were all extremely dead. One, half-covered by a bloody cloak, lay on top of a dead comrade; she tugged the upper corpse away and sighed in regret and exasperation.

No stones in this head. But the man was not a Rider either. He had ridden with the hunters, and Yaret had been friendly with him. Zan, the homeless vagabond: a solemn man, no fighter. She threw the cloak over his face, and straightened up. What was it that Yaret had done on being confronted with a death? Some ritual of her people. Some acknowledgement, a murmur in her own strange tongue.

Maeneb said to the cloak, "Sorry. You tried, at least. Go well, wherever you go."

Before she turned away it occurred to her that she could do with some shoes. Zan's feet were too big; and so were those of the dead stonemen beside him. So she returned to the first corpse, which was the smallest, and pulled the shoes off the now lifeless feet. They were surprisingly robustly made, with leather laced across the top, and a pattern of coiled rope glued on the soles. They fitted, more or less. At least they didn't feel too bad as she began to walk away.

And paused.

Maeneb turned around again, and said aloud, "I need the shoes. You needed to die. I suppose you were just following orders. Not always the best thing to do." Then she shrugged, and continued on her way.

The shoes felt odd, but they didn't fall off. As she walked she saw many Riders gathered over by the monastery, while others to her left were thronging round the ruined town in strange disorder. She heard raised voices, shouts. Where was Huldarion?

Recognising Parthenal, she waved and began to run towards him, until one of the new shoes did fall off. He strode towards her while she was retying the stiff lace.

"What happened?" she said.

"About twenty stonemen happened," he replied. "Must have been hiding on the shore; probably a small garrison who were left here. They attacked Solon and his company."

"He dealt with them, though," she said.

"Yes. But it wasn't as straightforward as it should have been," said Parthenal, frowning. "There was some fracas in the troops. Those men of Melmet; you know the ones that Yaret hung out with?"

"Vaguely."

"They were causing trouble. Don't know why. What happened to the giant darkburn? Someone said the sea had frozen but I haven't had a chance to look. Is it true?"

"It is. The darkburn fell from the monastery down into the sea, which froze. It got carried out on the ice; quite a long way out last time I looked."

"Leor's work?"

"Probably."

"Are you all right? You're very wet."

"I'll manage." She straightened up. "Where's Huldarion? I need to let him know Gaelera's safe. We both ended up in the water, but now she's back on shore."

"Alone?"

"She's got a Kelvhan captain guarding her."

Parthenal nodded. "Good. Huldarion's still inside the building." He pointed to the monastery, a newly-shattered, blackened shell. "The entrances are blocked so they've been trying to get him out."

They walked together to the entrance where Ikelder and a team of men were working in near silence, punctuated only by grunts. As Maeneb approached the rubble-filled doorway two men were lifting out a broken slab.

"Nearly there," Ikelder called into the wall. "Can you push it on your side?"

In answer, the heaped stones shuddered, and more fell away in a shower of gravel. Huldarion's head and shoulders appeared in the gap, grey and aged with dust. He looked as tired as Maeneb had ever seen him.

He withdrew, and after the clunking of more rubble, Meya emerged to clamber inelegantly through the enlarged opening with Ikelder's aid. Next came Ingebré and Yaret, then Tamu, the five Kelvhan soldiers, Herval, Delgeb, Leor and lastly Huldarion himself. All safe then. All safe except for Durba. It bewildered her.

"Maeneb!" exclaimed Yaret. "You're all right! *Are* you all right?" She was very pale. She stumbled forwards towards Maeneb as if about to take her in her arms. Maeneb gave her a look which made her stop.

"Yes. So is Gaelera," she said, now addressing Huldarion, who stood brushing grit from his clothes. "She's uninjured, and is down at the seashore half a mile west. The Kelvhan captain's looking after her."

"Novesnu," said Huldarion, his voice hoarse and sounding oddly desolate, when he should have been relieved.

"Whatever his name is. He saved Gaelera from drowning, but then the sea began to heat up alarmingly. We were all about to broil when the water turned to ice." Maeneb looked at Leor. "Your work, I presume, Leor? Very effective it was too. Apart from nearly freezing us alive."

"I froze the sea? The whole sea?" Leor wiped his face with his sleeve, leaving smears of ash. He sounded stunned.

"Not all. A good part of it. The darkburn was a long way out amidst the ice when last I looked."

"My Lord Huldarion," put in Ikelder, "I can confirm that the ice is widespread; the watchmen saw no darkburn, but did note a distant cloud of steam far out to sea."

"I froze the sea?" repeated Leor.

"You must know what you did," said Maeneb, impatient.

"Thank you, Ikelder," said Huldarion. "Please take three men, go to find the Lady Gaelera, and escort her back to us." His voice was emotionless; his mind a whirlpool of emotions that Maeneb could not begin to decipher. "Leor," he went on, "go with Ikelder. Find out exactly what this spell of yours has done. Make sure it's strong enough to keep the darkburn well away until we leave this place."

"But don't let the ice spread too far," warned Maeneb.

"I'll go and look," said Leor, subdued. He went off with Ikelder, and Tamu scuttled after them.

"We are most glad to see you are unhurt, my Lord Huldarion," said Parthenal. Maeneb could sense his true relief, unlike Huldarion's; an odd mixture of both pain and joy. "And my lady too, of course."

Huldarion, brushing down his sleeves, did not immediately answer.

"But we'd best move as soon as possible," added Parthenal, "in case this whole structure should decide to tumble."

"Indeed, we better had," said Meya. "Our carriages are over by the ruined temple, are they not?"

And now Huldarion looked out and saw the crowd of Riders arguing. A faint hubbub of raised voices was audible. "What has been going on?" His voice was weary.

"There was an attack by a small number of stonemen, who must have been lurking nearby. They were put down easily – Solon and his men saw to it – but it appears to have caused some dispute," answered Parthenal.

"I must go and see," said Huldarion. Still he did not move.

"Let us summon your people to the temple," Meya said, "where you may speak to all of them at once, and they may see you are unhurt."

"Indeed," said Huldarion. Yet it was a few more seconds before he stirred himself and walked away.

Yaret and Maeneb followed. Parthenal joined them, whispering to Maeneb, "Can you tell what's wrong with him?"

"He's shaken up," she whispered back. "I can't tell more than that. Huldarion has always been hard to read." But even if she knew Huldarion's thoughts she would not have divulged them. Up on the monastery roof she had felt from Huldarion a definite and surprising fear – blue-grey, as thick and clammy as the sea. She would not tell Parthenal that.

Parthenal shook his head. "I should have been readier when the alarm sounded. But I was fast asleep." He looked around. "Where did Tamu go?"

"With Leor." As they walked behind Huldarion she outlined to him, in brief words, how the linwyrms had attacked the group on top of the monastery, and had been attacked in turn.

"That was extraordinarily brave of you, to try and stab it. I couldn't move," said Yaret. "And when you fell over the edge into the sea..."

"I swam," said Maeneb shortly, to avoid any show of sympathy that Yaret might feel tempted to make. "I have both my legs, which helped."

As they neared the town Uld came hurrying up, saluted Huldarion and began to talk in a low, urgent voice. After a moment Huldarion stopped dead; then he moved on stiffly, and more slowly. The fear was back. A different fear perhaps; reddish-brown, less clogging. But dismaying to Maeneb none the less.

Huldarion is out of his depth here, she thought. What is going on? What more can go wrong than already has? What do I not know?

More Riders came running up, all wanting to speak to Huldarion. He motioned them away and kept trudging towards the temple.

There, on the muddy grass before the central stones, a fight was taking place – or rather, was just finishing. One of the men of Melmet was picking himself up off the ground, while Orbrel flailed at him with wild fists. Orbrel was usually so good-natured that it was a shock to see him being restrained by other Riders.

“Ach,” said Yaret in a tone of exasperation. “That’s Inthed. I might have guessed.”

“A trouble-maker, is he?” muttered Parthenal.

Maeneb did not hear her reply. The crowd was shifting, parting to let Huldarion through; and when it closed again she was separated from the other pair.

Huldarion climbed up on to a fallen slab and turned to face his people, who were restless, many calling out. The single upright stone leaned heavily towards him, throwing a shadow on his blighted face.

“Be still. I can hear only one of you at a time,” he said evenly, and out of long duty and respect for him the crowd immediately fell silent. He looked around and said again, “Be still,” although Maeneb knew that he himself was anything but. He was bidding himself as much as his Riders. Yet they stilled, like children calmed by a beloved teacher’s voice, and waited while he spoke.

“My people,” said Huldarion, “believe me, I understand how disturbing was that immense darkburn from the sea. A thing unprecedented – a dreadful thing indeed – but it has now been quelled, and the stonemen beaten. We shall leave this place as soon as possible. So have courage.”

“It wasn’t *that*,” said Landel, his voice high; and again a dozen voices called out, breaking against each other like turbulent waves.

“Stop,” Huldarion commanded. “Hilbré: speak.”

She spoke in clear, low tones. “My lord. As Landel says, it was not the darkburn that threw us into such confusion. Nor was it the sudden attack by stonemen over yonder. The outcome of that fight was not in doubt – until a rumour started up amongst Solon’s company, the ones who fought those stonemen. The rumour spread, and we all need to know the truth of it.”

“A rumour,” said Huldarion.

“A rumour that some of the stonemen may be really children.”

“Children!” echoed Landel, in an anguished cry.

Maeneb felt Huldarion’s mind freeze in apprehension. Yet his face frowned, as if he did not understand. “Children?”

“People are saying that those with the fewest stones are only boys,” Hilbré continued. “Not even teenagers, perhaps – no more than ten or twelve years old.”

“People are saying?” repeated Huldarion, more sternly now. “What people? Where did this story come from?”

“I heard it first from Landel,” Hilbré said.

“Well, Landel? What have you to say?”

“I heard it from Brodenir,” said Landel, his voice high with emotion.

Huldarion's gaze sought out Brodenir, who had acted as Solon's second-in-command since Aretor had been wounded. "Brodenir? What's your excuse? Did I promote you for rumour-mongering?"

"I had the story from a man of Melmet," he replied. "That one who's been brawling, over there." He pointed with some disdain to the man Yaret had named as Inthed.

Huldarion turned to Inthed, who was rubbing his arms. "So, a brawler and a trouble-maker. Why were you fighting Orbrel?" he enquired, with ice now in his voice as well as in his thoughts.

Inthed massaged his shoulder, looking sulky. "He called me a liar," he muttered.

"And are you not a liar? Did you not start this tale?"

The man shook his head. "I had it off the hunter Zan."

"Then where is Zan? Let him be brought forward."

Heads turned. Nobody brought forth Zan, whom Maeneb saw in her mind's eye quite clearly, lying dead and blood-streaked amongst the stoneman corpses near the shore.

She stayed silent. She did not wish to be the one who brought the news to this ice-cold Huldarion. She could tell him later. Or she could tell somebody else to tell him where Zan's body lay.

"So: the hunter Zan began this rumour," said Huldarion scathingly to Inthed. "But you decided to continue it – to spread it to my Riders in the midst of battle, knowing it would alarm and distract those who heard it, knowing that such distraction could be fatal to them."

"Only right that they should know," said Inthed with sulky defiance. "Zan told me just as the stonemen came running at us. They'd been hiding somewhere by the shore. When Solon called us all to arms, Zan said to me, they're only kids, the ones with two stones are only about ten, and it's magic makes them look so old. He was in a real state. Threw down his sword. I had to pick it up for him. He might have thrown it down again after, I don't know, but the stonemen arrived and I had to fight and I didn't see what he did next."

"Zan's first language, as I believe, is not Standard," said Huldarion dismissively.

"He speaks it well enough," said Inthed, lifting his chin.

"And he makes up stories well enough. I should like him to be found. Meanwhile we have other more pressing matters to attend to."

"Pressing?" demanded Landel. "What could be more pressing than the matter of whether or not we're fighting children?"

"Other matters," said Huldarion, raising his voice, "namely, the darkburn which still lurks out to sea. The Lady Gaelera is down on the shore: I have sent for her. But it would be wise to set a watch there also for the darkburn. Uld, please take half a dozen Riders and attend to it."

Uld nodded.

"The rest of you," Huldarion continued, "are to form into your companies. Crade, yours is to muster the horses and hunt for any that are fled: Orbrel and Rothir, yours are to organise the carts – where is Rothir? Never mind. Just find him and give him my instructions. Delgeb and Parthenal, your companies are to pack up the tents; and the others to scour the countryside for any remaining stonemen who may still lurk and try to ambush us. Patrol on foot, if necessary, if your horses are not quickly found."

"The scouts are out there, are they not?" asked Crade, waving to the north.

"They are. None have yet returned with any adverse reports. None the less we need to guard against the possibility." Huldarion spoke now with his accustomed authority, although Maeneb detected that his mind still heaved and coiled with shadowed turmoil. "While you search, look also for the hunter Zan. If you find him, bring him here. I wish to know from whence he got his information." With those words the shadows took a denser shape: not fear, but anger.

Maeneb turned away. She was certainly not going to reveal now that she had seen Zan's body, and risk the outpouring of that anger upon her. She rejoined Parthenal and Yaret in thoughtful silence.

"Well," said Parthenal after walking for a moment. "That's quite a story. Infant stonemen. It has certainly upset Huldarion."

"Does it not upset you?" asked Maeneb.

"I don't know," he said. "They're trying to kill me. I don't have time to ask how old they are while the axe is flying at my head. So I don't think it does particularly upset me."

"Huldarion didn't mention Durba, or the other dead," said Yaret quietly.

"No. That is surprising."

"How are they to be buried?"

Parthenal put a hand upon her shoulder. "We'll see to it once the tents are down. Maeneb? Would you like to be involved?"

Maeneb shook her head. "I'm going to look for stonemen," she replied. She would rather be away from everyone; from Durba, from the darkburn, from the dead Zan and the live Gaelera. Especially Gaelera.

Her horse Shoda was one of those that had fled. Maeneb did not waste time going in search of her, but gathered a pack with some food from a provision cart. After slinging a waterskin over her shoulder, she set out on foot along with several other Riders. Declining to pair up with any of them, she kept herself apart. While they progressed, they gradually fanned out. The fan grew wide: the gaps grew large.

The ruined town and monastery behind her were diminished. Mere toys of long-departed men. The waves' long chant became inaudible. The wind took over, sighing through the grass; birds tumbled, blown against the clouds. She found no stonemen but after a while she saw a lone horseman galloping towards her and stood still to watch him.

It was Rothir. He pulled up a few yards away and gasped, "Huldarion?"

She pointed behind her. He nodded and rode on.

No one else appeared; no figures marred the emptiness of grass. It ought to have been soothing. Soon she met a stream, and then another: her feet squelched and she regretted her lost boots, now at the bottom of the sea.

Along with Durba. But no, Durba was not in the sea. She was on the shore, a burnt thing waiting to be buried.

"Stonemen," Maeneb told herself severely. "You're here to look for stonemen."

There were no stonemen in that ocean of thick grass. No-one jumped up. No-one lay face down, and seeping blood. The land was blank.

But now and then, amidst the blankness, Maeneb glimpsed a face. She knew it was not real. It was a dead man's face: it had a neat red-golden beard, bright ear-rings, a foolishly surprised expression, as the man put his wavering hand up to his neck and felt her knife.

Then he was gone. And there he was again, for a flickering instant, until she looked properly. No, gone. The Kelvhan nobleman that she had killed. The secret only Maeneb and Gaelera knew.

The secret that the Kelvhans must not know. And Huldarion must not know. That anger...

Gaelera held her knowledge of the murder like a hidden knife. Did she mean blackmail? What would she want Maeneb to do in payment for her silence?

I will not do it, Maeneb thought, whatever she wants; I will not allow her, there would be no end to it. I will not let her near me. I will not stay anywhere Gaelera is.

And with that thought she kept on walking.

Chapter 37

After he had galloped away from the fires and the darkburn writhing on the beach, Rothir wondered if he was doing the right thing. Should he have abandoned his fellow Riders, leaving them to face that monster? His heart constricted as he thought of what might be happening behind him.

There had been no opportunity to consult Huldarion. Yet surely his chieftain would agree that their Kelvhan allies needed to be warned. Even if the main army was not at immediate risk, the Kelvhan commander Rhadlun and his men were currently imperilled; to say nothing of Gaelera – and if the Kelvhans were not informed, they would demand to know why not.

Even so, his heart misgave him. And it was heavy riding on these wetlands despite their flatness. He had reached the Red Roads now, and was some distance from the sea; the splash of Narba's hooves replaced the roar and hush of waves. The walk along the beach came to his mind – a brief, still idyll, a point of peace on that slow shining shore; a moment outside normal time, such as can never last.

Here too it was peaceful but in a different way. The standing stones in their long lines proclaimed their rule, but as stones only, with no echo of lingering humanity. The land seemed animated rather by the silky streams, the air tumultuous with birds – high clouds of them wheeling, calling. Rothir, as he slowed his panting horse, felt alone in a way he seldom did. He had never suffered loneliness on his long travels, no matter how solitary, till now.

I should like some company, he thought. He bent to pat Narba's neck and murmur reassurance to himself as much as to his horse. When he looked back up, he saw the path ahead was not empty after all.

But that was not an army there, behind the standing stones. It was a troop, no more than thirty men, whom he recognised as Kelvhan soldiers in their distinctive gear; so he steered Narba towards them.

Two horsemen came cantering to meet him, swords upraised. At closer quarters the swords were lowered and the men dipped their heads respectfully.

"My Lord of the Vonn. A felicitous encounter. Our greetings to you and to your kin."

"Who leads you?" asked Rothir, with no time for such niceties.

"We accompany his most glorious Highness, the Lord Faldron, High Prince and Royal Heir of Kelvha and its dominions."

"Take me to him." What was Faldron doing here, alone? – Well, not exactly alone, but separate from his army. It was unexpected. Even bizarre.

The prince's company, as he approached, made an attractive picture, with the red leather and gold braid of the horses' gear reflected in the meandering waters. Rothir felt drab as he rode up to the Prince, who, surrounded by his men and clad in a crimson velvet cloak, stood gazing up towards the nearest stone.

Faldron turned to greet him. "Captain Rothir, I believe. How goes it? Have you killed any more tigers lately?"

"My Lord," said Rothir, dismounting and making a perfunctory bow, "I bring troubling news from our camp further west. May I ask, where is the main body of your army?"

"Behind us," said Faldron, waving an airy arm at the distant haze east of the Red Roads. Rothir saw no trace of any army. "I had a mind to view this place close up. Most wild and strange, is it not? Yet I have a liking for these primitive structures."

"But the rest of your men?"

Faldron gave a shrug. "There was no need for all the train to follow me. An unnecessary upheaval, Nerogun thought, although Jeveran did not agree. Mind you, Nerogun is not really

much of an adventurer, is he? And Shargun, too – a lazy man. I have no great opinion of his enterprise or his abilities. I think I shall have him replaced when this campaign is over.”

Rothir was taken aback. He found this frankness alarming, although the men around the prince appeared unmoved. Perhaps they were accustomed to such comments; which in itself would be equally alarming. He glanced round at them briefly, assessing them. Only some half dozen had the appearance of warriors. Most looked like elegant courtiers. What had Nerogun been thinking of?

“I am glad you have a retinue with you.”

“Jeveran insisted on it,” said the prince.

“Indeed, there may be dangers lurking.”

“Not here, though,” said Faldron. “We can see for miles. I perceive no dangers.”

“None the less–”

“I am no child,” said Faldron, although to Rothir’s mind that was exactly what he was. But there was a cold edge in the prince’s voice. “What is this troubling news you bear?”

Rothir bowed again, more deeply this time. “I spoke through concern for your Highness, not through any disrespect. And my concern has foundation. I bring word of a gigantic darkburn, which emerged from the sea in the shape of a massive serpent. It destroyed some of our tents and attacked the building in which many of our Riders were camping, along with the detachment of your own men. The Lady Gaelera was also sleeping nearby.”

“Nerogun’s men. Nerogun’s daughter,” said the prince with casual hauteur.

“I hope and trust that they all remain safe,” said Rothir; “for I left them still fighting the darkburn, when I rode here to warn you.” He felt his warning was inadequate. It did not make the impact that he had expected. But how else could he say it? “In truth, my Lord–”

“A giant serpent,” said the prince. “That would be a thing worth seeing, would it not, Dughin?”

The man to whom he spoke grinned, showing all his teeth. “If it exists,” he said. He had fierce eyes beneath dark eyebrows that did not match his yellow hair. Rothir recognised him: the noble who had fought Parthenal in the castle jousts, and had cheated to secure a draw.

“We shall find out,” said Faldron. “We shall go down to the sea.”

“If the darkburn is anywhere close, you would be far better staying away,” said Rothir, dismayed. This was exactly the opposite result to what he had intended. “Believe me, it’s a monstrous beast that burns everything it touches.”

“But we have the stones,” said Faldron. “They will protect us.”

“They had little effect back there amongst the Vonn,” said Rothir grimly. “This creature is too large, I think, to notice them. My Lord, I beg you to return to your main army.”

“Oh, I shall: once I have been down to the shore. It is only a few miles from here, I understand?”

“That is so, sire,” said another of his men, more deferential than Dughin.

“Your Highness! Please send word, at least, to your commanders,” Rothir urged.

“Very well; if that will appease you, I shall send a message.”

Rothir heard this with relief. He was not so relieved when Faldron summoned the two most tough-looking of his men – the two who had ridden over to accost Rothir – to take his message to the army. He would have preferred the ablest warriors to stay with their prince.

Faldron scribbled on a paper and handed it over to one of them, unsealed.

“To whom shall we give it, Sire? The Lord Post-Regent or the Arch-Lord Marshal?”

“Neither. Give it to Commander Jeveran,” replied the prince.

“Sire.” The pair bowed and departed.

"Come, Rothir," said Faldron. "Let us ride together, to the sea." He mounted his horse, and without waiting for his companions spurred it on, to canter splashingly through the ruddy shallows. His men hastened to follow, but kept a careful distance.

So did Rothir. He felt that he had hardly discharged his duty as he ought: Faldron did not take the warning seriously. If he saw the darkburn, what might the Prince do? What rash foolhardy action might he take next?

"Sorry, Narba," he muttered to his horse. "It's only another few miles. And then we'll head back to the camp."

Narba shook his mane and ploughed on through the streams, his hoofbeats spraying Rothir's face. He tasted the drops: sweet at first, though a mere five minutes later they were salt. Sea birds called and he felt a rush of wings above his head quite separate to the rushing wind of riding.

When he looked up, there was a skimming flock, sharp-winged, flying with such rapid skill! Such arrowed lightness! He wished that he were one of them, free from the cares of this world below. Freed of the necessity to fight and kill... When he looked down again, for an instant he saw beside his path a line of faces, and knew them all for men that he had slain.

He shook away the illusion and hurried after Faldron. Before long the Prince arrived at the final ring of stones where Rothir had stood so recently with Parthenal, contemplating carts. But Faldron did not enter the stone circle. Instead he rode on past it to the shore, with his men in a royally gleaming train behind him. A fine sight, and a pointless one, thought Rothir.

Over the last low rise they went, until Faldron pulled his horse up on a dune. One heedless courtier rode on beyond him, realised his mistake, and retreated quickly.

Faldron gave the man a single, cold-eyed look. Then he gazed out across the waves. "I see no serpent." He sounded disappointed. Rothir was relieved.

"There is none," said Dughin.

"Look: there is a bank of cloud, or smoke, there to the west," one of his retinue put in tentatively.

"I had observed it," Faldron said. He walked his horse, more slowly, down to the lapping waves. But when his men began to follow he signalled them to keep away. Instead, he beckoned to Rothir to accompany him.

"Still no serpent," he remarked.

"I think that may be steam," said Rothir, carefully watching the far bank of cloud, "that marks the presence of the darkburn out to sea."

"A pity it is not closer," said the prince. "I have heard tell of enormous sea-serpents in our old legends. There was one called the linwyrm." His voice held a faint note of longing, and Rothir hastened to disabuse him of any fairy-tale imaginings.

"This one was not like the serpents of our stories; nor, indeed, was it anything like the smaller serpents of real life. It was vast, appalling, with scales burnt black, and although it came out of the sea, it was far hotter than a forge."

Faldron frowned out at the waves for several minutes. Then he sighed, echoing the wistful murmur at his feet.

"No serpent," he repeated. "Tell me, Captain Rothir, in whom should I trust?"

"What?"

"In whom should I trust? Nerogun or Shargun? Post-Regent or the Arch-Lord Marshal?" Rothir was at a loss. Was this a genuine query, or some sort of test?

"Have you reason to distrust either?" he countered.

"Only that they distrust each other," Faldron said, his voice flat and low. "I need advisors, and those two should both be by my side. But they do not pay enough attention to me."

"I am sure they—"

"Oh, I don't require them to bow and scrape. That's not what I mean. I do require them to treat me as an intelligent adult who will soon be sole ruler of my country. Those two do not know me, and they do not try to."

"They are... perhaps... accustomed each to rule alone," said Rothir cautiously, "in their own spheres."

"Not quite alone. They've been hand in glove, those two. But they have lately fallen out, it seems. Perhaps I should be asking you not which one to trust, but rather which one is the stronger."

"I know nothing of these matters," said Rothir. "Are they not fast friends?" That was what he had understood.

"Oh, they've always been friends at each others' throats. One would happily stick a knife in the other if he could do it with more benefit than loss." Rothir was shocked; yet he guessed that there was likely to be some truth in the words. "Recently, one did," Faldron went on. "A noble of Nerogun's family was killed in the Kelvhan markets, by Shargun's orders."

"I think I heard something about that. Who was he?"

"A man called Daravun. A decorative nobody. He won't be missed; but he was Nerogun's kinsman. It was symbolic."

"How can you be sure--"

"The knife found in his throat was made by Shargun's cousin," murmured Faldron. "All Shargun's family use those knives. And afterwards, to avenge his death, Nerogun sent an assassin to kill one of Shargun's clan."

"What?" Rothir was dismayed not only by this information but by the fact that the High Prince was choosing to confide in him.

"You saw him yourself. In the music hall: the assassin was a low-born serf, disguised as a musician. A poor musician, and not a very competent assassin, but the message was more important than the act. You were there, were you not, when he made the attempt?"

"Yes," said Rothir, "but I thought the man was aiming to kill Nerogun. I assumed he must be a fanatic – a religious zealot. He cried out the name of Borgun."

Faldron shook his head. "Camouflage," he said, "to disguise his real intent. Three of the men standing beside Nerogun at that moment were of Shargun's family. The castle is full of them. Like a warren full of weasels. One of those men could well have died had not the assassin been slain first."

Rothir was silent, looking out upon the sea; contemplating the mysteries held within. Mysteries everywhere.

"Your Highness, pardon me," he said after a few moments, "but how can you know who ordered the assassin to act?" That the assassin had been commanded by some higher force he did not doubt. But he had thought it was simply the imaginary Borgun.

"I have been informed that the slave received his instructions from Nerogun."

"Informed by whom?"

"By my own servants. A message was found within his quarters," said the Prince, "which bore the traces of Nerogun's seal."

"Another man might use his seal."

"None ever has before. Do you think he loans it out?"

Again that harsh note in the Prince's voice. He might be a callow-looking youth encased in velvet, but Rothir suspected that within the courtly casings was a man of steel. No wonder his courtiers were wary of him... Most of them, at any rate.

He looked around. "Was it not that man Dughin who slew the assassin?"

"It was."

"Whose man is he? Is he one of Shargun's family?"

"Dughin is his own man," Faldron answered. "Too proud to serve any master without arguing with him. I would not ask him to be my counsellor. So: whom should I trust? Nerogun or Shargun?"

"You must look to your own judgement in that."

"My judgement says that Nerogun is the abler man by far; but Shargun has power over the army."

"And is the army loyal?" Rothir was immediately shocked at himself for asking such a question, and feared it would be taken amiss; but Faldron merely nodded thoughtfully.

"I believe so," he said. "Mutiny is practically unknown – or was, until that recent incident with Captain Amerrun. Ah, well. Perhaps I should not concern myself over-much. I will soon reach my majority: next year I shall become High King and be rid of the necessity for either man."

"You will still need advisors, and an army."

"I shall choose my own leader for the army. Jeveran perhaps, if he acquits himself with honour in this campaign. He does not have high rank, but he seems to manage the army adequately well."

Rothir, who knew that Huldarion esteemed Commander Jeveran's abilities, said, "He appears most capable, certainly."

"As to advice," said Faldron, "I can take that where I choose. Throw off the shackles of the Post-Regent's presence. Appoint a new advisor. You, perhaps."

"Me?" Rothir was taken aback. "No, no, that would not do!"

"You are highly regarded amongst the Vonn."

"There are many others much worthier than me. Indeed, I see that you are joking."

For Faldron was smiling. "Perhaps I am. You must admit, however, that to make you my advisor would certainly throw Nerogun off his self-appointed plinth. If not you, perhaps your wizard, then?"

"Leor? He is bound in service to the Lord Huldarion of the Vonn." Although *bound in service* made the agreement sound much more formal than it really was.

"Huldarion, now," said Faldron thoughtfully. "Is he a man I should look to for advice?"

Here Rothir felt himself on safer ground. "I think you could hardly do better. He is both principled and meticulous."

"Apparently. But is he wise?" asked Faldron, gazing out to sea once more. "This expedition to the wilderness was his idea. Has it been wise?"

"He had good reasons," answered Rothir. "We knew this place was formerly a stronghold of the stonemen; the roads away from here will lead to other strongholds." But he was seized with doubt. In the light of what had happened, had this diversion been unwise?

And his mind lit on something which he had not fully thought through until then. Why had the monstrous darkburn attacked exactly where and when it did? Had Huldarion's plan to visit the monastery been known beforehand by the enemy?

This thought darkened his consciousness until Faldron gave him a still greater jolt.

"I wish Huldarion well," the High Prince said musingly, his voice just audible through the sighing waves, "but I do not think he will succeed in winning back Caervonn."

Rothir, dismayed, did not know what to answer. He tried to put strong disbelief into his response.

"Not succeed? I cannot agree with you, your Highness. Why, what should stop him – especially with the aid of Kelvha? Your army's might is unsurpassed. Why should Huldarion not regain his throne?"

Faldron looked at him fully now. Such a bland face the prince had. Too unformed as yet to be called fully adult; but the first signs of adulthood were there, in the faint lines on his brow,

and the knowing curve of his mouth as he replied. He spoke no longer like the eager, naive prince of old.

"Because Nerogun does not wish it. Nor Shargun either. In that one wish they are united, if in little else."

Rothir drew in a long breath. "How do you know?" he said, and heard his voice come out husky and appalled.

"I don't," said Faldron. "But I know Nerogun and Shargun. Yes, they wish to quell the stonemen. Yes, they wish for freedom from attacks by darkburns. And yes, they are keen to fight on the Vonn's behalf to enable them to win Caervonn. But then; but after that; think you that they will be content to let Huldarion keep it?"

Rothir was silent, mulling this over. He was horrified; but it was the horror of recognition. There had always been danger in allying themselves with a force so much the greater. Huldarion knew that; for it had been discovered that Nerogun had dealings with Adon. Still, Nerogun was not Kelvha. He did not command the army; and his power would soon be handed over to the Prince.

But now, to have that same prince lay the danger out so bluntly – it awoke in him a coiling fear.

"My Lord," he said, "You will soon be sole ruler of the Kelvhan Kingdom. What are your desires regarding Caervonn?"

Faldron laughed. "If I wished to take your lands, I would hardly tell you, would I? But I do not wish to. I will have enough, and I would rather have you Vonn as friends and equals than as serfs."

"I am glad to hear it," said Rothir, although his mouth felt numb.

"Well, first we have to get there," Faldron said. "A pity that this darkburn is not visible." He stared out seawards, and then frowned. "Rothir. What is that, out to the east? Is that the serpent?"

Rothir followed his gaze. "There is a movement, certainly," he said, "but it's not the serpent unless it's swum a dozen miles unnoticed. No steam. And I think..."

"I think it is not black," said Faldron softly, "but I see red."

"Red flecks. Yes. Could it be boats?"

"Many boats, with sails."

Rothir peered, trying to make the distant image take a shape. "Red sails. You Kelvhans have no fleet?"

"No. Why would we? We have no coasts within our territory. Could it be men from the southlands?"

"They seldom come here," Rothir answered. "And those boats are coming round the coastline, not across the sea."

"Do stonemen have boats? Could it be them?" For the first time, Faldron sounded shaken. Ah, thought Rothir grimly, danger in the abstract is all very well; but at a mere distant glimpse of an unexpected foe, composure leaves you.

He knew this was unfair. He felt shaken himself. But he was aware at once of what needed to be done.

"Stonemen use boats on the Darkburn river," he said. "So, yes. My Lord, how far are you from your army?"

"Two hours ride perhaps. Less with a swift horse."

"Then send the man with the swiftest horse," said Rothir, "to Commander Jeveran. If he catches up the other messengers, so much the better. Tell Jeveran about this fleet, and say that you with your remaining men are on your way back there to join him. Then go inland, and follow the route you took here, with all speed, back to your people."

Faldron looked at him. "You're convinced that those are stonemen?"

"We can't afford to wait and see. If they're just fishing vessels, no harm is done, and you may blame my over-cautious nature for the alarm. But if they're stonemen, we need to be prepared for battle. I'll return to the Vonn immediately. If at all possible, we'll bring our army back to the Red Roads to meet with yours."

"I hope it is possible," Faldron said soberly.

"So do I. You should depart, my Lord, without delay."

"I will," said Faldron.

"I bid you farewell," Rothir said. With a swift salute he wheeled Narba around and began to gallop along the beach, the thudding hooves sending up thick sprays of sand.

Ahead of him the heavy bank of steam still lingered out to sea; but the darkburn no longer occupied his thoughts.

For when he glanced back, the red-marked sails were unmistakeable. The fleet was coming in to shore.

Chapter 38

As Rothir rode up to the monastery it looked quite different to yesterday. In the sad, haze-ridden daylight he saw a wildly altered landscape.

The building squatting on the cliff was two thirds gone, a sight that filled him with grim apprehension. The ocean too, looked strange. When he came close he noticed a thin scum of icy fragments on the surface: a greyish, ugly, floating slush that rocked against the shingle. Further out, the bank of fog or steam was heaving up to mingle with the clouds.

He hurried Narba on towards a band of Riders near the ruined town. Some were loading carts or herding horses: a welcome and familiar sight, although appearing more disorganised than usual. Patting his tired horse's shoulder, he cantered over the last rise, and pulled up abruptly.

Close by was another group. Another familiar and much less welcome scene. The unmistakable shapes of three human bodies, wrapped in their cloaks, lay on the edge of a pit where men worked with spades. A pair of women knelt by the long still figures to carefully adjust the makeshift shrouds.

The women were Tiburé and Yaret. Rothir dismounted and walked over, conscious of his slow reluctant stride towards those who would now stir no more. His errand would have to wait one minute.

On approaching the pit he saw that it was surprisingly deep – so deep that surely it must have been here previously, and had been chosen for the burial for that reason. Rigal and Imbel down at the bottom needed to do little more than loosen enough earth to cover the bodies.

"Who?" he said.

Yaret raised her face to him. She looked tired and ill. "Rothir. You're unhurt? You found Kelvha?"

"Yes. Who lies here?"

"Durba," she replied, and turned her face away again.

He was shocked. This was an unexpected grief. He had known Durba moderately well; a pleasant girl, a friend of his sister, a friend of Maeneb. A friend of Yaret.

"I'm sorry. How did it happen?"

"She tried to stab the serpent and didn't run away in time." Yaret sighed and stroked the cloak before standing up. "Gaelera seems to think that Durba died to save her."

"Did she?"

She shook her head. "It's more likely that she died to prove herself no coward. It hurt her that people might think she was."

"Nobody thought that," said Rothir, with pity nudging at his heart. "She was too young."

"Too young to die, or too young to understand?"

"Both. Who are the others?"

"This is Norgil," answered Tiburé. "He was in one of the tents. We're lucky that he was the only one caught there. And the third is not a Rider, but that man from up north, Zan the hunter, the sole casualty of battle."

"Battle? Against who?" Rothir was alarmed.

"Just a handful of stray stonemen. Solon's company put them down. But apparently Zan wouldn't fight."

"Zan was no warrior," murmured Yaret, "nor a hunter either. He was adopted by the hunters after the stonemen laid waste to his home."

"He was adopted by you too, I think," said Tiburé to her.

"And saved from his captivity by you," Yaret told Rothir.

Thus are we bound together by a corpse, he thought, and felt a deep regret. He pictured Zan – an earnest, melancholy man, almost embarrassingly grateful for his rescue. But what had Rothir saved him for, in the final reckoning? To end up in this pit?

He knew that Zan and Yaret had been close; indeed, he remembered feeling oddly shut out by that closeness, as if he had any right to an exclusive friendship with her. Now he felt an urge to put an arm around her, as he had once done. Another memory, of a precious, dreadful moment in the darkness of the northern forts came to his mind. He pushed it away. Put it in a box. He had an errand to fulfil.

But still he lingered for few more seconds. "Why would Zan not fight?" he asked.

"Oh," said Yaret with sudden alertness. "Rigal – what's that, down by your foot? Let me see."

She began to clamber down into the pit. Rigal, busy with his shovel, looked up in surprise.

"There's no buried treasure here," he told her.

"This band," she said. "This coloured band." She pointed to a layer of earth within the pit wall; not orange sandy soil like the earth above it, but a stratum of a pale, almost bluish tinge.

"It's clay. What of it?"

Yaret put down a hand to examine the clay, and then raised her fingers to her mouth.

"Now what are you doing?" demanded Tiburé.

"May I borrow your shovel?" Yaret asked Rigal.

"Are you planning to set up a pottery? I can dig you out a chunk if you really want." Rigal set his shovel in the clay.

"Thank you. Do you have something to store it in? A spare waterskin, maybe?"

"Have this one," said Rothir, throwing it down. "It's leaky, and I have another. Where's Huldarion? I need to speak to him."

"Over by the carts," said Tiburé. "There's been a problem."

"Problem?"

She just threw up her hands and shook her head.

Rothir did not waste time asking more. He remounted Narba; the horse responded with a last gallant effort, swiftly reaching the ruined town and the Riders. He glimpsed Gaelera, sitting on the shaft of Lady Meya's carriage with a pair of women fussing round her.

And here at the edge of the ruins was Huldarion. He was surrounded by his councillors and others, in the middle of some heated conversation. Rothir strode over, breaking in without preamble.

"Huldarion. There may be stoneman coming from the east," he said. "There's a fleet of boats, with red sails, heading round the coast to the Red Roads. Hard to tell how many. But I've seen Faldron and sent word to the Kelvhan army to say that we will march to meet them."

Huldarion turned towards him. Rothir, who had experience in reading that scarred face, was shocked.

Surprise, he had expected. What he had not expected was the fury and frustration that he saw.

Huldarion almost spat at him, so angry was he.

"On whose authority did you go to meet the Kelvhan army, Rothir?"

He wanted to take a step back. But that would be to call in question his own judgement and his standing. He stood firm. "On my own authority," he said. "We needed to forewarn them of the serpent's presence."

"The serpent is gone," Huldarion said. "Leor saw to it. There was no need."

"There was great need, it seems to me," said Rothir. "They needed to be told of such a vicious enemy. How could I predict how soon it would be dealt with? It was a thing unprecedented in my experience."

"Which counts for little," said Huldarion, so uncharacteristically unfair a remark that this time Rothir did take a step back and gazed at him in frowning surprise. Meya, who was pushing through the crowd to join Huldarion, also paused in evident shock. The Kelvhan Commander Rhadlun, behind her, raised his eyebrows.

"What else has happened?" Rothir asked, because it was obvious that something had.

"He didn't tell us!" Landel cried out, from further back. That too was uncharacteristic of the easy-going Landel. "Huldarion knew it and he didn't tell us!"

"He didn't tell you what?" Rothir was bewildered.

"That the stonemen are children! We've been fighting children! The hunter Zan told Inthed; and he said Huldarion knew it all along!"

Rothir frowned more deeply. This must be nonsense, surely. Zan was dead and could say nothing. The stonemen were undoubtedly full-grown, their physiques and ferocity those of men, not boys. How could they be children?

"I daresay some of them may be as young as eighteen," he said, "maybe even seventeen, but that's not--"

"Ten," said Hilbré in her quiet, low voice. "The ones with two stones are as young as ten. We have been slaughtering children."

"How can that be?"

"It is a wild and unsubstantiated rumour," said Huldarion.

"It's not a rumour!" Landel yelled. Rothir had never seen him so worked up. "Ask him to deny it!"

"I have no definite knowledge of the matter," said Huldarion.

"Then you did know something!"

Solon put a hand out. "Landel. Modify your tone of voice."

Huldarion paused. "I heard a story," he said, with slow reluctance. "I had no evidence."

Hilbré spoke up again in her calm manner. "The stonewomen living amidst the great stones told us something which in retrospect confirms it. They said their children grew too fast. One said her daughter was but seven, when the girl looked twice that age."

"So the Lady Meya informed me," Huldarion said sternly. "She was of the opinion that the women barely understood their numbers: were you not, my dear?"

Meya nodded. "I was. They were completely uneducated."

"Everyone can count the years," said Landel. "*Is it true?*"

Again Huldarion hesitated. "I do not know."

"You mean it's true."

"Landel." That was Solon, with a warning note.

"My *Lord*," said Landel, in an angry drawl.

A muscle in Huldarion's face twitched. Then he said, "I do not deny that some of the stonemen claim to be younger in years than they appear. The truth of that claim has yet to be determined."

"I believe it's true," said Hilbré.

"And when did you first make this discovery, Huldarion?" That was Theol, Rothir's own second in command: a steady, unflappable man whose voice now held a shaking edge of anger, or of something else.

Huldarion drew in a sharp breath. Then he answered with clipped, military terseness.

"After the battle of the Outland Forts, the Baron of Melmet took two stonemen as prisoners for questioning. One had seven stones in his head, the other four. When I asked them their ages, they claimed to be fifteen and twelve years old respectively. I had no means of verifying that."

"Yet you did not think to tell us," Rothir said. He felt stunned. Worse than stunned. The threat of the boats was momentarily forgotten. He felt as if he were looking down into a pit and seeing something there worse even than a darkburn. It was too dark to be real. Children? Had he been killing children?

"I thought of telling you," Huldarion said, "and then I thought better of it, until it could be proven."

"What proof do you need?"

"Something more concrete than two ignorant prisoners deprived of their Athelid."

Rothir, through his shock, sensed that there was something more. "But Huldarion, why did you ask the prisoners' ages in the first place? Did you already guess at this?"

Huldarion glanced away into the distance. "I had some inkling. The archer Yaret said she'd killed a stoneman up in Erbulet, far in the north, who claimed to be only ten. I found that barely credible."

"Everything is credible where Adon is concerned," said Delgeb roughly.

"I did not think it possible, though Leor said it could be done by wizardry."

"So Leor knew as well as Yaret?" Theol said.

Rothir's sensation of unreality grew. The pit that had just opened beneath his feet yawned abruptly wider, so deep and dark it seemed to break his world in two. Then and Now, irreconcilable. There was no going back to Then. He felt as if he had been paddling in an ordinary shallow sea, when all the while the waves had been gathering themselves into a whirlpool to drag him dizzily down to unknown depths.

And he was being dragged now, down and down.

"Yaret?" he said, his voice strange to himself. "In Erbulet?"

"It happened before she came to meet us at the Outland Forts. She told me of it when she arrived."

Parthenal said, "It doesn't change much. It doesn't change the fact that the stonemen are intent on killing us if we don't kill them first. We're not the aggressors in this war."

"Hear, hear," said Crade. "We have to fight or die."

"I will not fight children," Delgeb said distinctly. "Some of these are younger than my son. Is it their fault that they get their heads drilled full of stones and are pitched headlong into battle? They're fodder for Adon's designs."

"That was always the case," said Uld. "But it makes it more difficult for us."

Solon said, "If a dog leaps up to bite your throat, does it not need to be put down regardless of its age?"

"These are not dogs!" cried Landel. "These are children!"

"These are stonemen," said Huldarion, his voice grating, "and we know their nature: we know their viciousness regardless of their age. Would you stand still in battle and have them mow us down? Zan stood still, and they mowed him down. His body lay amongst the enemy corpses."

"They are still our enemy. That doesn't change. I do not care a jot how old they are," said Crade.

"I care more than a jot," said Landel.

"But you are not head of the army," said Huldarion.

Rothir's thoughts, like drumbeats, pounded through his head. *They were children. Yaret knew.* Through the drumbeats, more dispassionately, he observed that as well as being angry, Huldarion was probably in pain; the scars that clothed his left-hand cheek and neck and arm were fiery red as if he had been newly branded.

"I should like to know," Huldarion went on, "who told this story to the hunter Zan, who then saw fit to spread it and cause chaos, putting Riders' lives at risk."

"Zan's dead," said Theol. "We cannot ask him now."

"Indeed, we cannot, conveniently. But one person certainly knew: the archer Yaret." Huldarion's voice was hard and bitter. "I commanded her to tell no-one. But she was close with Zan."

"Presumably the Baron of Melmet also knew," put in Uld, "if that pair of stonemen were his prisoners."

"He would hardly go blabbing to his troops. I want to speak to Yaret," said Huldarion harshly.

"She's burying Zan," said Rothir, his lips numb. "I passed her as I came here."

"Never mind her now," said Solon. "We have other matters to attend to. Rothir: you said you have just met with High Prince Faldron?"

"Have you indeed?" said Commander Rhadlun, with more interest than he had shown at the story of the stonemen. "I trust you planned to notify me of that. Where did you find the Kelvhan army?"

"I saw only Prince Faldron, with some thirty men," answered Rothir. "He was on an expedition of his own. But I hope that having seen the fleet of stonemen's ships approaching, he will by now have rejoined the main body of his army. I have told him that we'll march that way as quickly as we can."

"You had no authority to tell him that. What! Do you lead the Riders of the Vonn now?" exclaimed Huldarion.

"Of course not," said Rothir, both grave and alarmed. His mind was dazed; but he knew the most important thing was to keep his temper. Meya put a hand on Huldarion's arm. Huldarion shook it off.

"This fleet you say you saw—"

"That Faldron saw also."

"The High Prince Faldron, to you," said Rhadlun.

"I beg your pardon," said Rothir, with a slight bow. "My haste was greater than my care in speech."

"Your haste was greater than your wisdom," said Huldarion.

Rothir did not immediately answer. After a few seconds he said, "Perhaps. We saw some dozen ships, with red sails, coming from the east. More may have been waiting further round the headland. They might not have been stonemen but they cannot be ignored."

"I think," said Commander Rhadlun to Huldarion, "we should join our Kelvhan army now. Even if this little fleet does not pose much threat, it's high time, is it not? This jaunt of yours is over."

"Indeed that was always the Lord Huldarion's plan," put in Meya with dignity.

Huldarion's lips compressed. Then with suppressed feeling he said, "Parthenal. Bring me Yaret."

"We don't know it was her who spread the rumour," Rothir said, although an inner cry was pounding at his head. *She knew! She knew! No matter who she told, she knew!*

"Who else could it have been? Better you had never saved her life," Huldarion said wrathfully, "than let her live to bring such discord to our people."

That brought a general gasp throughout the crowd. Unfair, unfair, thought Rothir. He saw Parthenal looking at him. Indeed, all the Riders were watching him, to see how he would answer.

Better to stay silent than to fling back fury and resentment. So he gazed steadily at Huldarion without uttering a word.

"You flouted my authority," said Huldarion thickly. "Just go."

Rothir turned round and strode away. He would not show the anger, shock, resentment that engulfed him. Worse than a darkburn's heat, because he could not fight it. He could not take a sword to his own passion and cut it into harmless pieces.

Parthenal hurried away from the crowd and caught him up as he strode away.

"You did right not to respond," said Parthenal quietly. "I have never seen Huldarion so thrown off balance. In truth I don't understand it."

Rothir did not think that he could safely speak. He walked up to Narba, who was waiting on the outskirts of the temple, and put his hand upon the horse's solid shoulder. If only I could be a horse, he thought, and not be assailed by these emotions, this weight of knowledge; the horror of Huldarion's contempt.

"You heard this story of the stonemen?" he said. The words stuck in his throat; they came out with a rasp.

"Yes, earlier today," said Parthenal. "I heard it first from Theol. I don't know who told Zan. He wasn't the only one to throw down his weapons; but he was the only one who paid with his life."

Rothir glanced at him. "What about you? How do you feel about it?"

"It makes no difference to me," said Parthenal.

Rothir nodded. He had expected this answer. There was no sentiment in his friend: Parthenal was a ruthless warrior.

Yet he felt bound to object. "You really don't care if your enemies are children?"

"If anyone tries to kill me, I kill him first," said Parthenal matter-of-factly.

A ruthless warrior, yet such a tender carer for the sick, thought Rothir. He is a walking contradiction. As is Huldarion. A considerate leader who rejects his loyal follower.

Resentment rose again, thick in his throat. He tried to quell it. Surely Parthenal was right: Huldarion had been thrown off balance. Shaken by the giant darkburn and the seeming mutiny within his ranks, he had picked on Rothir as the nearest, easiest target.

Yet resentment would not be denied its rights. My experience is worth little? I have flouted your authority? You cannot appoint captains and then deny them any power to exercise their judgement. You should not appoint them only to denigrate them when you are caught out in a mistake.

You made a mistake, Huldarion, he said silently, in concealing such dreadful knowledge from your people: and you were caught. So now you pay the price.

"We have killed children," he murmured to Parthenal. "Is this what the Vonn are? The slayers of children? Is this the wave of glory on which we are to ride into Caervonn?"

"Rothir," said Parthenal firmly. "Listen to me, dwarf. This is our enemy. They look like men. They fight as men. When they attack us, what else can we do?"

Rothir nodded, not in agreement but in recognition of the problem's hopelessness.

No wonder all the stonemen hated us, he thought: how could they feel differently? Bred to fight, maimed and drugged and ignorant of any other matter, they were thrust into the thick of battle. They had no chance at any decent life before we took it from them. But we were ignorant too, as ignorant as they are.

Parthenal was gazing at the ruined monastery, the broken silhouette against the dull streaked clouds.

"It was a surprisingly comfortable place," he said reflectively, "for that one night."

"For you, maybe," answered Rothir. For him, all comfort had now gone. "We were kept in the dark. Yaret knew. She kept it secret." Not only that. She had killed stonemen knowing they were children. He could allow that ruthlessness in Parthenal, and did not understand why it should matter so in Yaret. Yet he felt his face, his body, his whole consciousness, turn away in lonely grief and loss and disappointment.

"You go and gather up your company, Rothir," said Parthenal gently. "They need your steady hand."

He nodded, for he knew his duty, although he did not want to do anything but sit down and maybe weep. However, that was something he had never done. Or hardly ever – he recalled, fleetingly, a dark night by the swirling River Thore – and with that memory of darkness almost blinding him he swung Narba's head towards the camp.

"Good horse," he said. "Good old friend." Narba at least had never failed him.

There were always tasks. And he knew from long experience that tasks gave him the best alleviation of such moods. His company of Riders was waiting for his orders, for the management of gear and horses before they could ride out.

But then: ride out to what? To return to the Red Roads, like stumbling people walking backwards. Back, to meet the coming stonemen. Back, to hunt and slaughter children.

Chapter 39

Aliya knew something was wrong as soon as she saw the thing fly overhead.

It woke her up. She was just having a little nap, like baby Doval did, when in the middle of her dozing there was a whippy sound of tearing cloth and a horrible smell. She opened her eyes and saw a strange thing flying over the open roof of the broken house. From her fireplace where she lay curled against Flodda, it was just a shadow, black and flapping heavily against the cloudy sky. Then it flapped on past the walls and she couldn't see it any more.

She sat up in the fireplace. "Flodda! Flodda!" she cried out in alarm.

"Mmm? What is it?"

Flodda had been dozing too. Aliya shook her. She felt a horrible trembly feeling in her stomach like when she was going to be sick, or when she had found one of the ducks had died. Something was terribly wrong. "*Flodda!*"

Veron came running in. She could see his eyes glinting and the knife that he carried glinted too.

"Get up," he said fiercely. "Darkburn."

Aliya jumped up and looked for her shoes. No sooner had she pulled them on than Veron grabbed her and thrust her at Camburé who was just coming out of the twiggy inner house. Camburé held a long stick; no, it was a sword. Had she had a sword all along, hidden in the cart?

"Take her to the outer sheds," Veron commanded. "Anywhere with a roof. This one can fly."

"What? Darkburns can't fly," said Camburé.

"This one can."

"Stonemen?"

"Not yet. Take Olbeth and Doval." Veron sped outside.

Olbeth appeared from the twiggy house, with Doval in her arms, asleep and lolling. Olbeth had a swordbelt and a scabbard strapped around her waist. What was a darkburn? Why was it flying over the house?

She was about to ask Olbeth when there was the tearing noise again. It got louder and the black shape came flapping low over the broken roof, like a huge lump of coal with wings. It was not really like a bird at all, because it was far too big, and its wings were raggedy and made that horrid whumping rasp. It smelt horrid too. It made her feel sick again and she had to crouch down.

Flodda gave a wail and Camburé said Stars Above and pulled Aliya sharply over to the doorway, just as the flappy not-a-bird plunged down upon the twiggy house.

There was a crash and crackle. The twigs burst into flames. It was so sudden that it took her by surprise. Usually when the servants laid a fire it took a long time to get it going. But this fire was all at once and very hot. She stood gawping at it for a second before Camburé pulled her sharply through the door and out into the yard.

Some of the hunters stood there, holding bows. Just as she heard the flapping sound again they all drew the bows up at the air. She heard the whick whick of arrows being shot.

She had sometimes watched Lord Hapligan play at archery, with lots of jokes and laughing. There was no laughing now. She wanted to turn round and see if they had shot the flappy not-a-bird but there was no chance because Camburé was still pulling her, too hard.

Camburé pulled her all the way across the yard and down a track. The track was stony and made Aliya stumble. Olbeth and Flodda were running along behind her: baby Doval was going ababab in Olbeth's arms. He sounded wide awake now.

Then Camburé pulled her into a big shed where it was dark inside. As soon as everyone was in, Camburé shut the door. It smelt like a cowshed although there did not seem to be any cows, because Aliya could hear no husky snorts, only the women panting and Doval still going ababababab.

"It's all right, Doval," Aliya said, "we're safe now." Because this place had a roof which kept all the light out so it would keep the flapping not-a-bird out too.

They stood there in the dark and panted and listened to the noises going on outside: loud crackings and then thudding feet and somewhere a whistle. She thought that must be Edrik, because he could whistle really well and the hunters sometimes whistled to each other instead of talking. There was no shouting so she hoped that the flapping smelly thing had gone away.

But then there was a huge *bang!* upon the roof which made her jump, and then a second *bang!* and bits began to fall on top of her. They were soft bits and when she picked one off her head it was only moss, but then there was another *bang!* and crunching noises and another bit fell on her head and this time it was hard. It hurt.

"Ow," she said, but she didn't scream even though lots of bits of roof had started falling down all over everyone. It got hotter and hotter and there was that awful smell again, worse than cowmuck, worse even than the dead rat Aliya had once found, and she thought she might be going to be sick.

But she said to herself sternly, no I'm not, I hate being sick; and then realised she could see, because light through the newly-opened roof lit up the cowshed stalls, all empty. She wondered if everyone could hide inside those stalls but then she heard the raspy whumpy flapping coming close again and Camburé was pulling open the shed door for them to run outside.

"Split up," said Camburé to Olbeth. "I'll take Aliya. You go north."

Aliya tried to say that she didn't want to go with Camburé, she wanted to stay with Olbeth and Flodda and the baby. But the words didn't come out and anyway there was no time, because Olbeth ran outside with Doval straight away.

Flodda looked at Aliya sadly for a second and put out a hand to touch her hair.

"My little duckling," she said, and then she turned and ran out after Olbeth. There was a loud clatter behind Aliya and when she looked round a whole lot of roof was falling down into the shed with thuds and smashes.

And then, to her shock, the flying thing fell in as well, with a clatter of its wings.

Down it came, black and smoking, amongst the blazing rafters. Its wings were trying to lift it out again, but they looked too torn, no more than rags, and she thought it had a strange head for a flying thing but it was too hot to look at for more than an instant, it hurt her eyes and her head and made her sick and then Camburé was dragging her out of the door and she could hear the thing crashing and thumping around inside the shed behind her. It was trapped.

Camburé pulled her over to the path and Veron came running towards them with two of the hunters.

"The woods?" said Camburé.

"Not safe," replied Veron. "Woods burn."

"Where, then?"

"I don't know this place well enough. Find Bruilde. Ask her."

"Stonemen?"

"Not yet. First they'll let the darkburn do its work," said Veron grimly. And then to Aliya's alarm he strode past them pulling some long chains from his belt and went into the shed that was still full of the flying thing banging and flapping around. So maybe that was the thing they called a darkburn.

"How will he," she began to ask, and then there was a crash from inside the shed and she had to run because Camburé was pulling her fast towards the farmhouse. She didn't want to go and when they got there she felt like saying I told you so, because the farmhouse was on fire inside with orange flames jumping up as big as trees inside the broken walls.

So they didn't go in. They ran all the way around it. Aliya's arm was hurting where Camburé gripped her. She wanted to stop being pulled but Camburé would not stop pulling. Camburé was calling Bruilde! Bruilde! and nobody was answering.

"Where in stars' name is she?" said Camburé in a cross voice, and she pulled Aliya away from the burning house, hurting her arm some more, and dragged her down a track. It was a windy path between tall prickly bushes that reached out and snagged Aliya's skirts. She recognised this path. It was the way to the woods.

"Where are we going?" she asked. She wanted to remind Camburé about the woods not being safe. But she could hardly talk for panting.

Camburé didn't answer. But at last she stopped and looked around and let go of Aliya's arm and while Aliya was rubbing it there was that creaky whippy flapping noise, and there was the not-a-bird again, the darkburn, a black raggedy splotch on the grey-blue sky, so it had somehow got out of the shed. It was trailing a chain and Aliya wondered what had happened to Veron. She thought maybe she wanted to cry, only crying might make the flappy thing notice her.

As the thing flew closer Camburé pushed her down behind some prickly bushes. The scratches really hurt. But she did not cry or even make a sound because the flappy thing was almost overhead. She kept very still. The not-a-bird kept whumping past from one side to the other but after a while the noise got less and less and when she looked up the thing was out of sight again.

Camburé stood up. Aliya wanted to ask her what would happen now but she found she couldn't speak at all. Her mouth wouldn't do it. And Camburé was looking down the path with her sword drawn and now Aliya could hear no flapping but instead new thudding crashing sounds, like running feet. She wondered if they were Veron and his hunters but the hunters were always quiet and these weren't quiet.

Camburé lifted Aliya right up out of the bushes by the armpits and put her roughly down upon the path.

"Run on," said Camburé. "Run on. I'll hold them off as long as I can."

Aliya wanted to say, Run where? Who? But her mouth still wouldn't do it and Camburé said "Go!" and so Aliya went.

She set off running the only way she could, which was down the track away from the thudding feet. On either side were prickly bushes so she had to follow the path although she knew this was the way further into the woods and she didn't want to go there, the woods weren't safe, Veron said so. Her legs felt wobbly and she wanted to stop and hide but everywhere was too thick and prickly and if the footsteps caught up with her what would happen?

The path was so narrow and over-grown that she could only just see her way along it. Lots of twigs were scratching her and once she nearly fell over but she didn't, and she could hear men shouting behind her so maybe the hunters had come to help after all except that the shouts still didn't sound nice, they sounded horrible and she was feeling sick again and everything hurt and she wanted to stop running.

So she stopped on the path and panted. After a few pants her head seemed to clear.

She remembered that this was the path to the big lookout tree. There might be men up in that tree still looking out. Maybe they could pull her up into the tree or she could climb the

knotted rope and hide there and be safe. High up above everything and all the shouting. She wanted all the shouts to go away. She wanted Mama.

But Mama was not here and Flodda was not here and Olbeth was not here and so she set off running again, hurtling along the path as fast as she could although the bushes grabbed her arms and legs and tried to trip her over. She wouldn't let the shouts and footbeats catch her.

And at last, at the end of the path, the big lookout tree was waiting. There was a wide empty space around it, with no bushes, just its tall grey trunk going up and up. The knotted rope was dangling down. She ran up and put her hands on the rope but she knew she couldn't climb it. She was too tired and it would only swing her round and round.

"Hallo?" she said, or tried to say, up the tree. "Are you up there?"

It was only a whisper. And now the shouts behind were getting louder. She looked for somewhere to hide but there was nowhere except prickly bushes that would not let her in, or behind the lookout tree itself. Maybe she could run round it to hide. It was big enough although it was the first place anyone would look.

But before she could do even that, the footbeats pounded with a huge loud judder and the shouts were right behind her, and when she turned to look there were men there, lots of them crowded on the path behind each other. They were holding axes. They slowed down and walked towards her.

"Got you," said a big man at the front. He had smears of something all across his face and lots of stones around his head and he moved his axe from one hand to the other. She looked at the others behind him in case some of them were hunters come to help but they were all men with smeary faces. She held tight to the rope and wished somebody would pull her up into the tree but no-one did.

In spite of that she looked up at the tree and said Help! but she could not see or hear anyone in the branches.

Instead she heard a whippy, creaky flapping sound above her head. She smelled that awful smell again. She felt so sick that she wanted to lie down and curl up in a ball like a hedgehog, blind and sleepy.

But she did not do that. She hung on helplessly to the rope and watched the great big flappy darkburn thing wheel round the lookout tree and then come down into the clearing, lower and lower. The men were standing still because they were watching it too but they weren't frightened. Instead they were waving and shouting at it and grinning. She thought one of them shouted "Here's your dinner" and she felt so sick she let go of the rope and nearly fell down. Instead she leaned against the tree which held her up, although her legs were very tired, so tired they would not do anything at all.

The not-a-bird kept coming down with lots of noisy whapping like curtains in the wind. It was very big, much bigger than a horse, as big as a monster, and the men all backed away from it but they were laughing so they still weren't afraid. Aliya thought they only backed away because it smelt so horrid and it was so hot.

She was too hot now and she didn't like it and she wanted to run away. But there was nowhere to run except around the tree and her legs couldn't do it. She thought of Mama – Mama would not run around a tree and hide. Mama would stand up straight and fold her arms and tell the thing to go away. And it would obey her. Because everybody did what Mama said.

So as the thing landed on the ground with a deep thud, Aliya leaned against the tree and folded her hot arms which did not want to fold and said, "My Mama says you have to go away." Her voice sounded thin and wobbly and not like her voice at all.

The flappy thing stood on its four stumpy legs and slowly closed up its wings. Black bits fell off them. They were not feathers. It was not a bird at all because its head was like a dog's, only burnt, and its legs were strong and thick, with big sharp claws, although they were burnt

black too. The bushes closest to it began to smoke and little flicks of flame were darting here and there amongst the prickly branches.

The thing did not take any notice of the flames. It stood in front of her and seemed to be looking at her even though it had no eyes. She was its dinner.

"That's not fair," she said. "I'm only five." Her voice wobbled worse than before and the smell made her feel terrible and she was scared that she was going to cry so she stamped her foot to hide it. She was much too hot and the woods were all going to burn down around her even if the thing did not eat her up for dinner.

But then with a creak and a noise of tearing, the thing opened up its raggedy wings again. She thought that it would pounce on her straight away but it did not.

Instead it leapt up in the air. Its wings were shredded and it flapped wildly as if it wasn't very good at flying. As it rose she could see the men behind it, and they were laughing and one was pointing at her. So she knew the flappy thing was going to pounce on her after all and eat her up. She wanted to run around the tree but she felt too weak and ill.

The thing flew up a bit more, with noisy whumps, and the men with axes were all shouting things like Go on! Get her! at it, loud and happy. But then the flappy thing turned round and lurched away from her. And it fell down towards the group of men and the shouting changed.

At first Aliya thought it was an accident because the thing was so bad at flying. Then she saw one big black claw reach out and pin a man against the ground. There was a horrible noise and the man burst into flames and then a bush beside him burst into flames with a loud crackle and hiss.

Aliya's legs suddenly decided to work. They ran around the tree with her, and then a minute later they stopped working again and she was sitting down on the far side.

It was cold and gloomy now that she couldn't see the fires. She rolled into a little ball like a hedgehog and tried to pretend she was a hedgehog sleeping underneath the look-out tree but it was too hard. She could hear horrible noises, screaming and crashing and it seemed a long time until the screaming stopped and she could hear only the crackle of fire. She smelt a lot of smoke. It was a rough angry smell.

The smoke made her eyes water and that made her want to cry again and she thought she ought to run away. But there was nowhere to run on this side of the tree because it was all a bushy tangle. The only way to run was back down the path past the flappy thing and the men. Although she found it very hard to move at all she uncurled herself and crawled slowly around the tree and put her head out to look.

She could see no men at all. There was the flappy darkburn, like a huge raggedy shadow standing in the path and drooping with its torn wings hanging down. There were lots of bonfires on the ground and in the bushes.

As she crouched on hands and knees and stared at the flappy thing it raised its black dog's head and stared right back at her although she still couldn't see its eyes. It knew she was there. Why hadn't it eaten her up? Was it because she had threatened it with Mama?

But it didn't know who Mama was, she thought. I didn't say Mama's name. I said, It's not fair. I'm only five.

Maybe it didn't want to eat up someone who was only five. Maybe it had a five year old black flappy monster somewhere, sitting in a nest. Except the nest would burn.

"You're setting all the woods on fire," she said, because orange flames were leaping from the bushes and smoke was swelling into round clouds and she couldn't even see the path properly. Where could she go? Where was everyone else? Where was baby Doval? "There's a baby," she said urgently. "Don't hurt the baby. Please."

The flappy thing just stood there staring at her with its eyes that weren't there, black against the golden fires behind it and around it. Still it did not move.

But it hurt Aliya to look at it and her throat was very sore and she was far too hot, so hot that she had to crawl back round behind the tree again.

It was cooler and darker than ever behind the tree and when she looked up she realised that the lookout tree was not on fire. Nor were any of the woods on this other side of it. She didn't know why, but it meant she could escape this way – if only she could find a path.

But there was no path between the trees, nothing but thick bushes and long brambles sewing all the trees together. She crawled over to the bushes and in the smoky flicker of the fires she could see that actually there were small gaps in there, low down: holes through the prickly stems where maybe rabbits or fangols or wild piglets had tunnelled their way through.

None of them looked big enough for her but there was nowhere else to go. So she crawled into the biggest gap and although stems tore her clothes and scraped her hands and pulled her braids and scratched her face, she kept on crawling. She wasn't a hedgehog any more, she was a rabbit, no no, she was a pig because pigs were brave and good at digging.

She kept burrowing and pushing through the twigs and prickles and she didn't care if they prickled her, because they were nothing but bushes and she was a wild pig. But sometimes they made her cry anyway because they hurt. When she came to a tiny thin stream in the middle of the prickly bushes it was a surprise but she drank from it, with her mouth right down in the water like a piglet. It was a messy way of drinking and the water was cold but it tasted like proper water and she managed to drink quite a lot.

Then she lay and rested with her head half in the stream. But she couldn't stay there because it was too wet and now that she'd stopped crawling she thought that she heard shouts and whippy flappy noises somewhere. She didn't want to hear them so she started burrowing again. Even when the stems above her parted she didn't try to stand up or to look around. She just kept crawling until she only heard the crack and snap of twigs as she pushed through them, and her own breathing. It was snorty because her nose was running but that was all right because she was a pig.

So she crawled and burrowed and tunnelled and although she sometimes came up against a tree trunk and had to go round it she still didn't try to stand up and walk. She felt safer crawling.

But suddenly she couldn't crawl any more so she lay down with her head on one side and put her hand under her cheek. Her arms were bleedy with long stripes and her sleeves were all torn. Flodda would be cross.

Mama would not be cross but she would be upset. She would hug Aliya tight and Aliya would say ouch but would let herself be hugged. When Mama hugged her she knew that she was safe. Nothing could reach her or hurt her then.

She wished that Mama would come hurrying through the woods to find her. But she didn't think that anyone could find her now, she was so well hidden.

And thinking of Mama made her want to cry again so she stopped thinking and lay on her side and looked at the twiggy stems sticking up through the messy prickly tangle. It was starting to get a bit dark and beyond the stems the sky was shining blue, not smoky, and she could see the moon like a bright button caught on the spiky branches. When she put out her hand to unfasten it she pricked her fingers.

If the moon was bright then maybe it was bedtime. But instead of a bed she had earth and pine needles and dead leaves underneath her. It was still light enough to see some pale pink flowers in little groups along the spiny stems. They had yellow dotty middles. There was a tiny fly on one and she wished she was a fly so that she could fly away and nobody would notice her.

She felt very hot and sore and itchy but there was no stream to drink from. The smoke had made her mouth dry and her eyes hurt and she thought she ought to crawl again and look for some more water but she was too tired, so tired. And it was quiet here.

So Aliya lay beneath the bushes and looked at the bright moon and the little pale pink flowers for a bit longer, and then she closed her eyes.

Chapter 40

Amidst the turmoil Meya stood at a loss. Around her, Riders ran and argued and hoicked their gear with grim or flustered faces.

I should not have come so far, she thought. What madness made me join this tiny army on their reckless expedition? No matter how brave the Vonn may be as individuals, as a nation they are nothing. I should not be here. I should be with my daughter. Oh, Aliya, my beloved Aliya.

With folded arms, she rocked herself a little, unobtrusively, trying to hold her anguish in. The Riders paid her no attention: all their wariness was for Huldarion, now issuing terse, clipped commands. Meya was a lost queen in an alien army.

The Vonn had promised to protect her daughter. She had been assured that Aliya would be safe. But of what worth were such assurances? Her heart felt rent in two, laid open with an axe of dread. The monstrous darkburn had filled her with appalling fear; but now that it was gone, the fear had not dissolved, as Huldarion had said it would. Instead, it stayed, transmuted into terror for her daughter. If such a dreadful enemy could appear so suddenly, so unforeseen, then where was safe?

And I assigned her to the roughened hands of a farmer's wife, she thought, in sharp dismay. No army protects my precious Aliya. A sick hunter and his band of ruffians, and a few farm labourers...

Numbly she gazed at the activity around her, seeing only Aliya in a shabby dress, her hair pulled back in an undignified disguise. She wanted to hold her daughter. To hug her tight, to never let her go.

Huldarion had turned his back on her to speak curtly to his Riders. Some of the horses had run a long way off, and he was angry. Thoronal came up to ask about the stowage of the damaged tents and got snapped at.

"Use your common sense – if you have any. What point is there in packing up a tent that's irreparable?"

At which Thoronal backed off, looking hurt and surprised.

Meya had heard anger many times, in Kelvha; yet coming from Huldarion, it shocked her. She had thought his self-containment so complete that the rashness of wild anger could not touch him. Yet he was clearly burning up with fury. It alarmed her.

And now the northern archer, Yaret, was being led over to him by Parthenal; although Yaret did not require leading. She walked straight up to face Huldarion with her head tilted slightly, and cool, assessing eyes.

How dare she, Meya thought, both irritated and admiring. For a common archer, and a female one at that, to scrutinise the ruler of Caervonn in that manner! Where is her timidity, her awe?

When Huldarion addressed her, his voice was thick with anger: clotted.

"You told the hunter Zan about the stonemen's youth – against my express orders."

"I told Zan nothing," answered Yaret steadily.

"You were close with him."

"I was. But I told him nothing."

"Then who did?" Huldarion almost snarled.

"I don't know. Perhaps the men of the Baron of the Broc."

"Really? Yet Zan showed no sign of any knowledge prior to this morning. So who told him? Who sent the army into disarray by such treasonous rumour-mongering?"

"A treasonous rumour? Zan told nothing but the truth," said Yaret.

"So it was you. It would not be the first time you have lied. Darkburns that tunnel through the earth? Oh, you were fluent there."

"That was necessary," said Yaret. "But this time it was not me. Are you quite sure that you told nobody?"

"Nobody." But Huldarion's head went up. "Leor," he muttered, his tone ominous. "Where is Leor?"

"Leor was in the monastery with us, during all that battle," Meya put in, feeling an unaccountable need to defend Leor from Huldarion's rage. She had no idea why. A wizard could surely look after himself.

In any case, Huldarion ignored her. Instead he called out harshly to his men. "Solon? Go down to the sea and summon Leor. Orbrel? Why is nobody rounding up those horses?"

He strode away, and Meya stood and rocked herself, again. Who cared about the horses? Who cared about Leor? Oh, my Aliya, she thought, Aliya, why did I entrust your future to this wrathful man?

Yaret stood looking after Huldarion as he strode off. Then she turned to Meya.

"Does everybody think I spread this story?"

"I don't know," said Meya. "I think it hardly matters who first spread it. The more important thing is its effect."

"Its effect on the army."

Meya nodded, although she also meant the effect on Huldarion. For did not a commander decide the behaviour of his army? Her father would have pointed out instantly that a problem was not necessarily a problem unless you dealt with it the wrong way. Huldarion seemed obsessed with finding the culprit, rather than dealing with the actual issue.

Which to her mind was not really a problem at all. Even if the stonemen were younger in years than they appeared, they were, to all intents and purposes, still men. They were not children. They looked like men and fought like men; and when she sought inside herself to ask her father what his judgement was, she heard General Borovin's deep voice clear in her head.

Whatever their age, they are the attackers. Unless they sue for peace, they have to be put down.

So put them down, Huldarion, she thought. Join with the Kelvhan army, put them down. And then let me find my daughter.

Meanwhile Yaret's gaze had moved over to the nearby carts.

"Is she all right?"

"Who? Gaelera? She seems perfectly all right," said Meya acidly. Her fellow Kelvhan had appeared unmoved by either dread of the darkburn or the shock of being thrown into the sea. The events that had horrified Meya seemed to have filled Gaelera with a strange enthusiasm.

"Actually, I meant Janeya," murmured Yaret.

"You meant Jebil," said Meya in reproof, before glancing around to check that they were within no-one's earshot. Jebil-Janeya, ten yards away, was being calmly harangued by Lady Gaelera about some detail of her dress.

"It is your job," Gaelera was instructing her, "to ensure my clothes are always ready for me."

"But, ma'am, two soaking wet dresses in two days!" expostulated the other, true, maid, Piril. Janeya did not know how to be a lady's maid, thought Meya. The girl just moped and hung her head and was altogether exasperating. It occurred to her, again, that Gaelera must know her true identity; for otherwise she would not bother talking to her at such length.

Time to step in. This was one situation, at least, that she could deal with. She marched over to the group, saying,

"Jebil, go into my carriage, please, and tidy up. Pack everything in the chests and make sure they are secured. We shall soon be moving off."

Janeya-Jebil shuffled away, her head still down.

"How soon do we leave, my lady?" Piril asked.

"Very shortly. Once the horses are all gathered." In fact Meya had no idea how soon Huldarion intended to march; but she added, "To linger in this place another night cannot be safe. We shall depart inland and east to meet the Kelvhan army."

"I'll go and find the archers," said Yaret. "But first – my Lady Meya? May I have one more word? It is a private matter."

Janeya was the thought that sprang at once to Meya's mind: what other subject could have such need of privacy?

"Please step into my carriage," she said majestically. Yaret swung herself up into it, and Meya followed with more difficulty. "Leave us for a moment, Jebil," she said to the drooping girl within.

"How are you?" Yaret asked her with compassion.

"I am alive," said Janeya dismally. "I suppose." Exasperation washed over Meya again. The girl was a high-born lady of Kelvha – could she not show some grit?

"You saw the darkburn?" asked Yaret.

Janeya nodded.

"You will see more," said Yaret, "if you stay with us."

"Good," said Janeya, raising her chin with unexpected resolution. "I want to fight."

Yaret surveyed her thoughtfully. "You've heard that some of the stonemen are no more than children? Would you be able to fight them?"

"It's Nerogun that I want to fight."

Meya was both shocked and irritated. Too much grit, of entirely the wrong sort. "That will not happen," she told Janeya.

"So you always say. *That will not happen*. Yet it does."

"Well, never mind now," put in Yaret. "Have you skill with a sword, or bow and arrow? Can you shoot?"

"Young ladies do not learn to shoot in Kelvha," Meya said. "Nor use a sword."

"I can learn," suggested Janeya.

Yaret grimaced. "Well, I suppose you can be useful in the medics' tent."

Janeya looked somewhat deflated; and quite rightly too, thought Meya.

"That private matter," said Yaret to her. "Janeya may hear it. It is this." She took a battered waterskin from her belt; it had been cut open to enlarge the opening, and re-tied.

Now, untying the cord, Yaret dipped her fingers into the stained leather. When she withdrew them, they were smeared with a bluish clay-like substance.

"You may be able to advise me, Lady Meya," she said. "Is this stuff similar to Athelid? I think it is."

Meya took a tiny amount on her own finger, sniffed it, and cautiously put it to her tongue before wiping both tongue and fingers on her kerchief. Oily, slightly metallic... it was certainly familiar.

"I agree," she said. "Although it looks different to the sample that that your herb-mistress showed me, the smell and taste are similar. Where did you get it?"

"From a deep clay pit over yonder. It seems to have been much mined."

"By stonemen?"

"So I assume," said Yaret. "Your archivist Tamu had an old document that said the stonemen dug their Athelid from the ground. That could mean a root; but why not a mineral? I asked Rigal to dig up more of this, in case it might be useful."

"If indeed it's a component of that stonemen's drug called Athelid," said Meya cautiously, "to what use could you put it? It's dangerously addictive, is it not?"

"Athelid certainly is. I don't know about this particular element of it. I think the main ingredient of Athelid is ethlon or a related painkiller; ethlon is moderately addictive. But there must be additional ingredients in Athelid that make the stonemen both aggressive to their enemies and submissive to the orders they receive."

"Then this, I think, tastes like the ingredient that makes them submissive," Meya said, thinking of the sample she had removed from the valet Kavaul's flask back in Kelvha Castle. When it had been added to Faldron's wine, it had certainly made the High Prince unusually passive and suggestible.

"How can you be sure of that, my lady?" asked Yaret in surprise.

"I have knowledge of that element. It smelt similar to this." That faint metallic sourness... She could not, of course, tell Yaret of the dosing of the High Prince Faldron by his servant: but she recalled who had appointed Kavaul.

Nerogun. How had he laid his hands upon it?

"Would you advise me to show this to Huldarion, my Lady?"

She hesitated. "Yes, of course," she said, "in due time, but not immediately, perhaps. He has a great deal to think about at present."

"Indeed." Yaret bowed her head. "My lady, would you broach the subject with him, if the opportunity arises? I am currently out of favour. You could say to him that Rigal keeps the samples."

"I will see," said Meya. She felt that she would not care to broach any subject with Huldarion just now.

When they clambered out of the carriage she could see him striding up to Leor in the middle distance. The two men stood still and appeared to be arguing. Huldarion took a step forward and Leor took a step back. Surely it could not be wise to antagonise a wizard?

Meanwhile four senior Riders were waiting near the carriage for her.

"Ma'am," said Crade, "are we to prepare to ride out?"

"You are," said Meya decisively. This was something she could do, at least. "We aim to leave" – she glanced up at the sky – "within the hour. The Kelvhan army, as I understand, is two or three hours' ride away. It may be possible to reach them before sunset. If not, a camp some distance from the sea-shore will certainly be safer than remaining here. Captain Crade: what is the situation with the horses? Is an hour feasible?"

"I believe so, Lady Meya."

"Good. Tiburé; have any stonemen been found by the Riders who went in search of them?"

"Only the footprints of one, heading north," said Tiburé. "They have distinctive shoe-soles. A lone escapee from the ambush, mostly likely, hardly worth pursuing."

"Then please recall those scouts and tell them of our imminent departure."

Tiburé left, without any salute. Meya decided to overlook the omission.

Meanwhile Parthenal was gazing towards Huldarion with a worried frown. And no wonder. She addressed him next.

"Can the companies be drawn up ready to leave in their usual formation, Captain Parthenal? I am sure you will know the procedure. I shall make it clear to the Lord Huldarion that you act on my command." This last, she thought, was necessary in the light of Huldarion's summary dismissal of Rothir. But he would not treat her so.

Parthenal bowed. "I will see to it, my Lady Meya."

"I know there have been points of disagreement amongst your people," Meya said. "But those, I hope, can wait for now, while we ensure an orderly departure. Your comrade Captain Rothir is a brave and principled man. I have no doubt he will obey the orders to ride out?"

"Rothir will always do his duty," said Parthenal soberly.

She nodded, and turned to the fourth Rider standing there. "Captain Thoronal. I believe you were to check the carts. Are we fully watered and provisioned?"

"I'm not quite sure," said Thoronal. "That's not usually my task."

"Then let us go and see." While the other captains hastened off, she walked briskly towards the provision carts with Thoronal. Before reaching them she addressed him in a quiet voice. "Captain, you are Lord Huldarion's cousin, and you know him well. Clearly, he is upset by the tragic recent occurrences. The weight of responsibility lies heavy on him. What might calm him? What method would you suggest?"

She did not really want advice from Thoronal – nor did she expect any useful answer; rather, she aimed both to acknowledge the difficulty of facing Huldarion's anger, and to warn Thoronal to tread carefully. His heavy-handed manner was not likely to improve things. She aimed, too, to keep Thoronal emollient by asking his advice; although he did not strike her as an emollient man. He was too stiff – too like Huldarion in that respect.

Now he frowned and pulled a face which presumably signified deep thought.

"Hmm," he said, "not easy;" a response even less useful than she had expected. He came up with none of the more obvious suggestions that had occurred to her. To soothe Huldarion by giving him matters to concentrate on that lay within his control. To distract him with calculations of riding times and distances. To guide him to think about his men – and women – rather than stay entangled in his own preoccupations. And she knew another way to soothe Huldarion; although it was not one that she could hint about to Thoronal. That one was up to her.

She hoped that Huldarion would not fall out with Leor. While she did not altogether trust the wizard, she recognised the value of the spell with which he'd frozen out the darkburn. Huldarion needed Leor, whether he realised it or not.

And he needed *her*, whether he realised that or not. With Thoronal at her side she began a swift inspection of the carts, checking what equipment was missing, how many sacks and crates of food were still intact, nodding and storing numbers in her head. She found the task almost familiar, being so accustomed to supervising the steward's work within Kelvha castle, with its many hundreds of inhabitants. What was an army but a castle on the move?

What surprised her a little was that the Vonn who manned the carts were so forthcoming to her, a mere woman taking liberties. She even won a smile from one or two as she discussed the quality of the dried meat – always unpredictable, but that variation could make the difference, she knew, between a well-fed army and a dissatisfied one. She heard her dead father speaking through her voice and was at first disconcerted and then moved by the memory of that committed general.

Meanwhile Thoronal was increasing her impatience. Why did he not know the amount of flour each man required for one week's worth of flatbread? It was simple enough, surely. And while the provisioning of water was something she had seldom thought about, it would, as she observed to a nodding driver, hardly be of such great moment in the water-sodden land that they must pass through.

In all, the only unsatisfactory answer came from the strange gaunt priest from the temple of Borgun, who travelled in one of the provision carts and who despite listing its contents refused to let her enter it to check them.

"You will do as you are bid," said Thoronal sternly.

"And the Lord Huldarion bid me allow no man but himself to enter," said the priest. "You know that, sir, for you were there."

Thoronal turned away in some confusion.

"The man is an eccentric," Meya said to him, "if not an actual fanatic. We will not press him." She was anxious not to flout any command that Huldarion might have made. In fact, she was becoming anxious about his reaction to the steps she had just taken.

With this anxiety growing she left the carts and walked over to Huldarion where he stood alone within the temple. He merely nodded absently as she informed him that the carts and Riders were being readied to depart. Meya bridled a little; anger would at least have shown that he was paying attention. Where was the acknowledgement of all her efforts?

"Your men – and women – await only your command to leave," she said, as meekly as she could.

"Then let us go," he murmured.

Returning to her carriage, Meya sat up behind the driver on the padded seat. Her driver, a withered elderly man called Argret, nodded to her. She did not expect him to speak – although he frequently mumbled to himself, his only words to her till now had been a distressingly casual "All right, m'lady?" She had thought of reporting him to Huldarion but had decided this might be considered too niggling a complaint.

"All right, m'lady?" offered Argret now, and then, to her surprise, he added, "Good work there, m'lady."

"See to your horses," said Meya coolly. After a moment, however, she added "Thank you," because the Vonnish ways were, after all, not as the Kelvhan. All the same she hoped he would not see fit to begin talking to her.

Nor did he; so they sat in silence while the earth began to rumble and the air to ring. The first companies of Riders had set out behind Huldarion at the front, the horses stamping. She as usual was far back in the train of trundling carts, and had to wait before her wheels began to turn.

Gaelera, in Meya's second carriage, was travelling alongside her, perched bolt upright just behind her own ancient, toothless driver. Her dress appeared to be clean and dry. How had Piril managed it? A good maidservant. Gaelera was looking around her, stretching her neck in all directions in an unexpected show of curiosity.

Fortunately the distance between her and Gaelera, coupled with the noise of the wheels and the creak of carriages, was too great to allow for any conversation. Meya sat back and mused on the wonders of this world outside Kelvha: the immensity of sea, which she did not like and was glad to see the last of; the ruined monastery, that black hulk at the end of the civilised world; and the forlorn remnants of the town so far in time and place from Kelvha City – a reminder that greatness was not Kelvha's only, and that Kelvha could, by some comparisons, be considered young. It was not a reassuring thought.

These musings occupied her as they trundled over grassy trackways with no glimpse of the ocean, although the sea-birds overhead still rode the wind and scraped the sky with their continual wails of grief and shrieks of warning. The great stones became visible and seemed to march towards her, like giant sentries making some unheard demand she could not satisfy.

Slowly the sun slid down behind them, streaking the dull cloaks of the Riders ruby red. And soon the thudding hooves began to spray out golden drops as they re-encountered the strangeness of the Red Roads. The waters up ahead were painted glowing scarlet by the sun: meandering streams of fire. Meya was acutely aware of them, and of the stark and massive presence of the stones.

Before the army reached the wide streams of the Red Roads proper, it halted, where the grassland was still relatively dry. A borderland between two enigmatic countries.

Argret pulled up with the other carts and looked at her expectantly. "All right, m'lady?"

Meya nodded, and climbed down from her seat to stretch her limbs. In the neighbouring carriage, Gaelera was still looking round. She addressed Meya from her perch.

"Where is my good friend Maeneb?"

"I don't know," said Meya.

"She should have been here."

"I expect she is further up the line."

"Perhaps," Gaelera said. Still she peered this way and that. Meya thought that Maeneb was very likely hiding from Gaelera. She wished that she herself could do the same.

Up ahead, Huldarion was directing men and women to deploy the tents. Fires were lit and suppers cooked. Meya ate within her carriage, accompanied only by Janeya-Jebil, in order to avoid Gaelera's company. She had hoped that Huldarion might come to join her, but he did not, and she would not encroach on him unbidden.

All the same, having exiled Janeya to the rear section, she waited in her carriage that night until late, her shielded lamp faintly burning, in hope blended with a strange and creeping fear. But the murmuring bustle of the camp subsided and gradually fell silent; and Huldarion did not come.

Chapter 41

Yaret lay awake, wondering what to do. Although she was fairly sure that Hilbré too was wakeful, she did not speak for fear of disturbing the other women in the tent.

They were fewer than previously, for tonight there was no Maeneb. Yaret thought that she was probably keeping well away from Gaelera. But there was no Gaelera either. Perhaps she feared another midnight onslaught.

While Yaret too was wary of attack, other, more intrusive worries were interweaving in her mind. She tried to get them into order, to make some useful pattern of their warp and weft, but they would not be controlled. They clashed and clattered round her head like a carelessly beamed loom.

The stones: did they still work? Would they repel the darkburns when the next attack occurred – as it inevitably would? She feared not.

Herself: could she still face even ordinary darkburns after the horror of that gigantic one, the thrashing coils demolishing the roof? She told herself again that it had not been the darkburn but the long drop to the sea that had made her feel so sick and helpless. Then witnessing the women tumbling down, down to hit the waves... Her stomach clenched again at the thought of it, while her leg throbbed painfully, reminding her of that dreadful fall from the high cliffs above the River Thore.

But whatever the reason for her weakness on the roof, she was ashamed of it: of being seen to have succumbed to fear. In any oncoming battles, not only might the stones prove ineffective, but so might she. And in that case why was she here at all?

The stonemen. Another worry. The idea that some of them might be mere children had haunted her ever since she'd found the abandoned stoneman Brael in the desolation of Erbulet. Ten years old, he'd said. Whenever she'd killed a stonemen after that she'd found herself counting stones, and calculating: would that one be fourteen? Twelve? Eleven?

Horrible to think about. Yet she had killed them anyway, despite the nauseous despair such violence brought. What choice was there? To throw down her sword and be slain by an axe? By all accounts, that was what had happened to Zan.

Maybe Zan had willed it to happen. He had lost his hope. He'd seemed to feel dishonoured by surviving the terror that had killed his townsmen. Yaret had tried to tell him there was no need of shame; but she knew the feeling could not easily be assuaged. She had felt it herself, the lonely guilt of being the one who had escaped. She grieved for Zan; and for poor Durba, too.

And the worst thing of all, which should not be set above those deaths, was none the less most grievous to her. She had lost Rothir's friendship. She knew it, because she'd walked up to him as he'd been checking horses and he had turned away without a word. Rothir could not face her. Parthenal told her, with a rueful shrug, that Rothir could not bear the thought of killing children.

But what else could they do? She could not abandon her vow to her dead townsfolk. That would be to abandon her history and herself.

There was no good solution. Yaret had thought the Athelid – or whatever substance she had dug up in the burial pit – might unlock an answer. But any key eluded her.

She settled her head again upon its roll of clothes and tried to still the inner clamour by concentrating on the gentle sounds around her. The sea was now inaudible. Some bird was wailing with an falling cry, *aaaah*, down and down; as if in answer, there came a long, far, sigh of wingbeats. Or perhaps that was merely wind in the grass. A nearby canvas flapped. Inside the tent she heard the soft breath of the sleepers; and even softer, closer, someone weeping.

Hilbré. Yaret put out a hand through the cold air to touch her shoulder. At once the sound of weeping stopped. Yaret did not ask her if she was all right, because it was obvious that she was not. Whatever grieved her – the youthful stonemen, or the memories of her own dead child – it would not help to make her talk about it, rousing half the tent to wakefulness by doing so. So she patted the shoulder until Hilbré reached up a hand and patted hers in turn, and then gently removed it.

Odd, the effect of such companionship in sorrow. Knowing that she was not the only one to lie awake, Yaret was able to relax at last, hearing the whisper of high fluttering breezes; and duly fell asleep.

In the morning on emerging from the tent she performed her daily ritual of Haedath, sometimes forgotten lately: touching the earth and then putting fingers to her heart, her lips, her forehead, while murmuring the familiar words in Bandiran.

Hilbré stood waiting till she finished. Then she said, "I'm sorry to have woken you."

"I was awake already," said Yaret. "What do you think will happen about the stonemen?"

Hilbré shook her head. "I owe all my allegiance to Huldarion," she said, "but in this matter, I don't know."

Yaret studied her with compassion and respect. A tall, quietly spoken woman, Hilbré commanded her company of Riders without fuss. Although her voice was never raised, her calmness masked a deep determination.

"Will it be discussed?" she asked.

"It will need to be," said Hilbré. "We need to think of tactics in case some of us refuse to fight."

Yaret eyed her cautiously. "Does that include you?"

"I don't know yet. Clearly, you have no such worries."

"I do have such worries," Yaret said, "and they kept me awake last night. I worry that it may drive a wedge between the different factions of the Vonn, if some will fight and some will not."

"Then let us not call them factions," Hilbré said. "Disagreement need not mean division." She put out her hand, mirroring last night's gesture, and Yaret took and shook it.

"Well," said Hilbré, "we'd better get ourselves in order. We need to gather all the Captains and their seconds before we meet with Kelvha."

"And pretend that nothing's happened," said Yaret.

"That will hardly be possible, when Rhadlun and his henchmen have been trailing us with long ears wagging."

"Will you tell me how the Captains' meeting goes?"

"You can come with me," she said.

"But–"

"No, you're not a Captain. But you are the representative of your country."

"A non-existent country," said Yaret.

"Our valued ally none the less. Jerred will be there, representing Gostard; so why not you?"

"I'm out of favour with Huldarion."

"Huldarion is out of favour with himself. Come."

So Yaret went, as the lonely representative of a very small ally. As they approached the gathering in a space outside the tents – a group of perhaps two dozen stern-faced listeners in all – the first voice she heard was Rothir's.

Hilbré had said Huldarion was angry with him, and yet there he was, earnestly addressing the company of captains. Meya stood behind them being ignored, and looking on tight-lipped.

Yaret felt a surge of pride and sadness. She had feared that Rothir might abandon the Riders; but he was not a sulker nor a skulker. He was speaking now with passion but no anger. It was, of course, the issue of the stonemen that they were debating. Or quarrelling over.

"I suppose you would not kill the darkburns either," said Huldarion, his words grating. "In case they might be children too."

"This is not about the darkburns." Rothir's deep voice was level-toned. "This is about a people who have been effectively enslaved, exploited--"

"Enslaved? By their own will. Exploited? With their own consent."

"The fact remains--"

"The fact remains that you choose not to fight. Captains and seconds?" Huldarion called out. "Now that all of you are gathered, let it known that Rothir chooses not to fight. He chooses so-called compassion over loyalty."

"So-called?" said Rothir.

"You would stand aside and let the stonemen massacre your fellows."

"I would not."

"Oh? Then what exactly will you do, if you refuse to kill the enemy?"

"They need not all be killed--"

"What, then?" demanded Huldarion. "Taken prisoner? And if we could stop them from killing themselves – which in the past has proved quite difficult, as you know well – what should we do with several hundred or a thousand or ten thousand captive stonemen?"

"Only the youngest," said Rothir. "Not all are children."

Solon leaned forward. "So: do you recommend that in the midst of battle we just stop and count the stones in every head, perhaps asking them to turn around for easier counting; and then kill those with, say, more than ten stones? Or twelve? Fourteen? Where would you draw the line, Rothir?"

"We *could* draw a line," said Tiburé from the side. Solon frowned at her in disapproval. "It's quick enough to see which ones have only two or four stones in their heads, and which have many. I expect ten stones should mean a true age of at least eighteen years: and that seems to be roughly the division between the stoneman foot-soldiers and their commanders. The ones who will not surrender will face death. But we could give the others chance of life."

Solon turned on her. "Ten stones? And will you do the counting while we fight? Oh, that would suit you, wouldn't it?"

"That is not what--"

Solon cut across her. "If you can't talk sense, be quiet, woman. Stonemen never surrender in any case. The thing cannot be done and you should know it."

"And indeed," said Thoronal ponderously, "to keep any stonemen captive would be difficult for us. Even a hundred would be too many – we have not the resources nor the manpower to hold them."

"We shouldn't be fighting them at all!" cried Landel. Yaret saw that he was almost in tears. Theol, beside him, put a hand upon his arm; but he shook it off.

"If not kept as prisoners, perhaps the stonemen could somehow be disabled," Rothir said. "What about their drugs? The Athelid?"

"What of it?" snapped Huldarion.

"If we could reach that supply, and cut it off--"

"And have the stonemen die in agony? Is that your best solution?"

"It's worth exploring, at the least." But Yaret knew that Rothir was clutching at a straw.

Huldarion's response was biting. "And how exactly would you infiltrate the stoneman lines to tamper with their Athelid?"

Yaret thought that here she maybe ought to intervene, and say that she might have found one of the drug's ingredients. She felt for Huldarion, for this was a dreadful dilemma. But he was not handling it well. His fury was alarming and surely disproportionate, for the secret of the stonemen's age would have had to be revealed at some point; and she sympathised with those who found it difficult. As for herself, she had tried hard not to think about it, because her dead kinsmen called for vengeance.

But for her to speak now would only fuel Huldarion's ire. And indeed, maybe he knew about the clay already; for had not Meya promised she would tell him?

Now Meya herself spoke, in a clear and measured voice. "My Lords? May I add an observation? Kelvha is strong. We have men to spare. Kelvhan troops can be put at your service, my Lord Huldarion, if you wish to hold stonemen as prisoners."

"I do not wish it. And I will not be beholden to Kelvha any more than I must." Yaret saw Meya draw back at this. It was just as well that Rhadlun and his lieutenants were not present.

"Indeed," said Rothir, "you would be wise not to."

"And why is that?" asked Meya coolly.

"I have a reason for saying so. But I may impart it only to Huldarion."

"Oh," said Huldarion, "and yet you will speak freely to all the Riders when it suits you to spread discord and dissent. Perhaps it was you who spread this news about the stonemen in the first place?"

"That was not me," said Rothir steadily. "I had no knowledge of it till last night."

"And yet the foreign archer swears it was not her, and Leor swears it was not him. Strange, is it not, how everyone denies it?"

Yaret saw a few heads turn to glance at her. She wondered whether it was worth denying it again; but held her peace. Instead, she heard Leor's voice behind her.

"I spoke the truth to you, Huldarion," the wizard asserted firmly. "You told me of the stonemen's ages before we ever rode into Kelvha, but I did as you commanded, and mentioned it to no-one. I do not know who passed the news to Zan."

"And you haven't cared to find out," said Huldarion.

"How could I do that?"

"With your wizardry," said Huldarion, "but no, I forget: you have forsworn your magic, have you not? Except in service to Kelvha. You used it to save Gaelera from the sea."

"I used it to save everybody from the darkburn," Leor said, his voice low and grave. "Would you have preferred me not to? You asked me to do something."

"I did not bid you freeze the ocean. And back there in the Outlands, you raised that darkburn from the pit at Kelvha's bidding," said Huldarion.

"I gave him authority to do that," said Rothir.

Huldarion turned on him. "Yes, I know you did," he said with bitter, cutting force.

"In your absence."

"And against my wishes."

Leor said, "You were far away, so Rothir and I agreed that it was best to do as the Kelvhans asked us."

"Indeed." Huldarion's face had grown dark red all down one side, as if his scar expressed his rage. His voice was tight and thick. "I was not so far away as all that. Yet I was not consulted. I wouldn't be surprised if you destroyed the darkburn that was held captive inside Kelvha City too, without my knowledge or consent. Was that you, Leor?"

Leor hesitated. He had indeed, as Yaret knew, played a part in that darkburn's destruction. She caught her breath.

"No," said Rothir gravely and reluctantly, "that was not Leor. That was me."

"What?"

"And me," called out Yaret, so that Huldarion should not think Rothir alone had been responsible. After all, it had not been his idea.

"And Veron," said Leor. "Veron planned it, because he'd learned that Kelvha City was in danger from the darkburn."

Huldarion stared at Rothir and then Leor. "So: you had a hand in it! And Veron! Are all my Riders thus disloyal?"

"It was not disloyalty," Leor protested. "Nerogun could not be allowed to let the darkburn loose within the city."

"What?" This time it was Meya who exclaimed. "What are you talking about? What has Nerogun to do with it? The darkburn escaped from its captivity."

"And tell me," Huldarion almost snarled, ignoring Meya, "did you succeed, Rothir? Did you save the city? Remind me, how did the northern quarter fare? Do you recall those burnt-out streets around the temple? Do you remember that the priest was almost lynched by the Kelvhan mob? Would you have confessed before they strung the man up from his doorway?"

"Huldarion," said Uld with a note of warning, "we are departing from our purpose. This matter of the darkburn in the city can be discussed later. Right now we need to counsel, do we not, on our best means of battle if the stonemen should attack."

"There's no sign of it yet," said Solon. "According to our scouts, there are no stonemen in the vicinity except those boats; which have stayed off-shore, and they are few. Six vessels, which might hold three hundred men; that's no army."

"Then what are they doing there?" asked Tiburé. Solon shrugged.

"But Kelvha are on their way over here," Uld went on. "Do you not see their flags on the horizon yonder?"

Yaret looked up. A long snake moved across the far side of the Red Roads: a snake made up of cavalry and carts, tall standards waving, livery sparkling in the sun.

"Perhaps an hour away," said Parthenal.

"But one of them's much closer," Uld remarked; for a lone horseman was galloping towards them from the snaking train, water fountaining from his horse's hooves. A small group followed him some way behind. "An emissary from the High Lords, probably. We have no strategy to offer them for battle – if battle is to come."

"Battle will be fought," said Huldarion, who seemed to be fighting some other, inner struggle. "Those who do not wish to fight may, of course, withhold themselves. I cannot compel them."

"We can be stretcher-bearers," Rothir said.

"Stretcher-bearers! And carry off those who have been wounded in your stead! You can withdraw altogether."

"That will not help the Vonnish cause."

"But that is not your aim, is it, to help the Vonnish cause?"

Rothir looked him straight in the eye. "Huldarion, my aim for the last dozen years has been to help you to regain Caervonn," he said evenly. "That has not changed. Nor will it. It is unfair of you to cast doubt on my loyalty when you have had so many proofs of it." He bowed to Huldarion and walked away, the small crowd parting to let him go.

Parthenal and several other people reached out their hands to touch him as he left. Meya looked as if she wished to speak; but after a glance at Huldarion she stayed silent. Yaret felt an almost overwhelming urge to push through the crowd and follow Rothir – to tell him she admired his resolution not to fight: to try and win his friendship back: to regain his esteem, no matter how...

It would not work. For she herself was bound to choose the opposite course. Her dead stood by her shoulder and could not be repudiated. So she stayed where she was.

"And the rest of you?" snapped Huldarion. "Landel?"

"You know what I think," said Landel, and he too turned away and barged off through the crowd. Yaret saw that his eyes were bright with unshed tears. She felt tears rise in her own eyes in response, in pity for the man's distress, for the distress of all those Riders who were filled with grief to think they had been killing children.

"And what about you others?" Huldarion demanded, whirling round to face them.

"There is no time for all this now," insisted Uld. "Kelvha are almost here. Huldarion! Be still."

The sound of galloping had grown loud, though it was but a single horse that sprang towards them, with the others still following at a distance. Now Yaret could see this was no emissary, but a lord, with a crimson cloak and glittering gear and tassels flying from his horse's mane.

"The High Prince," announced Parthenal in astonishment. Yaret wondered if Faldron's followers had been actually out-riden or merely needed to appear so.

As he pulled up his stamping warhorse, she could not help admitting that Faldron certainly looked princely – far more so than Huldarion in his drab gear; and she was probably not the only one who thought it. What would the Prince of Kelvha make of this scarred and beggared chieftain, whose troops were now so disarrayed? Whose strongest warrior – apart from Parthenal – had just walked away? As Faldron dismounted with a flourish and a jangle of gold spurs, she was apprehensive.

But Huldarion rearranged his face to meet the Prince. The anger was concealed, his dignity to the fore; and if the darkness of his scars did not abate, his voice held only courtesy as he shook Faldron's hand.

"Your Highness. My hearty greetings to you. I am glad to see you in such health, and only wish that we had had the chance to prepare a more fitting welcome. But you find us still in council."

"Council? I see you have been arguing," said Faldron. Surely, thought Yaret, such a remark must be a breach of diplomatic protocol? But the prince went on, in a tone of almost casual interest, "It is a very novel idea to me, that men may argue freely with their commander. It seems extraordinary. Such a thing would be seen as mutiny in Kelvha, and punishable by death."

"No doubt," said Huldarion with cool aloofness.

"In fact, you yourself witnessed some mutiny of the sort, did you not, Huldarion, within the castle? A Kelvhan captain had been accused of failing to guard the darkburn that went missing."

"Yes, I remember."

Faldron nodded thoughtfully. "The thing had burrowed its way out, apparently."

Yaret remembered too, very clearly, and was glad the Prince was not facing in her direction. Huldarion's coolness increased almost to the point of freezing. "Let me assure you that there is no mutiny here."

"I expect you wouldn't want any appearance of it in front of Nerogun," said the prince. "He's not far behind me. Luckily I'm less easily shocked."

"You may be sure that despite some trifling disagreements, which I need not bore you with, the Vonn are in accord," Huldarion said. "We were discussing strategy in case of further trouble."

"Like that linwurm? I heard about the creature, though I've–" Faldron paused and frowned. A noise had interrupted him: a long, clear, musical note, low and faintly throbbing. At first Yaret thought it was someone singing, over by the carts – someone with a particularly bell-like voice.

But the sound did not stop to draw breath. It grew and resonated; not a voice after all, although as it swelled it sounded almost like a choir of impossibly pure voices, perfectly aligned. It must be a bell or gong rung by some unseen watcher.

And now she knew the sound. She'd heard it ring at Olbeth's farm, just before the onslaught of the stonemen.

Chapter 42

Meya immediately recognised that singing note. She turned to Huldarion in consternation.

"The alarm bell! Does it mean that stonemen are nearby?"

Everyone was looking at the carts, whence the ringing came, with puzzlement.

Thoronal, however, shuffled, and said, "Perhaps we..." with a sidelong glance at Huldarion, who now appeared to be completely frozen, a man of ice, immobile, his face pale. It alarmed Meya as much as the bell did. Then, with an abrupt movement, but without a word, Huldarion started forward and began to push through the Riders.

"Is it an ambush?" said Meya anxiously to those around her.

"Ma'am, there is no enemy in sight," said Parthenal. "The sentries have not given any warnings."

"Then who is ringing the bell?" asked Faldron. "A mystery! Let us go and see."

He strode after Huldarion; and so did the other Captains, while Meya scurried to keep up with them. Huldarion was walking so fast that he was almost running by the time he reached the carts.

"Well, this is most intriguing," Faldron said. "A cart that rings!"

Huldarion passed Meya's own pair of decorative carriages, where Gaelera was standing like a bland-faced, dressed-up doll. She dipped her head to Faldron and looked at Meya with one eyebrow raised a very small amount. She took no notice of the approaching retinue of Kelvhans although they were now close.

Close, enough, indeed, for Captain Rhadlun to be hurrying over to greet them, followed by Iajo, the unpleasant armourer. Meya discerned with a sinking heart the burly figure of Lord Nerogun. Shargun, too... She felt a deep foreboding. Faldron's presence was difficult enough, with Huldarion in such unsettled temper. She did not want the Kelvhan lords to unsettle him any further.

For a moment she remembered that huge serpent on the monastery roof: its twisting coils, making the air steam and stink. It had filled her with repulsion, and a fear so deep it still rippled through her brain. Had it been the same for Huldarion? He had often been exposed to these dire creatures. Such terror must have its effect.

As she glanced back at the Kelvhans, she realised that her instinct was to protect Huldarion. Rothir had told him to beware of Kelvha, and she had not liked the implication. But where Nerogun was concerned she understood it.

Huldarion headed for a plain wagon that stood near to Gaelera's: the cart occupied by the Kelvhan priest from the Temple of Borgun. So was the priest now ringing the alarm?

Meya pushed past Riders who parted courteously to let her through. The sound certainly emanated from here: extremely loud, yet managing to retain a singular sweetness, a layered note as if of many notes all sung at once by clear inhuman voices.

Huldarion climbed stiffly up onto the boards and pulled aside the awning. Meya could see in: there was no-one visible. Nor could she observe a bell. Yet the ringing did not cease. When he turned round, he looked both furious and horrified, and her heart gave a thump. What was happening?

He glowered over at Gaelera – the only person who had been close – and spoke in loud, accusing tones, his voice harsh over the insistent ringing of the bell.

"What did you do?"

"I?" Gaelera said.

"Did you go into this cart?"

"I did not," she answered calmly.

"Then who has been interfering with it?"

"I have no idea."

But now the other Kelvhans had ridden up, with Nerogun at their head.

"Of what do you accuse my daughter?" he demanded, and for a bizarre moment Meya thought he was actually eager for his daughter to be accused of something. But that was a nonsensical idea.

Huldarion opened and closed his mouth before saying, "My Lord. I accuse her of nothing."

"Father," said Gaelera. "So you have managed to find me at last."

"I knew where you were all along," Nerogun snapped.

Gaelera put her head on one side with a faint half-smile, and laid her hands across her skirts.

"And I am very glad to see you too," she said.

"What? I can't hear you for that dreadful noise. What in stars' name is it?"

Huldarion did not answer. Turning away, he dived back into the singing space of the priest's cart, pulling the awning roughly closed behind him.

MeYa immediately scrambled up on to the shafts to follow him, thinking: *Let Nerogun mock me; I am still nimble enough for all my size.* It was not curiosity that impelled her, but rather a strong wish to be seen to support Huldarion; and also to get in the way of anybody else who might decide to climb up here.

When she peered through the awning she saw nobody but him. The dim brown light that filtered through the canvas roof fell on a pile of lidded crates and boxes, one of which he was wrenching open. He reached inside: she glimpsed a blanket as he tried to swathe the contents, crouching over the box like an anxious father bent over a crying cradle.

The sight made her afraid. What could be in there that was as important as a child to him, that gave him such concern? It was surely no ordinary bell that he was trying to conceal. Was this sorcery?

For despite his efforts the sound would not be muffled. Yet it was not unpleasant; rather, it seemed to summon. It commanded attention.

And it was gaining it. The cart swayed as someone else climbed up behind her. She put out her arm instinctively to bar the intruder – only to find, to her dismay, that it was Prince Faldron.

"Let me look," he ordered over the ringing, so that she had to move aside. "What is it, Huldarion? What have you there?"

Ducking under the awning the prince stepped over to the crate and drew away the cloth from Huldarion's reluctant hand. MeYa heard him gasp.

"My word," he said. "A pretty thing, Huldarion, and a pretty noise it makes."

"I need to silence it so that it will not disturb us." Huldarion tried to pull the blanket from him, but Faldron would not release it.

"This should be displayed," he said. "It is a thing of quality. Let us take it out."

"It must stay hidden," said Huldarion, his voice straining against the long sweet chime. "It is an heirloom and most precious."

"So I imagine. It is a thing to be admired. You would surely not deny the Lords of Kelvha a sight of such a splendid artefact? Let us lift it down." The prince called through the awning. "Rhadlun? Come up and help me with this source of all the ringing: and a wondrous source it is too."

MeYa had to give way. She stepped down carefully, accepting Thoronal's hand. As she watched Rhadlun climb up in her stead, she wondered at Huldarion's reluctance to display the bell: for anything that impressed the prince so greatly must be fine indeed. And a rich heirloom would certainly raise Huldarion's standing with the Kelvhan lords.

But it would inevitably be made extremely public now. Riders and Kelvhans alike stood craning their necks to see the cause of all the fuss.

"What is this bell?" she asked Thoronal in a murmur.

"No bell," he answered, in his self-important manner – no doubt waiting for her to ask him more. So she did not. Instead, she watched.

Rhadlun and Faldron carried down an object wrapped in the blanket, and carefully set it upright on the shafts. It was wide and evidently heavy. She was surprised that the High Prince would exert himself in such labour; but he whisked aside the covering blanket with a flourish and the object was revealed.

Meya caught her breath. It was indeed no bell, but a great bowl: a golden bowl, most beautifully wrought, with lines of writing delicately engraved around the outer surface.

And still it chimed. The murmur of the watching crowd mingled with the sound.

"Well," said Nerogun, evidently impressed.

"What a treasure!" exclaimed Shargun shrilly, his narrow eyes boggling.

"It is an heirloom of our house," said Huldarion. His scars were fiery red as if he were under some great stress. Meya could understand that he might not wish for Shargun to lay greedy eyes upon this bowl – but she did not understand why it had been kept a secret from *her*. Would she not soon be Huldarion's queen? Was she not entitled to know about this heirloom? She had entrusted the man with her daughter. Could not he entrust her with a sight of this?

The strain in Huldarion's face bid her stay silent. Indeed it was hard for anyone to speak. But now the ringing was starting to diminish, as if having gained its audience the summons was required no longer. The long chime grew more distant, and yet more lovely as it lost its force. After a few more seconds the sound was just a shimmer in the air.

"You carry it around with you?" said Nerogun.

Huldarion's mouth barely moved as he replied. "For now – until it can be reinstated at Caervonn."

"And what does the engraving say? I can't read that curly writing," complained Shargun, stooping to peer with a frown at the interior. Can you read at all? thought Meya with dislike.

"Inside the bowl," Huldarion answered with an effort at calmness, "are written the watchwords of the Vonn: *Honour, Care, Fidelity.*"

"No fourth? Not courage?" asked Nerogun.

"There is a fourth word," said Huldarion, "not written, but implicit in the rest."

"And what is that?" asked Faldron.

But Shargun interrupted. "What's that scribble on the outside? What does that say?"

"Your archivist has read it for us," announced Thoronal, "and he said–"

"–that the bowl was inscribed at the command of King Dorial of Caervonn," finished Huldarion.

"The archivist? You mean Tamu?" said Nerogun.

"He's been hanging around here," said Iago.

"He's here – with the Vonn? Why on earth?" Nerogun looked both suspicious and perturbed.

"That over-educated little runt," said Shargun.

Meya felt it was time for her to speak. "I gave Master Tamu leave from his position in the castle," she answered haughtily. "It was well overdue. Tamu has an interest in old lore and accompanied us in order to observe the ancient stones." She had no idea if this was true. She had granted Tamu his freedom after he had glimpsed and recognised Janeya in her maid's disguise; and while he had obviously been relieved to escape from Kelvha City, Meya had not expected him to follow the Vonn army all this way. Possibly he had nowhere else to go.

"Indeed, Tamu translated the runes on the great stone a few miles away, where the Red Roads meet the sea," commented Rhadlun. "The inscription spoke of victory going to the righteous, as I remember." Mentally Meya thanked him for this unwitting support of her explanation. And as a further, welcome distraction, the priest now came hurrying over to the cart, his long robes gathered in both hands.

"My Lord?" he panted. "I was helping with the tents, when I heard--"

Nerogun turned to him wrathfully. "You're the wretch from the temple of Borgun. What in the stars' name are you doing here?"

"The priest Hokiyo is here with us to guard the bowl," put in Thoronal, somewhat pompously. Huldarion gave him a look.

"Why? What has your heirloom got to do with this renegade priest?" demanded Nerogun.

"It was in..." The priest faltered, looking at Huldarion, who was at his most immobile.

"It was in what? Spit it out, man!" Shargun said.

"I act in Borgun's wish," Hokiyo murmured. "I am commanded by Borgun to guard the bowl. I trust it is not damaged? When I heard it ringing, I was afraid that someone might be stealing it."

"Borgun! I think we heard too much of Borgun in the city," said Nerogun contemptuously.

"This knave is not a fit custodian of your property, Huldarion. I am suspicious of his motives. He ought to be detained."

"The man is harmless," said Huldarion.

"I've done nothing wrong," the priest said anxiously.

"Then you won't object to being taken for a little questioning, will you?" snapped back Nerogun. "What do you know of this bowl, and this inscription?"

"I cannot read the script."

A cold finger went down Meya's spine. Although she did not know exactly what Nerogun meant by questioning, she imagined that it would not be merely verbal. And while she did not care much for the temple of Borgun – which merely encouraged the poor to think above their station – she felt pity for the priest. She pitied anyone subject to unfriendly questioning by the Post-Regent. The unlucky serving-man Lorolo, Janeya's lover, jumped into her mind; those soft brown eyes, the gentle smile... What had become of him?

"Please leave Hokiyo here with us," Huldarion said. "He travels under my protection."

"Why does he need the Vonn's protection? He's a Kelvhan citizen, ain't he?" snapped Shargun.

"I do not wish to go with them," Hokiyo said plaintively.

"If you are an honest man," said Nerogun, "which I have to say I doubt, you have nothing to fear. Take him, Iajo."

The armourer snapped his fingers: two soldiers stepped up to seize Hokiyo and lead him away. Huldarion said nothing. Faldron looked from man to man, but did not speak.

"And while you're at it, Iajo, find Tamu," Nerogun added. "His place is with the Kelvhan army."

"I must protest. Tamu is on leave," said Meya, in horror. What if Tamu were questioned? What if he spilled out his knowledge of Janeya's presence?

"I don't know what he wants with leave," said Nerogun contemptuously. "Do you think I get leave, to swan around at leisure? I do not. Iajo! Find Tamu."

The armourer grinned and strode away, without so much as the pretence of a bow. Faldron looked after him thoughtfully.

"And what about that wayward daughter of yours?" said Shargun to the Post-Regent with a sneer in his voice. "Shall we have her taken back to Kelvha, hey?"

"Master Shargun," said Gaelera in her clear, unexpressive voice, from her perch up on the carriage, "I advise you not to rise above your station. My duty is to my father the Post-Regent, not to you." She turned to Nerogun. "Father. I have no doubt that you are pleased to see me."

Nerogun seemed momentarily taken aback. Then he put out his arms.

"Of course, my dear daughter! I am relieved to see you safe – and uninjured, I trust?"

Gaelera did not climb down to meet his embrace. Instead she gave a curtsey, and Nerogun let his outspread arms drop to his sides.

"I am entirely uninjured," she replied, "due to the efforts of the Lord Huldarion's Riders, and one of our own soldiers, who put his life at risk to rescue me."

"Which of our soldiers? He shall be rewarded."

"Indeed he shall," Gaelera said, her voice perhaps a little higher than usual. "His name is Captain Novesnu."

"Hmph! Not a Kelvhan, then."

"None of the Kelvhan men jumped into the sea to rescue me. I should also like a memorial raised to the Rider Durba, who sacrificed herself to save me from the linwyrn."

"Yes, yes," said Nerogun, with a puff and snort like an impatient horse, "but none of this would have happened had you not driven off to join the Vonn. A fair fix you managed to get yourself into, daughter!"

Gaelera put her head on one side. "Father. It must be hereditary. I shall remain amongst the Vonn for now. I am pleased you are so glad to see me safe. Because if anything were to happen to me..."

Nerogun stared at her. "I would not have anything happen to you for the world," he said, his voice a little husky. Meya found herself moved. Perhaps it was possible that Nerogun cared, after all, for some human being besides himself. But a second later he spun round and addressed Huldarion.

"What now?" he demanded with impatient gruffness. "No attack seems imminent, Huldarion. Those stoneman boats are few, and stay off-shore. They're just there to keep an eye on us."

"We don't know that," Huldarion answered. "The stoneman army will be gathering."

"Miles away. Not here. Or are you expecting more giant worms to swim out of the sea? Or giant beetles to crawl out of the ground, maybe? Or perhaps a giant bird, shitting down on you as it flies overhead? Well, while we wait for those wonders to arrive, I'm going back to camp."

Meya gasped, outraged at this extraordinary rudeness. But Nerogun strode off, with a leering Shargun scuttling after him. Faldron gazed after them for a moment, his brow furrowed, before he followed: and the Kelvhan troop went with him, heading back towards their army. Like their masters, they gave Huldarion no salute.

Huldarion stood as still as one of the great stones, her heirloom on the shaft beside him, a thing of dazzling beauty, now silent and ignored. His Riders too stood silent, with questioning looks: confused, upset, and sombre.

And how very, very few those Riders were, reflected Meya. A small band of hapless Vonn, lost amidst the vast bewildering maze of the Red Roads, where the Kelvhan army swarmed in such great numbers: hardly more than a huddled boatload of landless fugitives, left to drift or wreck themselves upon this swirling shore.

Chapter 43

Brulde felt marooned; shipwrecked.

Her farm was gone, again. Last year, when the darkburns had destroyed Deloran's farmhouse and its outbuildings, the land had largely been unscathed. This time it was different. Her fields, her woods, her orchards – all were burnt. Although the fields would be restored in spring she would not live to see her woods recover.

I am too old for this, Brulde thought. So much for a tranquil retirement, a rest from riding out to battle. All that effort turned to ashes. I should grieve.

But she did not grieve. She could not afford to, yet. There was no time to even let it sink in now: for Aliya was lost, and nobody knew where to find her.

She stood with Olbeth and Flodda on the edge of the dam, listening to Veron's terse speech. The women were all dripping wet – as was Doval, who wriggled, whimpering, in Olbeth's arms. The murky pond had been their refuge while the fires roared past them in an orange whirlwind. They had cowered up to their chests in water with their feet in mud, and watched the flames grasp out across the surface, beckoning them with flickering fingers. Once or twice she heard the rasping wingbeats of the flying darkburn, busy setting all her lands on fire.

Stonemen too were audible, shouting with triumph in the dark. But they had not found the pond until the dazzlement of flames receded and the day began to mould the darkness into shapes. Brulde was still trying to work out what she had witnessed then.

Eyes fogged with smoke and tiredness, her body shivering despite the burning air, she'd heard the voices first. The morning breeze had blown the smoke aside – and at the water's edge she saw a group of stonemen.

More shouts. They pointed at the huddled, weary group that cowered in the pool. One of them started to wade boldly in.

And then, with that dreadful noise of slowly ripping canvas, the flying darkburn had appeared. It flapped above the smouldering trees, a dreadful, clumsy, ugly monster. It flew towards them, soaring – no, not soaring, rather struggling – low over the water as it hurtled down at the half-submerged women.

As the thing swooped across the dam, Brulde ducked instinctively beneath the water. It was fear for the baby that made her rise back to the surface only seconds later.

Doval was unharmed, crying and squirming in his mother's arms. That had been a mere reconnoitre by the darkburn, thought Brulde grimly; the true attack would come at any moment now.

The darkburn swerved and veered around, its movements heavy, bits falling from its wings as it flapped with laborious effort: and then it swooped again.

But this time it did not fly across the water. It plunged straight down upon the men who stood along the shore.

Some tried to run. Despite its clumsiness the darkburn dived with shocking speed; and a stoneman was encased in flames. Again it dived, a gargoyle made of charcoal, smouldering amidst the fires that it had set. Brulde heard the screams.

Soon no stonemen stood there any longer. Instead, new bonfires raged along the shore: bonfires that writhed and twisted before becoming still.

She had to turn away. For all her hatred of the stonemen, she did not wish to see them die in agony. When she looked back the darkburn was no longer visible.

"It flew over us and went west," Olbeth said next to her, breathless, almost voiceless, standing with the baby on her shoulder. Doval dabbled his toes and squawked, exasperated

with being held. Olbeth's wet face shone like gold, reflecting flames. "It flew right over us and it didn't..."

"I thought," said Flodda on her other side, "I thought..."

Bruilde finished for her. "You thought that we were going to die."

"Why didn't we?"

"I suppose the darkburn got it wrong," she said. "An airborne one like that must be hard for stonemen to control."

"But their stones," said Olbeth. "Their stones should have stopped it."

"Maybe they don't work on that type."

"Do you know what it was?"

Bruilde shook her head. She was shivering harder now, and desperate to get out. None the less they stayed there in the water while the man-shaped fires burned around them, a perimeter of crackling death. It did not take long for them to slump into red embers.

Where were the hunters? thought Bruilde. Had they escaped? At times she seemed to hear strange cries beyond the hiss and crackle of the continuing fires; and though no further flames leapt up, she feared the worst.

Doval was passed from arm to arm. Bruilde took her turn; but he was heavy, and she was very tired. The roar of fire dulled to a rustle, a shuffle of red feathers. A single bird called with a questioning note; no answering chorus followed.

Dawn came shrouded in a stinking coat of smoke. Somewhere the sun must have risen; yet she could not see beyond the smouldering wrecks of her small willow trees, kept coppiced for wicker. All those withies dissolving into ash. As she watched, one fell, crumbling. Doval went to sleep upon her shoulder and Flodda took him back.

But no more stonemen came. And then a familiar figure stepped out of the smoke and stood to gaze across the water. It was Veron.

"Is it safe?" she called.

"We think they are all dead," he called back, hoarse with smoke.

So the three women waded from the water, numb and heavy-limbed and shivering although the air was hot and full of shreds of ash. Bruilde could hardly walk. Olbeth lifted Doval from Flodda's arms and hugged him; he did not appreciate being woken.

"Aliya?" said Veron sharply. "Where is Aliya? Is she not with you?"

"No. She was with Camburé," said Olbeth.

"And where is Camburé? I told her to find you, Bruilde." He sounded angry.

"I haven't seen Camburé all night," said Bruilde, "nor Aliya," and her heart seemed to fold up like a collapsing tent. The storm of fire had swept not just her home, her life, away, but Aliya, a child of only five.

Aliya. Who was perhaps the cause of all this fire and destruction; though who knew? The stonemen might have chosen to attack her farm in any case. And it made no difference, because the outcome was the same: the child was very likely lying dead somewhere, burnt beyond all recognition, like those cindered stonemen on the shore.

"We have to find her," said Veron.

Bruilde, weakly dripping by the dam, bid herself delay her grief, and asked him, "How?"

"Come with me, Bruilde. You know this place: I don't." He turned and she dripped after him. The other women followed silently. There were clouds of choking brown smoke everywhere: through them she glimpsed myriad miniature fires.

"How are your hunters, Veron?" she asked.

"Irtuk is dead, killed by an axe. Three wounded," he threw back over his shoulder as he strode through the smouldering remnants of the withies.

"I'm sorry."

"Yes. But it could have been worse. Should have been worse. That flying darkburn set alight everything it touched. But it didn't touch us. Very odd."

"It touched the stonemen by the dam," she said, and then described what she had witnessed from the ash-spattered water.

"Very odd," was all Veron's answer. By now they were approaching the ruins of her farmhouse – its stone shell, for her wooden inner shelter had burnt up, although she did not really care about that. It had only been temporary. It was the land that made her farm. And that was devastated.

The farmhouse stones were hot; too hot to linger by. Some of the huntsmen and her own men were scouring the surroundings, checking the shattered outbuildings, turning over charred rafters.

"Where would she have gone?" Veron demanded.

"Camburé? She knows this place no better than you do. She could have gone anywhere."

"Aliya," he said.

Aliya. She seemed to feel a small hand in her own, an insistent tug; a determined round face looking up. Where would the child have gone?

"The lookout tree," she said, and pointed at the path that led there. "Aliya was keen to go and see it. She seemed to like it. Maybe she went there." It was not much of a hope; but it was the only place that she could think of.

"Those woods around it are still burning," said Veron.

"All the same." What would she herself have done, when she was five years old and frightened? It was surprisingly easy to project herself back to childhood, as if old age were bringing her full circle. She wouldn't have jumped in a dam, that was for sure; not into muddy water of uncertain depth. No – she would have run, run, run, as far and fast as she was able, until she found somewhere to hide.

So Bruilde, although she could not run, tried to hurry as she led the way towards the lookout tree, despite the awareness before they were even halfway there that it was hopeless. For all along the path stood ghost trees, charred and grey, their foliage stripped and turned to ash. It felt as soft as snow beneath her feet. Warm snow. Some of the lowest brambles had survived; that seemed both amazing and appropriate. But higher up everything was burnt – as if the flying darkburn had dipped down many times to set the trees aflame.

She stopped abruptly in the middle of the path. There was a body lying just ahead. With its blackened flesh and clothes it was unrecognisable; but it held a sword.

A Vonnish sword. Straight, long-hilted, double-bladed, without the slight curve which the stonemen's weapons had.

"This is Camburé," she murmured.

"Are you sure?"

Bruilde bent down and made herself look. "That's the clasp she wore on her collar."

Veron nodded. Then he scanned the area carefully, frowning through the smoke. "There's no child here," he said. "Let's look further on."

Bruilde thought it very likely that the child was indeed somewhere here, also unrecognisable. How could Veron know if any of these black lumps spilling ash had not been Aliya rather than just trees? If only Leor was here with them: he could do some spell, perhaps, to show Aliya's presence – or absence.

She did not know why Leor sprang to mind. He had never been reliable. But oh, for a comforting touch of those long fingers. She wished that he were here instead of this taciturn hunter.

The hunter was striding off along the path at a great rate. So Bruilde followed, trying not to lapse into despair. But after a while they came upon more charcoaled bodies, six or seven of

them; and her heart did a slow roll over and over before she registered that these ones were of course too big, and bore curved swords.

"Stonemen," she said. Veron gave them no more than a glance.

"Look up," he said.

She looked up. The smoke was thinner: now she could see the lookout tree not far away. She walked over to it. To her surprise, it wasn't burnt.

And the woods beyond it were not burnt. The closest trees were badly singed, but behind those, though greyed by smoke, the woods looked green and brown as always and the undergrowth beneath them as thick and impenetrable as ever.

"The fire started here," said Veron, gazing around the clearing. "It got blown towards your farm." She felt the steady wind and nodded. Then she peered up into the lookout tree, as if by some new-grown agility Aliya could have swarmed up the knotted rope and out of sight.

Veron had walked around the tree. She heard him say, with a strange note of his voice, "She's been here."

"What?" Bruilde hurried round to join him. "Where? How can you tell?" For she could see no more than a shapeless crush of weeds and prickly shrubs.

"I can tell," he said. He stooped to carefully inspect the briared entanglement of undergrowth.

"There's no way through there," Bruilde objected. "If she really was here she must have gone back down the path we came by." She was about to leave, but Veron, squatting down, said roughly,

"No. She went this way."

"Through there?" Bruilde peered at the gap in the brambles. "That's an animal's burrow. She wouldn't fit through that."

"Is this an animal's hair?" He held up something all but invisible.

Bruilde rubbed her smoke-sore eyes and shook her head. "I don't know. Is that Aliya's? Could she really get through there?"

He did not answer, but was already wading into the undergrowth, pushing through spiky bramble stems that clutched his legs. He stopped, and broke and parted stems, and set out again.

I am too old, Bruilde's mind repeated to her miserably, too old for all this. As she tramped after him along the rough track that he laid down, her breeches were constantly snagging; before long they were ripped irreparably, and her legs were bleeding. Veron did not seem to notice the tearing of the thorns. Perhaps after his recent experience, such pain was of small account.

But a five-year old! In all this density of prickles! They were like steel pins: worse, because finer. Bruilde stopped and demanded, "How could she have crawled all this way?"

Still Veron did not reply, but kept on wading through the bushes. He made surprisingly little noise – she herself was noisier by far – and after a while he stooped again and lifted something in his fingers. A shred of cloth caught on a thorn.

"Is that hers?" she asked.

He nodded and walked on. There was no other sound now but the crunch and rustle of their movements, as if they were the only people in this world. No bird sang, no creature moved; the woodland seemed to Bruilde to have been paralysed by fear, its life all hidden. An endless forest of wordless terror and concealment. Where was Aliya?

Veron stopped. "She's here," he said quietly.

"Where?" She did not believe him. But he drew aside a frond of bracken, and she saw the figure curled up underneath, so small; so small and still.

"Aliya," she said, her voice barely audible. "Aliya!"

And, dear stars be thanked, the figure stirred. It stretched an arm and then a leg and then the head turned and the eyes opened.

"I was being a pig," Aliya said. She rolled over to sit up stiffly in between the briars and held out her arms to Bruilde. Her clothes were ripped and filthy, and her face, beneath the dirt, was burnt and red.

Veron stepped aside and Bruilde picked up the child – which did her back no good, but she did not care – and held her close. Warm, bony, frail: scratched and bloodied, but alive. Myself, aged five, she thought. After a moment her back complained intensely, so she handed the child over to Veron.

"I'm thirsty," said Aliya. Veron held her in one arm and studied her. With his other hand he offered her a waterskin. She drank a little. "I want Flodda," she said drowsily.

"You've got us," said Bruilde, "and we'll take you back to Flodda now."

"I want mama." But then she seemed to fall asleep on Veron's shoulder. He carried her back through the smoky woods, much as he might have carried a side of venison, Bruilde thought as she trailed wearily after him.

It was a long way to the farmhouse, past Camburé's body. Bruilde paused there, thinking that she ought to do something with the corpse; but what? So she continued walking after Veron and his slumped burden.

The farmhouse was too hot to be habitable. The others were in the stable yard, Olbeth and the hunters tending to the injured men while Flodda dandled Doval. Aliya seemed to wake up again and Veron set her down carefully upon the cobbles.

Flodda almost dropped Doval in her hurry to run over and embrace the girl.

"Oh, my dear, my dear," she said, hugging her tightly. "Oh, my precious little one."

"Don't," said Aliya. "I'm all prickled and it hurts." She pulled away and held out a hand towards Doval, now bouncing in his mother's clasp. "Hallo, baby. I told it not to hurt the baby," she said.

"You told what?" said Veron, kneeling down beside her.

"I told the flappy thing. I said, there's a baby. Don't hurt the baby. Maybe it has a baby too, that's why." Aliya rubbed her eyes and then began to fall over. Veron caught her before she collapsed to the ground: a pile of floppy limbs and shredded clothes.

"We need somewhere better than this to lay her down," said Flodda. "What about the cart?"

"The carts are burnt," Bruilde replied wearily. Tiredness was rushing at her now that she knew the child was safe. She wanted to collapse like Aliya into a pile of limbs and have someone carry her away, insensate. But she was responsible for this place. She racked her brains. "The chicken house," she said. "It's roofed with slate. Over this way."

The chicken house, set back from the other outbuildings, was small and low, too low for the adults to stand up in. No chickens lived here now. But the earthen floor was free of ash; there was even half a bale of unburnt straw.

So she made a straw bed for Aliya and commandeered a dry cloak from one of her men. Flodda wrapped Aliya in it and sat down with Aliya's head in her lap.

"I'll get some food for you," Veron said.

"Where from? Everything is burnt."

"Not the horses. They had sense enough to run. Some of my men are finding them, and their packs. We'll need them, because we can't stay here. We'll have to think what next to do." He went out. Doval rolled over to Aliya and poked her with his fingers until Olbeth picked him up and carried him outside again.

Lowering herself down carefully, Bruilde sat on the floor beside Flodda to wait for the promised food. The child was restless. At times she seemed to sleep. Then she would murmur in incomprehensible bursts, speaking to somebody who was not there.

"What was that?" said Bruilde. Aliya didn't answer. She turned again in Flodda's lap, and wouldn't take another drink of water. When Flodda tried to wipe the soot and blood from her face she was pushed away.

Flodda's mouth was trembling.

"It's all right," Bruilde told her. "She'll be all right."

"Yes, ma'am." But she was weeping and trying not to.

"It's the strain," Bruilde said.

"Yes, ma'am."

Meanwhile Aliya slept, her eyelids fluttering. Then she woke and said, "I like that story."

"What story?" Flodda asked her softly. She felt Aliya's forehead. "Oh she's hot, too hot." She offered Aliya water. Again, Aliya refused to drink.

Veron came back in with a knapsack, from which he pulled a slab of bread and some dried meat, both greyish.

"She can't eat that," remarked Bruilde. "Is that what you hunters eat? It looks disgusting."

"Give me the bread," commanded Flodda, "and the water cup." She made a mush of bread and water and fed a little to Aliya with her fingers. Bruilde looked on and wondered what the child's mother would make of all this. Her child attacked by a flying monster, chased by murderous stonemen, nurtured in a chicken shed on bread and water... It was as well that she did not know.

"My head hurts," said Aliya.

"Eat a little more, my love," said Flodda.

"Where's the other lady?"

"I'm here," said Bruilde, "and Olbeth is just outside," but Aliya shook her head.

"No, no," she said, "not you. The other lady. When I was lying down next to the flowers. She told me a story."

"That's nice," said Flodda.

"She's delirious," said Bruilde.

"She's a lady who lives on the moon," Aliya said. Bruilde saw Veron, squatting at the hut's entrance, swivel his head round sharply.

"Is she now," said Flodda.

"She likes the moon because she can see everywhere," Aliya murmured. "And it's very quiet."

"It certainly would be, up there," said Bruilde.

"But sometimes it gets too quiet so she comes down here to talk to people. Or else she gets lonely."

"Poor lady on the moon," said Flodda. "Never mind her now."

But Veron demanded, "How does she get down here?"

Aliya rubbed her face. "I don't know. I think she jumps."

"She must be very good at jumping," said Bruilde.

"Yes, she is," Aliya said. "She jumps like a."

"Like a what?" said Veron.

"I don't know," said Aliya. Her head turned restlessly. Her fingers twined themselves in the cloak she was wrapped in.

Veron persisted. "Do you know her name?"

"Leave the child alone," Bruilde said. "She's delirious. She needs to rest."

But Aliya stared into space and said, "Her name's a secret."

"It is," said Veron. "What story did she tell you?"

"I can't remember. It was about a tree. There's an important tree."

"She means the lookout tree," Bruilde offered, but Veron shushed her with an imperious movement of his hand.

"What about the tree?" he said.

"Someone wants to catch the lady," said Aliya.

Veron went still.

"That's not a very nice thing to do," said Flodda.

"She should be safe enough, up there on the moon," Bruilde said.

"But she has to come down to talk to people! And she has a cub."

"A cub? You mean a son," said Flodda.

"I don't know," Aliya wailed fretfully. She pushed Flodda's caressing hand away.

"Who wants to catch the lady?" asked Veron. His voice was stern and Bruilde looked at him in some surprise.

"Leave her alone," she said.

"I don't know," Aliya murmured. "He's made of gold or something. He's all shiny like the sun and he wants to catch the lady off the moon."

"How?" Veron demanded.

"He's hunting her. He wants to make a trap."

"What sort of trap?"

"I don't know." Aliya's face began to crinkle as if she might be going to cry.

"She's been dreaming," said Bruilde, her sternness now matching Veron's. "Go away and let her rest."

Veron turned round abruptly and went out. Flodda soothed Aliya, singing softly to her. She persuaded her to eat a little more mush, and then sat stroking the child's head until she went to sleep.

Bruilde levered herself up from the hard floor. The moon itself could not be harder and colder, she thought, for a lady's aching limbs to rest on. No wonder the lady of the moon needed to come down to earth.

She walked outside and saw Veron standing a small distance away. He did not appear to see her, or more likely did not care.

He was intently gazing at the sky. Through the smoky daylight she perceived a pale moon, so frail, so delicate it looked as if it could dissolve and be blown far off on a breeze, like a wisp of silver ash.

"You should have told me," said the hunter. "Why did you tell the child and not me? You should have told me."

He was evidently talking to himself. But he paused and seemed to listen for an answer although there was no sound that Bruilde could detect.

Then he said, "I am not the first and I will not be the last. But for now I am the one. And all my fealty is yours: my strength, my skill, my heart, my life. You should have told me."

Chapter 44

Tamu was lurking when he heard the tuneful ringing of the bowl. It charged him with even more anxiety than he already felt.

He was lurking because he did not know where he was safest. Since the arrival of Rhadlun and Iajo, he had kept his distance from the Kelvhans, moving discreetly between the priest, certain friendly females of the Vonn, and Leor. He would have liked to lurk with Parthenal but that, of course, was out of the question. He didn't want the Kelvhans to see him anywhere near Parthenal.

But he was comfortable with Leor. He felt an empathy with the wizard, as another man who really did not know what he was doing here.

His companion, though, had barely spoken on the journey back to the Red Roads. Once he said aloud, "I froze the sea!" and Tamu could not tell if pride or awe or fear infused his voice. Perhaps all of them. Leor seemed so wrapped up in the mystery of his own magic that he was aware of little else.

And Tamu was wrapped up in memory. The dreadful serpent tried to keep a writhing habitation in his head: but he had found a way to shut it out. Again and again he relived that magic hour with Parthenal in a dazzling inward vision, as if of some winged messenger whose glory scattered shadows. It glowed within his consciousness so brightly that he feared it must be visible to everyone, and was almost surprised that they didn't notice any change in him. When he gazed back at the forbidding black hulk of the monastery he found it had become to him the most precious place in all the world.

Or one room within it had. That room with the deep window full of dusk. The low straw bed. The way that Parthenal had bent and kissed him... He shuddered with anguish and delight, remembering.

And now he was shuddering with apprehension at the ringing of the bowl. Clear and lovely as the sound was, it held for him a threat. He knew that strife and anger lay within, waiting to pour out.

There was already enough strife and anger at the news about the stonemen's youth. Tamu was not sure what to make of that, having seen stonemen for the first time only very recently, at a distance, before they were all killed by Solon's company. But whatever the truth about the stonemen, it was plain that no more strife was needed now: and if the inscription on the bowl were to be understood by Kelvha, it would cause uproar. Kelvha – a mere vassal state of Caervonn! Kelvha's first king not a king at all – no more than a tribal chieftain subject to the ruler of the Vonn!

It would not matter that the ancient bowl had no legal standing. It was the fact of its existence – its being treasured by Huldarion – that would make it so offensive to the Kelvhan lords.

And Tamu had translated the inscription. So at the onset of the bowl's ringing, his first instinct was not just to lurk, but to hide.

Leor came striding fast towards him, almost at a run.

"What's happening?" asked Tamu.

"Huldarion's furious. I'm getting out of the way."

Tamu shrank from the idea of such fury – not just Huldarion's, but the Kelvhans'.

"Leor," he said desperately, turning to the wizard, "I would rather not be seen for a while. Can you help?"

"What?"

"Can you make me invisible?"

"Why?"

"Just because," said Tamu helplessly. The ringing continued, like a brilliant lamp of sound, a summons that caused the feet to twitch and want to run towards it – as indeed many Riders were now doing. Nearby, a group of men from Melmet began to argue whether they should follow the ringing. But Tamu wanted only to escape.

Leor shook his head. "I can make myself invisible," he said, "or hard to see, at least, which is not really the same thing. And I've done the same to animals. But I cannot do it to another person."

"Can your brother?"

"Probably," said Leor gloomily. "Why do you want to disappear?"

"Like you, I'd just prefer to stay out of the way." Now he could see Nerogun riding up to the priest's cart, along with Iajo the savage armourer; and his heart thumped. What were they saying? He could not tell. But at last the ringing faded into silence. That was a relief.

The tallest of the men of Melmet standing nearby said, "They're all looking at something that they took out of that cart. Wonder what it is?"

"Stars help me!" muttered Tamu.

The man turned and looked at him: a loud and thuggish man, whom Yaret had once introduced to him as Inthed, and whom ever since Tamu had been careful to avoid.

"You're that friend of Yaret's, aren't you?" he demanded.

"Yes," he said. "Where is she?" But he knew that Yaret couldn't help him either.

Nobody could. For now he heard a shout. "Tamu! Tamu!" And he saw a figure by the cart mount a horse and start to ride towards him.

He knew that purposeful, strong figure. It was Iajo, of all men after Nerogun the one he feared the most. Should he run? No, that was useless. If Leor could not hide him, he could not hide himself. And running implied guilt.

So as Iajo approached he waited, trying not to tremble. He was guilty of nothing, after all.

The armourer pulled his horse up sharply. The animal jerked its head and snorted. "So here you are, Tamu. You're wanted by the Lord Nerogun."

"What for?" said Tamu. He found himself amazed that he could speak at all.

"For questioning," Iajo answered with a leer. "About some fancy bowl. Your master the Post-Regent thinks your place is with the Kelvhan troops where he can keep an eye on you."

"I am not at present in his employment," Tamu said.

"You're always in his employment," said Iajo. "Are you coming, or do we have to drag you?"

To Tamu's great surprise, another voice spoke up: not Leor, but the thuggish Inthed.

"You can't take him," he said. "He's mine."

"What?" Iajo looked confounded for a moment.

"He's mine. He's my slave," said Inthed belligerently. "I won him in a bet."

"True enough," said his companion, a grizzle-headed barrel of a man. "Inthed here won him fair and square at dice. Tamu is ours."

"And we're not Vonn," said Inthed. "So you can't tell us what to do."

Iajo looked enraged. He wheeled his horse round so vigorously that it tried to buck until he hit it round the shoulders. Then he laughed. "Oh, so you won him? He's your type, then, is he? A little crooked bum-boy?"

"What?"

"Don't you know what he is?"

Tamu wanted to melt into the ground. Inthed looked taken aback. But then he said determinedly, "I beat him at dice, and he's in our service now. To groom our horses."

"Oh, of course. Well, grooms are famous for it." There was a sneer in Iajo's voice.

The second, grizzled man looked levelly at Iajo. "Live and let live, is what I say."

"It's what I say too," announced Inthed pugnaciously. "He's mine, won fair and square, and you can't have him."

In answer, Iajo wheeled his horse around again, grabbed Tamu by the collar, almost choking him, and forced him to stumble to the horse's side. He could feel the horse trembling almost as much as he was himself. He felt for it but also feared that it would kick him.

"Try and stop me," Iajo snarled at the pair. They looked wary.

"We'll want him safely back here in one piece," said the grizzled man.

"We'll see," Iajo said, and he wrenched Tamu away. The men of Melmet shifted but did not try to hinder him.

Nor did Leor. That hurt Tamu more than the grip of Iajo's fist. The two northerners had made an attempt on his behalf, quite unexpectedly, and he was surprised and grateful. He would not forget it. But Leor! The wizard had more authority, yet he had said nothing, done nothing. Tamu felt that he would never be able to forget that either.

And now he was being dragged along past scattered members of the Vonn, and some of them did remonstrate with Iajo about his roughness though not about the armourer's right to kidnap him. He was being restored to his proper place with Kelvha, and they could not interfere.

But then Parthenal came striding over and stood full in the horse's way as Iajo pulled Tamu along. He was not a man who could be sneered at like the Melmet soldiers: his standing as one of Huldarion's captains, his reputation as a warrior, his very stature and demeanour forbade it. Tamu felt a tremendous flood of love and pride flow through him. At the same time he wished furiously that Parthenal would go away, just walk away, say nothing! For he was terrified.

"You will treat him kindly," said Parthenal, his voice stern. He put his left hand upon the head of Iajo's horse. It stilled.

Iajo laughed. "Do you mean that beast? It's mine and it knows to obey me. Or do you mean your little pet? We'll treat him just as he deserves."

"Which is kindly," answered Parthenal. His right hand rested on his belt, next to his sword hilt. Tamu did not look at him. He willed him desperately to shrug and leave, because he did not want the armourer to link the two of them in any way.

"Oh, we know how you'd like to treat him," said Iajo. "You soft-headed Vonn. No better than wanton girls, some of you. Now get out of my path."

Tamu understood these veiled allusions although possibly Parthenal did not. *Jaul knows*, he thought. Jaul knows what happened. So Iajo knows. So Nerogun knows. Perhaps they all know about me and Parthenal.

And with the thought, his legs lost all their strength. He would have fallen but for Iajo's grip.

Still Parthenal stood there, despite Tamu's fierce willing. His right hand released his belt to rest lightly upon Tamu's shoulder.

"Have courage, Tamu," he said. "Kelvha will not hurt you."

Go, go away, pay no attention to me, thought Tamu at him. Parthenal's touch burned through his skin. He could not look up at that beautiful beloved face. And after a moment Parthenal did turn away at last and Iajo rode on, dragging Tamu with him.

Over the Red Roads the armourer led him, splashing through the shallow waters which caught at Tamu's legs as if entreating him to stop and play. By the time they reached the Kelvhan camp his lower half was soaked and he was shivering from cold as well as fear.

"Where's Nerogun?" said Iajo to a group of Kelvhan soldiers.

They bowed; one answered cautiously, "Still with the Vonn, sir. Is that the master archivist you've got there?"

"Wanted for questioning," said Iajo. The other man looked at Tamu and then again at Iajo. He turned away, saying nothing.

As everyone in Kelvha does, thought Tamu in bitterness and anguish. Turn away and say nothing. He was dragged through a *melée* of horsemen – all looking at him, then looking away and saying nothing – until they arrived at the long ranks of Kelvhan carriages, so much grander and more colourful than the plain carts of the Vonn.

Now Tamu saw that he was not alone in his captivity. Fifty yards away the priest stood, trapped against a carriage, and surrounded by a gaggle of Prince Faldron's underlings. When Iajo pulled Tamu over the underlings dispersed like rats at the sight of a snake. Tamu saw that the priest's wrist was shackled by a chain tied to the carriage shafts. It filled him with a fresh surge of panic.

"We are citizens of Kelvha," he said loudly and breathlessly as he was shoved towards the priest, and bundled round to face the cart. "According to the dictates of the fifth king of the city Khal-Torgun may his majestic name be lauded we may not be mishandled without a legitimising mandate from the highest authority of justice, for such is the right of the obedient and law-abiding citizen of the second tier."

"Where do you get all that from?" demanded Iajo.

"That is the law," said Tamu. In fact although such a citizen's right had been made law at the time of the fifth king – a favourite period of his within the chronicles – he was not sure if it had since been repealed, or was simply generally ignored.

"Well, you're in luck then, aren't you," sneered Iajo, "seeing as the highest authority of justice around here is his Lordship Nerogun. You'll get full justice at his hands, don't you worry."

"Actually," said Tamu, horrifying himself by his boldness, "you're wrong. The highest authority here is not Nerogun. It's the Lord High Prince."

Then he winced as he faced the cart, expecting his retort to bring a blow, or at the very least a sneering dismissal.

Instead, there was a silence. Tamu half turned his head and saw Prince Faldron, sitting upright on his horse, looking down at them with an enquiring gaze. The other Kelvhan guards shrank back surreptitiously. After a moment Iajo made a sketchy bow.

"Hmm," said Prince Faldron. "The fifth king, did you say, Master Archivist?"

"Yes... Yes, your Highness, the most august King Khal-Torgun the Wise, may he be honoured."

"And the name of his son?"

"He had two, your Highness," said Tamu. "King Khal-Meridigun the Impetuous, and his younger son Prince Sangiron the Adventurer."

"Sangiron, yes," said Faldron reflectively. "I recall. Are you familiar with the Chronicles of Sangiron?"

"I – I am, your Highness."

"Well enough to recite them?"

"I believe so," said Tamu, wondering where this was leading.

"Good," said Faldron. "I would like some entertainment on these weary nights. We should have brought a minstrel or two. But you will do instead, my Master Archivist. You may stay within my valet's cart, and be at call for when I require diversion."

"Lord Nerogun wants him for questioning," growled Iajo.

"Yes, I am aware of that, armourer. Some trivial matter of an inscription. Let us get it done with now. You read the writing on the Vonnish bowl, did you not, Master Archivist?"

"Yes," admitted Tamu, inwardly trembling.

"And what did it say?"

"It said, that, ah, that the bowl was made at the request of King Dorial King of Caervonn, mighty and victorious, to celebrate the vanquishing in battle of some tribe whose name was unfamiliar to me."

"Is that all?" asked Faldron.

"It gave some additional titles to King Dorial: um, the Magnificent, the Unsurpassed Warrior, The Bold Commander, Protector of his People..."

Tamu ran out of ideas. But Faldron nodded casually. It was the sort of inscription he was familiar with.

"That all seems straightforward enough," he said. "Iajo? You may pass that information on to the Post-Regent Nerogun."

"But Nerogun wants the man."

"As I understood, he wanted merely the translation, not the man himself," replied the prince. Tamu knew that it was probably the exact opposite of the truth. Nerogun cared little for the words upon the bowl – since he did not know what they actually were; but he cared much more to exercise his power upon a truant archivist of Kelvha. He licked his dry lips and waited for Iajo's reaction.

Iajo seemed stymied for a moment. Then he demanded, "What about this priest? He's here for questioning about the bowl as well."

"The priest knows nothing of the bowl," said Tamu to the prince, before Hokiro could speak. "He cannot read the script. He joined the Vonn in gratitude to the Lord Huldarion, who defended his temple against a mob after the fires. When he heard that the Lord Huldarion carried a fine heirloom in his train, he offered to protect it. That is all there is to the matter, is it not so?" He looked at the priest.

Thankfully Hokiro nodded, if a little uncertainly. "I am guided in all things by Borgun," he said, and cast his eyes up to the clouds.

"Then Borgun can guide you off to Nerogun," said Iajo. "Unless you want this one as well, Highness?"

"Armourer. You forget your place." Faldron's voice was cool and distant.

"My...?" The armourer turned and stared at the prince. Then, reluctantly, he bowed. "Your Highness." There was an edge there, not quite of insolence, but not far off it.

"Take the priest. You are dismissed."

Iajo unlocked Hokiro's fetters and began to pull him away, Hokiro offering a hasty bow to Faldron before Iajo dragged him off. Tamu stood there submissively, feeling immensely relieved on his own behalf if not Hokiro's, and wondering how much gratitude it would be wise to show. Certainly some.

"Your royal Highness, I am honoured by your attention," he said, and would have added more had not Faldron waved him away.

"Yes, yes. You may stow your things inside that carriage. I may call for you later."

Tamu did not dare to say that he had nothing to stow; which was surely obvious to the prince in any case. Faldron no doubt meant that he should stow himself well out of sight.

So he climbed up into the carriage – a substantial wagon, with a royal standard fluttering from its roof – and found it already occupied by a tall, middle-aged man, folding up clothes, who showed neither indignation nor surprise.

"Master Tamu," he said. "Not much free space. You'll have to sleep on top of that gown chest." The cart was tightly packed with three large clothes chests, a couch, a folded decorative travelling-table, several gilded chairs, what looked like at least two suits of armour, but in bits, and smaller crates, one open to show jars of spices. All the accoutrements needed by a prince of Kelvha riding into battle.

Tamu looked around at this display of grandeur and then, more carefully, at the servant. "I thought you were a footman," he said.

"I was. The castle steward, Mister Greshal, put me forward for this post. My name's Obor."

"What happened to the previous man?"

"Caught stealing," said Obor. Tamu sat down upon the chest and watching him folding the gown. The man did not seem to mind. He was stolid, calm, quiet. Restful company.

I am fortunate, he thought. So much unforeseen good-will, or not ill-will, at least.

Apart from Leor... There, no will at all.

But am I any better than Leor? I have abandoned the priest, just as Leor abandoned me. Still, at least I gave Hokiyo what I could. I gave him a story. Not enough, probably. But what else could I do, against the might of Kelvha?

What else could Leor do, against the might of Kelvha? Why should I have expected him to do anything? He would only get himself in trouble.

Trouble everywhere. The inside of the carriage seemed a haven of delights, a cloud of dreams. Sounds from outside were pleasantly muffled. This was a tiny world cocooned in finery.

He studied the gown in Obor's careful hands, which was embroidered with a pattern of lozenges in gold thread on a silk of peacock blue, with braided buttons down the front. Its collar was softly trimmed with what Tamu thought at first was soft, fine fur. But as Obor gently straightened it, he saw that it was lined with feathers. Swansdown, maybe.

A sudden faint disturbance of the air made him and Obor both look up. There was nothing for them to observe but the heavy painted canvas of the carriage roof.

"Wings," said Tamu. "I think I heard them earlier, beating overhead. But I could see no birds."

Obor nodded, and kept on folding.

Chapter 45

Leor stared upwards with a frown. Those soft, vibrating wings, again. Perhaps some flight of birds behind the driving clouds, chasing the Red Roads to the sea...

He glanced around to see if others noticed. There seemed to be more people than he'd thought, standing in a grave, attentive line. He blinked, and shook his head, and looked again. No, nobody stood there. His brain was playing tricks. The Riders of the Vonn were milling round in discontent, at odds with one another, and uneasy.

I wish that I had wings, he thought, to fly away from here. Huldarion's displeasure was unfair. I don't think I mentioned the stonemen's youth to anyone. I'm almost sure I didn't. Yet he seems not to believe me.

And now there is some issue with a singing bowl which I can't comprehend. I've been friendly with the Vonn for centuries and yet I never heard of such an heirloom. Why has it been kept so secret? Why does it sing, and how? It has a magic I can't fathom.

But then what magic can I fathom? True, I quelled the serpent, he thought glumly, staring at the churning clouds; but I don't know how. I commanded my powers to do something, and they did – far more than I imagined possible. I froze the sea! Except I didn't. It was just them; those powers that I've been given, have been loaded with, afflicted with, adorned with, crowned with, punished with.

And when I try to pin them down, my powers diminish. I don't know how to use them. Before Tamu was dragged away, I tried to throw a cloak of wizardry around him, to make him so unobtrusive that the armourer would forget that he was there. I thought it might just work, because I did succeed in cloaking all those wolves up north before the battle. But wolves aren't people. I can't cloak any person other than myself.

Yet myself I cloak so often, he reflected ruefully, and in so many ways. I proudly wrap myself in the dramatic sweeping robes of wizardry and the deep authoritative voice and the pointed finger and the muttered spell, and I have no idea what any of it means. Everybody thinks me wise and powerful and I am drowning in ignorance.

And Tamu – my friend Tamu – he doesn't even know I tried.

This last thought made Leor want to hurl himself upon the ground and wail like a sea-bird, with long sobbing cries. But he had to keep up his appearance. So he crossed his arms and wailed inwardly instead.

The men of Melmet still lingered, watching the movements of the Kelvhan troops across the water. The taller one kept giving Leor unfriendly glances.

"Thought you were a wizard," he said.

Leor stared into space and clutched his failure tighter to him.

"Leave it, Inthed," said his comrade. "He could have pulled a lightning bolt down on that bully-boy – and you know what would have happened? Six more bully-boys would have run up and grabbed us as well as the little chap, and carted us all off."

But Inthed walked right up to Leor and stared at him nose to nose. He was almost as tall as Leor and considerably heavier.

"Couldn't do it, could you?" he said. "Call yourself a wizard? Next to useless really, aren't you?"

"Leave it, Inthed," repeated the other patiently. "Let's go and get some food." He strolled over and took Inthed by the arm. Giving Leor a careful nod he said, "Don't take it personally. He's upset."

"I'm stinking furious," said Inthed. "Get off me, Jerred."

"You're hungry," advised Jerred, and he steered Inthed away.

Still Leor did not move. He stood like a rock amidst the sea of Riders. Nobody seemed to know what was to happen next. They were arguing and clattering around with cooking gear and stowing it away again. The words replayed within his head. *Next to useless really. Next to useless.*

Could I have sent a lightning bolt upon Iajo's head? he wondered. Would it have worked? It didn't work on the monastery roof – it just inflamed the darkburn. So I expect it would have all gone wrong again, like that man Jerred said.

He walked away to seek more sympathetic company. Maeneb? Delgeb? No. Shebel; or Yaret: she would understand. Perhaps.

As he wandered through the camp he found himself remembering Bruilde. If only she were here... but she was old, too old to ride out any longer, no doubt sitting in a rocking chair, enjoying her retirement. Too old to farm, too old for anything: it was the curse of his long life, to see his former lovers growing old.

Yet he recalled his meeting with Bruilde last year, at her burnt-out farm. After his first shock at her grey hair he had found her not so very different to her younger self. Angry, patient, wise, unsympathetic – and strangely, unexpectedly alluring regardless of her years.

The truth is, he thought, that despite my own far more excessive age I don't grasp this whole business of growing old. I thank the stars it won't happen to me.

With this reflection he came upon Rothir and a number of Riders pitching camp; and noted that Rothir seemed to have aged a little overnight.

"Do you know where Yaret is?" he said.

Rothir glanced up from wrestling with the heavy canvas of the tent and shook his head. Leor looked round at the company. Theol, Rothir's second in command, was there – but why were Orbrel and Hilbré, who were both Captains in their own right? Altogether there seemed to be too many people here, and the wrong ones.

"That upset about the stonemen," he said. "Huldarion's anger won't last. He will come round."

"But I will not," said Rothir.

Now, Leor informed himself, now is the time to offer the wisdom of the years. Now is the time to draw on that accumulated knowledge; that weight of generations known and gone.

"Nothing will be achieved if the Vonn do not agree," he said. "Success can only come if you are loyal."

Rothir straightened up fully. He said, "What will you do, Leor, in the coming battle? Will you kill children?"

"I will do whatever's necessary."

"And so will I, apart from that. Perhaps you could offer a solution."

"Me? How?"

"You're a wizard," Theol said. "Surely there are a hundred ways that you could use your magic. To stop the stonemen in their tracks; to fell their leaders so the others run away: or simply scare them off."

"Scare them off?"

Theol shrugged. "You froze the sea. Can't you freeze the sky and rain down giant hail on them? Or freeze the men themselves, paralyse their limbs? Blind them, or make them fall asleep? Open up the earth to swallow them? Make the standing stones fall down on them? There are so many things that you could do."

Leor was bewildered. So many things, indeed; yet he had thought of none of them. Such power was beyond his expectations.

"I might make everybody blind, or paralysed," he said.

Theol snorted. "You could try, at least."

"But I never know the consequences!"

"You've had time enough to work them out," said Theol. Leor realised that he had come to the wrong place for sympathy.

"You don't know where Yaret is?" he pleaded.

"No." Rothir did not look up again.

Leor moved on. He could read Theol's unspoken comment in the shake of his head: *Useless*. Not even next to useless.

His heart was heavy as he trudged away. Indeed, why did he deserve sympathy? Why was he even seeking it, instead of doing what he could to help?

"But I cannot help," he said aloud, and immediately was contradicted by his mind. Or conscience. Or something from within.

Of course you can, it said, brisk and impatient. What about Tamu? You couldn't shield him, but you can shield yourself. So do it! Make sure Tamu's safe.

Leor had misgivings. But his conscience, or whatever it was, was contemptuous of his unease. To appease it he walked over to the edge of the camp, and looked across the Red Roads. A couple of the Vonn were splashing out with waterskins to test and collect water.

He cloaked himself. Not physically, but with deflection. Anybody looking at him would see only a minor figure, just part of the landscape, entirely unremarkable and instantly forgettable. He waded out towards the Riders, and made as if to dip and fill a waterskin, although he had none with him. The other men didn't even look up.

So he kept on going, fording the meandering Red Roads to the far side where some Kelvhan troops were watering horses. One raised his head and seemed about to speak; but then his gaze wandered off across the streams, as if the wizard had faded from his sight.

None the less Leor found his heart was thumping. He wanted to turn round and go back, and had to remind himself that even were he to be recognised, what harm could it do? These were allies. He was come to discuss high matters with the Kelvhan chiefs – no, no, he did not want to be led to Nerogun – no; he was come to offer greetings to the High Prince Faldron. A very proper undertaking for a wizard.

With this excuse ready he threaded his way between the Kelvhan carts: such a huge camp, this, so many thousands of soldiers that they seemed to stretch for miles. He made himself into one of them as he walked. Men stepped aside for him without noticing; one began a salute and then let his hand drop, looking faintly puzzled, before resuming polishing his armour.

There was a lot of armour-polishing going on. The Kelvhans' idea of readying themselves for battle was presumably to make themselves as bright and glittering as possible.

No, Leor reproached himself. These Kelvhans were skilled, hardened fighters. The polish no doubt helped their mental readiness, and gave them confidence... If they needed more confidence than they possessed already.

At least their love of ornament made the nobles' carriages easy to spot, for over them fluttered the tallest standards. He wove his way towards them, thinking he might hear some word of Tamu.

Still no one paid attention to him as he reached a great circle of carriages. The lords eschewed tents; instead, each had at least one carriage, heavy with gilded curlicues. None was larger or more ornate than the pair standing at the centre: a grandly embellished travelling carriage and a long gear-wagon, hardly less decorative. Above each drooped the royal standard. There was an empty space around them; two guards stood sentry at their front.

Behind him were hurrying serving-men, who carried plates of food and armfuls of equipment – parasols, wine flagons, braziers. Their masters meanwhile drifted through the

area, laughing and joking, or lounged on camp-chairs. But nobody approached the central pair of vehicles.

Leor mingled with the servants, trying to catch the words that floated past him. Where was Tamu? He drifted to a group of Lords and listened.

"A star-forsaken place this is."

"You think the battle will be worth it?"

"If we even get to fight. The booty won't amount to much."

"You think not? The Lord Nerogun doesn't ride along to battle unless the booty is considerable."

"Well, I'm sure he knows what he's doing. Where is he now?" The speaker glanced around warily as if Nerogun might be eavesdropping.

"He's questioning that priest," a third man said; one vaguely familiar to Leor, with a fierce gaze under heavy brows that did not match his orange hair.

A snort. "That priest should be strung up by his ankles, like all priests. What's he doing here anyway?"

"I imagine that's what Nerogun is finding out," the third man said. And he looked straight at Leor. "You there. When will our meal be ready?"

Leor stood there gaping; but a servant stepped forward with a bow and a prompt "Very soon, my Lord," and the man's gaze glided off him.

Feeling shaken, Leor slid away. He continued to drift amidst the crowds, yet learnt nothing of Tamu. At last he came upon a row of plain provision carts – and there he saw the priest Hoki-ro, chained up like a dog.

At least he bore no mark of injury. With so many guards around, Leor thought it wisest to approach no closer. His faith in his self-cloaking was not so great as all that.

So he retreated to where the guards were fewer, and the languid nobles were sitting down at trestle tables to eat. It made Leor hungry. He hadn't thought to bring food with him. But these lords weren't like the workmen he had sat down with in Kelvha city; he couldn't risk pretending to be one of their number.

Instead he moved to and fro with the serving-men, and watched and listened. He had a stroke of luck when a roast fowl tumbled to the grass and was rejected by its eater, who cursed his lackey's carelessness. Leor swooped on the fowl and bore it away. Withdrawing behind a carriage, he ate greedily: it was well-cooked, well-spiced, very tasty.

As he licked the last bones, a young equerry climbed down from the central travelling-carriage and walked past the pair of guards to stand outside the other royal wagon.

"Obor!" he shouted. A tall footman appeared under the wagon's awning.

"My Lord?"

"His Highness requests the company of the archivist Tamu."

Leor's heart leapt as the footman bowed, and then retreated. Seconds later, there was Tamu underneath the awning, thankfully unhurt, and wiping his fingers hurriedly on his kerchief as if he too had just finished eating. Tamu climbed down awkwardly from the wagon and hauled himself up into the neighbouring carriage. The door closed behind him. The equerry seemed to be dismissed, for he sauntered off. The guards took up their posts again.

So who was in there? Prince Faldron, Shargun, Nerogun? Was this the moment for Tamu's interrogation?

Leor walked round to the back of the vehicle and adopted an upright stance. I am a Kelvhan guard, he thought, no need to question me or my presence here; indeed you dare not, for I am here by royal command.

Then he strained his ears to listen.

Two voices. One was Tamu's.

"What would you like to hear, Sire?"

"Sangiron the Adventurer," said the other voice: it was the High Prince. "You said you are familiar with the chronicles. Do you know the tale of The White Bear?"

"I do, Sire."

"Relate it to me."

Leor could almost see the High Prince settling back amidst silk cushions, a goblet ready to his hand. And he could almost see Tamu, earnest and bumbling as he began to narrate.

Only he was not bumbling. Leor stood upright, pressed against the carriage's canvas back, listening to the story of Prince Sangiron; his expedition north with half a dozen men, the traversing of the hostile plains of ice; the distant vision of the great white bear...

He stood there while the grey sky darkened and the campfires flared before being subdued to embers for the night; he travelled with Tamu and Faldron into the white wastes, following those huge pawprints, seeing wonders of slow rivers of ice and huge gaunt birds of prey. Tamu did not falter in the telling, until at last the Prince spoke.

"That will do," he said. "We shall resume tomorrow."

"Your Highness. I wish you peaceful rest," said Tamu. Leor heard the carriage creak in the darkness as he went across to the other wagon and climbed within.

So Tamu was safe. No thanks to me, thought Leor glumly. As for the priest, I can't help him, surrounded as he is with soldiers. I could cause a distraction – but then what? I can hardly whisk him back across the water to the Vonn.

His mission was accomplished. His conscience seemed satisfied, in part: he told himself he'd done all that he could. But he did not relish splashing over the Red Roads in the dark. He needed to see where he was going; and although he himself might be invisible, any light that he created would certainly be noted.

So he stayed where he was. After a while he crept beneath the royal carriage, and used a small and harmless spell to dry out the damp ground underneath him and warm it up. Then, wrapped in his cloak, he dreamed of snowy fields and mountains made of ice, with a silver moon above, and giant footprints, blue, below.

Chapter 46

He awoke abruptly, fearful. The sun was up and it was light even underneath the prince's carriage. Had his cloaking spell still worked while he had been asleep?

Looking sideways, he saw several pairs of feet; ill-clad, hurrying. So he rolled out. A servant stopped to look at him.

Leor stood up with dignity and wrapped his spell around him.

"Go to your business," he commanded, and the servant bowed and answered, "Sir." Next second he looked confused; then shrugged. As he turned away Leor sensed his presence was already fading from the man's awareness.

A narrow miss. It was lucky he had woken. Soon the nobles would be emerging from their carts. Before that happened, he had better cross the Red Roads to rejoin the Vonn. There was nothing more to do here, for with Faldron's patronage, Tamu was as safe as he could be.

So Leor left the royal carriages, sniffing: he could smell campfires. Not far away, somebody had burnt the flatbread. They might throw it away, and he wouldn't say no to charred flatbread right now.

So he strolled amongst the hurrying serving-men towards the odour. Hearing a beat of wings overhead, he glanced up: nothing. Even so, another rustle of wings followed, so that people raised their eyes in puzzlement.

Then Leor frowned, and shook his arms, for small black specks had appeared upon his sleeves. And more were falling on his arms and shoulders: grains and flakes, like soot. They left smears on his clothing when he brushed them off – and they felt warm.

Not just warm. They were hot.

Around him men cried out with sharp, quickly muted cries, as if they were afraid of disturbing their sleeping masters. Black dots were falling from the sky, some drifting, some heavier and plummeting straight down, like a mixture of dark snow and hail.

Did I do this? Leor thought in sudden consternation. Has my wizardry somehow pulled down soot and ashes from the clouds?

He felt faintly sick with the possibility. But he had commanded nothing. He had intended nothing. Surely he would know if this was him? No, this was something else.

He stared upwards and a flake hit him just below the eye. He yelped and wiped it hurriedly: that was definitely hot. The smell of burning had grown strong.

But what was burning? Flatbread was not cooked up in the sky. What were these sooty flakes? Fear ran through him, liquid, oily... a familiar dread.

His heart thudded as he recognised it. This was not just apprehension at the falling flakes. It was the darkburn fear, the darkburn aura; and he looked around him frantically, seeking the blurred rushing shape, the whirl of smoke and darkness that must be somewhere close, about to leap on him.

He saw none. But now the Kelvhan nobles had begun to stir, throwing back awnings and jumping down from carriages. Some grasped swords, their faces taut with alarm as they looked into the sky, which was a changeful, speckled sheet of grey. Nothing could be seen against it but the dark flakes falling, falling.

Burning. A large one landed on his shoulder and he heard and smelt the snake's hiss of singeing cloth before he flapped at it and put it out. One caught in his hair: he shook his head frantically, raking his hands through it. Then the nearest cart began to smoke, its canvas roof sending up a thin white plume that turned with frightening rapidity to a flickering yellow flame.

"Fire!" yelled Leor – along with several others. Someone ran over with a sloshing bucket, and threw its contents over the cart's roof. The flames fizzed down to nothing.

But more and more shards of soot were falling, sizzling as they landed on the wet grass; there were more shouts, more loudly clanking buckets, which summoned the remaining lords from sleep; more men running to the nearest streams to fetch water. At least here, at the edge of the Red Roads, there was no lack of it. He saw several soldiers throw themselves down and roll in the slow current, before leaping up again, dripping and immune to falling embers and looking for an enemy: but there was nobody to fight, just the ashen rain.

Leor saw the sense in what they did. Despite having so carefully kept himself dry all night, he now ran to the nearest pool and knelt down while he splashed the water over head and shoulders. The sense of dread was so strong that it made him lurch back to his feet in a hurry, thinking surely a darkburn must be on him! He swirled around in panic.

Nothing. No smoking, rushing shapes. The only smoke came from scattered tents and the roofs of a few carts, and was rapidly extinguished. The falling flakes of soot hissed all around him as they landed on the twining waters. Those streams had lost their languid smoothness; a thousand tiny ripples hunted over them.

Leor watched a larger flake drift down past him, rocking as it fell. Strange... Though charred, it was undoubtedly a feather.

Then something else, much bigger than a feather, followed it. Black, still flapping, shedding pieces.

He jumped back in horror and alarm. What was it? A rook, caught by the sparks and burning?

It fell into the stream's edge with an almighty sizzle. He saw a hooked beak like a falcon's. No legs. A black bundle of burnt feathers.

His mind was filled with a panicky dread as thick and vague as smoke. He stared down at the small, burnt corpse, which now lay twitching until the gently nudging water pushed it downstream.

Another flapping body landed on his other side, with a second fierce hiss. Again, a bird – this time with a long tail, which disintegrated as it landed. Yet the thing kept flapping even as it was carried away by the water.

An object hit him in the back, and with a cry, he spun around. A blackened, crow-like shape had just bounced off him and was floundering in the stream, until it too was cradled and borne off by the Red Roads' gently inexorable flow. Leor felt warmth in his submerged feet as it swept past him. He put down his hand: even underwater the corpse was hot to touch.

As he stared at the charred corpses in the streams they were joined by more and more. He looked up to see the air thick with them, fluttering and wind-tossed or simply hurtling down: a pelting rain of dead and dying birds.

They filled him with a terrible sense of fear; of loss and sorrow. He did not know what to do. One flapped frantically on a level with his face, spraying him with smuts, before it too descended with a splash.

And they smelt. He became aware of the stink now, the odour of decay. That darkburn stink combined with the sense of dread and horror convinced him that these falling things were truly darkburns.

But they were not attacking the camp, or not intentionally, at least. Even those that started fires did little damage. All around him, Kelvhan men were quenching small, temporary blazes, and swiping at the falling creatures with their swords. As he watched, one, struck by such a blow, shattered into half a dozen pieces. The worst effect was on the horses, which were whinnying in fright, and a few were running wild.

What was the point of such an onslaught? No other enemy rushed out to assail them. Indeed, there was no hiding-place for any enemy to rush from. The air was warm with small, dark, smoking bodies; but no worse.

Meanwhile a nearby group of Kelvhan soldiers, as bewildered as he was, looked round in fear and wonder. And then they looked at Leor.

"What are you doing here?" said one.

In all the shocked confusion, he had neglected his disguise. Now, flustered, he drew the spell back into place, and said commandingly,

"Get after those horses!"

One set off, but still the others stared for endless, painful seconds until their gazes drifted, recaptured by the falling birds. His presence was forgotten.

Another narrow escape... His heart thudding, he hurried away from the soldiers in his wetly clinging robes before realising he was hurrying the wrong way, back into the camp instead of out of it. Here were the lords' carriages again, amidst a sea of agitated servants and lordlings flinging on their armour and panicky horses and lost boots and abandoned breakfasts. All around him birds kept falling, like mad crows down a chimney. Frantically he smacked away one that landed on his arm. It tumbled to the grass and crept, flapping, underneath the nearest cart. The wet grass steamed but did not burn.

What was this he felt? Grief, it is grief, thought Leor, but that is just the darkburn aura. There is no cause for grief, for these are only birds. Cause for pity but no more.

He was back by the royal carriages now, and saw Prince Faldron standing with three of his courtiers, arguing. He held a sword and was calling for his horse, while his equerry tried to persuade him to take refuge.

"Withdraw, while we are being attacked?" the prince cried angrily. "My place is here. Where are my horses?"

"Your Highness, this is hardly an attack," an older lord assured him in a soothing tone guaranteed to aggravate the prince, to Leor's mind. "It is a minor nuisance, with which you need not concern yourself. These little fires are easily put out." Indeed, Faldron's own groom stood on the carriage shafts with a bucket, and his carriage roof was dripping.

"Please, my lord," urged the equerry, and he threw open the side door. A cloud of grey smoke billowed out. The equerry leapt back in alarm.

"What sorcery is this?" Faldron exclaimed. And then Leor saw flames beneath the carriage, licking round its edges.

As more servants rushed past him to quench the fire, Leor pulled his cloaking spell more tightly round him. But they were all busy with a flurry of buckets and sloshing water.

"I think, sire, that a burning bird crept beneath the carriage," observed the older lord.

"But how could the ground burn? It's sodden!" argued Faldron. "This is sorcery, indeed!"

Leor froze in case he could be spotted and accused. But the nobleman said wearily,

"Indeed, sire. If you will just step within your second carriage while we put this one to rights." He led the disgruntled prince towards the gear-wagon. As Faldron climbed up and disappeared inside, Leor glimpsed a tall footman, and, behind him, Tamu's face staring wide-eyed at the disorder.

Still safe, then. Leor thought it high time to disappear himself before there were any more cries of *Sorcery!*

It was not until he was squelching away that a sudden idea made him stumble. That fire beneath the prince's carriage – no, surely not? It had only been a very minor spell that he had cast, to dry the grass and make his night more comfortable. A very little, harmless spell.

"Consequences," he muttered as he strode off again, trying to dodge the falling birds, and began to splash across the Red Roads. For a disconcerting moment he saw himself not as a

sorcerer, but as a lanky, overgrown, red-tufted squirrel – a ridiculous creature, all activity with no useful result.

But there was a result, he thought. I've made sure my friend is safe. What else could I do anyway?

The rain of soot and feathers was still falling, to be extinguished in the water with a hundred tiny sighs. Together with the gurgling streams they made a softly sibilant choir. He looked along the Red Roads at a procession of black corpses being carried on the current, a thousand leisurely funerals.

On the far side of the streams the Vonn were running to and fro as busily as the Kelvhans, passing buckets along efficient human chains. Some of the archers had formed ranks, but with no enemy in sight they did not know which way to aim their bows.

A bird's wing fell beside him and was swept away, the stream holding it reverently. What was Adon trying to do?

These things are toys, he thought, toys tossed at us. I wonder why. He caught a feather as it drifted past: warm, dissolving into charcoal powder. He brushed it from his fingers, and glanced up at a strange shimmer in the air – a wave of heat, perhaps. He looked downstream again, looked back upstream: and saw as if pulled out of empty space a crowd of stonemen, silent, running, charging at him down the Red Roads, running in silence, faster than the flow of water.

"What?" said Leor. He took a step back. Where was his sword? Strapped to Bryddesda's saddle. Where was Bryddesda? Stars only knew.

Where did these stonemen come from? Where had they been hiding? They've come running out of nowhere, thought Leor in amazement. Such a long column, a full twenty men in width!

Yet no sound. No thudding feet, no shout although their mouths all opened in unheard yelling. Were they real? An illusion, surely...

The charging stonemen arrived at an unlucky Kelvhan who had fallen in the stream. While he struggled to get up they mowed him down and scythed his head off. They were real.

This is Adon, thought Leor, as he staggered back. This is Adon's work. He hid them from our sight and hearing while we were all distracted with his toys.

I could not even cloak Tamu, he thought, in a passion of dismayed self-hate. I couldn't even hide one man; and yet Adon could shield this whole vast stoneman army, and plunge us without warning into battle. Here it comes.

Chapter 47

Yaret loosed an ill-aimed, ineffectual arrow, dropped her bow and pulled her sword out with a swift rasp. It felt like months since she had wielded it in battle; she feared she would have forgotten how to use it.

She had about six seconds to remember – for the silent stonemen were now very close. They had divided as they ran into two columns, one to face the army on each side of the Red Roads. The Kelvhan cavalry were struggling to control their horses. The Vonn, not bothering with horses, were readier for the assault.

But they were few, so few compared to this on-rushing horde! And then she heard the wake-horn blowing wildly behind her: and glancing back, she saw more distant stonemen charging up the Red Roads from the sea.

Those boats, she thought. That troop will take a while to reach us, and it's not so big. We could overcome them easily if they were the sole foe. But as it is – they'll hold us in our place while the main force cuts us down.

As she faced front again, there crashed abruptly on her ears a thunder of feet and blood-curdling yells and clattering swords. It was almost powerful enough to knock her over on its own. The stoneman army was soundless no longer.

She braced herself to meet the charge: side on, shield up, swiping from right to left, thrusting the whole body forward to deflect the first assailant's bulk. The impact was a shock. But he was thrown off balance, and with a grunt rebounded from her shield. Kalbe, standing next to her, finished him off.

Four stones.

No, no, she told herself, don't count. If you stop to count you're dead. Guard up: slash and swipe, now stab; again. Another fallen. No groans of agony, just rage and curses. No pain could touch the stonemen. They fought until they dropped, surprised and furious.

A man fell in the shallows at her feet, and then reached out to grab her ankle. So she speared him through the ribs. A dreadful feeling as his flesh resisted. Three stones... No, no, don't count.

"For Obandiro!" she cried out, her voice barely audible even to herself in the mindless clamour. Beside her swarmed the ghosts of her imagination, who had accompanied her from that dead town, demanding vengeance.

But Yaret could not kindle any hunger for revenge as she had upon the northern battlefield. No bloodlust gripped her. This was just work: a horrible, messy, soul-destroying job that had to be got through, that allowed her no respite, no chance for mercy, no room for humanity. No time to say Oveyn for any of these killings. Just stab, slash, heave and swipe. Though bigger than she, the men were clumsy. They lacked co-ordination.

She and Kalbe worked together in unspoken grim agreement. Kalbe yelled aggressively at a stoneman, and when he turned towards her, Yaret stabbed him in the back. Two stones.

No. Just fight. Forget Oveyn.

Yaret had no idea what Kalbe thought. She was an unfamiliar though efficient comrade. Where was Maeneb? Vanished. Where was Durba? Buried. Where was Zan? – no, don't think of Zan.

Yet when she gazed out on the sodden battlefield she thought she saw his sad face gazing back at her, asking some impossible question. It was the effect of stress: Zan was not there. But she could have paid him more attention while he lived. She had a strong idea that he had cared for her, and she had chosen to ignore it, because it had seemed the wisest course.

Stab, swipe, slash.

And then a sudden brightness. Was that lightning? Another flash; across the Red Roads, the water steamed: several Kelvhan horses and the stonemen attacking them keeled over as suddenly as if shot by an arrow. She felt her own legs tingle. What had happened? She glimpsed Leor, his arm upraised, looking aghast. Had that been him?

The stonemen's onslaught paused for a moment – but only for a moment, before half their force peeled off and ploughed away across the streams to join the combat against Kelvha.

There was a brief lull. Yaret took advantage of it to lean over, hands on her knees, and pant down at the water, where no fish swam, no tiny creatures busy with their lives. All scared away. Instead a flotilla of small corpses blotched the streams. A few charred feathers were still falling from the sky: she hastily brushed one from her head, as Piril came hurtling up.

"Where's Janeya?" demanded Yaret. "You're not supposed to leave her."

"But it's this!" Piril held up a sooty feather.

"What about it?"

"It's *them*," cried Piril. "It's them, the spirits, they're being burned, these are their feathers falling, they're the spirits of the dead who should be flying to the sea and their long home and what will happen to them now?" She was crying.

"Piril, these are darkburns. Or they were. This is darkburn ash. That fear and grief you feel, it comes from them."

"So the spirits of the dead are being turned to darkburns?"

"No, no," said Yaret. "Darkburns have nothing to do with the human dead."

"But this is where the dead must gather on their journey! This is what the stones are for, to guide them! I'm sure of it." Piril's voice broke apart. "I saw – I saw my brother on the way, I saw him standing underneath the stones, and I thought, he goes down to the sea with all the others, all the flying birds, and I was glad that he was not alone. I was comforted. But now what happens to them? Oh, Keril! Oh, my brother!"

Yaret did not know what to make of this. She knew she ought to sympathise, but not right now. Such sobbing talk of spirits was no help. She remember her own tears up north; she felt now as Rothir had back then, that tears were pointless.

This is the price I pay for fighting, she thought grimly, and commanded Piril, "Get behind us. They're about to attack again."

"I have a sword," said Piril, and she produced it clumsily from a twisted swordbelt: the boy's training sword that Yaret had purchased from a Kelvhan forge.

"Just get behind us!"

Too late. The next wave of stonemen was upon her, and she and Kalbe were once more at work. The first man stumbled in the water and was easily dispatched. Another lunged at Yaret and tripped over the falling body, shrieking curses. She stabbed him through the neck. She caught the one after that in the eye, by accident, when he was pushed on by the men behind him, which sickened her; but they kept on pushing, yelling, so that she and Kalbe needed all their strength to hold them off.

Piril darted in, slashing determinedly with her sword, which though short must have been extremely well sharpened to cut the man's hand off just like that. At her warning shout Yaret spun round the other way, throwing up her shield arm to deflect an axe's heavy blow. While the axeman struggled to free his weapon from the leather shield, she thrust her sword beneath it, hacking at his legs. He staggered backwards, and a blood-spattered Rider to her left ran in to finish him.

But that Rider was not Kalbe. Beneath the blood Yaret recognised Janeya, waving another child's sword.

Janeya had no shield. She was exposing too much of her body – as was Piril. These are children that I have to defend, thought Yaret wildly, stepping aside as the next man came

rushing at her. She dealt him a two handed stroke that almost severed his spine. Three stones. Nausea heaved up within her and she tried to ignore it. But these were children. It should not happen.

That is martyrdom, she thought, what have they been promised?

Grown as battle fodder, fed with endless drugs and lies. The thought made her so angry that the fury fuelled her for the next ten minutes of desperate hacking, stabbing, swiping.

Then another lull. It was unexpected and she wiped sweat and blood from her face, aware that her shield arm was gashed, the elbow painful, and her scalp was stinging. She ran a hand along it: that blood was probably her own.

But why did the stonemen hang back now? Although so many lay dead or injured, they still far outnumbered the Riders of the Vonn.

Somewhere behind her, Huldarion was rallying his troops with a strained, exhorting tone. When she risked a look around she saw little order in the Vonnish ranks. Many wounded. She glimpsed Parthenal picking up one limp man only to let him fall to earth again with a grimace. Meanwhile Theol was roughly pushing Crade, Landel was arguing with his good friend Rigal, and Tiburé was shouting furiously at Solon. What a mess.

She looked for Rothir. Where was he? Had he fought, or thrown down his sword? No way to tell. All her limbs were aching. How tiring battle was. Exhausting, draining all life and hope out of her. The sheer smell of it... the sour, metallic reek of blood and spilled guts.

"What now?" Janeya said.

Yaret shook her head. "I don't know."

But seconds later, the enemy force began to move. This time all the stonemen surged towards the Kelvhan army. Kelvha are the ones they need to conquer, thought Yaret: our force is insignificant.

"To Kelvha's aid! To Kelvha's aid!" she heard Huldarion yell, although what could the Vonn do? None the less, the weary Riders regrouped before Solon led the march out across the churning water.

Yaret turned to Janeya. "Go back to Gaelera's cart and hide," she said.

"I'd rather fight," replied Janeya. She looked fierce.

"You're sure? Well, keep your head down."

Huldarion and a handful of others on horseback were riding in a splashy trot over the Red Roads. But so many of the horses had run off – her own Poda included – that most of the Riders were on foot: a straggling infantry. She saw Landel shouting even while he lurched into the streams, with Rigal evidently trying to soothe him. Poor Landel. What were the other rebels doing?

Her own company moved now, wading into the slow-flowing water. She felt it seeping through her boot seams. Occasionally it was warm and she looked down to find a small black feathered body being swung downstream. When her eyes followed she saw Rothir, towards the back.

So attuned I am to his broad figure, she thought sadly, I'd know him from a mile away. He was with a tail of lingerers; the unwilling or the undecided. He laid one hand upon his neighbour's shoulder, while hefting his long sword in the other. So maybe he would fight then, in some fashion.

Beyond him the carts looked lonely and abandoned; she thought that she glimpsed Meya sitting high upon her carriage with her driver, viewing the battle from afar. On the neighbouring cart, that bowl of skirts must surely be Gaelera: standing, her head turning as if seeking something.

As the Vonn waded across the Red Roads the Kelvhans paid no heed to their arrival. Why would they? The Vonn brought a mere tenth of their number to the battle. And the crowd of

stonemen had already begun to charge: the armies collided with a crunch of multiple swords on shield or blade or bone.

There was no chance to shoot a single arrow. Before they left the water they were in the thick of battle – and thick it was: Yaret had difficulty wielding her sword in the confined space between threshing bodies. She tried to work her way closer to the Kelvhan carts, which would provide some cover. Maeneb with her long and lethal knife would have been useful here.

But Janeya was downright dangerous, the way she waved her sword around. One swipe of it bounced from Yaret's shield before it took a stoneman's nose off: and when he screamed and brought down his battle-axe Yaret had to hurl herself upon Janeya to throw her out of the way.

Alburé killed the man. Meanwhile Yaret dragged Janeya into the shelter of the narrow space between two carts.

"Be careful, will you! Don't wave your sword around like that!"

But Janeya was staring at the cart before her. "Where is he?"

"Who?"

"Nerogun. That's his coat of arms. It's his gear wagon."

"So?"

"I want to kill him," said Janeya with new fierceness. "Where is he?"

"He won't be in his gear cart. For stars' sake, come down! It'll be guarded," warned Yaret; for Janeya was already climbing up onto the shafts.

"It's not," she said, disappearing underneath the awning.

Yaret did not have the energy to pull her back. No stonemen had followed them into this gap; so she leaned against the cart amidst the clash of fighting, thankful for the brief respite, until Janeya re-emerged.

"He's not there."

"I told you," said Yaret.

"But someone else is. He's unconscious."

"What? Who is it?"

"I don't know."

"I'll come up," said Yaret, and she climbed up after Janeya into the dim stillness of the cart.

A smell of smoke. The roof had been set alight and then doused from the outside; it was still dripping. It dripped upon a figure that lay upon the floor, face down, part-covered with a blanket thrown awry. Beneath the blanket he was half-naked, bloody. He had been beaten.

When she tipped his head, she knew him.

"Hokiro?"

The eyelids trembled: a sort of gasp came from the priest's mouth, but no more.

Such an earnest, gentle, sober man, she thought in bewildered fury. She too would gladly have killed Nerogun just then. This must have been done by him or with his full approval.

"What shall we do?" whispered Janeya.

"Let's try and lift him out. If stonemen get into the carts they'll kill him."

The priest was slender; not as heavy as she had expected. Together the pair of women managed to carry him to the entrance and part lifted, part slid him to the ground.

Lying on the grass he opened his eyes and looked at Yaret.

"I did not tell," he murmured.

"Good for you," said Yaret, although she didn't understand his meaning. "Can you crawl beneath the cart? Stay there until the fighting stops."

With the women's help, he managed to shuffle his damaged body past the wheels, until he was almost out of sight.

"Leave me here," he murmured. "Borgun is with me. I am not alone."

"Janeya?" said Yaret, for pity tore at her. "You stay with him."

"I'm not staying here! I'm fighting."

"Stay here and guard him."

"But I—"

"Stay here!" Despite the command she put into her voice, she doubted if Janeya would obey for long.

Then, after drawing two quick breaths, she ran back out to join the other Riders in the battle. This time she used the thought of the defenceless priest to stoke her fury. And that was not even the stonemen's fault, but Nerogun's... It was absurd.

But battle was absurd. She ran a stoneman through the stomach.

Too easy. Only two stones. Don't count. They want to kill you. None of these men call out for their mothers. So just stay furious.

As ever, the stonemen were so clumsy that they were easily overcome; yet their combined force was proving overwhelming. Yaret and the other Riders were being gradually pushed away from the streams, past the lines of gear carts, and into the centre of the Kelvhan camp.

Where was Huldarion? She heard his voice calling above the clash of battle. But he could not be seen. A Kelvhan soldier staggered backwards into her, an axe buried in his throat; she grabbed the axe and pulled it loose from the slumping body, to turn it on its owner as he advanced. It was heavy, with a greasy handle and a surprisingly sharp bite. The stoneman looked surprised, at least, when it smote him in the chest.

Six stones. No, stop it.

Of course Janeya had not stayed where she was. Yaret caught sight of her to her left but couldn't reach her in the crush. For both Vonn and Kelvhans were being pushed steadily backwards through the Kelvhan camp by sheer weight of numbers. The stonemen ploughed on regardless of their own dead, whom they trampled underfoot: their faces were inhuman, glazed, distorted. She was being carried helplessly on a tide of defenders who had no room to defend, no recourse but to be pushed back and back.

They passed more wagons, and were driven into an open area around two larger, ornate carriages, one of them severely burnt. She glimpsed Parthenal nearby, unable to move his arms in the crush of the retreating army. When she tried to call to him her voice was lost amidst the swelling shouts.

But she heard another harsh voice trumpeting across the crowd.

"Prince! Your Highness! Get back into your carriage!"

It was Nerogun. He was on horseback: one of the few. From above the fray, he bellowed at the soldiers: "Get him inside!"

And then she saw the High Prince, in full armour, trying to climb down from the unburnt carriage. Three Kelvhan soldiers were trying to persuade him back in.

"I will not!" Prince Faldron shouted. "I command you, let me go! I will lead my men!"

"It's for your own safety, Faldron," cried Nerogun. "Get him in!"

Yet the men were reluctant to compel the prince. It seemed he would have leapt down if there had been space for him to leap into. But another Kelvhan waded forcefully through the melee to climb up on the shafts and reach him.

"Get him in, Iajo!" shouted Nerogun, and the Kelvhan manhandled Faldron through the awning. A footman emerged to grasp the prince's arm as he was shoved roughly inside. By the time the Kelvhan jumped back down a minute later, Yaret and the human flood around her were being propelled on, past the royal carriage, swirling inexorably through the Kelvhan camp.

She was a piece of flotsam on the flow of men. The greatest danger now was of going down beneath these feet, of being stamped into the mud. The stonemen still surged up behind them,

a frenzied river of bloody tunics and grey-smeared faces distorted by contempt. When those in the forefront fell to Vonnish swords, their fellows clambered over them and pushed on.

They swarmed around the royal carriage. Caught in the flood of stonemen, the carriage itself began to move. It heaved and sank like an ungainly boat caught on the tide. The Kelvhans shouted; but they could not push back the army that surrounded it.

The royal standard on the roof shook wildly. Then it tilted and moved upwards. Yaret realised that the carriage was being bodily lifted, slowly tipping, as it was raised to the stonemen's shoulder height.

How can that be? she thought, amazed. Are the men lifting it? Could such a heavy carriage be hoisted so efficiently by hand? Maybe an organised group could do it; but the stonemen?

Wizardry, she thought. Was this Leor?

When she tried to turn her head to look for Leor, she could not. She could scarcely breathe, trapped as she was amidst a knot of bodies. Her feet at times had ceased to touch the ground. Nerogun stood on his stirrups, trapped by the crowd, bellowing words she could not hear.

The carriage began to move away from her. Its awning was thrown back by the tall footman.. Clinging to the canvas, sword in hand, he slashed down at the nearest stonemen. But seconds later he fell back through the awning with a stoneman's axe embedded in his shoulder.

No-one else emerged, and the stonemen attempted no invasion of the carriage. It rose and sank as it continued its slow progress over the stoneman sea.

Neither Riders nor the frantic Kelvhans had the power to halt it. A moment more, and Yaret could no longer see it: too many heads were in the way. She had to let herself be carried onward, concentrating on staying afloat, hoping to be cast up on some emptier ground.

Then suddenly the press of bodies slackened and relaxed. Her feet met solid earth again. She had lost both sword and shield, and her leg had been twisted painfully. She was surrounded by the bruised, shocked Vonn.

"Round the side! Round the side!" yelled Parthenal. Many Riders were already running to the east, hoping to reach the stonemen from that side. Yaret ran after them for three steps until her leg gave way. She fell down and stood up again, cursing, before limping on.

"Find the horses!" That was Tibur  s breathless voice. But any untethered horses had been scattered across the Red Roads. Yaret followed the stream of Riders and Kelvhans back to the water, which had acquired new rapids where it ran across the corpses: mostly those of stonemen but too many not. Black feathers drifted down to lay themselves upon the dead.

Hobbling through the shallows to a pair of horses, she tried to seize their reins. They kicked and backed off nervously. But another horse came over to her at a trot, hooves sending up wide fountains of spray.

It was Narba. He stopped and put his black head down to hers. Yaret leaned on him for a moment, blessing this faithful horse, on whom she'd learned to ride, on whom she had been carried, half dead, to safety.

Now, with an effort she swung herself up onto his broad back. From this new perch she saw an ebbing sea of people spread before her: the royal carriage, a hundred yards away, bobbed on a wave of stone-bound, shaven heads. The stonemen streamed towards two of the giant stones. Although the carriage still swayed at shoulder-height she could not make out any men actually carrying it. It was moving up the enemy army; in a moment it had overtaken all the stonemen and was at the front.

It reached the two great stones. As it passed between them, the carriage disappeared.

So did the stonemen who ran behind.

Both Vonn and Kelvhans stood and gaped. The stonemen had been swallowed up into the same empty air from which they had arrived. The enemy force was pouring steadily back into that invisible nowhere.

"After them! Get after them!"

The shout was taken up. Men on foot and horseback raced after the retreating stonemen. The stragglers were cut down, while a handful of Kelvhan horsemen cantered on to seek their prince and his attackers.

When they came to the gap between the stones they abruptly halted, the horses flinching and neighing in distress. Again they pushed forward, only to stop again as suddenly. Others tracked round the stones to the far side: they too were barred by some unseen force from passing through. They could not follow the royal carriage, wherever it had gone.

And gone it had. Prince Faldron had been taken. A strange, high keening began to emanate from the mighty Kelvhan army. It brought unexpected tears to Yaret's eyes. She grieved not only for the prince and his companions in the carriage, but for the Kelvhans so shockingly bereaved, and for all the Vonnish dead. For the stonemen she had slain, and for the necessity of slaying them. No more, no more, she prayed. Please let there be an end.

She looked around. No blackened birds fell now. They were no longer needed, Yaret thought, to cause distraction – which surely must have been their purpose. Nor was the darkburns' aura needed to deluge her with sorrow, shame and fear; for she had plenty of her own.

Corpses, corpses strewn in every place, lying in the water or fallen at its edge; tattered dull red tunics and the fine gold of Kelvha and drab Vonnish green all mixed, all mingled in the mud, their voices stilled, their breath stopped, their silence growing until it filled the whole vast battlefield.

Despite the mourning of the living and the sobbing of the sea-birds, that silence was all that she could hear. The standing stones looked out unmoved upon the sight; and the Red Roads ran on unperturbed, in their ceremonial passage to the sea.

Chapter 48

Alone at last, Huldarion leaned wearily on his sword and looked out along the Red Roads in the sullen glow of evening. Truly, now, they ran with blood.

The streams were littered still with slaughtered stonemen, heaped like boulders. The dead and wounded Riders had been dealt with; the Kelvhans had efficiently borne away their casualties; only the stonemen lay unheeded, causing diversions in the water's tranquil flow.

All else was calm – in a strange, flat way. After the hours of directing, ordering, maintaining discipline, this calm was not as welcome as Huldarion would have thought. It left him too much space: which was immediately filled up with his losses.

So many losses. Not just of Riders. He grieved for them; but also for his loss of face, the loss of credibility. The loss of self-belief, of self-control, of the former certainty of his own rightness.

Yet the greatest and the most dreadful loss, he knew, was that of High Prince Faldron. Both Vonn and Kelvhans had scoured the land and found no sign of either the royal carriage or its occupants. He thought that Faldron was probably already dead.

Now he felt the Kelvhans were avoiding him; for they would undoubtedly blame him for the disaster, despite their own failings in defence. They would censure him for dragging the Kelvhans here to the Red Roads; a sitting target, they would say, and given what had happened how could he prove them wrong?

Even Meya was avoiding him. He had glimpsed her helping to direct the moving of the Kelvhan wounded but she did not come near him. So, there too I have failed, he thought. She will leave me now.

He knew he ought to go back to his own injured people: but not just yet, for in truth he lacked the strength to face them. Lifting his gaze to the grey sky, he tried to call his mind to its accustomed certitudes. But the heavens aroused no stir of lofty hope. The low streaked clouds seemed to reflect the tainted water: the lurking sun created a long, hostile shore that sat above him, judging.

Huldarion was reminded of another vista – not so long ago – another coastline of streaked clouds. A fantasy-land, serene and bright and almost within grasp. Where had that been?

On the escarpment near Bruilde's farm, he thought. I stood there looking down upon the Darkburn River and its forest. Thoronal was there. I remember that huge lode of life below me, the weightless clouds above. In between, a soaring bird. I remember asking for some words of guidance. And they came: *Protect the land. Protect the people.*

And what have I done now? The land is indifferent to me at best; at worst has turned against me. That weed that lamed our horses and attacked Veron. The fog-bank where we lost our carts. That sea that spawned the serpent.

As for the people.... I've tried, the stars know well. I've tried to keep my people out of danger. Yet danger followed me. Considering what my mission is, what else could I have done to keep my Riders safe?

Not your people only. Whose voice was that?

"My voice," he said. "My cursed, unhelpful conscience." But what had his conscience to complain of?

Everything.

I should not have come here, he said inwardly, I should not have sought the truth about the stonemen unless I was prepared to act upon it. Pity and humanity drove me to the Place of Terns: where are they now? I have laid them aside. I came here for nothing. No matter what

the stonemen's age, we had to slaughter them before they slaughtered us. And those Riders who feel pity – I accuse them of betrayal.

He stared at the reddened clouds, that bloody handprint smeared across the sky. When his heart spoke again he did not wish to hear it.

You have choices.

"Hah," he said aloud.

You came on this long detour, his heart told him, hoping for some rebuttal, some reason to ignore the truth about the stonemen. It was procrastination. You delayed in marching to Caervonn because you do not wish to slaughter children. You came here not to learn the truth but to put off your decision. That was a choice. There are always choices.

"Should I choose therefore not to fight?" Huldarion muttered. "Should I abandon everything, walk away, and leave my people homeless, desolate?"

They are already homeless.

But if I walk away I fail them, he argued to himself. I fail my people, and my ancestors, and my lost home. To win my homeland back was always my desire; a deep, alluring dream. Is it to be no more attainable than those red lands in the sky?

He sighed and lowered his gaze. Rothir and Theol walked past some twenty yards away, carrying a stretcher. They were alive, then.

Rothir looked up at him. Huldarion felt again that beat of anger for the man who had defied him, however courteously. He did not know what he should do – what it might yet be possible to do – but he knew he needed somebody to hate just then, someone to blame besides himself.

The truth is, he thought, I hate Rothir because he voices the opinions that I cannot say. I have responsibilities. I have a realm to win. I have an exiled people who wait for me to win it. He ought to know that. He does know it. He too has a choice, and he has chosen to reject me, publicly. Well, I reject him back.

He made no sign to Rothir. The stretcher was carried over to the hurriedly erected tents; from that direction he saw Meya come, walking purposefully towards him. What did that purpose signify? Would she still stand beside him in this disaster, or return to Kelvha? The latter would destroy his chances of Caervonn. Yet he knew it was most likely.

She marched up to him. He stood silent, waiting for the next catastrophe.

"Well," said Meya, "this situation is not ideal. The enemy dead cannot be burnt, with everything here so soaking wet. It would be best to move the army on as soon as possible, to avoid the risk of contamination and disease. I've made sure that the water-carts are being replenished from the cleanest streams."

He found himself unable to respond. Instead he looked at her.

"Prince Faldron will be kept as hostage, I expect," continued Meya in the same down-to-earth, undramatic manner. "I doubt if he will be mistreated. A dying hostage is no use to anyone. I fear more for his valet, and that meek little archivist, Tamu, who apparently was also in the carriage. However, there's nothing we can do about them at the moment."

Huldarion made a questioning noise in his throat.

"I'm sure you'll be sent word of them," said Meya, "by some means, soon enough, and then you can decide what action it is best to take. Shargun and Nerogun each blame the other. And they blame you, of course, and the wizard Leor; but they have less power over you, and they'll look to Leor to use his wizardry to find Faldron. So I'd advise you to stick close with Leor, and with Jeveran. He's not interested in making excuses. He's a general of the old school."

"And you?" His voice came out in a harsh, impatient creak. Yet it was not impatience that he felt, or even resentment at her daring to advise him. Rather, it was wonder. Did she then mean to stand by him?

"Until I see my daughter," Meya said, "of course we work together. But you know my daughter's safety must come first." She sighed. "I should have stayed with her. But I was torn."

"We are all torn," said Huldarion.

"One other thing I had no chance to mention earlier. Perhaps this is the wrong time; but still. A couple of your men – and women – dug up some clay which may be an ingredient of the stonemen's drug called Athelid. Certainly it smells the same as the liquid with which Faldron's former valet dosed his wine, and tried to administer to you. If you have a use for it, Rigal keeps the samples."

He nodded. Perhaps there was some use for it; but he could not think just what. He could not think at all. It was terrible, this inability to think, to plan, to use his logic.

Meya was eyeing him with a mixture of what he felt were compassion and impatience. He needed to respond.

"Thank you," he said.

"Don't. So. What now?"

"Caervonn," Huldarion said, without conviction. It must be visible to all, he thought, that he had lost his faith in his own destiny.

She studied him and nodded, slowly. Then she put her hand out and took his. For the first time he realised how cold he was, both in body and in soul; for her hand was warm and welcome.

"Caervonn," she said. "But first, I pray you, let me see my daughter."

Chapter 49

As she walked towards the cliff edge, Bruilde was aware of the small fingers laced in hers.

"Not too close," she said.

"I won't be," said Aliya, although Bruilde had actually been talking to Veron.

Who, of course, ignored her. He was standing far too close to the high brink for safety, looking down upon the land. Such a huge land it appeared from up here on the edge of the escarpment.

Near to her, the many tiny streams that ran across the plain were quickly swallowed up into the forest – a forest that stretched to the horizon, its size beyond imagining, its dense distances melting like smoke into the hazy clouds. A bird of prey called, drifting in the space between: that warning scream was the only sound apart from trickling water.

A land of streams, she thought. I have not seen the Darkburn forest from up here before, although I've been down there, along its borders; and I do not want to go that way again. I'm too old. I want my comfort. Fifty years ago I would have pranced along that cliff edge and down it like an antelope – but age brings caution. Or it ought to.

Aliya let go of her hand and held up her own, framing it against the great green spreading hand below.

"What is that?" she said.

"A forest," said Bruilde.

"A wood, with fat green fingers," Flodda added. "One, two, three, four, five, six, seven."

"I can count," Aliya said. But she sounded tired rather than annoyed. Bruilde immediately wanted to pick her up, to cuddle her, although she was not a cuddler by nature; and in truth Aliya was not a cuddly child – or not with her at any rate. So it was odd the way she made Bruilde's heart ache.

She is the memory of the children that I never had, she thought. Leor, was that down to you? I didn't wish to bear a wizard's children. I feared how they'd turn out. And of course I always knew that you would leave me, once I started to grow old... unless I left you first. So that was what I did. My choice.

"See how the streams all run into the wood," said Flodda.

"I see," said Aliya distantly, and she turned away, trudging back over the cold stone slabs to where the horses waited with the others. Flodda immediately followed her.

Aliya needs a home, Bruilde thought. She needs a place to huddle in, a cosy bed. She needs a den. Somewhere that's hers.

And we have nowhere. No farm, no house, no shed. Not even carts: they are all burnt. All we have are horses, and ourselves.

She looked round at the group. Besides Veron, there were two hunters, two of her own farm workers, Flodda, Aliya, Olbeth and the baby.

She walked up to Veron, as close as she dared. She no longer trusted her body not to take a sudden bad decision, to give way at the legs, to wobble, to collapse.

"Where shall we find shelter?" she said quietly. "I see none from here."

"I see plenty," said Veron.

"Inside the forest?"

"Why not? The stonemen will expect us to turn south to join the army, or west to Kelvha City; or north-west to the estates of Outer Kelvha."

"How about north?"

He shook his head. "Blighted. And further north again is burnt."

"We could go north-east, and find Farwithiel."

"Have you ever been there?" asked Veron.

"No."

"Me neither. The Farwth doesn't know us. It very likely wouldn't let us in."

"Let's go south-west, then, back to Wiln's, with Olbeth and her baby." Olbeth wanted to rejoin her husband, and Bruilde's two farmhands were to accompany her. Flodda had been urged to join them on the journey but would not leave Aliya. As for Aliya herself... Bruilde knew before she finished speaking what Veron's response would be.

"And take Aliya back into the lion's mouth?"

"South-east," she said. "South-east, towards Caervonn."

Even to speak the name awoke in her the echo of desire, the old ache of homesickness. She had been fortunate that her family owned Deloran: in exile she had not been homeless like so many of the Vonn. She knew that Caervonn was not the source of such intense and helpless longing for her as it was for many of her friends. But still it called.

Veron snorted. "Caervonn is surrounded by stonemen. And soon that area will be a battlefield."

Bruilde was silent, looking east at sky and forest. The sullen mass of trees shut out the world. She remembered the darkness that had lain within. Yet she hadn't been in very far.

"I would not take her where our enemies are," she said. "And we know that they have strongholds in the Darkburn forest."

"Not at this end, not at the river's head," he argued. "They're much deeper in. And they won't look for us to come this way."

"But there's a reason no-one comes this way! It's uninhabitable!"

In answer, he pointed to the land north of the forest; the flat, bare, sparsely vegetated plateau with blue faded hills beyond. What had Yaret called that area? The Darkburn Loft. A land of rain and goats and little else.

"Smoke," he said; and then she picked out what she had not seen before, the thinnest thread of smoke that spiralled up from that wide empty space where nothing else was moving. "So there is someone there."

"Stonemen."

"Maybe. But not many. We can deal with them."

"If we don't go south to join the army," Bruilde said, "we must send a message to Huldarion, and Aliya's mother."

Veron shook his head. "No messengers. They can be caught."

"But, Veron. This is... this is not..." She took a breath and tried again. "Inside that Darkburn forest," she said, finding the words oddly difficult to say, "far inside that forest lies a road that leads towards the river. I've been there. It's guarded by some fearsome creatures: firedrakes, and who knows what else? It is a place of wizardry. Veron, that forest is not safe."

"That's why the stonemen will not seek us there. It's our best hiding-place, until Caervonn is won or lost."

"No," said Bruilde.

"Yes," said Veron, still gazing past the sharp edge of the escarpment; past the circling hawk, across the forest's hazy bulk towards the blurred horizon. "No stoneman will expect us to conceal Aliya there. So once we've said farewell to Olbeth and your men, the remaining six of us will head that way. We shall take our chance, and go down to the Darkburn."

End of Book 4

The tale continues in Darkburn Book 5: Caervonn